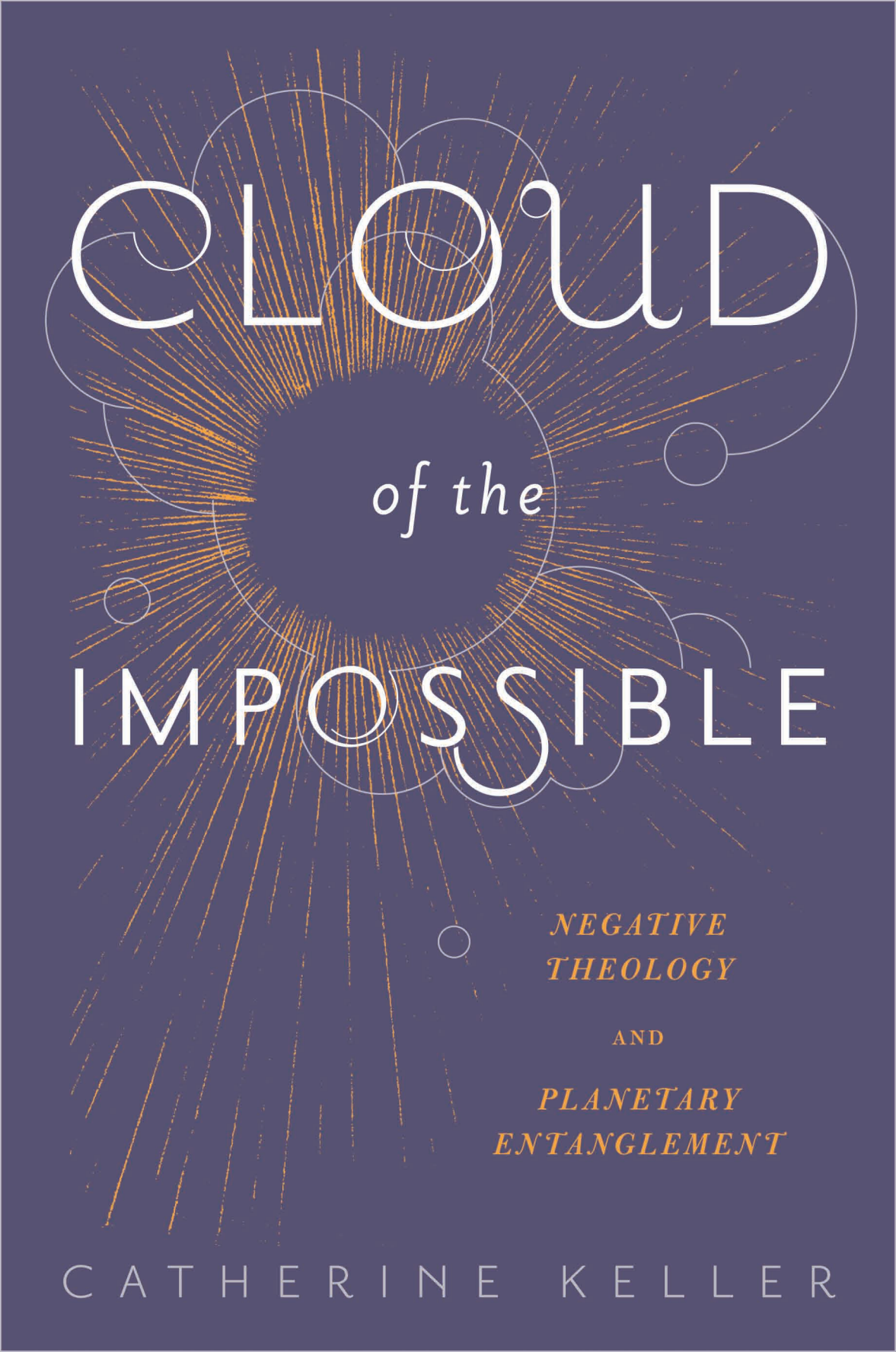




CLOUD

of the

IMPOSSIBLE

*NEGATIVE
THEOLOGY*

AND

*PLANETARY
ENTANGLEMENT*

CATHERINE KELLER

CLOUD OF THE IMPOSSIBLE

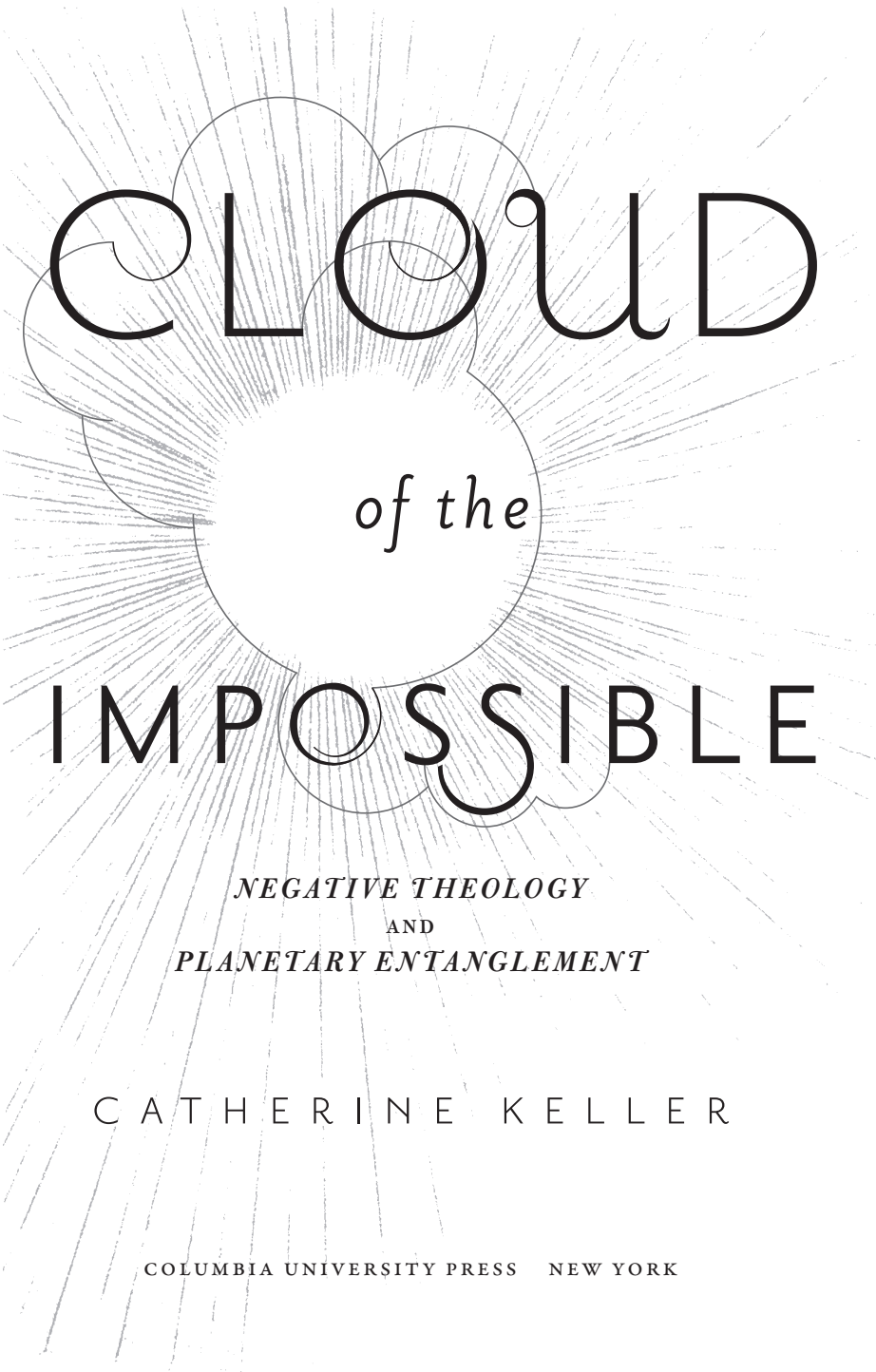
INSURRECTIONS: CRITICAL STUDIES
IN RELIGION, POLITICS, AND CULTURE

**INSURRECTIONS: CRITICAL STUDIES
IN RELIGION, POLITICS, AND CULTURE**

SLAVOJ ŽIŽEK, CLAYTON CROCKETT, CRESTON DAVIS,
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cloud

of the

IMPOSSIBLE

NEGATIVE THEOLOGY
AND
PLANETARY ENTANGLEMENT

CATHERINE KELLER

COLUMBIA UNIVERSITY PRESS NEW YORK



Columbia University Press
Publishers Since 1893
New York Chichester, West Sussex
cup.columbia.edu
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Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data

Keller, Catherine, 1953–

Cloud of the impossible : negative theology and planetary entanglement /
Catherine Keller.

pages cm. — (Insurrections: critical studies in religion, politics, and culture)

Includes bibliographical references and index.

ISBN 978-0-231-17114-4 (cloth : alk. paper)—ISBN 978-0-231-17115-1 (pbk. : alk.
paper)—ISBN 978-0-231-53870-1 (e-book)

1. Negative theology—Christianity. 2. Mysticism. 3. Planets—
Miscellanea. I. Title.

BT83.585.K45 2014

231—dc23

2014017597



Columbia University Press books are printed on permanent
and durable acid-free paper.

This book is printed on paper with recycled content.
Printed in the United States of America

c 10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

p 10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

Jacket Design: Alex Camlin

References to websites (URLs) were accurate at the time of writing.
Neither the author nor Columbia University Press is responsible for URLs
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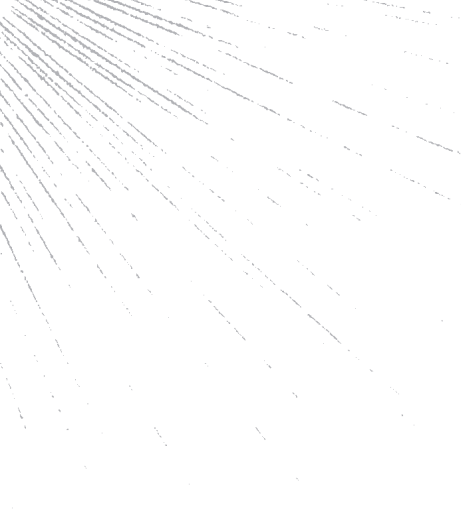
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CLOUD OF THE IMPOSSIBLE



BEFORE

*And the more that cloud of impossibility is recognized as obscure
and impossible, the more truly the necessity shines forth.*

—NICHOLAS OF CUSA, *DE VISIONE DEI*

*At the bow there is still something we now share: this murmur,
cloud or rain or peaceful smoke. We know ourselves as part and as
crowd, in an unknown that does not terrify us.*

—ÉDOUARD GLISSANT, *THE POETICS OF RELATION*

PLAYING FRENCH HORN for the school musical—it was *The Man of La Mancha*, and I was fourteen—I fumbled the high C. On the stage Don Quixote was belting out the climax of “The Impossible Dream.” Few in the auditorium would have noticed my tremble. But that cracked C may have betrayed an early resistance to the whole drama of “the impossible”—and an inability to let it go. So here I am, in another millennium, still trying to crack open the im/possible.

Aren’t we all? What relationship that matters doesn’t twist us to the faltering edge of possibility? Desire and fear blur together. What future comes before us unclouded?

Still, had not “that cloud of impossibility” floated before me later in the voice of a fifteenth-century meditation, I might have eluded the theme. By our own epoch, in an altogether different voice, the “experience of *the* impossible” had reached a high pitch of theory: a climactic deconstruction. Why wouldn’t it? In

our age impossibility has gone planetary. It has metastasized politically, economically, and—with deepening rumbles of apocalypse—ecologically. Dream, in German *Traum*, becomes trauma. Faith in the right outcome fades. Yet an answering planetarity of social movements, a great convulsiveness of gender, sex, race, class, species, keeps materializing against the odds. Echoing still from the World Social Forum in Porto Alegre: “another world is possible.” Possible, not probable. The hope haunts, lacking the determinism of progress or the guarantee of providence.

We have been warned against the very notion of possibility: “to go there where it is possible,” writes Jacques Derrida, “is to be already there and to paralyze oneself in the in-decision of the non-event.”¹ If we are already there, there is nowhere to go. And possibility often signifies this predictable presence of the already known: a smoothly determinate Aristotelian possibility. Hence passion directs itself to “the impossible.” But is there a danger that such a wan notion of the *possible*, degraded to a mere foil for the theatrics of impossibility, proves all the more paralyzing? This might be my cracked C speaking; but might such a tack not abandon us—all too predictably—to an impossible dream, tilting quixotically with rival notions? When big shifts do occur, the great exodoi, the collapse of an apartheid, a wall, impossibility suddenly yields to actuality. But does this not happen only by way of the actually *possible*? Does it happen without the enigmatic persistence of those who attend, but do not *know*, the possible? Who *mind* what may after the fact prove to have been possible to *enact*? In other words might some fumble, some crack in the impossible itself, disclose some other kind of possibility?

Fortunately Derrida wavers at this very edge, just as he is reflecting, not for the first time, on so-called negative theology. He hails in this late text the “more than impossible, the most impossible *possible*.”² Fleetinglly he affirms what long ago Nicholas of Cusa (in his own late text) offered as a nickname for God: *posse ipsum*, possibility itself. Another relation to possibility suggests itself. And with it—if the present text has anything to say about it—another possibility of relation itself.

We—a “we” I mean invitationally, not presumptively—find ourselves already pushed to a precarious threshold of language, and not for the first time. The cloud of the impossible materialized long ago, right at that crumbly edge, in a kind of speech unspeaking itself. It is speech as the most *knowing*, indeed erudite, sort of nonknowing. But of what? Of “that which to all humans, even to the most learned philosophers, seems wholly inaccessible and impossible.”³ Thus Cusa,

speaking of the cloud, precipitates a fresh event of the speech that unspeaks itself, of what had been called negative or apophatic theology—from its start a millennium earlier an intensively philosophical operation. It was never separable from its contrasting *kataphasis*, its eloquent affirmations. Such a theology performs its negations for the sake of the most positive relations possible. This nonknowing is to its alternative knowing as im/possibility—the most impossible possible—is to its possibility. But the seeming impossibles of, say, the fifteenth-century Cusa may appear alien to the dreams and nightmares of the twenty-first. We might say now, amidst necessities and indeterminacies he could not foresee, that the more “that cloud of impossibility is recognized as obscure and impossible,”⁴ the better we may face what is actually possible.

And what becomes possible, let alone knowable, except what comes into relation? Entangling us in whatever we do know and much of what we don’t, the cloud of our relations—or is it a crowd?—seems to offer itself as the condition of our every possibility. We know nothing beyond our relations. Alfred North Whitehead cut to the quick a century ago: “If anything out of relationship, then complete ignorance as to it.”⁵ So we hope here not for complete knowledge but for an incomplete ignorance. Such an ignorance does not close in on itself in defeat or exhaustion. It finds in the limits, ruptures, and fogbanks of consciousness new relations to—anything that matters. And what is consciousness, anyway, but, first of all, a knowing-*with*, materially resistant to our formidable attempts to fix its objects firmly out there where we can master them? Thus the Caribbean thinker Édouard Glissant could forge his poetics of relation from the following strangely hopeful decolonial condition: “the consciousness of Relation became widespread, including both the collective and the individual. We ‘know’ that the Other is within us and affects how we evolve as well as the bulk of our conceptions and the development of our sensibility.”⁶

We “know” what we know only with the irony of apophasis, of a language open to its own undoing. It would put scare quotes all over this text if it could. The relations are always too many, too much, dreamy or traumatic, enigmatic or incalculable, impossible to encompass. In the perspective of this book and of its cloud, we—“we”—do evolve, we develop, we select. But we do so in this “consciousness of Relation,” this knowing-together, that only knows itself as entangled in the complicated histories, bodies, indeterminate collectives, human and otherwise, that enfold us. They exceed

our knowing backward or forward in time, outward or inward in space. And from these endless enfoldings we each unfold—here, now, and differently.

Amidst this connectivity that crowds, that clouds, what can we learn? If Glissant was right, if a relational consciousness is spreading—can it retain, clarify, intensify its democratizing forcefield? “We’re all connected” was a ditty of Bell Telephone even before cell phones or Internet. And now the cloud also signifies a smooth network of connected computers. In view of a global economy enmeshing the planetary ecology—shall we abandon relation itself to cliché and commodification? Or might we instead expose and differentiate its incongruent collectives, its insidious deformities, its rhizomatic multitudes? With what priorities of perspective do *you*, here, now, cut through the relations overcrowding or beclouding the possible? With what wisdom, for what ethics, in the name of which truth, for the sake of which others, which Other? Is this why the question of God—“God”—arises always again: to name an impossibility? To break open its possibility?

Of course at any moment that Other “within us” may turn impatiently imperious—and rip right out of all the tangles. Indeed God may be the main name of an Absolute absolved from and so ordering all relations pyramidally. Today a dominant form of Christianity partners with the Pharaohs of global capital. Or to the contrary, the God-word may stir exodus from unjust relation: the column of cloud going before the terrified multitude. We may denounce the deified betrayals. But will we liberate ourselves from the ancestral trope of liberation? We may deconstruct the mystifications of ignorance that keep a collective under control. But will we ignore the folding of our relations—good, ill, or ambiguous—into whatever mysteriously exceeds our knowing?

I wager that traces of God will continue to inflect our relation to that pressing excess that comes within us and before us—even when it goes silent and unnamed, even when it is distributed amidst all those others permeating, populating, and eluding us. (Pascal in an age of ecological indeterminacy might wager not on God’s existence but on ours.) One may then keep weeding out the traces, imagining a final exodus from all religion. Of course “after theism” or “after the death of God,” after so many names and so many unnamings, so many disappointments, so many dullings and dyings, what we nickname God must seem obscure

and impossible. That does not mean It will ever have been captured by the names of what has died.

So one might resist the bipolar impatience—Nature versus Supernature! God yes or no! One might grant some experimental time, some cloud space, to theology well-practiced in self-critical mindfulness, in “learned ignorance” (Cusa), in ecofeminist, genderqueer, divinanimal subversion or “divine multiplicity” (Laurel Schneider). Would this mean “the autodeconstruction of Christianity” (Jean-Luc Nancy)? And “what would theology be and do among the damned and damaged,” asks Sharon Betcher, “in the winter of the worn-out and wrecked relics of commodity capitalism?”⁷ In its most affirmative intercarinations, beyond every Christian anathema, would it find itself close to the apophatic “God after God” of Richard Kearney’s “anatheism”? “It is only,” he writes, “if one concedes that one knows virtually nothing about God that one can begin to recover the presence of holiness in the flesh of ordinary existence.”⁸ The flesh of such possible theologies and such live potentialities comes suffused with every manner of “negative capability”—as Keats famously captured it in a letter to his brother: the capacity “of being in uncertainties, mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason.”⁹



In this risk and in this opening, what is called *theology* will pose its own im/possibilities. Only so may it open the way of another relation to possibility itself—posse ipsum. This book will consider how the cloud surrounding what we say about “God” here enfolds the entire crowd of our relations. In other words the ancient *via negativa* now offers its mystical unsaying, which is a nonknowing *of God*, to the uncertainty that infects our knowing of anything that is *not* God. The manifold of social movements, the multiplicity of religious or spiritual identifications, the queering of identities, the tangled planetarity of human and nonhuman bodies: these in their unsettling togetherness will exceed our capacities ever altogether to know or manage them. In their unspeakable excesses they press for new possibilities of flourishing. So I do not find it unrelated that in the same time, in the very neighborhood of these earthbound interactions, the ancient speech of the

unspeakable is emitting new resonances: of something “more than impossible,” *infini*, unfinished.

A book, however, demands some responsible finitude—a speakable finish. The task before us will be to stage a series of encounters between the relational and the apophatic or, to paraphrase, between the nonseparable and the unknowable. Many of these encounters will take place as readings of nontheistic texts, requiring little God-talk. But the series will nonetheless unfold chapter by chapter as the pulses and queries of a theology constructing itself even now.

Relationality and apophasis, however, do not simply jibe. Indeed as discourses they may careen toward mutual contradiction. Or they may lay back in cool incommensurability. Of course along the way there have been crossovers between the negativity of unsaying God and the negation of unjust world relations, between the infinite eros of mysticism and the earthy loves of any relational theology. Yet, on the whole, the recent theological movements in which responsible relation comes to the fore bear almost no resemblance to the apophatic tradition, with its ancient Neoplatonic sources. Relational theologies philosophically align—however explicitly—with a Whiteheadian process ontology, affirmative of the indeterminate becomings of our interlinked materialities, far sooner than with any strand of negative theology. With the latter, the mystical atmosphere of an initiatory elite, of detachment from bodies and crowds, never altogether dissipates. And the deconstructed subjects and objects of the cloudy unknowing may drift into a haze of dispassionate transcendence.

So we cannot in the present project escape tensions between the contemplative apophasis and the urgent evolution of more liberatory movements of race, gender, sex, ability, class, ecology. As relational theologies, these on their end are tempted toward a conveniently transparent subject—and, in its image, a revised, erotically charged, justice-empowering but perhaps all too knowable God. Without those revisions, however, this book, this author, would not be possible. Let alone actual. They have given voice to this speaking woman whose silence would otherwise have been compulsory rather than contemplative. Like crowds of others. Yet without the crossover, the chiasmus, to the apophatic, theology turns for many of us incredible. And the knowable knots of traumatized relation then do not open into the plenitude—or is it planetude?—of entanglement. This subject and her matter would lose heart before the metastases of the impossible.

How shall we think the relation, then, between the nonseparability encoded in entanglement and the nonknowing minded by apophysis? How do they fold in and out of each other? The response that unfolds through the chapters of this book will take the form of what I will call *apophatic entanglement*. It signifies the perspective of a possibility and the possibility of a perspective that come to light in the dark zones of relation itself. This is not the darkness of evil, but of the deep variegations of nonknowing that it may do ill to ignore or to manipulate. The perspective of apophatic entanglement springs open just there where knowledge, which happens only in and as relation, exposes its own *knowable* uncertainty. Epistemology here folds in and out of ontology.

The Cloud of the Impossible hopes to demonstrate, billowingly, that these relations that materialize as selves and as collectives, the relations that crowd, that differ and matter, come also apophatically entangled in and as *theology*. For at a certain point the darkness—just where it turns theological, beyond all light supremacism—begins to glow: “in the brilliant darkness of a hidden silence.”¹⁰ Thus the sixth-century Pseudo-Dionysius situates the discourse that can properly be called negative theology. But the enigma of the dark and shining cloud precedes the theology, as we shall see. It can be said to precipitate its possibility. And I suspect that it does so again, improbably, differently, now.

PRECAPITULATION

The cloud seems to drift spaciously before us. But its temporality is deceptive: our entangling relations may move too fast or too far. So let me try to summarize in advance how the present contemplation is structured, how this cloud forms its own template. In this book it performs a series of variations on the theme of apophatic entanglement. Each chapter unfolds a set of creaturely relations to an excess that enfolds them; each chapter, like each creature, envelopes what precedes it in order to develop it differently. Folding itself (to ply, as in Latin *pli*, French *plier*, or German *falten*, the root of “faltering”) emerges as a theme of negative theology. This happens historically when Cusa names God the infinite—the not-bounded and so not-known—inasmuch as it enfolds (*complicans*) and unfolds (*explicans*) the boundless manifold of the universe. Haunted by this

language, the book passes through three parts: Complications, Explications, and Implications.

The three chapters of the first part explore the specific theological traditions that in their interweaving form a lineage—though no party line—for an apophatically entangled theology. In the first chapter we confront the conflict that verges on contradiction between the two families of discourse indispensable to the present project. The former, as noted earlier, registers our mutual participation as creatures and as constellations of creatures, the relationality that forms and deforms us all. Relational theologies, specifically in their process, feminist, and ecological versions, developed in close and irritable intersectionality with the liberation traditions. None idealize relationality; all recognize the variant ambiguity of our entangled conditions. For the knots that bind us may tighten oppressively; they may thwart rather than foster the democratic unfolding of a becoming planet. Then the vital complication gets hidden, the interdependence sliced into the gross asymmetries of independence and dependence. In the meantime, the tangled relations *within and among* emergent social identities have also imported the political essentialisms of the left into the prophetic theologies, inhibiting needed coalitions of the multitude, the 99 percent, and, if you add the nonhumans, the whole planetary crowd of imperiled creatures. At that point the contrasting register of theology, that of the ancient apophatic negations, may only seem to deepen and mystify the founding hierarchies.

And so-called negative theology, as a current possibility, evinces internal tensions of its own. It is not within theology proper but within continental philosophy, in its own recent engagement of theological themes, that the ancient apophatic practice has reappeared in strength. Poststructuralism has at certain cloudy edges become famously entranced with the apophatic. It has given it new life. It is especially in Derrida's later meditations on the apophatic that the impossible opens into its radical *possibility*. Yet deconstruction cannot be identified with negative theology, which remains, after all, theology, indeed a theology indebted to the Neoplatonic One—of which poststructuralism is having *none*. Deconstruction is heir to the legacy of the death of God, the God of ontotheology whose Being *is* that One.

Nonetheless it is through this aporetic involvement of philosophy that negative theology represents now an active possibility. If the apophatic is for the most

part still registering only indirectly, or through a Thomist sublimation, upon theology proper, the present book takes up the difficulty and the potentiality of a direct (if never quite proper) encounter. And so the doubling of tensions—of a deconstructive apophysis and a prophetic relationalism—forms for the book a mobile chiasmus: a co-incident of opposites.

Offering a selective genealogy of negative theology, chapter 2 pursues a historical itinerary of clouds. It begins in the Sinaitic wilderness, where we also spot a rabbinic rendering of the opaque cloud as Presence, Shekhinah, Herself. From there we track the tradition of the brilliant darkness up to the fourteenth-century *Cloud of Unknowing*. This ancestry of speculative mysticism, wrapped in strands of Neoplatonic apophysis from Gregory of Nyssa on, then moves in chapter 3 to Nicholas of Cusa. Here his *docta ignorantia* unfolds fresh names for the unnameable. (It bequeaths one of them to this part: the *complication*, the folding together of the universe in the apophatic infinite.) Then comes the dramatic Cusan swerve into an affirmative cosmology of the manifold material world as the very *explicans* of the *complicans*. It yields the fundamental oscillation or mantra of this book: enfold, unfold.

Part 2 examines certain layered explications—scientific, philosophical, and poetic—by which our ontological entanglement comes to matter. To go materially all the way down, I found it necessary in chapter 4 to risk a transdisciplinary journey through what Einstein named “spooky action at a distance.” Here the simultaneity of enfolding and unfolding reappears as that of an “enfoldment” and “unfoldment” in quantum physics—part of the paradigm-busting problem of “nonlocality,” or what is called entanglement. Fortunately, certain physicists have already made explicit the radical relationality of the quantum level. Henry Stapp announces a “participatory universe.” Karen Barad has launched across the disciplines an indispensable language of “agential intra-activity.” Epistemological uncertainty here morphs into an ontological indeterminacy keyed—from the quantum up—to an ethic of mutual response.

As process thought has long worked the affinity between postmodern physics and a relational cosmology, the physics of apophatic entanglement yields to the wider concern of this section: that of the *explicatio*, the unfolding, of a relational ontology of entangled difference. In chapter 5 we read Deleuze reading Whitehead by way of a Leibnizian “fold.” Here too—in the face of a God-process

which persists in unfolding—the apophatic is more readable as the indeterminate than as the uncertain, as becoming, rather than enigma. I then tried but failed to subdue Walt Whitman, who demanded a chapter of his own. He plies the human with an extravagant transhuman imaginary of folds physical, animal, vaginal, queer, democratic, terrestrial, astronomical, and impiously divine.

In chapter 7 Judith Butler brings to twenty-first-century fruition the implications of her earlier undoing of gender as she makes explicit an ethics of relational ontology. In her influential work these constituent relations emerge only as we “come undone” in a dispossession of the human subject expressive at once of an opaque nonknowing and a work of mourning. I invite attention also to the non-human entanglements that continuously undo and revise the human, which happens to be undoing its planet. And so we turn to the more grievous effects of our civilization.

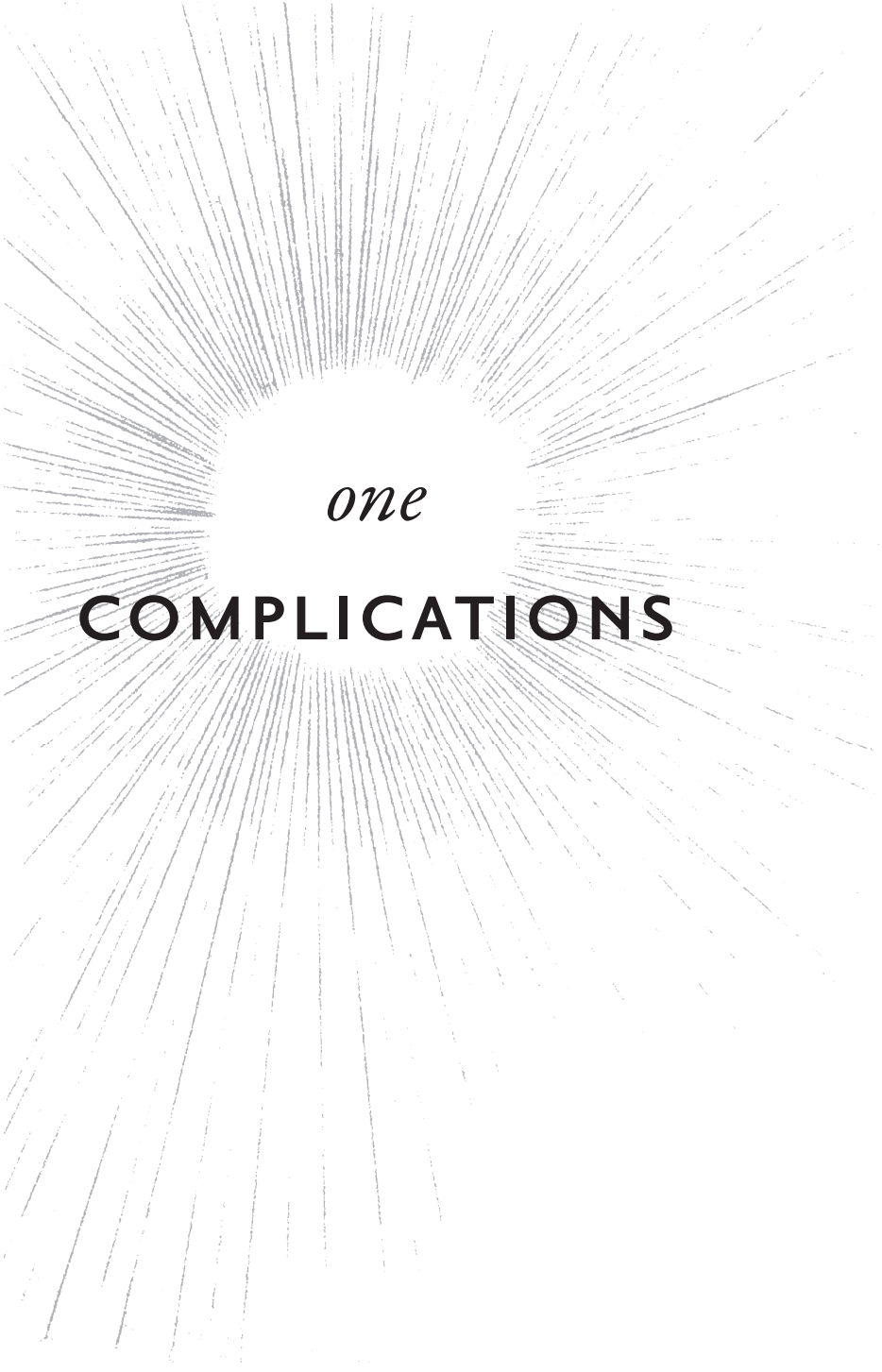
Part 3, Implications, examines the theopolitics of two specific planetary complexes. These narratives unfurl certain ethical implications of a globally entangled Western history. In chapter 8 I tell a story of our crusader complex, which at the dawn of the modern can be observed repressing an apophatic alternative to Islamophobia. The complex implicates an old theopolitics in a current economic globalism. At once older and more definitive of our future is the story of another global complex, rooted in a Greco-Roman entanglement, as narrated in the ninth chapter: here an ancient ecophobia comes home to roost. I hope that recognizing its imperial antiquity will help us “face Gaia” (Bruno Latour) while we still can. But the totalizing ignorance, the opposite of the knowledge that knows its incompleteness, has grown formidable under late capitalism. Ironically, in the face of global warming, certain climate skeptics now appeal to the literal clouds. As cloud feedbacks represent the “greatest uncertainty” in current climate science, it is hoped that they may—like the chorus of clouds in Aristophanes’ farce—“save us.”¹¹

The theology precipitated by the *Cloud of the Impossible* will not call upon the clouds, let alone God, to save us. Nor will it save God. Not, at any rate, if salvation is something someone does to another. If, however, saving is the opposite of wasting, “saving the name” might be just good ecology. Why waste every metaphor of our infinite entanglement? Unless we trust in progressive human supersession of the past, we might more honestly unsay and so say differently rather than cleanly

erase “God.” By a related and reciprocating logic, Whitehead’s poet God “saves whatever can be saved”—not by intervening but by receiving and recycling “what in the temporal world is mere wreckage.”¹² It evinces a dark tenderness, even in its failure to fix our world for us. So a constructive apophatic theology yields at last to the question, the questioning, of love. It finds in chapter 10 voice there where *theos* and *logos* cancel each others’ unquestionabilities. If in a Pauline epistle appears the “love that surpasses understanding”—the self-implicating, late-biblical form of the apophatic entanglement—it precipitates here no final biblical answer. Love isn’t all we need. But it does deliver narrative resources for an amorous cosmopolitics.

In the dark theopoetics of the cloud, might the very fold between our non-knowing and our nonseparability begin to appear as possibility itself, *posse ipsum*? But what events, what becomings, of planetary solidarity might yet be actually and not just abstractly possible? Possible, that is, to actualize—but perhaps not, even in the face of cataclysm, without a spacetime of contemplation?

Dimly, a broken high C echoes the elemental call of the shofar in the wilderness.



one

COMPLICATIONS



one

THE DARK NUANCE OF BEGINNING

*And everybody here is a cloud
And everybody here will evaporate
Cause you came up from the ground
From a million little pieces*

—CLOUD CULT, “EVERYBODY HERE IS A CLOUD”

I am going to come to you in a dense cloud.

—EXODUS 19:9

IF THIS IS a book of theology, we’ve got a problem. Not only is *theos* a questionable notion, with the impressive tradition of “the death of God” to shadow it/him/her. The very artifact of “book,” *biblios*, the old bearer of the *logos* and its filial *-ologies*, seems to be dying—as I write or you read—into a cloud of virtual text.¹ The clouds accumulate. Storm front of an apocalypse? One might celebrate such presumptive deaths; one might lament them; one might ignore them. I *mind* them. I wonder. I feel the loss of a certainty I never knew. And I notice a more subtle cloud.

Indefinite, it drifts around or through all the defining dramas of “the End.” It requires a prolonged attention. For under cover of its opacity there sometimes comes to light an unlikely possibility.

Such a possibility may present as the impossible: as when some crisis of uncertainty amplifies contradiction toward catastrophe; or as the possible clings softly,

subtly, to the actual losses knotted round every terrestrial event. So in its very nuance (from the French *nuage*, cloud) this possibility billows into dense ecologies, personal, political, planetary. These materializations shiver with their own endings and rumors of endings. They will not reduce to theory or to fact. They do not finally dissolve. Yet they also shimmer with life, with difference, with relation. Here, it seems, the uncertainty that could not be solved shades into variegations of enigma.

This peculiar cloud shapes, as this book will suggest, a certain kind of theological space. In what questionable sense, however, does this book confess to being *theology*? It does speak God, the word. So do the theologians who render their authoritative word on the Word of God. But the word *logos* signified a speaking, a plea, an expectation, a reason. Theos-logos here makes a plea for a theory of *theos* as a word, a speaking therefore of—something else, or more than the word *God*. In its living contexts the practice of theology is always more and other than speech. So its theory has offered contemplative sanctuary in the face of the most dire uncertainties: a chance to regroup before the impossible, to practice an alternative possibility, to prepare for—no matter what. It works, when it works, to prepare its public, across manifold, shifting tongues and times, to confront suffering and death, injustice, catastrophe.

Theology in the Abrahamic register has however often answered trauma by ramping up certainty. Promises of truth, salvation, and eternal life thus morph into guarantees conditioned on acceptance of the operative premises. Such certitude surely offers solace in the face of the unendurable. And its political legacy of righteous unquestionability has wrought not only reaction but revolution. However, the cloud of the impossible—a book, a citation, a meditation—emits the antique promise and unrealized possibility of a different theological atmosphere.

Far from disappearing, the uncertainty that confronts us at every bend and scale is along this way granted its moments of speechlessness—whether of trauma remembered or prophesied, of tender curiosity, or of “strange wonder.”² For along this path uncertainty gets edged by a contemplative silence, a pause, of knowingly not-knowing. It bears no resemblance to ignorance, mystification, or repression. Those systemic simplifications are just the shadow side of certainty: they operate the *apparatus of the unquestionable*—religious or secular.³ The apparatus encloses knowledge in simulacra of certainty, in truth-closures providing salvation

from unwonted complexity. God either exists or He [*sic*] does not: let us get on with it.

But the present contemplation practices an alternative answerability; it remains insistently question-able. It draws upon strategies of theory, affect, critique, and poetics that will not add up to knowledge, at least not to knowledge straight-up. Nor do they keep quiet, but yield instead an experimental alter-knowledge that keeps verbal faith with its silence. And *that* offers no easy grace: “Silence is all we dread / There’s Ransom in a Voice / But Silence is Infinity” (Emily Dickinson).⁴

In the pause that this book enacts, the alternative to mere knowledge and mere ignorance finds enfolded in itself the ancient theological ancestry of the *brilliant darkness*. This cloudy luminosity, already articulated in a fourth-century Cappadocian exegesis of Moses’ mountaintop theophany, unleashed the current of what is called negative theology—the way of negating in speech that which can be said of an excess, the infinity that escapes speech. The negation—a hopelessly misleading term, as it imports an affect of contrariness or lack—is nothing but the negation of a reification, a false positive, an ontotheological idol. As the Syrian writer known as the Pseudo-Dionysius said, just a bit later, of none other than God: “Not some kind of being. No.”⁵ These mystical negations do not, contrary to a standard reading, simply bow to an ineffable and transcendent absolute, absolved of all relation. If they did, the mystic would have . . . nothing to say. Exceeding language *in* language, negative theology positively glows with relation. Even at its most Neoplatonic early pitch, the divinity “is, as it were, beguiled by goodness, by love, and by yearning and is enticed away from his transcendent dwelling place and comes to abide within all things.”⁶ These relations exceed their world even as they reconstitute it. But they could never quite materialize as an explicated relational ontology within the classical terms of substance metaphysics.

The present argument depends upon a certain hinge or fold of Western intellectual history, where the apophatic alternative comes into its own, comes into materialization, in the transition between medieval and modern Europe. It takes the form of a fifteenth-cosmology, that of Nicholas of Cusa’s *docta ignorantia*, the “knowing ignorance” that negates the certainty of any theological, human, and so finite perspective. By this procedure he affirms the infinite complication of God and of the cosmos *in theos*. By way of this nonknowing knowledge leaps ahead: we will see him, for example, negate the geocentrism of the universe a century

before Copernicus; indeed he negates any fixed center of the universe. Yet this theory, this entire genre of alter-knowing, was soon repressed theologically, and then scientifically, by the early modern conditions, coercive as well as constitutive, of power/knowledge.

Under much more recent conditions, in the aftermath of the modern, the poststructuralist fascination with the apophatic has precipitated startlingly fresh engagements of theology. For the most part, however, it plies only the negative epistemology, *not* the relational cosmology, of the apophatic. Indeed it has little truck with the Cusanic legacy, which like all relationalism would tangle theory in some version of ontology, even metaphysics. And despite the rich philosophical and historical examinations of so-called negative theology, surprisingly little actual theology does more than gesture at its cloud.

This book may collapse into the infinity of silence. The ransom may be insufficient. But it means to draw its sources into a *constructively* theological contemplation. Something is experimentally building up, rickety still, knowing itself to be ever in construction, in process of collaboration, experiment, and wrenching selection. The apophatic is not a wrecking ball. But of course theology as an apophatic construction recognizes itself as a possible oxymoron: one more impossibility, one more last gasp, of theology itself? Or might this very tension of affirmative construction and deconstructive negation count as a late and never symmetrical activation of that indeterminate third space Cusa dubbed the *coincidentia oppositorum*—where prior truths undo each other? A space of cloudy (de) construction. “Hence, I experience how necessary it is for me to enter into the cloud . . . and to seek there the truth where impossibility confronts me.”⁷

IN A MIRROR, AN ENIGMA

The cloud of the impossible, at least as this present text, does not propose a *return* to the truth of any prior mysticism. Its deep loops of repetition unfold now and uncertainly, in an intertextual indeterminacy mindful of its own history of Christian overdetermination. If an abyss gapes open—not a void, for on the contrary, its theological space may be too crowded—I hope it does so with some pleasure of amorous expectation. For the cloud does suggest an enigmatic embrace, an enfold-

ing of the uncertainty of whatever it is that matters most. To you, now. In other words something about this historical moment (but which moment is it that has not already passed, surpassed this, any, “book”?) pleads for a fresh practice of the mindful unknowing. Such a practice at times repeats, and will never be the same as, prior stretches of the *via negativa* and of its Christian theism. It also touches base, and does not identify, with an atheology that negates all mystical negation, West and East, as not negative enough. The current alternative performs instead a disciplined uncertainty, its *docta ignorantia* continuously productive of learning potentially in any register at all, not just traditionally associated with theology. But there are few disciplines with which theology has not come into association.

If over a couple of centuries theology has come into a suspense compounded by every manner of legitimate or allergic suspicion, so much the better. Theology is invited to enter the cloud of its own impossibility. Losing control, it may keep faith. Paul Tillich, for instance, no stranger to the mystical abyss, unfolded in the face of postwar nihilism a faith that is the opposite not of doubt but of certainty. Faith, however, returns to its Sunday school every time it nails its language into positive propositions about just what it has faith *in*. For, in the cloud, in its darkness and its necessity, what we find ourselves *in*—“an unknown that does not terrify us”⁸—may be just what is coming unsaid in the saying. Perhaps it is after all not surprising that few theologians (conservative or liberal) practice such terms, that apophasis still plays a minor role in contemporary theology. Bad for business? And indeed because so much theology has practiced such an unquestionable orthodoxy those of us who question it from within do have so much, beyond mere critique, to *say*. Besides, when the religio-economico-political certitudes of the right menace the very possibility of that other and material world, that more convivial heaven and earth—how shall we take time for yet another round of mystery, uncertainty, ambiguity, poetry?⁹ We who would counter the anthropogenic apocalypses must muster relentless clarity of fact and value, no?

No doubt. We want to muster a trusty solidarity of activating con-sciousness that will ripple through the relations comprising our world. But we will need to *mean* it. Which may be different from benign propaganda for ailing liberal churches, fragile seminaries, and aging social movements—and which may release new resonances among those and vastly more and different theologically curious publics.

Let us dip for a moment into the supreme speculum of Christian theology. The phrase, “in a mirror darkly” in Paul’s letter to the Corinthians translates literally “in a mirror, an enigma.”¹⁰ But how does the doubling of an image in a mirror yield an *enigma*? Mirroring suggests clear representation. Is the effect of obscurity here not produced by the bouncing of light off a surface with which, far from revealing its other, *alter*, as a discrete object seen transparently, my own image interferes? The very reflection turns to diffraction. Here it beclouds—crowds—vision (all the more so in the ancient world, where a mirror was a speculum made not of glass but of polished brass—a cloudier surface). There is someone, some other, before me. But I and the other *alter* each other. My perspective constructs what I see *before* me—*before* I see it. As William James put it, you cannot “turn up the gas quickly enough to see how the darkness looks.”¹¹ Yet more darkly: does what I observe observe me observing it? (The allusion to quantum relationality, indeed to physicist and philosopher Karen Barad’s “intra-activity,” will come to the fore in chapter 4.) The enigma suggests the puzzle of perception, language, or knowledge in the face of that which eludes it. But does it encode here a simple void of knowledge—or rather the entanglement of the knower in the known?

The immediate context of the text is that of the seductive Corinthian entanglement, greater than faith or hope: “though I speak with the tongues of men or of angels, if I have not love . . .”¹² And the image of the speculum follows directly upon “putting aside childish things,” as in, presumably, the literalism that mistakes its God-word for a God-entity. My own perspective implicates itself, mirrors itself back to me—differently. Enigmatically. What happens is not solipsistic self-reference but self-implication, a relation to relation itself. Faith can never mean certainty but only *con-fides*, faith-with, the socially explicated trust, troth, that love demands.

Nothing in other words is known outside of relation—whether of terror, tedium, or love. Nothing knowable comes constructed *ex nihilo*, void of context. If something is known at all, it cannot be absolved of relation; therefore nothing is known ab-solutely. Not God, not me, not you, not truth, not justice, not Earth, not flesh, not photon. Each is what it is only in relation to its others. To know another is to participate in the construction of that other within the mirror play of a shared context. But both are still happening in and through each other. Nor does context lend closure. The boundaries of a context are constructs. One con-

text shades into the next, and the next. In truth and in uncertainty—the whole earth might come tangled in every local relation.

This presumption of inescapable connectivity carries from Whitehead the theory of the mutual immanence of things. The absolute space-time of modernity here exploded into a boundless interrelation of actual events. We will discuss later his “ontological principle”: “Everything is positively somewhere in actuality, and in potency everywhere.” Potentiality implies nonseparability; actuality materializes difference. So he inscribes “the universe as a solidarity of many actual entities.”¹³ Outside of these relations we know nothing. But to know some thing is to participate in its actualization. Therefore there is no simple outside from which to know it absolutely. Archimedes had a perspective, not a certainty.

The relational threshold of uncertainty cannot, in other words, be blasted away. It can, however, be ignored, thus producing not knowledge but more *ignorance*, and with habituation a *willful* ignorance, an ignorance oblivious to itself—and often characterizing authoritative knowledge. (As in “climate change is too uncertain to be good science.” Or “the quantum vacuum makes any notion of divine creation meaningless.” Or “Jesus saves.”) It will emerge as the opposite of the *learned* ignorance, the learning that knows its own ignorance and therefore does not cease to learn: we may call it, not without a Buddhist echo, the mindful unknowing.

But theologically speaking: if we are eventually to see “face to face,” may we not at least expect *eschatological* closure? What about those promises of justice that drive all liberation theology? Aren’t we talking about *God* here, not the faceless . . . whatever? But upon the biblical face of the deep, each image, in the meantime, washes out. The waters mirror fluently, chaotically, the shape-shifting clouds. Infinity may bear no resemblance to determinacy. At what end or death, would the primal circulation—above, below, around, before, personal, planetary, pluriversal—simply make an end of it: *finis*?

GETTING THE DRIFT

In the meantime—what if, upon contemplation, every edge, every *eschatos* of space or time, appears as a fold or a tangle of further relation? What if relation

itself does not, cannot ever altogether, exclude or enclose but *enfolds*? And *unfolds its relata altered*? The other comes before us then in the alterity not of a discrete over-against, not in the bounded exteriority of some flat face to face, but *as altering and as altered* in the act of relation. For alterity is relation in action and so in *alteration*. Difference then appears to take place nonseparably. Nonseparability (a synonym for entanglement in quantum physics) obtains no matter how alien the alterities, how quickly they shift to alienation or altercation. It is this *nonseparability of difference* that renders injustice intolerable. For good or for ill, in cosmology or in ethics, differentiation is not an effect of separation but of an entangled unfolding. However crudely an agent may strive to foreclose, to capture and subdue its relata, its entanglement in the relation itself will leave telling traces: the child of mixed race, the contaminants in the groundwater, the brooding revolt. There is always some tarnished effect of the golden rule taunting the triumph of separation. Some failed love haunts the borderline. But because nothing reveals nonseparability more clearly than love, love is perpetually sliding toward narcissism. Of course, on the other hand, love has—in the name, above all, of Christian unity—powered some of the most violent separations in history.

What we might hope for in this cloud of contemplation is neither unity nor separation. What is a cloud, after all? Not a one, not a fluffy unit, but a collection of billions of water droplets, frozen crystals, each folded around a bit of dust, each utterly distinct. A cloud is a mobile manifold, as are each of us, as are each of our contexts.

If our difference is always a relation, we drift apart, vary endlessly, storm off. We can come unfolded, undone, or unsnarled, but not disentangled. So then we might practice such differentiation as might shift, for example, in William Connolly's political relationalism, antagonism toward respectful agonism. The tensions of difference coming into opposition may inspire totalitarian dialectics—or spur the democracy of contrasts.

For now, without a dreary excursus mapping the mutual implication of the epistemological and the ontological, I want only this thesis to be clear: that the learned ignorance, or mindful unknowing, sanctions not the cancellation of difference but its intensification. It does not draw the line between known beings, or between the known and the unknown, except in the sense of Paul Klee's "a line is a dot that went for a walk." Or of Derrida's late "limitrophy," which in reflection on

the animal limit of the human insists upon “complicating, thickening, delinearizing, folding, and dividing the line precisely by making it increase and multiply.”¹⁴ Therefore this *unknowing never lessens or reduces knowledge, but makes new knowledge possible*. Despite the difficulty of language, which will keep unsaying not only its supreme objects but whatever it finds at its limits—we do not give up on knowing. Knowledge always signifies a specific *relation to and between differences*—a contrast of this or that, blue or red, good or ill, being or becoming. So attention to difference does not separate into cognitively contained units. It notes the cloudy consistency of the limits. And so it makes learning—new knowledge—possible.

In other words, if the boundary marking difference shows itself also as fold, membrane, or connection, alterity requires an alter-knowing of its others, an altered state of radical interlinkage: what you do to the least of these you do also to me. *Tat tvam asi*, that thou art. If each relation is a differentiation, a fold within a manifold, it bifurcates, multiplies, accumulates into a complication too complex to be simply, fully, or transparently known. Not unlike cumulus clouds, which may appear—at once visible and opaque—singly, in series, or in crowds.

FOLD UPON FOLD

Only occasionally, of course, does this ontology of relation, in its impossible width, come to mind, to matter. Even if it is everywhere materializing. In a famous verse of Mallarmé’s, a mist lifts like “incense”: “As furtively and visibly I sense / Fold upon fold of it stripped to widowed stone.”¹⁵ The prehensions of ruins and a lost friend surface with the flash of a swan, the “flight of the winged spirit,” in an affect that Mallarmé calls elsewhere “liturgical remembrance. “Fold upon fold,” *pli selon pli*: set musically by Pierre Boulez, the poem is etched in *The Fold*, written by his neighbor, Gilles Deleuze, for whom the *complicatio*, the “folding together,” of Cusa, comes enfolded with Bruno, Leibniz, Whitehead. The cloud of the present project is composed of folds, theirs among others, folds philosophical, cosmological, ecological, sexual, political. Each concept is a droplet, folded, crystallized around a bit of dust.

The fold, the *pli*, will be *plied* (“to ply,” what a fine old verb, meaning to “work hard, use diligently, *practice*”) in a self-implicating language, a language seeking to

stay mindful of its hidden entanglements. It will be faltering (“to fold,” in German, *fallen*—these folds are everywhere, just out of hearing) between misty remembrance and raw experiment. Hence it appeals recurrently to poetry, which plies the edges of language, as metaphors mix, fold, multiply into metonyms for what might occasionally be called an *apophatic theopoetics of relation*.

We will observe, across the registers of this book, that where a boundary stood firm and erect a fold appears instead, where more than one fold appears at once, an entanglement. Whether rats’ nests or networks, these tangled webs so proliferate—if one *minds* them—that they keep disappearing from consciousness. Or rather the folds comprise consciousness, as con-sciousness, a knowing-together that complicates or coimplicates each subject in its others. We subjects fold in and out of a pre- or postconscious fog. For the boundaries blur while the subjects differ and proliferate.

Here theology breaks into an indigenous multiplicity: an internal, indeed self-implicating resistance to the “Logic of the One” that Laurel Schneider finds colonizing the world.¹⁶ Not a many but a *manifold*, not one set of ones, but a *multiplicity*, this collection of creatures is folding in and out of each other, forming collectivities that may dissipate or organize. These are not the dissociative quantities of a numbing relativism but the ecologies of an unbounded relationalism. In relation to doctrine, it has been called polydoxy, enfolding the disarmed honesties of theological orthodoxy. Right teaching is not the problem; nor is the liturgical remembrance of its practice. When they harden monodoxically into theological positivism, however, theology itself rightly rises in negation. Here the alternative, admitting its constructedness and its unknowables, plies an altered theos, an uncertain logos. It depends upon the “pure multiplicities” of Deleuze, the “multipitude” of Hardt and Negri, the “polyphilia” of Roland Faber, who brings us to a “theoplicity” with which the present work is always complicit.¹⁷ The cloud keeps morphing in and out of a crowd.

In the gritty poetics of the indie ecorock group Cloud Cult: “Everybody here is a crowd / We all walk around with a million faces.”¹⁸ Human, nonhuman, these others, creatures within creatures, fold into us and out. The entanglement will prove itself boundlessly physical, endlessly nuanced. The million faces are my own, and I do not own them. Nor does the interface of mass interdependence deny us the face to face. It *does* expose the excess of relation to be as impossible

to enclose in knowledge as it ever was. But now it seems to demand a new collective leap of the docta ignorantia. As never before, the ecologies of our inextricable entanglement seem to threaten—without some evolution of collective attention, possibly impossible—to fold *down*. In the age of climate destabilization with multiplying masses too multiply oppressed to yet organize themselves, ourselves, into a militant multitude, uncertainty ceases to be an alibi for ignorance.

I make reference and will continue to make reference to the climate, the atmosphere in which clouds play their mysterious role in cooling and in warming, as an embodiment of the apophatic entanglement. I am aware of verging upon the apocalyptic limits of polite discourse. Even as global warming is becoming common parlance, it remains its own kind of unspeakable: of fright with one constituency and censorship with another. Unthinkably distant from the names of the Ineffable that any apophatic contemplative had on her mind, its science is bristling with new knowledge and must at every level “manage uncertainty.” Here the negative is at once epistemic and normative: it includes the life negating, the destructive, which otherwise we distinguish from apophatic negation.

In other words, and nonetheless, this book plies the fold between a positive multiplicity of relations and a negative theology. The positively indeterminate universe of relations, good, bad and neutral folds out of an epistemic uncertainty as to the name or theos that enfolds them. That fold between will itself multiply, oscillating in and out of knowability. Reclaiming its old work of negation, theology resists its own positivism. It pleads for a speech positively modulated by its own silences. By the same token, in its constructive affirmations—as the original meaning of *poiesis* is “to make, to construct”—it may also be called theopoetics. Fold upon fold, cloud upon cloud.

GOD’S HOSPICE

The Cloud of the Impossible—the Cusan phrase echoing *The Cloud of Unknowing*, the book of the fourteenth-century anonymous British contemplative—offers sanctuary to the whole tangled crowd. At least in theory. It is in such cloud contemplation that a particular possibility may come to light, whichever barely possible possibility it is that most needs realization now. The unknown before us,

larded with known and knowable crisis, will appear in endless diversities of perspective. I do not in this book argue for one unifying impossibility: if I were to, I might agree on this point with Slavoj Žižek: “it is easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism.”¹⁹ We will, however, explore certain webbed complexes of historical potentiality that call with peculiar planetary urgency. Each eclipses in importance any theory it exemplifies. But without the habit-changing work of theory, the web of relevant possibility remains *merely*, rather than apophatically, unknown. We might, in other words, apply to theology, perversely, this antitheological mandate of Bertrand Russell: “To teach how to live without certainty, and yet without being paralyzed by hesitation, is perhaps the chief thing that philosophy, in our age, can still do for those who study it.”²⁰ He would be quick to point out the Christian history of oppressive certitudes and paralyzing otherworldiness. The theology constructing and deconstructing itself here would concur. Indeed the implication of a certain Christianity in global economics, the “capitalist-evangelical resonance machine,” exceeds his mid-century projection.²¹ But we find no resonance in the opposing apparatus of atheist unquestionability, with a body count of state violence that more than matches centuries of theistic slaughter.

For that matter, the operative certainties of my own progressive, often Christian history are trying and failing to ply an effective public alternative, ecclesial or political. Did we get divided into an identitarian *many*, discouraged, lacking the solidarity of our fold? If faith is not certainty but the courage of our connections, then confidence—*con-fides*—comes only in minding our *complicity* with a vast range of others, even with those we most resist. Across the impossible, shifting distances of class, of culture, of race, of sexuality, of abledness, of species—we remain asymmetrically folded together, *complicans*: my whiteness implicated in the slave traumas of your ancestry and also in the beauty of my multihued classroom. But speech falters there, awkwardly, promisingly. Beyond both guilt and innocence, the possibility of the humbling empowerment of planetary solidarities is forever coded theologically as the new heaven and earth. Or more faithfully translated: the new atmosphere and earth.

Then a voice in me shrills: let unsaying mean “enough with the talking”—an activist apophasis! *Do* this truth, make it happen!

And if *you* do know how just to *do* it, please do.

If, however, you are uncertain, some cloud-thinking, some complicitous contemplation, may help. *Not as an alternative to practice, but as the practice of an alternative*—to what is all too predictable, all too known, to a knowledge that acquiesces in itself. The conceptual content of this alter-knowledge will come not from within a theological enclosure, nor from any discipline in isolation, but from the manifold arts and sciences, humanities and posthumanisms, by which we *ply the human*. Most of these disciplines, while currently predicated on certifiable unbelief (even as “religious studies”), do, when they take pause, recognize strands of their own historical, political, or literary entanglement in theology. Is it possible that only the recognition of that contamination, indeed that complicity, will release resonances needed—as Connolly insists in *Why I Am Not a Secularist*—to operate new solidarities of ecological and political becoming? These solidarities carry the chance of new *exodoi*, liberations from oppression, a “commonwealth of God” (John B. Cobb, Jr.), resistant to each secularist purge. They comprise the data for the so-called political theology of the religious or irreligious left.²² But they get thwarted by the modern separation of the disciplines, which, above all, means to secure secularism.

And, for the time being, given the disciplinary boundaries that still thwart cooperation, it may, ironically, be theology that is able to offer the needed *trans-disciplinary* hospitality. But perhaps only inasmuch as we welcome the religions and their critics into their nonseparable difference from each other. *To host* roots close to its opposite, “hostility.” Hence Derrida’s “hostipitality.”²³ The host may claim, even through a sacrificial gift, a sacred dominance. So does the hospitality of theology depend now upon its autodeconstructive—not self-destructive—contemplation, that of a cloud of unknowing in which it *minds* its own complex constructedness? When it does so it becomes alert to the “regimes of power” (Foucault) operative in all certified knowledge, theological, ontotheological. We are then discerning a threefold alter-knowing: of *mindful nonknowing*, of *constituent relationality*, of *manifold justice*. These serve as criteria—apophatic, ontological, ethical—for a theology that finds its theos folding in and out of logos, its theory folding in and out of practice. And so its language offers harbor, sanctuary.

Such sanctuary practice may be a gift of theology’s currently acute vulnerability. And in the personal context in which I first wrote this sentence (my mother Jane gradually dying in the next room), I am mindful of the proximity of

hospitality to *hospice*. What am I saying? That postmodern theology is nothing but the hospice for a dying God? If so, hospice neither rushes nor denies a death. It honors the cloudy space between life and death. In the case of divine signifiers—long ago Tillich warned that symbols are all mortal—ambiguity is raised to the second power: if the boundary between life and death is uncertain, so is the designation of just what it is that died or is dying or will die.

Does “God” quite capture what is dying? Is God the name of the problem whose death is the only honest solution? Which God? God the Name, the known, the fact, the metaphor, the metonym? God he, God she, God it, God-head, YHWH, trinity, divinity, the divine, infinity, ground, groundlessness, being, nothingness, Love, Life, abyss, I AM? God black, red, yellow, green, queer? All current Judeo-Christian variations of Hashem, The Name, the ultimate nickname for the Unnameable. Is the multiplication a symptom of resistance to death, of stubborn liveliness—or of some stranger planetary metabolism of life and death?

Theologians on one side may fear and fight the modernist theocide. On the other they may leap with negative grandiosity to embrace it. But what if theology would instead pause within its own apophatic unknowing?

What if we “acknowledge the possibility of the impossibility of religious belief”? Why not, asks Philip Clayton, build “the controversial nature of religious belief into theology itself?”²⁴ If theology minds—does not paper over—its own possible impossibility, what new possibilities emerge even now from within its darker places? Might it get the benefit of its own doubt?

Is this just a trick for cashing our liability into a strength? Or might we find here a clue to the sort of contemplation that can cut—*de/cisare*—through paralysis? Every actual subject, human or otherwise, according to Whitehead, is an act of decision, of actualization of *this* possibility and not that. It may take place by heroically cutting off one’s besetting others, one’s undecidable alternatives. Such manful decisiveness may—as in the case of Žižek’s “divine violence”—actually only yield ethically a new paralysis, or parallax, of apocalyptic waiting, an inhospitable waiting that, unable to distinguish between co-optation and contemplation, shuns any mystically tinged nonviolence as “Eastern,” “Buddhist,” or “New Age.”²⁵ Each impatient apocalypse, always revolutionary, risks further paralyzing those already faltering in the uncertainties of complexity, empathy, vulnerability. I am

thinking that this possible, still possible, multitude—not locked into some certainty no argument can alter—are those who may find their own resilience in the dark hospitality of the cloud. Is it these citizens of an atmosphere and earth yet to come who can metabolize a new planetary solidarity?

Of the dark place of theos, theology does offer a deep past and a manifold practice. It no longer lays down the disciplinary rules of a grammar to be protected from foreign contamination. The matter of theology here mingles urgently with every kind of worldly knowledge. Exposed to its own enigmas, knowledge bounces back the image of its living interpreters—implicated, interfering, inextricable.

Theology of course frames the widest enigma as *God*. But when I repeat that word I feel the thud of an old enclosure. I hear Georges Bataille: “If I said decisively: ‘I have seen God,’ that which I see would change. Instead of the inconceivable unknown—wildly free before me, leaving me wild and free before it—there would be a dead object and the thing of the theologian—to which the unknown would be subjugated.”²⁶ Oh that thing. We do admit that even the apophatic edge of theology, the very source of the discourse of the inconceivable and the unknown, can be paraphrased as: it is a mystery—do not question! Cliché, conquest, or commodification: the frame freezes. Really, though, “*the* theologian”? Must one still picture, say, the cleric of Bataille’s seminary sojourn? Has the theologian not in the intervening century been broken and distributed into bodies of divergent colors, sexes, voices? Hasn’t she said and unsaid “the thing of the theologian”? Hasn’t she spent decades at His deathbed? The “death of God” reflects back to her, in enigma, the deadened things of a world subjugated to the godly. And to the godless. But in the subdued light of this hospice, what do we actually see dying—besides just what we are able to see? These images appear, with Feuerbachian precision, as mirrors of ourselves, diffracted. If we linger, if we are not afraid of this dark, this dying, another liveliness suggests itself. “The insistent stirring of the event” begins dimly; in, as Jack Caputo insists, “a thought that perhaps all this *really* is through a glass, in the dark, and perhaps the darkness goes all the way down. Perhaps we *really do not* know at all what we mean.”²⁷

Why does the darkness enliven? What *is* it? *Is* it? “Wild and free”—utterly, inutterably. But with some further nuance, some complication of freedom whereby it fosters the most complex orders, not just anarchic egos. And it—or she or he

or they or you or we—leaves *us* free to destroy the lingering wildness of our world. In the name of God or of godlessness. Yes we can.

How then could the *question* of God be silenced, except by one final mimesis of His unquestionable voice?



“Therefore pray God that we may be free of God.”

—MEISTER ECKHART

If an ancient apophatic heritage arises now again, it does so as a theological iconoclasm—language “breaking truth from jail.”²⁸ Its silences, landing between every line, offer opportunity for fresh speech. Whose? Old voices oddly new? New voices around and within us, barely audible? Do they still speak of that “not Being” of which God remains the primary Western nickname? At one level the cloud of the impossible remains a meditation on the question of God-talk, logos or poesis, which is to say on the possibility of some relation to an infinity that no finite relation can manage. Or escape. The ancient tradition first rendered it the Infinite, as the next chapter will show, not as a transcendent substance or Being so much as an evasion of any *fin*, finish, boundary by which it could be named and known. This transmuted Neoplatonic infinity offered resistance to its own—*being*. To its being “God as he is God, as he is spirit, as he is person” . . .²⁹

At the same time we are beginning to consider how an apophatic *not-knowing* *tinges everything that is not God*. For if we know anything that we know only in relationship, perspectively, we know at best partially, in enigma and in engagement. This relational knowing, marked in the Hebrew *yada* as erotic knowing in paradise and out, makes possible every act of justice—“He judged the cause of the poor and needy; then it was well. Is this not to know [*yada*] me?”³⁰ The concern is not to achieve an abstract epistemology that will only distract from the urgencies of the world. Nor is it now to trade thought for frantic acts of raw sex or politics. But we may want to support a minding, an alter-knowing, that stimulates the interactive potentialities of our entangling relations. Our nonseparable difference crosses every register of our relations, every economy, every politics, every social or ecclesial movement, every ecology, whether it ignores or minds its own dark

nuances. The challenge is to mobilize the democratizing solidarity trapped in our tangles. So a constructively apophatic theology folds continuously into the cosmos of a relational ontology.

The hope and the hospitality of such a meditation require that we mind the intensity of the tension between the cloud of our nonknowing and the crowd of our nonseparability. For instance, J.-L. Marion writes approvingly of the negative ultimate: “the ab-solute: undone from any relation.”³¹ It would be precisely the radicality of the apophatic deity that ab-solves it from relation. In this it bears resemblance to the orthodox freedom of the transcendent One. Yet for Marion, the poststructuralist undoing of ontotheology, of any Supreme Being, expresses that absolute. This captures the problem for the very notion of a negatively theological entanglement—won’t it swiftly undo the tangles of relation itself? And yet for any theory of constituent relation we come undone *in*, not *from*, relation. So does the absolute, which henceforth ceases to be the ab-solute. For it remains a meaningless abstraction for us if extracted from its relation *to* us. In other words it might come to little more than theological irritation and theoretical incommensurability between the ethically charged relationality of this project and a post-structuralist apophasis.

The cloud of the impossible is not in other words guaranteed to open into the possibility it promises. Still, I hope it does. If so, it will be through an odd coinciding—never unifying—of opposites, a play of antitheses carving out a sort of interactive chiasmus. For, as I shall show in what remains of this chapter, a certain apophatic depth opens up *within* relationalism, indeed at the heart of its prophetic praxis. And, conversely, a radical, indeed cosmological, relationalism will appear from within the apophatic, before and after its modernity.

INESCAPABLE NETWORKS

Of course it isn’t as though Christian theology has successfully fostered an ethic of our planetary interdependence. “Mind your relations,” chants Thought Woman. And soon, in Thomas King’s great satire set among the Blackfoot First Nations, Changing Woman floats by on Moby Jane’s back, passing through the colonial “Christian story.”³² The Christian characters, even Young Man Walking on Water,

advance their own mission by appropriating and repressing the relations that precede and exceed them. Western subjects grew bloated, metaphysically substantial, on the properties, physical and metaphysical, of the subjected. To mind our relations is to mind the complicity of our theologies in the metaphysics of substance and its mutually independent essences. So the relational theologies (often Christian) all arise in protest of the voracious individualisms and imposed unities of the West.

Whether primarily ecological, liberationist, or decolonial, feminist or womanist, these relationalisms of the latter half of the twentieth century share the sense and ethic of an inescapable interdependence. Occasionally they were nourished by the older Whiteheadian cosmology of process. They variously redescribe, without erasing, individuality. Rather than a subject internally indivisible, *atomos*, each subject is indivisible *from* its world. That world of relations calls us, context by context, to account. These constructive relationalisms, however, are not one. They have energized the multiple genres and genders of our difference. They have produced new cultures of analysis, requiring divergent, overlapping, and inevitably competing theological practices. I do not need to rehearse the productive conflicts of such recent history. Theological relationalism rides with the progressive politics of late modern religion. So it came linked with the assertive identities that, in reacting against oppressive essentializations, was necessarily tempted to new essentialisms (Woman! Gay! Black!). At the same time, a “simultaneity” or “intersectionality,” articulated by African American women already in the seventies, resisted the contextual closure of such reactive identities. The multiple vulnerabilities of some subjects of liberation—as the “triple jeopardy” of race, class, and gender early framed by womanist theologians for theology became “multiple jeopardy”—push right through identity politics into a more honestly entangled ethic.³³ The theology of social justice has in this way gradually absorbed and reshaped social ontology.

All along, the influence of process theology, in its critique of the metaphysics of substance, its positive cosmology of creative and open-ended connectivity—was directly or indirectly in play. Process theology itself was inspired to articulate an affirmative new vision of God and world, holographically exhibiting a way of open becoming in immanent relation. Its ontology critically displaced substance metaphysics, but also resisted the blanket antimetaphysics of continental trends.

Divinity here trades omnipotence and impassivity for the sensitive interdependence of panentheism: God's own experience, God's open becoming, depends upon the becoming of creatures.³⁴ The aseity of the absolute dissolves into "the fellow-sufferer who understands."³⁵ Unable to claim the minority voice of a liberation theologian, John B. Cobb Jr. early cultivated "process theology as political theology." He made the positive alteration of the ecosocial world its urgent priority. Its interdisciplinary constructs attend far more to an empirical multiplicity of experiences, and to the new knowledges that they make possible, than to mysteries of unknowing.

In other words, attraction to either apophatic mysticism or deconstruction was in this atmosphere of late twentieth-century constructive theology not manifest. Those of us articulating subjugated knowledges and challenging oppressive ones had little interest in our own nonknowing, except to overcome it as a systemically internalized blinder. Why deploy some postmodern apophasis to dim the exuberant *kataphasis*, the emphatic affirmation, of radical new language? Would we, even now, unsay the fresh self-naming of subjects still vulnerably "hearing each other to speech,"³⁶ working out whole new alphabets—LGBTQI—of identity? On the other hand, notice how the new names have worked: by a recurrent un-naming of a prior name. Are we feminists or womanists or *mujeristas*; negroes or Blacks or African Americans; homosexuals or lesbians/gays or queers . . . We might speak of an apophasis, dynamic and on principle open-ended, determinately indeterminate, of human identities.³⁷

And of divine identity, in the mirror colorfully? Would we already unname all those new names of God? Does the *docta ignorantia* then only still and defuse what Kathryn Tanner named "the politics of God"? Of course we reminded ourselves and our interlocutors regularly—and from the beginning—that all God-talk, including our own, was "metaphor."³⁸ New metaphors—painted in race or class or eros—jostled with each other for place, not without their own productive confusions. But the metaphors, when they succeed, as had earlier analogies or symbols or myths, do stabilize and stick. And they transfer their creaturely content, understood as such (mother or wisdom as much as father or warrior), to a One receptive to many and new revealing images. Yet that one remained quite straightforwardly *God*: the entity, the Being, the One: the not-metaphor, the transcendental Signified, upon which the signs are inscribed.

I do not now question the valor or the necessity of these metamorphoses. I am, however, insisting that for a strong enough, that is, iconoclastic as well as iconoplastic, third-millennium theology, some apophatic deconstruction will be key. This is not to say that the Neoplatonic mystical tradition developed any adequate sense of metaphor, or of the signifier, let alone of the metonymic mist in which significance materially circulates. (That is where deconstruction can never *be* negative theology.) It *is* to say that even the most relationally passionate and compassionate God, rewired through our most sustainably just politics and our most cosmologically correct metaphysics, will still need to “free us from God.” S/he/it will for too many theologically thoughtful thinkers suffer a credibility gap if left to congeal into the discretely being One. Or entity or Being, however many and friendly its faces.

This experiment in apophatic entanglement will feel forced, however, if not simply self-contradictory, unless it can discern in the theological relationalisms the germ of their own unsaying. Otherwise there is no chiasmic passage between the entangled relations and the apophatic deconstruction. Let me here share two concrete performances of the prophetic activation of a relational manifold. Truly they have unfolded in the face of impossibility. And they give evidence of their own deep entanglement in an *apophatic practice of just relation*.

The first activation appears as a genealogical complex—an entangled rhizome—of the social movements that render religion a public force, just as in the 1960s secularization loomed triumphant. It is a story of the dark nuance of beginning. It was in 1965 that Howard Thurman published a book with this elaborate subtitle: *A Personal Interpretation of the Anatomy of Segregation and the Ground of Hope*. Its title is *The Luminous Darkness*. The book makes no mention of negative theology or its history. But it opens with the parable of a student’s account of deep sea diving: “As he drops deeper and deeper into the abyss, slowly his eyes begin to pick up the luminous quality of the darkness; what was fear is relaxed and he moves into the lower region with confidence and peculiar vision.”³⁹ (This oceanic darkness enabled in *Face of the Deep* the peculiar meeting of apophysis with materially dark faces.⁴⁰) Thurman solicits that shining darkness by way of Psalm 139: “If I say ‘Surely the darkness shall cover me / Even the night shall be light about me . . .’ The darkness and the light are both alike to Thee.”

Thurman had been a mentor for the young Martin Luther King Jr., and, before that, a classmate of his father. Already in the thirties Thurman led a delegation of African Americans to India to meet Gandhi, who suggested that the idea of nonviolence would reach the wider world through the struggle against white oppression. Thurman would later introduce the idea of nonviolence to the young King, who then traveled to India in 1959. King took with utmost seriousness Gandhi's meditation practice of *satyagraha*.⁴¹ That the politics of nonviolent civil disobedience was empowered by a Hindu form of silent contemplative practice seems hardly incidental to the present narrative. Performing a new kind of entanglement—interreligious, international, interethnic—Gandhi himself, and King later, credit Tolstoy's radical Christian ethic of loving the other—enemy included—with the activation of the originary impulse.⁴² A cloudy im/possibility, older than Christianity, precipitates a new actuality.⁴³ Fold after fold. Nor is it then accidental that one finds Quakers, with their radical “apophatic practice,”⁴⁴ everywhere in this story: mentoring Thurman, sponsoring his trip and King's to India. And then there appears the Quaker Bayard Rustin. King's main adviser during the early movement, Rustin strongly advocated the Gandhian strategy. He was the main organizer of the 1963 March on Washington. If he is little known, it is not just because he worked behind the scene, but because of the challenge posed to the movement, not least among fellow African American Christians, by his open homosexuality. In the seventies this Black Quaker helped to initiate the gay rights' movement: issues tangle with issues.

And in this world-transforming entanglement, let us note that the ethic does not arise as *just do it*, but from a full-fledged relational ontology of which there may be no more important wording than this: “all life is interrelated, and we are all caught in an inescapable network of mutuality, tied in a single garment of destiny.” I want to pause, not letting overfamiliarity numb the *novum*. He continues: “Whatever affects one directly affects all indirectly. For some strange reason I can never be what I ought to be until you are what you ought to be. And you can never be what you ought to be until I am what I ought to be—this is the interrelated structure of reality.”⁴⁵ I will not here discuss the intriguing question of just how extensively King's prophetic cosmology of interdependence was influenced at Boston University by early forms of process theology, tangling with his Black

Baptist heritage and the Quaker silence. We have to do not just with mobilizing metaphor but with metaphysics (“structure of reality”). Here unfolds—explicitly—the ethical *implication* of every relationalism.

In activating our nonseparable differences, the darkness begins to glow. This connectivity at one level simply iterates and amplifies the golden rule. And, not unlike a gospel, the God-talk remains understated. No divine guarantees, only the exodus memory of a past, the mountaintop dream of a future.

The crowd of planetary religious, ethnic, sexual multiplicity performed in this genealogy seems to have plied a possible world by beginning to actualize it. And it did so by confronting the forbidding cloud of empire, racism, heterosexism, and class. If that is not facing the impossible, what is? The effects ripple on—not just in every wave of African american liberation politics and theology, but also in the Polish Solidarnosz resistance to totalitarianism in the early eighties, deeply Catholic, inspired by King and in turn inspiring the nonviolent resistance of Occupy Wall Street—and so much more.⁴⁶ I am only wanting to draw from a well-known slice of history the less known nuance of its apophatic underground: without the persistent hospitality of a complex counterculture of mystical silence and contemplative prayer, would the impossible have cracked open *in possibility*?

I do not say: into a dream fulfilled. But into as much progress (“progressives” might want to admit to an occasional burst of it) as the world seems to evince at a time. Amidst the betrayals, the contradictions, and the capitalization of the globe, the work unfinished, *infini*.

In the subsequent two decades, however, the luminous darkness receded even further into the background of the liberation theologies, Latin and African American, as surely as did its ontological network of mutuality. The nonviolence seemed perhaps too mild or convenient to the cold war assault on Latin American socialism and U.S. Black Power.⁴⁷ Indeed any cosmology, any ontological relationalism, seemed also to many liberation theologians a strategy of distraction. It would take the dynamisms of feminist and ecological theology to push forward against the imaginary of the radical interdependence that constitutes all things. But also here the effect of a contemplative mysticism upon liberation theology, by way of so many dissident Roman Catholic feminists and priests, has not been given its due.

It is above all in the entanglement of Roman Catholic feminism with questions of socioecological justice that not only the relationality but with it the apophatic gets explicitly theorized. “We believe in the dimension of ‘not-knowing,’ a fundamental dimension of our being,” writes Ivone Gebara, a Brazilian sister—also barely tolerated by the Roman hierarchy—dwelling among the poor of the favelas of Recife. Here an explicit apophasis becomes political praxis: “*a not-knowing* that makes us humbler and at the same time more combative in order to gain respect for differences and the possibility of building *an interdependent society*.”⁴⁸

She has thus put forth, in plain view and in *possibility*, a practice of apophatic entanglement: the living pressure of nonseparable difference that makes known “the dimension of ‘not-knowing.’” The multitude of the populations of the poor and the vulnerable, human and otherwise, exchange certainty for respect. For Gebara “relatedness as a condition for life” translates the substantial God of the Thomist metaphysics into “relationship itself.”⁴⁹ Kicking free of the metaphysics of discrete subjects and their subjected objects, Gebara draws upon the ecofeminist panentheism of Sallie McFague—a theorist of metaphor and the constructiveness of all theological models.⁵⁰ The “body of God,” the metaphor McFague unfolded out of its earlier enunciation by the process philosopher Charles Hartshorne, becomes “our Sacred Body” in Gebara’s indigenously tinged relationalism. It is the site of a wounded and amorous relationality incarnate in all of our bodies. Her *manifesta* continues: “We proclaim quite simply the deep desire and the urgent necessity of having our individual and collective body more widely respected. We dream of a tender justice; we yearn for democracy and respect for the *res publica*.”⁵¹ It is the materially mattering multiplicity not then simply of “the poor” of the liberation fathers but of the female, the indigenous, the *mes-tizaje*—and indeed of the whole clamoring interdependent crowd of creatures—that finds sanctuary within such a theological space of radical democratization. (Marcella Althaus Reid’s *Indecent Theology* would break further into the impossible, exposing the heterosexism of the liberation construct of “the poor.”)⁵² But the surprising role of *not-knowing as respect for difference* here extends the nonviolence of hospitality to an alternative public, to the possibility of what we may call a planetary *convivencia*. The cloud of nonknowing does not silence but mobilizes the crowd of nonseparabilities.

I hope that these two performances of theological relationalism in efficacious practice manifest the germ or nuance of the apophatic already at work, really *working*, within historical worlds of indeterminate interdependence. If so then at least one side of the chiasmus of apophatic entanglement has become *explicate*—it unfolds. It manifests a *manifold justice* and a *constituent connectivity* operating in tandem with the *mindful nonknowing* of the present project. More recent voices will exercise the negative capability of their relationalities ever more deliberately.⁵³ So the question remains—how does that later negative theology, within the genealogy of its own much more antique history, drive the other side of the chiasmus? How for its part would the apophatic lineage have in itself the potentiality to foster and not only negate a robust relationalism?

UNSAING THEOLOGY

Not powerful, not power,

Not light,

Not living, not life,

Not being

—DIONYSIUS THE AREOPAGITE, MYSTICAL THEOLOGY

If theology begins with its own possible impossibility, it is in no position to offer itself as a firm foundation. The shaking will not desist. The flooding washes out the knowing words. The traditional formulae of faith may reassure, but the traditions themselves are desperate for reassurance, twisting in cycles of lost hope and junk faith. The know-it-all of religion only provide more fodder for the know-it-alls of science, and, in between, a vast know-nothingness, systemically produced as ignorance of its own ignorance, makes a mockery of democratic difference.

At such impasses, how likely is it that theology can be of help? Even among religiously engaged intellectuals one cannot miss the increasing impatience with the theos of liberation. Each, the *God of the Oppressed*, the *God/ess*, *She Who Is*, folds into a context; each remains a splendid irruption of language on edge, each unsaying whole histories of the oversaid. If they turn into slogans, so much the

better: that means they are making a difference beyond the academy. But do these positive names also morph into that “thing of the theologian”—albeit now a just, ecological, tender, perhaps erotic, female or queer being, but surely “some kind of being.” Really positive. But without the negative gesture, without the nuance of unknowing, does one feel pressed toward Jamesian overbelief and so sucked toward unbelief?

Because these fresh and multiplying metaphors communicate a poetics of relation, urgent and alive, I want them credible. These are *metaphors* of God. But these are metaphors of *God*. And to say so leaves “God” somehow there, waiting to receive the transfers (*meta-phora*) of fresh attributes. The unquestioned Entity, cross-dressing for our particular party. Mirroring us back to ourselves, enlarged. No way out of the enigma. As long as we recognize the mirror play, perhaps we remain good post-Feuerbachian theologians, mindful of our projections. But projections onto—just what? Once revealed, has it congealed? In the meantime the intellectual force continues—for centuries—to drain out of the theological world.

For this reason the ancient lineage and practice of unsaying God, of saying away not only another’s idolatry but one’s own certainty, is making a theological return. It comes, however, mainly through *philosophy*, there where the tropes of the “death of God,” Hegelian and Nietzschean, came home to roost. And to continue to *raise* the question of God. So where a mere postmortem had been expected comes instead a ferment, a cascade, of *theological philosophy*—of Bataille’s passionate negation, of Derrida’s bottomless nuance; then so close to theology as to slip across the philosophical boundary—of Caputo’s weakness and then insistence of God; with Vattimo of God after the death of God; of Kearney’s atheism—God *after* God; of radical theology building its particular death of God into political *theology*.⁵⁴ And, make no mistake, it is a conversation charged with its own ethical passions for justice, for a great democratic pluralism. As Clayton Crockett poses the question: “What would it mean to think divinity as democracy?”⁵⁵ For the most part, however, the regnant poststructuralism has disregarded (as ontological, as metaphysical, as physical, as cosmological, as sentimental) relation itself. It has not attended to that relation of which Édouard Glissant says “‘Being is relation’: but Relation is safe from the idea of Being.” Yet

it is especially to poststructuralist retrievals, however ambivalent, that we owe the contemporary effervescence of so-called negative theology. But first let us touch upon its historical sources.

THE FLY IN THE ABYSS: NEGATIVE THEOLOGY

Negative theology was itself born in its Christian format as a hybrid of Greek Neoplatonism and Hebraic narrative. “For in what concerns God,” as Cyril of Jerusalem put it in the fourth century, “to confess our ignorance is the best knowledge.”⁵⁶ Socrates’ “know that you do not know” has been baptized. “For we explain not what God *is* but candidly confess that we have not exact knowledge concerning Him.”⁵⁷ Confession is a language of *relationship* to this not-known divinity. Of course some Him-Being is presumed. That is not surprising. What is more startling is how explicitly the explanatory “God is,” the slippage toward essentialism, was already recognized and resisted from within—right there, in the formative matrix of Christian theology as such. Within this relation of self-conscious ignorance there is no pure negation. An absolute unknowing would deprive the candid confession of all content. How would I know that God is unknowable if I did not know myself to be in relation to . . . something, someone that somehow answers to the revelatory God-words.

These early thinkers, such as Cyril, Gregory of Nyssa, the other Cappadocians, were making theology possible, at the edge of its own cultural improbability. In the throes of the late antiquity of a fickle empire and a mobile Christian Jewish movement they merged, building on Philo Judaeus, certain permutations of Platonism with a scriptural fount of metaphors, filtered through the Judaism of the unpronounceable YHWH. “To confess our ignorance,” far from silencing discourse, is to complicate it with an alternative knowing.

Of course one might ask—do they *mean* it? When they ask their readers to confess their own ignorance, is it not always in the name of the Truth? The performance of a humble unknowing finitude before the infinite might seem to cash out as “don’t ask questions. It’s a mystery.” When that happens, we have to do with epistemic closure, not apophatic disclosure. No escaping it: mystery will have lent itself to mystification; producing knowledge/power well before natural philoso-

phy or science took the lead. We are contemplating ancestral resources for theological honesty—not a return to a pure origin. There won't be any way here out of this complicity in alien contexts. So the appeal to ancestral relation means here not to bolster authority but the energy of relation itself.

There is no pure unsaying, no ultimately purifying negation, even by way of a pure atheism. For it would *know* what it is that certainly *is* not. So when pop atheism comes up with the stereotypes of a supernatural Being in a transcendent Heaven intervening arbitrarily, it is *presuming* the very image of what both early apophatic theologies and late relational ones have *negated*. There is neither a pure nothing nor a pure something available to the apophatic relation. If such an absolute outside, absolved from relation, exists as being or as not-being, we can say nothing about it—least of all that it “exists.” “Nonbeing could not be except outside Relation.”⁵⁸

“The term apophasis,” writes Michael Sells, “is commonly paired with kataphasis (affirmation, saying, speaking-with). Every act of unsaying demands or presupposes a previous saying.”⁵⁹ The unsaying negates the substantialized signifier, but not that which dis/closes itself before or after congealing into a substance. But then it is not as though language can carve out and conserve its live meaning. It would only again be capturing an essence. Like “saving fish from drowning.”⁶⁰ But then the aporia lies at the tangled heart of language—and has been signified *in* language over and over, as in the Jewish name of the nameless—like Hashem, like gospel parables or Daoist ironies or Zen koans. But every icon might harden into idol. Every truth may turn propositional, every revelation orthodox. The question is whether they get stuck there, in the modalities of cliché, commodification, conquest. Over time, therefore, the iconoclastic impulse within the apophatic heritage sharpened correspondingly.

In the thirteenth century, for instance, we register the startling flash of the negation: “if you love God as he is God, as he is spirit, as he is person and as he is image—all this must go!”⁶¹ “All this” is pretty much: theology. No wonder Meister Eckhart was compared by Suzuki to a Zen master.

Lovely also that Eckhart died shortly before the authorities could do him in. Not so Marguerite de Porete, who also plucked “God” out of all stereotypes, finding a Lady Love, an erotic Minne or Far-Near nonseparable from her own “annihilated I.” Whether or not she anticipated her own literal annihilation, she was not

unprepared for it.⁶² Eckhart seems to have read Porete's proscribed manuscript at the Dominican headquarters in Paris, where he too would later face the inquisitors. Neither the substance of the ego nor of the deity survives these thinkers. In his language God as *Gotttheit* undergoes the most radical desubstantialization: the ground of God, which is the ground also of soul, becomes *Ungrund*, the abyss of an infinite from which all things flow, indeed overflow. To mistake that ultimate no-thingness for a simple nothing, a mere negation (a proto-atheism) is to lose its nuance and therefore its radicality. After all it is not only a dearth but a style of God-talk that provokes the inquisitors.

"Were it the case that a fly had reason and could rationally seek out the eternal abyss of divine being, from which it came forth, we say that God, insofar as he is God, could not fulfill or satisfy the fly. Therefore pray God that we may be free of God."⁶³

That impossible theologoumenon—at least as iconoclastic as anything we feminist theologians uttered in the eighties—revels in the unspeakable. Its second sentence became a motto for theological poststructuralism. Caputo, once a monk himself, wrote his dissertation on Eckhart and Heidegger, and places the former in the pantheon of "radical hermeneutics." He frequently refers to Eckhart's "breakthrough," which "must have felt like a 'breakdown.'"⁶⁴

Eckhart exemplifies Sells' distinction between "apophatic theory" and "apophatic discourse." The Meister "affirms the ultimate ineffability of the transcendent" but does not turn back on itself; the latter not only asserts but performs unnameability.⁶⁵ With its performative jolts, this discourse interrupts the smooth production of the other as object by a metaphysics of substance or, for that matter, by a popular literalism. We will recognize this turning back on the self as the *self-implication* of apophatic entanglement.

Eckhart has his fly perform her idol-smash in our hearing; theology thus turns God against God. "Apophasis is a discourse in which any single proposition is acknowledged as falsifying, as reifying. It is a discourse of double propositions, in which meaning is generated through the tension between the saying and the unsaying."⁶⁶ Apophatic discourse, in other words, does not acquiesce in ineffability—in the mystery of a transcendence just too awesomely big for the language of us finite creatures. The irritating fly insults the Majesty of God and of His theologians. We might further surmise that the fly is unsatisfied by what is called

God—because she has never constructed such a Being: “insofar (*inquantum*) as he is God.” Remember the minor bug when we come to consider the minimal quantum.

Deconstruction, a fly in the ointment of any smooth ontology, circles close to the abyss of the apophatic. Though Derrida has earlier, and with reason, refused to identify deconstruction with negative theology, in “Sauf le nom” he yields to admiration for the entire lineage. He had been musing on the Pseudo-Dionysian legacy, and also on an Augustinian sense of confession beforehand, as it streams toward the protagonist of the essay, the Baroque Silesius. But when Derrida nails the radicality of this tradition he has especially Eckhart in mind: “whence the courage and the dissidence, potential or actual, of these masters (think of Eckhart), whence the persecution they suffered at times, whence their passion, whence this scent of heresy, these trials, this subversive marginality of the apophatic current in the history of theology and of the Church.”⁶⁷

Eckhart’s writing flows from a lineage that as a self-implicating discourse can be said to find its crystallization in the slim sixth or seventh century corpus of Dionysus the Areopagite. The apophatic influence of this pseudonymous Asian monk on centuries of theologians Eastern and Western, heretical and orthodox, remains (even if one can count the seventeen hundred references to him in Aquinas) incalculable.⁶⁸ The divinity undergoes in *The Mystical Theology* a relentless unsaying of anything one can say of it: “It is not sonship or fatherhood and it is nothing known to us or to any other being.”⁶⁹ And that is only a morsel of his unknowing . . . The continuity with Eckhart is unmistakable. The apophatic procedure, which as we will see in its cloud lineage circulates back over Sinai, internalized the Hebraic critique of idols in a new way. It directs its iconoclasm against its own theo-logos, against “the thing of the theologian.”

The tradition—Mosaic and Neoplatonic—remains, needless to say, overwhelmingly patrilineal. And yet, with nothing that one could call (apart, rather vaguely, from Porete, Hadewijch, and other Beguines) a protofeminist intention, all the andronyms come undone. The familiar divine names of the He-Person do come unsaid, without being erased. They will be rendered, later, “analogies” incapable of delivering direct or certain knowledge of God. Thus the *via negativa* worked its way into the great Thomist synthesis with positive doctrinal utterances. And its third “way of eminence” has been indispensable, not surprisingly, to the

feminist theology of the late twentieth century. Elizabeth Johnson has negated with magnanimity the specific idolatry of masculine God-talk. She performs this apophasis precisely not as mere negation but inasmuch as the he-language is used “exclusively, literally, or oppressively.” She lodges Aquinas’ dictum (anticipated we saw by Cyril) at the heart of feminist theology: “we know not *what* but only *that* God is.” The “what” is the “is” of essence—the knowable substance. Like Eckhart, Johnson has survived inquisition. The metaphors affirmatively proposed—in a trinity of Spirit Sophia, Mother Sophia, Jesus Sophia—remain self-implicatingly metaphor: they do not congeal into the sort of discrete persons and univocal assertions they replace. Because her feminism is inseparable from an ontological relationalism, and does not absorb the Thomist essentialism, she remains indispensable to our cloud chiasmus: for here a contemporary relationalism locates itself explicitly, genealogically, at a juncture with the *via negativa*. “Divine nature exists as an incomprehensible mystery of relation.”⁷⁰

Such theology cannot however in its moment abide long with its own apophatic deconstructions. It quickly and courageously reconstructs, befitting an analogical practice and an im/possible feminist transformation of Christendom. As Johnson derives her negative capability from Thomas, God remains quite substantial. She ministers to passionately dissident Christians. So does the cloud. But it also offers hospitality to those whose faith is more kin to deconstruction. So we push further, after the fly, into the luminous shadows.

MORE THAN IMPOSSIBLE

When Derrida first chose to confront the relation of deconstruction to negative theology, it was to Dionysius the Areopagite that he turned. Within an early twentieth-century philosophical context richly inflected by French neo-Thomism, negative theology had already undergone a certain revival. But for the young Derrida the engagement with structuralism was paramount, and any dalliance with the mysticism that had originally attracted him was potentially disastrous. “Very early I was accused of—rather than congratulated for—resifiting the procedures of negative theology.”⁷¹ He here quells any identification of deconstruction with theology, no matter how negative. Derrida is concerned instead to perform his own negation: “No, what I write is not negative theology.”⁷² He

exposes the implication of the tradition in the classical essentialism that it might be thought—with its *not*-being, *not*-one—to have itself exceeded. He does not congratulate the tradition at its most radical, in its movement beyond essentialism, *hyperousia*. Instead he mistranslates “beyond essence” as *hyperessentialism*. The language used to move *beyond* being is reduced to an inflation *of* being. One must ask if the essentialization is being performed less by the ancient text than by the Derridean reading. And yet even as he denies deconstructive street cred to those mystics he cannot let them go.

Theology of course does not need philosophical permission to engage its own ancestors. But it is the case that later, in “Sauf le nom”—punning on a saving that is also a negating, the name that is everything “but the name”—Derrida offers a more hospitable reading. It is written (in the vicinity of his dying mother) in intimacy with of Silesius’s eighteenth-century *Cherubinic Wanderer*, a theopoetry greatly influenced by Eckhart. He now admits that he “trust(s) no text that is not in some way contaminated with negative theology, and even among those texts that apparently do not have, want, or believe they have any relation with theology in general.”⁷³ It is perhaps here that I cease to trust any theology that is not in some way contaminated with deconstruction. This is not accidentally the period of his so-called ethical turn, a turn more messianic than apophatic, but not so as to disentangle the twin impulses. They will be recognizable in the cloud as two emanations of the same much older desert. “Would you go so far as to say that today there is a ‘politics’ and a ‘law’ of negative theology?” he asks himself. “A juridico-political lesson to be drawn from the possibility of this theology?” (81). No, he answers “not to be deduced as from a program, from premises or axioms. But there would no more be any ‘politics,’ ‘law,’ or ‘morals’ *without* this possibility, the very possibility that obliges us from now on to place these words between quotation marks. Their sense will have trembled” (81).

Derrida here recognizes the subversive space “of this bottomless collapse, of this endless desertification of language” (56). His metonymic desert connotes not the sterility of nonlife but the biblical wild place of exodus, contemplative retreat, and messianic coming.

The cloud-figure of negative theology, as we will trace it in the next chapter from a third-century Cappadocian exegesis of the Exodus, first of all crystallizes coolingly over the desert. Pressing close to the planetary relationalism of the liberation legacy, Derrida signals the “common desert . . . the chance of universal

peace” as the unlikely future raised by the via negative (81). This chance—*the possibility*—drives the “democracy to come,” the justice that is “as undeconstructable as the possibility itself of deconstruction.”⁷⁴ The “to come” of the “messianicity without a messiah”—without, that is, a reified person, god, being—energizes an irresistibly evolving sense of the im/possible.

“The most impossible is possible.” Thus Silesius. Derrida now concedes in negative theology something “strangely familiar to the experience of what is called deconstruction . . . the very experience of the (impossible) possibility of the impossible.”⁷⁵ When he translates it “hyperimpossibility” (as a compliment) he can only be mimicking his earlier accusation of hyperessentialism. The hyperimpossible is the “more than impossible, possible because more impossible than the impossible.” He concludes with the potent invocation, far from paralysis and kin to the Cherubicin theopoiesis, of “the greatest power of the possible.”⁷⁶

As to the indubitably undissolved difference between deconstruction and apophasis, Kevin Hart early offered a chiasm within the chiasm: “My position is not that deconstruction is a form of negative theology but that negative theology is a form of deconstruction.”⁷⁷ This works—if and only if we may consider deconstruction a procedure for the reading of constructions as such. Theology as theopoiesis—God-speech as God-constructing—makes its affirmations not as mirrors of an entity but as enigmatic coconstructions. “God” will remain willy-nilly one overdetermined way of protecting difference from reduction to the predetermined. Not just the classic difference of God from the material world, but the difference of whichever worldly entanglement is most mattering. All positive theology—except perhaps the more positivist forms—bears the traces of distributive difference: God is not just loving but the Love by which any fragile difference is cherished. So if this deconstructive apophasis returns now with some sense of urgency, it will come contaminated—entrained—with some positively relational language: Mother Sophia, Black Christ, Queer God and all.

Does the apophatic now minister to the experience of the possible impossibility of theology itself? As Derrida says, “the other, that is, God or no matter who . . . For the most difficult, indeed the impossible, dwells there: there where the other loses his name or is able to change it in order to become no matter what other.”⁷⁸ *No matter what other*—as Derrida announces in another theological contemplation, neighboring Kierkegaard’s “faith in the impossible” in a reach of

desert denuded of any mystical cloud: “If God is completely other, the figure or name of the wholly other, then every other (one) is every (bit) other.”⁷⁹ *Tout autre est tout autre*. So then the sheer transcendence of Kierkegaard’s wholly other God “is to be found everywhere there is something of the wholly other. And since each of us, every one else, each other is infinitely other in its absolute singularity, inaccessible, solitary, transcendent, nonmanifest, originary nonpresent to my ego . . . then what can be said about Abraham’s relation to God can be said about my relation without relation to every other (one) as every (bit) other.”⁸⁰ Transcendence thus radically redistributes itself without being cancelled. We might sense here the im/possibility in Derridean terms of an apophatic relation of difference itself. Then “to become no matter what other” might, in another neighborhood, signify the different names by which to call upon that which enfolds all those others. Is there not a hint here of our missing fold of the apophatic into the relational?

In this distribution of the Other into and as every possible other, do we sense the life and movement of the crowded manifold, the terrestrial multiplicity? Might the *any* unfold the mattering *many*? Does difference of “any other” begin to expose, just at its threshold, the density of its folds? *Possibly*. But the “other” readily locks into a dyad—mere separation. Or the “any” collapses into an indifferent mass—mere sameness. And deconstruction, even in its antiquity as negative theology, does not much attend to the shrieking socialities making us up as subjects or as worlds. Too material, too cosmological, too many? The language on this apophatic side of our chiasmus remains elegantly bare of the cosmic crowds. But under cloud cover they may be sneaking into its desert.

Derrida, very close to the end of his life, returning once more to negative theology, again breaks open an im/possible. Just in passing, he calls upon “a theological vein, in the work of Böhme, Bruno, Nicholas of Cusa, that defines God not as being . . . but as ‘perhaps.’”⁸¹ I was surprised, accustomed to Derrida ignoring this particular vein (as, no doubt, too metaphysical).⁸² “According to a potentiality or a dynamis, a *posse* they call it—the word is theirs—a *posse* that no longer depends on the metaphysical definition of the possible.”⁸³

Posse ipsum, “possibility itself,” is the theme of Cusa’s own last text. It was his final favorite name for God. It appears as the possibility which is the *ability*—realized, actualized, by the *creature*: “What child or youth does not know *Posse Itself*,

since each says one can eat, one can run, or one can speak?”⁸⁴ This agency, this “can do,” answers, as we will see in chapter 3, to a certain effect of that which he had called, following the way of his *docta ignorantia*, the cloud of impossibility.

In what follows the chiasmus of crowd and cloud will depend upon a Cusan crossing. For we shall see that it was in the current of his negative theology that there takes place, perhaps for the first time in Christian thought, a *theological cosmology of relation*. Through his teaching of an infinite *complicatio*, and its manifold *explicatio*, there occurs the explicit formulation of a perspective that until the twentieth century’s emergence of theological relationalism had little possible public: that constituent interdependence that makes its fleeting appearance in Cusa as “all in all and each in each.”

And therefore the present work, in its *coincidentia oppositorum* of deconstructive negation and affirmative interrelation, will find in a fifteenth-century ancestor a haunting foldover. Not thereby, of course, an origin or an aim. For the beginnings and the ends of theory, as of its unfolding theos, do not cease their mutual complication.



She had to think how to put it. “Well, I’m impossible. It’s impossible. Everything’s impossible.” He looked at her an instant. “I see where you’re coming out. Everything’s possible.”

—HENRY JAMES, *THE AMBASSADORS*

And so as relational theology showed its apophatic edge in prophetic practices, the apophatic heritage yields a deep dynamism of relation. If the cloud will offer for a while the contemplative space—hospice or feast—of a theologically entangled hospitality, it may help us to activate uncertainty as *possibility*. Acute historical limitation yields unexpectedly to some animacy of becoming.⁸⁵ If then the cloud chiasmus we seek precipitates a new alliance for the indeconstructible justice, that is, for the barely speakable hope of a planetary conviviality across our species, our sexes, our spirited materializations, it is as an opening into a more densely crowded entanglement than any deconstruction, however theological, could host on its own. The nonknowing of what is nicknamed God is “an incom-

prehensible mystery of relation,” crossing chiasmically over into the unknowable margins of our most intimately known relations.

Fold after fold. If it is a mindful nonknowing that might save (us from) the name of God, it rescues a space for the uncertainty of our God-relation and so of theology. And it holds a space *for* theology. This possible impossibility of theology lets us mind the specific uncertainty of any relation—when it matters. We may then attend knowingly to the nonknowing into which, at each crisis of relation, our nonseparable difference plunges us. The truth we then test, the troth we pledge, plies a mindfulness of our interdependence and at the same time a patience, sometimes even a pleasure, in its enigmatic excess. I am guessing that right there, in that very fold, cracks open some possibility, however minor, that had appeared as the impossible. Then is activated the ability—*posse ipsum*—and therefore the response-ability to transmute a knotted indeterminacy into a vibrant network. Chaos sifts chiasmically into “the chaosmos of Alle”: a bit of world comes unsnarled but stays entangled.⁸⁶

For the nuance of beginning, for the fly in the abyss, for the mindful, wrenching and collective materializations of the im/possible now: is there time? Is there space? Only “in an unknown that does not terrify us.”⁸⁷ Here would begin ever again, amidst whatever cloud confronts us, the practice of an apophatic entanglement.



two

CLOUD-WRITING

A GENEALOGY OF THE LUMINOUS DARK

For with your question you have brought me into that same darkness, into that same cloud of unknowing where I would you were yourself.

—THE CLOUD OF UNKNOWING

TIME HAS TURNED DIGITAL, POINTILLIST. What of its clouds? What of the folds and tangles of the past within the present? Without the layered past of its texts theology also turns to digits, its literality fixed upon entities—“the people,” “God”—abstracted from their own context and therefore from ours. If I summon the mists of theological time, it is by way of apologia for the backwards motion of this chapter and the next. They do not present a historical summation or definitive typology of negative theology, let alone an orthodox pedigree. They do attempt a genealogy of the apophatic figure of the cloud. Mistier than Foucault’s genealogy, this history complicates the times of its subjects with the anachronistic present: *this* momentary perspective, requiring its interchange between a forward-facing relationalism and the archaicism of the mystical darkness. So in this chapter we follow the trail of the originary cloud as it folds explicitly into certain currents of negative theology.

The path begins over a millennium earlier than what is named negative theology. I will not be able to do justice to the Jewish hermeneutics of the cloud, but nonetheless we begin in the Sinai. There Moses pulls away from the crowd to climb

the mountain—and meet God in the cloud. The swerve from the Exodus event into what appears to be an opposing discourse, that of the mystical discourse of Christian Neoplatonism, can only take place within an atmosphere charged with a dissonance, an electricity of unrealized expectation. Nor can we here plumb the Greek sources; but certain traces of their own complexity will flash through. So we head first to the desert scene and its midrashic aftermath; then to the reappearance of the cloud in Alexandria, leading to its rich exegesis in Gregory of Nyssa; to the dazzling darkness of the pseudonymous Dionysius; then to the anonymous *Cloud of Unknowing*. Traces of Moses, Plato, and Paul, especially he of the journey to Athens, may appear at any juncture. The trail leads to the threshold of the next chapter where, through Nicholas of Cusa, a cosmological relationalism is born from the womb of the “sacred ignorance.” But in a positively erotic tension of “distance and proximity, alterity and intimacy,”¹ negative theology, itself a rendition of the unpronounceable tetragrammaton, makes its earlier appearance.

DESERT CLOUD

*Then the people stood at a distance, while Moses drew near
to the dark cloud where God was.*

—EXODUS 20:21

The book of Exodus features a theatrical series of new encounters between Moses and his I AM. The people arrived in the wilderness of Sinai on the “third new moon” after the escape from slavery, in one long sea-parting story of the impossible. “Now they have heard that You, O Lord, are in the midst of this people; that you, O Lord, appear in plain sight when your cloud rests over them and when you go before them in a pillar of cloud by day and in a pillar of fire by night.”² In this mobile chiasmus the darkness-in-light oscillates with the light-in-darkness. Far from cloaking an inaccessible transcendence, the cloud reveals the entangled immanence: “in the midst.” But this “plain sight” signified by “your cloud” lends its own cover.

And then the cloud enwraps an entire mountain. Moses “went up to God”—and in a courteous reciprocity, “YHWH called to him from the mountain.” Everything is now at stake—the people have made their great getaway. Here is the

kairos, the chance to “keep my covenant.” The chance reverberates through time, in the unlikely *kairoi* ever since, when we have escaped another slave state, a foreign empire, holocaust, wall, apartheid, national security state, even a pharaoh in Egypt, one recent spring . . . After a triumphant exodus—“see how I bore you on eagles wings and brought you to myself”—the work of the future begins. Now it will not be *they* who stand in our way, but we ourselves. The indeterminacy of the promise is upon us: “if you hear my voice and keep my covenant . . .”

YHWH made a date to meet Moses in the darkness of the cloud. Hidden in plain view. The plan is not for an intimate mystical communion *à deux*, but for a complicated public mediation. “I am going to come to you in a dense cloud, in order that the people may hear when I speak with you and so trust you ever after.”³ In other words the cloud, like the transmitter for a paranormal experiment, would make this encounter audible. I AM arrived at the appointed hour, accompanied by fabulous sound and light effects: “thunder, and lightening, as well as a thick cloud on the mountain, and a blast of the trumpet [*shofar*] so loud that all the people who were in the camp trembled.”⁴ In this *tremendum*, in awe or terror, they must trust Moses to translate. So they stood back, while he “drew near to the *araphel* (‘cloud, heavy or dark cloud, darkness, thick darkness’) where God was.”

This God-place will become the later site of intense hermeneutics. Clouds pervade the biblical theophanies. Indeed “‘the glory’ (*kavod*) of God appears in the form of a cloud.” For “the glory of the Lord abode on Mt. Sinai and the cloud hid it for six days.” Hidden in plain sight, the *kavod* emits its brilliance in and through the darkness of the cloud. “While the cloud, the pillar of cloud, and the cloud appearing with the *kavod* are generally discrete images in the Bible, the midrashim quickly assimilate the three.” The “clouds of glory” of the Tannaitic midrashim (compiled by the mid third century CE) became writable as the very Shekhinah (from *shakan*, to dwell), the “Indwelling Presence,” of God: *anan shekhinah*, “the cloud of the presence.” And “the dominant characteristic of the clouds of glory,” we read, is not terror, not secrecy, not incomprehensibility, but “protection.”⁵

In the dense metonymy of ancient rabbinic writing, the mercy of shade in a desert assimilates the cloud to a “tabernacle” or “booth” (*sukkah*, pl. *sukkot*) in the Second Temple period, where the clouds morph into “a forcefield that surrounds the camps.”⁶ Protecting the people from human enemies and nonhuman wilderness, the cloud “poignantly expresses love, harmony, and intimacy.” The clouds of

glory are then also compared to a bridal canopy, the festive sukkot of erotic consummation.⁷ In Daniel's vision of the Messiah, "one like a human being came with the clouds of heaven."⁸ The feminine Shekhinah, the masculinity of Moses, and then the Messiah cloudily queer the *kavod*. One might say that the cloud enfolds or invaginates the divine in worldly immanence; at the same time it shields the finite creatures from the divine power, even as it would protect creatures—if only it could—from their mutual violations. Neither material nor immaterial, both awe-ful and intimate, this soft heaven was read, amidst circumstances of migrant risk and perpetual diaspora, to offer safe haven.

"Glory gleams in the midst of ambiguous situations and common experiences, in flesh and matter—in finitude."⁹ As Mayra Rivera reads the Mosaic epiphany at the burning bush, it remains "susceptible to appropriation and counterfeit, as much as to simple disregard." Not without shekhinic ripples, this glory cannot be abstracted "from realities of injustice, from the vulnerability of flesh." She infers polydoxically: "Glory is the trace of a divine relationship woven through creaturely life and its relationships. It is the cloudy radiance of the ungraspable excess that inheres in ordinary things—something that manifests itself, that gives itself." So she concludes, with a more broadly incarnational invagination than either Jewish or Christian orthodoxy might sanction, that it can "appropriately be called divine glory, as long as its divinity keeps materializing in earthly grounds, becoming vulnerable flesh."¹⁰

For the sake of that earthly flesh, the darkly brilliant texture of the cloud unfolds on Sinai its text of right relation. Yet those ten imperatives of Torah seem hardly cloudy. For good measure the editors return Moses to the scene rather quickly, in this take leaving him in the cloud—far removed from the crowd—for forty days and forty nights. And now, in this patriarchal powwow of Moses and the Lord, the law is written in stone.¹¹ Note, however, that this prolonged contemplative time is not a retroprojection of a later Hellenistic style of mysticism. In the separation from the crowd, it paradoxically marks the apex of the hyperrelational narrative of the Exodus. The relation to the dramatically Other comes altogether entangled in a new relation to the human others, for which it carves out the minimal social terms. The event of the liberation, the wandering, the mountaintop epiphany have chiselled the ethics of inescapable relation ambiguously and indelibly into history.

Flashing outward in the turbulent exodoi of human collectives, folding inward, in the meditative quiet of the luminous cloud, the text of the cloud—or is it a trail of clouds?—travels to this day. Between the letters of these laws we recognize an outline and a discipline for a just and sustainable conviviality, for life-together beyond tribal origins and between empires. If we now read the later Christian contemplative itinerary with an ear to the midrashic echo, the difference of context and discourse roars. But, as Daniel Boyarin points out, the midrashim evince their own “powerful rendition of an apophatic hermeneutic.”¹² He considers, for instance, Rabbi Akiva’s commentary on a story of Moses’ own incomprehension “a powerful rendition of an apophatic hermeneutic.” That story is too subtle to tell in this context. But “at about the same time that Moses was being told to be quiet and recognize that there is much that human beings cannot know,” Boyarin notes that “Gregory of Nyssa was elaborating his theology of language and interpretation.”¹³

THE MULTITUDE OF ONE

*And when the Scripture says, “Moses entered into the thick darkness where God was,”
this shows to those capable of understanding, that God is invisible
and beyond expression by words.*

—CLEMENT OF ALEXANDRIA

As a new form of Judaism morphs and spreads in the first centuries of the epoch that would be called Christian, Moses keeps being spotted in the dark cloud. In, for example, the hermeneutics of Clement of Alexandria, in Egypt, an early theologian who all too symbolically was born in Athens (150 CE) and died in Jerusalem (215 CE), fresh discursive potentialities crystallize. His own writing was influenced by the discourse of the unnameable originated by an earlier Alexandrian, Philo Judaeus (20 BCE–50 CE). That diasporic cosmopolitan had effected the first great synthesis of Hellenistic philosophy and scriptural revelation.

Philo would inaugurate that transmutation of the One God into Being that can be called ontotheology. And in a different vein, by way of a mid-platonic play of paradox brought to the foot of Mt. Sinai, he launches a new speech of God as

the unspeakable and the inexpressible. “Thus,” he writes, “the voice says to Moses ‘I am that I am,’ which is equivalent to saying, ‘It is my nature to be, not to be described by name:’ but in order that the human race may not be wholly destitute of any appellation which they may give to the most excellent of beings, I allow you to use the Lord as a name.”¹⁴ Philo is sometimes dubbed “the father of negative theology.”¹⁵ He remains at the same time munificently positive in his development of the method of allegory. As Christian supersessionism hardened in subsequent centuries, however, (non-Christian) Judaism abandoned the Platonic adaptations of scriptural narrative. It opted instead, as Boyarin has demonstrated, for a distinctive rabbinic discourse (at least until the medieval emergence of the densely Neoplatonic Kabbalah). The rabbis developed a freshly relational language for the unspeakable tetragrammaton—the nameless one called Hashem, the name.

Platonism continued to develop as a pagan philosophy, while Judaism, largely then through its Christian apologists, complicated the intellectual paradigm of the Greco-Roman world. Even as it registered as incarnate and as triune, the One lifted ever higher, into the mystical summits of ineffability. Yet the one was always already “beyond being” in Plato—*epekteina ousios*. Here originates the problematic, as noted in the last chapter, of the *hyperousia*.

There was, however, already something oddly inimical with what is called Platonism going on in the late Plato, something later captured and intensified in multiple Neoplatonic commentaries on Plato’s *Parmenides*. I can here only register it in a couple of startling bits from that late dialogue. Here he dialectically undoes the very notion of the One and its Being. For, he argues, if the One *is*, it *has being*—which is then something other than the One, which *has* it. “Therefore the One in no sense *is*.”¹⁶ The one, the One, is *not*? And with relentless wit, Plato—in the persona of the original Parmenides credited with the first formulation of monism, of reality as “One Being” changelessly the same—cracks open the One itself: “For it appears, then, that unity itself is parceled out by being, and is not only many, but indefinitely numerous.”¹⁷ It is as though Plato in this late dialogue (which he refers to as “playthings”) offers a deconstruction of the very legacy of the sixth-century Eleatic identification of Being as the One and so of the static ontotheology that would freeze into “Platonism.” And, riveted to the contradictions, the paradox, the exposed *impossibility* of its logic, the commentaries—by

Plotinus, Porphyry, Proclus—multiply, distributing a fresh language of the ineffable.

“We find ourselves in an aporia, in pangs at trying to speak. We speak of the unspeakable; wishing to signify it as best we can, we name it.”¹⁸ In his fifth *Ennead* Plotinus names this experience “apophatic.”¹⁹ Here in another Egyptian interpreter of Plato, writing in the third century as neither a Jew nor a Christian, occurs the monumental unfolding of the One, which is identical with the Good, in its emanation as Mind and as Soul. Centuries of Platonism are enfolded in a contemplative mysticism, producing ecstatically nondualist events of oneness with this One: “The one is all things but no thing.”²⁰ It would be called Neoplatonism and effected an elastic fold between negative and positive theological language.²¹ But in Plotinus the knowledge *that* “there [is] One” is hardly positive: it is knowledge of the whence of all; in Pierre Hadot’s terms, “the One is utter gratuity of that which gives.”²² Its One remains simple, transcendent of all multiplicity; yet the Many emanate from it not as caused *ex nihilo* or extrinsically, but as *itself*—the One is to multiplicity as white light is to the spectrum of a rainbow.

The mainstream Platonism of simple, impassive, changeless unity, however, dominates Western logos all along in its Christian and its secular logics of the One. So we continue to wonder: do its apophatic margins then service that sovereign transcendence, by rendering it inaccessible, distant, unquestionable? Or do they in their textual generativity betray a more nuanced “touch of transcendence” (Rivera)? Indeed do they actually *unsay* the One and energize a proto-deconstruction of its reifications? How would we answer that question without ourselves reifying the terms by which such a question is posed, now, after such long historical complication?

We will take refuge in the figure of the cloud. It lets Clement advance the Alexandrian legacy of Philo and then of Origen, Clement’s own student. It is he who would render the negative way an integral strategy of Christian theology. He is so moved by certain resonances between biblical and Greek insights into the divine unknowability that he floats the theory that Plato, and before him Pythagoras and Orpheus, had availed themselves of Moses’ teachings. When Clement interprets Moses’ entry into the thick darkness, he couples him with “the truth-loving Plato,” as having claimed of the “Father and Maker of this universe” that “it is impossible to declare Him to all. For this is by no means capable of expression.”²³

For, Clement claims with a certain intertextual impossibility, Plato “had read well that the all-wise Moses, ascending the mount for holy contemplation, necessarily commands that the whole people do not accompany him.” Designating the dark cloud as the “unbelief and ignorance of the multitude,” Clement cites the legendary “Orpheus, the theologian” as poetic source: “Him see I not, for round about, a cloud / Has settled.”

Such a creative coalescence of cloud tropes can only of course momentarily occlude the tension between scriptural and Greek sensibilities. William Franke, introducing a magisterial synopsis of “what cannot be said,” captures the tension handily: “Whereas Plotinus’s highest One, his ‘first hypostasis,’ based on the ‘first hypothesis’ of the *Parmenides*, is *absolutely relationless*, the God of Abrahamic monotheistic religions is *intimately in relation with all things*: he creates and providentially sustains them in being. Relationality is essential to the Being of this God.” In contrast, he notes, in the Plotinian, Neoplatonic model, “relationality is relegated to lower ontological levels beneath the One—to Intellect and Mind”²⁴

Yet elements of Plotinus may fund the very sources of the relationalism soon thereafter anchored in the Christian trinity: In *Ennead* VI.8.15, lines 1–3, he says of the One/Good: “And he, that same self, is loveable (*erasmon*) and love (*eros*) and love of himself (*hautou eros*), in that he is beautiful only from himself and in himself.”²⁵ Lover, Beloved, and Love itself will appear as the three Persons in Augustine, and then Lover, Lovable, and Love in the apophatic analogue of Cusa. Whether the “in itself” seals the erotic complication into an unbecoming transcendence may remain in question. But we have to do then not with the tired, polemical opposition of “Jerusalem” to “Athens,” but with a tension besetting and stimulating the self-critically mystical interface between them. In the cloud-space, remembering Moses, Clement reminds his readers at the same time to remember Paul. This is Paul, never not a Jew, himself cunningly reminding the “men of Athens” of their own “altar on which was inscribed, To the Unknown God.”²⁶ The marble of the altar here serves as an alternate, a placeholder, for the place the whole tradition will track, the nebulous place “where God was.” The Pauline epistles represent indubitably the key biblical texts for the peculiar hybrid of Greek and Hebrew thought forming the condition of the possibility of Christian theology.

Christians in the Plotinian force field, from Justin Martyr to Clement, Origin, and, as we will see, Gregory of Nyssa, deployed their brilliant *theoria* to hold in relation to all that is—the unknowable One transcendent of all relation. The relation to its relationality is plied as thought, prayer, and ecstasy. The tension unfolding the present book, that of an apophatic relationality, means to unsay any separative transcendence, but the unsaying will come entangled in the alter-knowing, the darkening complexity, of the most transcendent early efforts.

THE DARK INFINITY

*When, therefore, Moses grew in knowledge, he declared that he had seen
God in the darkness, that is, that he had then come to know that what is divine
is beyond all knowledge and comprehension, for the text says,
Moses approached the dark cloud where God was.*

—GREGORY OF NYSSA

“What God?” asks Gregory of Nyssa, rereading the ancestral cloud. “He who made the darkness his hiding place, as David says, who was also initiated into the mysteries in the same inner sanctuary.”²⁷ Gregory intensifies attention to the darkness itself. In fourth-century Cappadocia, Moses is led “to the place where his intelligence lets him slip in where God is. This is called darkness by the Scripture, which signifies, as I said, the unknown and unseen.”²⁸ This darkness is different from Clement’s. It signifies not the place of unfaithful ignorance but quite the contrary: here he gains knowledge that God is beyond knowledge. Neither the sheer presence of the Shekhinah, nor the mere absence of the human crowd, the cloud is here transposed into the key of the Plotinian apophasis. The visibility of the invisible, the knowing of the unknowability of that which is to be comprehended, bursts into vision: “This is the true knowledge of what is sought; this is the seeing that consists in not seeing, because that which is sought transcends all knowledge, being separated on all sides by incomprehensibility as by a kind of darkness. Wherefore John the sublime, who penetrated into the luminous darkness [*photeino skotadi*], says, *No one has ever seen God.*”²⁹ And so here, as the

author of John's gospel slips into the cloud with Moses, Gregory offers the first utterance of that most radiant of *theologoumena*: the luminous darkness.

As biblical narrative is enfolded in Alexandrian allegory, light and dark, truth and incomprehension, divinity and cloud, now form a compact paradox. (One could almost call it a Christian midrash, if the rabbis were not by now crafting that genre in resistance to the allegorical method.) The peak experience of the Exodus becomes here indistinguishable from that of Plato's Republic: Moses' ascent to the top of Mt. Sinai becomes one with the ascent of the philosopher from the cave of ignorance. As "the mind progresses and . . . as it approaches more nearly to contemplation, it sees more clearly what of the divine nature is un contemplated."³⁰ Thus Denys Turner pegs Gregory as "that most Platonic of Christian Old Testament exegetes."³¹ "In both the Allegory and in Exodus," Turner notes, "there is an ascent toward the brilliant light, a light so excessive as to cause pain, distress and darkness: a darkness of knowledge deeper than any which is the darkness of ignorance."³² The darkness is like an overflow of light. But this is then no straightforward Platonism of ascending degrees of light. In the Republic the darkness meant the ignorance of the *hoi polloi* trapped in their cave, ridiculing the bearer of illumination. This is echoed in Clement's mid-Platonism, but not in Gregory's Neoplatonism.

In Gregory, as in Moses, the darkness, as seen "more clearly," is not a lack but a gain, whether in proximity or in comprehension. Toward those innocent of this interplay of light and darkness, for whom darkness, or blackness, can only mean ignorance, lack, or evil, Gregory remains pastoral. For "religious knowledge comes at first to those who receive it as light. Therefore what is perceived to be contrary to religion is darkness."³³ The identification of truth with light, with illumination, characterizes the *least* mature faith. To grow spiritually means here to outgrow this pious fear of the dark. Gregory can be said here to launch a radical challenge to what I have called elsewhere the light supremacism, which finds in Christianity both apocalyptic and philosophical forms.³⁴

Let me not, however, imply that this originaive apophasis, which unsays any neon literalism or theological reification, faithfully subverts doctrinal positivism. Gregory is a venerable father of orthodoxy and champion of the triumphant Nicene Trinitarianism against the hereticized followers of Arius. The emergence

of apophatic discourse in late antiquity is implicated in mounting disputations around the criteria of Christian truth. Gregory's greatest opponent was the neo-Arian Eunomius. Not unlike most later orthodoxy, Eunomius averred that humans can in a sense know God, through knowledge granted by God himself. But in the context of these debates the heretics might be the ones insisting on the knowability of God, while the orthodox might demand incomprehensibility. Virginia Burrus warns that "the mystagogue's foreclosure on the pursuit of God's unfolding depths and heights—rather than his assertion of divinity's mystery itself—underwrites what Richard Lim describes so compellingly as the foreclosure, through ideological mystification, of an ancient tradition of discursive reasoning and public debate."³⁵ As noted earlier, mystery can turn to mystification, invitation to prohibition, boundlessness to boundary.

We come forewarned against any facile identification of deconstruction with negative theology. But Charles Stang has more recently proposed an alternative reading. He argues that the neo-Arians Aetius and Eunomius are "radical negative theologians" and that the debate between them and Gregory is not about God's unknowable transcendence *per se*, but rather about whether God's radical transcendence implies sheer distance. Building on Rowan Williams's account of an "inaccessibility of divine 'hinterland,' . . . [an] overplus of 'unengaged' and inexpressible reality," Stang finds in Gregory's opponents "an apophatic vision that forecloses any and all relationship with the transcendent God, forecloses any possibility of intimacy with the God who is essentially other—in other words, a vision that forecloses the possibility of mysticism."³⁶

The Cappadocians were deploying the avowed paradox of the co-eternal Son as "begotten not made"—the *homoousios* (same being)—against the more monotheistically reasonable *homoiousios* (similar being) of the Arians. So Gregory caricatures Eunomius as "near to shouting aloud to any who will lend an ear, 'You can be perfect in knowledge, if you do not believe in the Only-begotten God, that he is truly God.'"³⁷ In this antagonism of our "faith" versus their "knowledge," orthodoxy tilts toward the apparatus of the unquestionable one may expect negative theology to question. But it remains noteworthy that it is the intellectual *certainly* of Eunomius's "theology" that Gregory reacts against. Gregory will not even use the word *theology* for his own work, as though its logos claims too much—thus provoking his satiric ire against Eunomius. Proposing not to take off the Goliath's

head but to show he has already lost it, Gregory accuses him of claiming to know *essentially*, to know God's being. Yet "we know that he is, but admit we are unable to understand his Being." Gregory is developing the distinction between the unknown *essence* of God and the relationally trusted *existence*. "For us . . . [God] comes to be known as existing, by means of his activities bestowing only faith, not the knowledge of what he is." That distinction—knowing *that* but not *what*—will become standard (of which we noted earlier Johnson's feminist deployment). We may sense its heat in context, at a turbulent moment preceding the theocratic establishment of truth by power: "they toy vainly with the impossible, and with childish hand lock up the incomprehensible nature of God in a few syllables."³⁸ Nyssa targets all too aptly a "lockup," a closure, indeed a foreclosure of meaning. And as Stang shows persuasively, the knowledge that Eunomius is claiming to have perfectly "amounts to knowledge that the unbegotten God is unapproachably remote."³⁹

What a constructive apophaticism in its solicitation of its past must avoid is both foreclosure by knowledge or by the knowledge of not-knowledge: the fixing of mystical "no trespassing" signs on the boundary of the unknowable. And it seems that Gregory shared this concern. Thus he satirically embraces his "ignorance of things incomprehensible"—in the face of the neo-Arian accusation. He touts Paul "as the premier apostolic ignoramus, who rightly applies to the transcendent God a series of negations, including 'unsearchable' and 'inscrutable' (Romans 11.33)."

Indeed it may be *any* fixed boundary that is coming undone in this "place where his intelligence lets him slip in." The "slipping in" becomes insistent: "penetrating deeper until by the intelligences' yearning for understanding it gains access to the invisible and the incomprehensible."⁴⁰ Here the language of the Hellenistic Eros, as the driving spiritual desire, enters right into the heart of Christian orthodoxy—to the consternation of later orthodoxies, such as that concentrated as *agape* versus *eros* by Anders Nygren (and also well exposed by Burrus).⁴¹ And in Nyssa, in a way unprecedented among Christians, this slippage is itself becoming boundless: *apeiron*. So this apophasis cannot be read as the effect of any fixed boundary between God and human. The human in its yearning transgresses such a limit, just by pushing into the cloud. Eunomius and Aetius in effect impose a limit on God—who as the Unbegotten "cannot essentially communicate with the

begotten Son or even creation.”⁴² And Gregory answers with a new logic: “For nothing is Divine that is conceived as being circumscribed, but it belongs to the Godhead to be in all places, and to pervade all things, and not to be limited by anything.”⁴³ The argument for the divine infinity is thus born to sustain not distance but intimacy.

What clouds and obstructs the intellect, though, if there is *not* an impenetrable boundary? Nothing, it appears, but the very boundlessness—the *infinity*—of “what is sought.” The incipient logic of the infinite, presented as a thought experiment, deserves a closer reading:

If the Divine is perceived as though bounded by something, one must by all means consider along with that boundary what is beyond it. For certainly that which is bounded leaves off at some point, as air provides the boundary for all that flies and water for all that lives in it. Therefore, fish are surrounded on every side by water, and birds by air. The limits of the boundaries which circumscribe the birds or the fish are obvious: The water is the limit to what swims and the air to what flies. In the same way, God, if he is conceived as bounded would necessarily be surrounded by something different in nature. It is only logical that what encompasses is much larger than what is contained.⁴⁴

If God were limited, it would have to be by something *greater than God*. That would cancel out any meaning of the word *God*. And if God signifies the boundless, what boundary can lie between God and creation—between the infinite and the finite? The challenge to any Creator/Creation dualism follows immediately. Until Gregory, the notion of a divine infinity was hardly thinkable.⁴⁵ Christian theologians, with few exceptions, held to the Greek—and certainly Platonic—sense that the deity must be bounded by form, in order to be knowable, indeed to be the most intelligible of all beings. For classical sensibility the *apeiron* was formless, repugnant, kin to chaos and the deep. Nor did this bounded deity directly conflict with biblical figures. Origen had argued for the knowability and therefore finitude of God. It was Plotinus who had shifted Platonism toward the new idea of the divine infinity.

However—and this is key to the operative theologic—while there is *no fixed boundary*, there is nonetheless a heightened *distinction* between creator and creation. “Here Gregory in his juxtaposition of creator and created beings,” writes

the theologian Michael Nausner, “seems to make an absolute distinction between the encompassing creator and the encompassed creatures.”⁴⁶ The difference between the finite and the infinite appears as *infinite*. But *difference*—especially infinite difference—is not boundary, but *relation*. “The interaction *across* or *at* the borderline,” continues Nausner, finding slippery inspiration for a diasporic politics of immigration, “between divine and human is more than just an exchange from *inside* to *outside* or vice versa.” So the contemplative does not here close into its interiority, but opens inside out, deconstructing any foundational opposition of outside and inside, of transcendence and immanence.⁴⁷

Gregory’s ascending soul, spurred on by desire, is penetrating that which will have already always penetrated the soul. For the embracing infinite exposes us to the unknown excess of that which we are getting to know. In other words, the apophatic gesture is, from its Alexandrian start, inseparable from the embrace of infinity, which is no thing, no entity, but a negation, the not-finite. For “it is not in the nature of what is unenclosed to be grasped.” The knowing that is possible is then not that of “grasping,” enclosing, bounding. It reverberates with an erotic knowing (recall the Hebrew *yada*) whose desire is never exhausted—because its beloved is itself inexhaustible, the inexhaustible itself. “This is truly the vision of God,” Gregory exults, “never to be satisfied in the desire to see him.”⁴⁸ Satisfaction would here mean satiety or (fore)closure, not joy—which he finds at every level of his own unfolding. And so with apophasis and infinity a third innovation drives Gregory’s hermeneutics: that of “perpetual progress,” *epektasis*. Neither Hebrew nor Platonic in conception, this growth process continues along the entire, “eternal,” life of the soul: there is no heavenly endgame. This evolving psyche reaches only relative climaxes. And yet it is not a case of endless deferral and frustration. The process is itself ecstatic.

In other words, the apophatic infinity begins to unsettle the Greek idealization of the changeless. Against the “fateful Platonic (and Origenist) equation of change with degeneration” Gregory postulated instead “a positive form of changeability.” The glowing cloud begins to melt down the classical hierarchy of immobile being and the mobilities of becoming. “This is the most marvelous thing (*paradoxotaton*) of all: how the same thing is both *a standing still and a moving*. For he who ascends certainly does not stand still, and he who stands still does not move upwards.”⁴⁹ If the process is incessant, we may rest composed within it.

Almost, within this momentary relativity, this *standing motion*, this *moving stillness*, the classical ideal of stasis seems to autodeconstruct. (This deconstruction, key to the definitive Cusan motion in chapter 3, is already eerily anticipated in the *Parmenides*, as it infers that “the one is neither at rest nor in motion.”) Yet even if this discourse energizes a new contemplative space, the promisingly enigmatic interplay between finite and infinite, between creature and creator, hardly eludes the classical dualism of the unknowable, invisible deity, as the model of an immaterial intelligence that masters the inferior, altogether knowable, bodies. Moses might seem to perform an intellectual exodus from the visible and visibly suffering world. Despite the paradoxes, or perhaps because of their failure to move from the stasis of mere contradiction to the nuance of alter-knowing, the metaphysics of a mind ascending to the desired One above and beyond the material Many entrenches itself among the presuppositions of all classical theology, even in its apophatics. That unquestioned metaphysical hierarchy would seem after all to foreclose the possibility, key to the present genealogy, of an apophatically contoured cosmology.

More precisely, it defers it until the end of the medieval period. For if the solution to limiting God to our knowledge in fact limits our not-knowing to God, we would not get much closer to the fold between negative theology and a relational cosmology. For the matter of the world would, in its finitude, be all too known—and so fail to matter “intellectually.” There would be little to learn there. Yet already in Gregory the opening appears. For he swerves sharply from a discussion of “the impossibility of knowing divine things” to the assertion that “*we lack essential knowledge of soul, body and universe.*”⁵⁰ So it is not just a matter of the finite incapacity to grasp the infinite. For just as we cannot make of God a thing, we cannot know the essence of *any* thing. “For Gregory,” insists Rowan Williams, “we could say, there is no such thing as the soul in itself; it is always implicated in contingent matter, and even its final liberation for pilgrimage into God . . . depends upon the deployment and integration of bodilienss and animality.”⁵¹

It is as though a certain apophatic entanglement of becoming begins to materialize—in matter itself. “As we look at the sky, and somehow grasp with our visual sense its exalted beauty, we have no doubt that what we see exists; yet if we are asked what it is, we cannot explain its nature in words.”⁵² Is this just Gregory’s

prescientific ignorance? Certainly there is endlessly much we can say with confidence about the sky. But he himself continues with a long and detailed description of the sky, drawing on the astronomy of his time. The point is subtler: there is always *something* that eludes us. We cannot nail an “essence” of anything. Precisely in searching scripture “one may explore every divinely inspired word and not find teaching about the divine nature, nor indeed *about the essential existence of anything*.” What a crucial hermeneutical message to all biblicalists: “Hence, we humans live in total ignorance, in the first place about ourselves, and then about everything else.” This is a fruitful hyperbole. For he now asks “who is in a position to understand his own soul? Who knows its inner being?—whether it is material or immaterial; whether it is to be seen as purely incorporeal or as having something of a corporeal kind about it; how it comes to be . . .” These rhetorical questions continue for several lines. Indeed, he asks whether one might not “reckon that he had a crowd of souls gathered within him. . . . This multiplicity and plurality of what is to be observed in the soul . . . who is there that understands even half the soul’s function in these respects? You tell me!”⁵³

Gregory has just made a beautiful case for what Kathryn Tanner will also root here—an “apophatic anthropology.”⁵⁴ Ultimately there is here an intuition of the plasticity, as she puts it, of the *imago dei* in the image of the unknowable divinity. But he does not stop there, where classical immateriality still holds a certain sway. “Why speak of the soul?” he asks. “Not even in the physical being itself, in which the bodily qualities inhere, has so far been captured by clear comprehension; for if one mentally analyses the phenomenon into its constituent parts and attempts to envisage the subject by itself, stripping it of its qualities, what will be left to reflect upon, I fail to see.”⁵⁵ He thus undoes in advance a whole history of essentialist reduction. For “when you remove from the body its color, shape, solidity, weight, size, spatial location, movement . . . its relation to others things, none of which is in itself the body, but all belong to the body, what will then be left to which the thought of a body applies?—that is something we can neither perceive by ourselves, nor do we learn it from scripture.”⁵⁶ Nyssa seems here quite presciently to deconstruct the Cartesian doctrine of primary and secondary qualities, the unrecognized abstractions that, according to Whitehead, have dominated a certain colorless modern empiricism, a dualism that feeds current economies of

objectification. It happens also that for Nyssa the *imago dei* means that the soul in its freedom also “does not admit of the distinction of male and female.” The plastic indistinction echoes the Pauline “neither male nor female.” While unsatisfying to a certain stage of feminist commentary, as we were seeking to firm up a new identity, if not an essence, its neither/nor may be more queerly promising now. In Gregory this gender-negation emulates the boundlessness of divinity and amplifies the apophatic anthropology.

If the luminous darkness, from its textual beginnings, can protect every finite thing from reification, it still cannot dissociate itself from the Mosaic original. For in this later ascent corporeal creatures are, after all, not excluded; they too find shelter from the glare of an objectifying gaze. It sweeps back to the desert as idolatry or covetousness; it aims ahead to desertification by information and commodification. But what of the motif of exodus itself? Of human liberation *not from this world but from worldly oppression* there would persist movements within and beyond Christianity. Yet few traces in the history of theology, positive or negative, until the last century. Indeed it is disheartening to examine, for example, the entire history of the church’s relation to slavery: in almost every document of the Roman Catholic magisterium until the mid nineteenth century the church condemns not slavery, but those who resist it.⁵⁷ So I was surprised to discover that Gregory of Nyssa actually wrote against—literal—slavery. In a deployment of his apophatic anthropology, he writes that if the human “is in the likeness of God . . . who is his buyer, tell me? Who is his seller? To God alone belongs this power; rather, *not even to God himself*. For his gracious gifts, it says, are irrevocable. . . . But if God does not enslave what is free, who is he that sets his own power above God’s?”⁵⁸ Is there a certain historical epektasis here, beyond scripture itself (which contains no universalized opposition to human slavery)? If so, Moses’ I AM insists itself even in and through an allegorization that threatens to eclipse all relation to the materiality of liberation. But somehow, in pervading all things, this Neoplatonized deity circulates radically in and through the mattering creatures. Amidst the “adventure of ideas,” the idea of human freedom moves, as Whitehead mapped its journey to the termination of the institution of slavery, at a strangely slow pace. Progress in his cosmology is neither consistent nor predetermined, but fitfully in evidence amidst the beginningless and endless process, called creativity, of the universe. For Whitehead it is a flux of indeterminate—free but nonsepa-

rable—becomings, as though the soul's journey of epektasis were gathered into the infinite cosmological process.

The precipitates of liberation are too slow, Nyssa's "impossible and incomprehensible" too—infinite.⁵⁹ Did exodus nonetheless seed its possibility in the mystical cloud as the provocative eros, the yearning that reaches always already beyond the boundaries of any imperial or tribal, ecclesial or orthodox enclosure?

"BRILLIANT DARKNESS OF A HIDDEN SILENCE"

Here, being neither oneself nor someone else, one is supremely united by a completely unknowing inactivity of all knowledge and knows beyond the mind by knowing nothing.

—DIONYSIUS THE AREOPAGITE, *MYSTICAL THEOLOGY*

Where is this place—this "here" where one is "neither oneself nor someone else?" How would I go there? A place beyond or beside oneself, in language or in ecstasy, a knowing beyond or beside the point of knowledge? The language resonates with the Buddhist *anatta*, no-self. But it directs us back again to the same not so far eastern desert, the same moment, with which this chapter began: "standing apart from the crowds and accompanied by chosen priests, Moses pushes ahead to the summit of the divine ascents. And yet he does not meet God himself, but contemplates, not him who is invisible, but rather where he dwells."

Dionysius the Areopagite, this late fifth- or early-sixth CE Greek-speaking Syrian monk, performs for the genealogy of the dark cloud the next great hybrid Plato-Moses. He is called the Pseudo-Dionysius because he was for centuries mistaken for the figure whose name he adopted, the Dionysius of the court of Areopagos in Athens, converted, according to Luke Acts, by Paul. In Dionysius' unparalleled condensation of the brilliant darkness into theological practice, the genre of negative theology comes into its own. The effects of Dionysius's brief corpus, especially his *Mystical Theology*, pierce the margins of the Middle Ages, riveting thinkers such as Eriugena, the anonymous author of *The Cloud of Unknowing* (they both translate him), Aquinas, and Cusa. One of his primary commentators, Denys Turner (who unselfconsciously refers to him by the anglicized name "Denys the Areopagite"), argues that "if and insofar as 'mystical

theology' is the product of the convergence of sources in Plato and in Exodus . . . then it is scarcely an exaggeration to say that Denys invented the genre for the Latin Church."⁶⁰ If we owe the Christian mystical language of darkness, light, and eros to Dionysius, "he owed it, as he saw it, to Plato and Moses."⁶¹ The intensification of that eros through the interplay of negation and transformation goes to the heart of the question of an apophatic relationality: for the interplay of unknowing and altered knowing further transforms the Neoplatonic One. This One becomes again love. But this love is not a self-sufficient agapic immobility but God "beguiled," giving itself as "a gift to all things." In the process the eros precipitates what I take to be the first Christian explication of an *apophatic panentheism*.

But such a claim, especially if it seems to synthesize Exodus and Platonism in some warmly ethical, perhaps process theological, relationalism, will also negate itself in the Dionysian darkness. For as Jean-Luc Marion insists admiringly, and not without warrant, through the Areopagite's procedure we approach "the point of view of the absolute . . . admitting it as absolute: undone from any relation, and therefore also from any thinkable relation."⁶² Dionysius puts it thus: "Disclose this not to the uninitiated: not to those, I say, who are entangled in beings, imagine nothing to be beyond-beingly beyond beings, and claim to know by the knowledge in them 'Him who has made the dark his hiding place.'"⁶³ Those still incapable of the unknowing are entangled in definite things and make God into one. This criterion will trouble in advance the hospitable hope of apophatic entanglement. And must we not read the Dionysian tropes of ascent as precisely an absolution from the world of our relations? Even more than in the Cappadocians, Moses becomes the mystagogue "standing apart from the crowds" who "pushes ahead to the summit of the divine ascents."

Indeed Dionysius's *Ecclesiastical Hierarchy* offers some of the rhetoric one might expect from the man who invented the term *hierarchy*. "Let your sharing of the sacred befit the sacred things: Let it be by way of sacred enlightenment for sacred men only."⁶⁴ And then later, the text charges deacons with the task of purging the church of those who are not suited for Holy Communion, including the possessed, the uninitiated, the incompletely initiated, the previously-initiated-but-now-degenerate, the intemperate, the intemperate-yet-resolved-not-to-be-intemperate, and, finally, "those who . . . are neither completely unblemished

nor completely unstained.”⁶⁵ We could also dredge up older warnings against the *hoi polloi*. Has the cloud turned into an elitist crowd repellant?

Without apologetics, let us nonetheless press further into the murk. Here at the end of the first chapter of the *Mystical Theology*, Moses “does not meet God himself, but contemplates, not him who is invisible, but rather where he dwells.” That *place*. “This means, I presume, that the holiest and highest of the things perceived with the eye of the body or the mind are but the rationale which presupposes all that lies below the Transcendent One.” And then the Moses-persona moves beyond and through even these holiest objects of either physical *or mental* vision that seem to form the surface of the cloud. We should then not mistake this ascent for any mind/body dualism, or its Transcendent One for an idea or any such intelligible entity. It is precisely the masterful work of reason—the tool of the intellectual or doctrinal elite one fears in such hierarchy—that he *escapes*. “But then [Moses] breaks free of them, away from what sees and is seen, and he plunges into the truly mysterious darkness of unknowing. Here, renouncing all that the mind may conceive, wrapped entirely in the intangible and the invisible, he belongs completely to him who is beyond everything. Here, being neither oneself nor someone else.”⁶⁶

Moses, plunging into the dark cloud, becomes an ecstatic not-self not-knowing the things of sense perception *or* of cognition—“supremely united to the completely unknown.” What kind of relation is that? Is it really just exodus from all relation? Or does this Neoplatonic Moses perhaps also break free of the absolute itself—or any mental conception of such an abstract freedom? For “absolved from all,” this X—for which God is only a convenient label—is also “not king, not wisdom, not one, not unity, not divinity, not goodness.”⁶⁷ And on this list goes. It negates all the terms of the Platonic absolute. But then it goes also “beyond all negation”—plying Sell’s apophatic discourse, which turns on the negations of its own negative theology. Is something more performative, more Zen-like than any mystification of spiritual supremacism, not taking place in this undoing of any substantial “being”?

That “mysterious darkness of unknowing” may certainly be read as a standard patriarchal occultation of the fleshly particularities and urgent interdependencies of existence. Then the sage is merely fleeing the cave of the *hoi polloi*, up the mountain: Moses in Exodus, the philosopher in the *Republic*. But in the context

of the burgeoning Christian light-supremacism of the early centuries, and in the current neon spectrum of certainty of modern factualism, we may want to pause for a moment, in our own uncertainty, before this startling overflow of darkness. It is a darkness lacking in any demonic associations. The famous poem with which Dionysius opens *Mystical Theology* begins where his audience does, with the trinity, and swerves immediately into a discursive impossibility: “higher than any being, any divinity, any goodness!” Again the *epikeine tēs ousias*, the beyond-being. And *hypertheos*: beyond God. (Eckhart, as we noted, would later pick up, in a time of greater risk, this negation of the very being and divinity of God.) And there follows in the same verse the single most beautiful paraphrase of Moses’ cloud:

in the brilliant darkness of a hidden silence.

Amid the deepest shadow

they pour overwhelming light

*on what is most manifest.*⁶⁸

The light floods the darkness without overcoming it; and the silence hides within the poetry of speech. In the chiasmus of antitheses, Christianity is itself illuminingly enfolded in its own deepest shadow. This text indulges in no polemics against wrong views or headless heretics. Yet it practices the most radical negation, a negation directed against the affirmations to which any reader, like the author himself, would inevitably have presupposed. “Denys designs this prayer on the structural principle of what I shall call the ‘self-subverting’ utterance,” writes Turner, “the utterance which first says something and then, in the same image, unsays it.”⁶⁹ This is utterance undoing itself—equivalent to an autodeconstruction.

It is the Areopagite who makes explicit the (in)activity of “the unknowing of what is beyond being.” No wonder it was Dionysius to whom Derrida found himself compelled to turn in order to nip the identification of deconstruction with negative theology (and all of its hierarchies) in the bud. Thus he negates it: “No, what I write is not ‘negative theology.’”⁷⁰ But as we sensed in the last chapter, Derrida must be thereby cunningly echoing Dionysius himself, on God: “For God is not some kind of being. No.”⁷¹ It is in the Dionysian Plotinianism, sharpened through Proclus—who had first used the terms *kataphatic* and *apophatic* to describe opposing theological gestures—that the “the very concept of a negative or

‘apophatic’ theology is first formulated.”⁷² But then is it not in the debate about the relation between the apophatic and the deconstructive that the subversive potential of the former is lifted up as an honorific, made explicit, intensified? Derrida would necessarily suspect the beyond being, the hyperousios, of designating a hyperessence, an excess of metaphysical self-presence and thus an “ontotheological reappropriation”: “still it is the immediacy of a presence. Leading to union with God.”⁷³ Put thus, a reappropriation of the very being that the apophatic seems all about subverting remains—always possible. We see already in the debates between Gregory and neo-Arians the paradoxical switchovers, indissociable from the power struggles of orthodoxy versus heresy, of the knowing nonknowingness. But then would we not have to raise the same question of deconstruction?

Marion picks up the argument against Derrida at a future bend, averring that “negative theology does not furnish deconstruction with new material or an unconscious forerunner but rather with its first serious rival, perhaps the only one possible.”⁷⁴ Thus the rivalry is locked in—as an anachronistic spillover of more recent competition? This debate at any rate produces its own cloud. Perhaps for now we might iterate the claim of the last chapter, that to read the apophatic as deconstructive is not to perform an identification or a competition so much as a strategic entanglement. From that point of view Hart (“deconstruction is not negative theology, but negative theology is deconstruction”) captures more closely the nuance—if its own productive anachronism is acknowledged. Or we might say that negative theology remains, like deconstruction, indeconstructible—inasmuch as it subverts every theological construction. Indeed it lets us follow Derrida’s own self-subverting avowal, later, of “the subversive marginality of the apophatic current in the history of theology and of the Church.”⁷⁵

For the apophatic as it comes into its Dionysian crystallization aims no longer at heretics and pagans but at the idolatries to which Christian theology at its most orthodox is prone. So let us consider more closely the work of the Dionysian negative.

The Dionysian hierarchy of ascent unfolds as a series of negations. But like any good deconstruction, the apophasis is not a destruction; it respects its own dependence on each prior affirmation. Dionysius here reminds us first that in his earlier works he has “praised the notions which are most appropriate to affirmative theology”—from the One, the triune nature, fatherhood and sonship, on

down through conceptual names like “good, existent, life, wisdom, power,” and then down lower, to “images we have of him,” “the ornaments he wears,” “his anger, grief, and rage, of how he is said to be drunk and hungover, of his oaths and curses, of his sleeping and waking.”⁷⁶

Indeed “the sheer crassness of the signs is a goad,”⁷⁷ reminding even the liter-
alists among us of the difference between our signs and that which they would
signify. But finally *any name at all* can refer to God, and no name quite fits. This
so-called God “*is rightly nameless and yet has the names of all that is.*”⁷⁸

Now, in the *Mystical Theology*, performing the negative procedure, Diony-
sius reverses direction. He begins with the lower attributions. “The cause of all
is above all and is not inexistent, lifeless, speechless, mindless. It is not a material
body.” That much is evident. But moving upward, the subversive force of the pro-
cedure becomes ever more evident:

It is not soul or mind, nor does it possess imagination, conviction, speech or under-
standing. Nor is it speech per se . . . It cannot be spoken of. It is not number or order,
greatness or smallness . . . It is not immovable, moving, or at rest. It has no power, it is
not power. It is not kingship. It is not wisdom. Is neither one nor oneness, divinity nor
goodness. Nor is it a spirit . . . It is not sonship or fatherhood and it is nothing known to
us or to any other being. It falls neither within the predicate of nonbeing nor of being.⁷⁹

Not *son* or *father*? May I exhale one almost ancient feminist sigh of relief? And
yet: *nothing* now to us or to any other? And yet again: no more nonbeing than be-
ing? (And here my inner Buddhist also takes a refreshing breath.) In other words,
not only the *biblical* names, which the hoi polloi take literally, forfeit any pretense
of rendering God knowable. So do all the *classical* attributions—the abstract set
of immutability, immobility, omnipotence, and indeed the unity, the simplicity,
the good itself. None of these names represent their object. God “is not”—even
God. Again, note the predicative pattern does not presume the “God” of “God is”
or “God is not.” Theos as logos: it speaks in us the ancient cipher of an unknown
that insistently attracts our attention, even as it escapes all retention.

In the negative movement of the mystical theology upward, there is so little
of the ascent of the mind toward the Mind, of a disembodied intellect toward
ever greater light and clarity, as to confuse every stereotype of Neoplatonism: “the
more our words are confined to the ideas we are capable of forming; so that now

as we plunge into that darkness which is beyond intellect, we shall find ourselves not simply running short of words but actually speechless and unknowing.”⁸⁰ The ascent is actually a plunge: the cloud circulates in an atmosphere that undoes the very axis of up and down.

The final negation, the “highest” and last passage of the text, elegantly summarizes the Dionysian hermeneutics: “We make assertions and denials of what is next to it, but never of it, for it is both beyond every assertion . . . free of every limitation, beyond every limitation; it is also *beyond every denial*.”⁸¹ The negation of the negation again: the punch line of the negative procedure. It is achieved not by light and darkness canceling each other out—not by their producing an umbrageous synthesis. Marion is rightly insistent that Derrida reads wrongly when he reads this negation as a mere reappropriation or restoration of the affirmations of an orthodox theology—if only Derrida could be thus pinned down. In fact his interrogation of the Areopagite also manages to negate his own negations. Yet there remains a metaphysically larded discourse not entirely absolvable from its context of “absolute absolution,” in need, for the liberation of its own deconstructive force (or its ability to rival deconstruction), of current supplementation.

It is not that now one returns to the prior state of kataphasis and can with equal validity claim that “God is” *that* father, *that* divinity, *that* being. One may now acknowledge that any language might name it, but only in the recognition that all this language is “falling away,” being unsaid: none of it will ever mirror such an entity, represent it by an image or a concept. Nor, however, is the truth captured by the *not* (no ancestor here for modern certainty that God is not). Marion himself inserts here the third way of the *supereminencia*, as a true absolute. But his well nigh Thomist rendition of the “beyond” poses its own threat of scholastic reification. The eminent way, with the great teaching of analogy in place of univocity or equivocity in language, brought Dionysius into the High Middle Ages, but with a difference: Aquinas insisted on the identification of God with Being, whereas Dionysius, like the series of interpreters of the Parmenidean autodeconstruction, had built in the unsaying of that Being, insisting on its beingless Beyond. In other words, the *via eminentia* congeals the ontotheology that the *via negativa*, left to negate itself, had always already undone.⁸²

Eugene Thacker, in resistance to the Thomist balance, emphasizes the radicality of the negation: “While positive theology always sublimates the negative into the positive, negative theology employs a different strategy: that of contradiction,

limitation, and irresolution. Negation in negative theology is not just a temporary ‘not-X’ but an absolute ‘not-X,’ a notion that leads both the Pseudo-Dionysius and Eriugena to consider a contradictory ‘superlative negation.’”⁸³ Does the very absoluteness of that not-X absolve it from its own resolution into the Absolute—with its eternal immobility? But that superlative negation is precisely the auto-deconstructive negation, the negation of the negation, and so just as superlatively affirmative. One may read in the Dionysian exercise, rather than the binary dialectic or the triumph of the third way, the mistier third space of an unfinished, indeed boundless exercise in self-transformation.

Though Dionysius does not use the language of the infinite, the oscillation or coinciding of knowing and unknowing in the space of the cloud suggests the austerity and the ecstasy of an open-ended alter-knowing. Turner captures the unfinished and unformed character of this theological space: it is the collapse of our affirmations and denials “into disorder, which we can only express, a fortiori, in bits of collapsed, disordered language, like the babble of a Jeremiah.”⁸⁴ Or of the broken monolingualism of Babel, or of the Pentecost polyglossia. “And that is what the ‘self-subverting’ utterance is, a bit of disordered language. Since that is also, for Denys, what theological language is when stretched to its fullest extent, that language naturally, spontaneously, and rightly takes the form of paradox.”⁸⁵ Of course paradox too can become the tool of an order prohibiting further questioning; so it too wants collapsing into the indeterminacy that precedes and exceeds any predetermined oppositions. Or is this just, after all, an overintellectualized failure to articulate what a good later theory of metaphor could do for us? But like icon, allegory, paradox, and symbol, metaphor in its time does not escape the threat of reification, whether in the conceptualization of a God-entity or the deification of a godless one. Advancing to *metonym* or *trope* won’t save us. The heart is “a factory of idols,” fulminated Calvin, productive along those lines himself. But these linguistic forms are no sin—as long as they braid in their own unsaying. That is what as living events of language—allegory, paradox, symbol, metaphor in their epochs—*do* after all, that is the *poiesis* of language itself, its “making,” its becoming: “words stretch, crack, will not stay still.”⁸⁶

For a moment I picture the twining of the kataphatic and the apophatic as genetic strands not held together in a third “way,” but effecting it at each twist, each fold, of their intersection. As Sells puts it, apophasis “is a discourse of double

propositions, in which meaning is generated through the tension between the saying and the unsaying.”⁸⁷ The tension between the apophatic and the kataphatic then does not transcend apophasis but is its own precipitant.

The nothingness of the “knowing nothing” is not a neat *nihil* of names but a chaotic multiplicity, an overflow “in excess” (Marion) of any *theos logos*. In this it may minister to contemporary atheism, if only in passing, in intersecting, in exceeding. At the fold, the *pli*, between the negative and the affirmative ways, It, this God that is not God, remains “rightly nameless and yet has the names of all that is.” Of course “all that is” exceeds hermeneutics: “For the unnamed goodness is not just the cause of cohesion or life or perfection so that it is from this or that providential gesture that it earns a name, but it *actually contains everything beforehand within itself*.”⁸⁸ In other words all things dwell *in* this apophatic ultimate. Therefore all the names “are fittingly derived from the sum total of creation.”⁸⁹ Dionysius does not refer this “beforehand” to any sense of divine foreknowledge or predetermination. It suggests all are there in potentiality (in a “boundless and uncomplicated” manner). This gesture toward a cosmological panentheism remains in context undeveloped. But there is another hint, pronounced as one of the most concentrated utterances of what we may properly name *apophatic panentheism* in the history of Christian thought: “He is all things in all things and he is no thing among things. He is known to all from all things and he is known to no one from anything.”⁹⁰

“In all things” marks the difference from a simple “is all things,” and so of panentheism from pantheism. This nuanced Dionysianism is also arguably Plotinian. In an apophatic panentheism may precisely coincide the radicality of absolute transcendence with that of pure immanence. But then such a panentheism will also not settle God into the posture of an actual entity entering other entities and being entered by them, if thereby is conjured a reciprocating interaction of bounded beings. The process panentheism pullulates, however, with an open cosmos of creatures, entangled in one another even as they are divinely enfolded.

We find, however, no apophatic cosmology explicated in the Dionysian interconnection of creator and creation (as Gregory did initiate); no cosmos of mutually interrelated bodies, let alone any reception and influence of the creature upon God, materializes within the Dionysian germ of panentheism. Nonetheless it seems to me that we discern the condition of the possibility of a full-bodied

apophatic relationalism in this radicalization of the theological eros. Dionysius not only absorbs the eros introduced in Gregory as the *human* motive of the *epektasis*. We find an idea ruled out by any orthodoxy of the absolute and self-sufficient One—the idea of the *divine* yearning: “the very cause of the universe in the beautiful, good superabundance of his benign yearning for all is also carried outside of himself in the loving care he has for everything.”⁹¹

Love carries the divine outside itself—in an ecstasy heretofore reserved for humans. “Our ecstatic yearning after God,” then, writes Stang, “is in response to God’s estatic yearning after us, and indeed all creation.”⁹² In what may be an unprecedented Christian resistance to the notion of a self-enclosed, self-satisfied agape, better suited to an indifferent One, let alone to the unmoved mover of a later Aristotelian consensus, Dionysius almost anticipates Hartshorne’s “Most Moved Mover.” The Areopagite argues—affirmatively—that we should not be intimidated by the carnal implications of this “yearning” (*eros*), that eros and agape have the same meaning. So it is not just a generous and parental love, a unilateral gift, but a craving for ecstatic relation that after all produces the world. God “is, as it were, beguiled by goodness, by love, and by yearning and is enticed away from his transcendent dwelling place and comes to abide within all things, and he does so by virtue of his . . . ecstatic capacity to remain, nevertheless, within himself.”⁹³ God beguiled: the silhouette of an apophatic relationalism begins to appear, it seems, where the negation of the negation of divine love folds the distance of its transcendence into intimacy.

Stang demonstrates in Dionysius an intentional “elision between eros and agape” in this passage from *The Divine Names*: “it may be boldly said with truth, that even the very Author of all things, by reason of overflowing Goodness, loves all, makes all, perfects all, sustains all, attracts all.”⁹⁴ How does eros here become—without the Nyssan infinite—apophatic? Stang puts it beautifully: “Eros is the engine of apophasis, a yearning that stretches language to the point that it breaks, stretches the lover to the point that he splits.”⁹⁵ If we can embrace this insight—that the very desire that drives us beyond ourselves in earthly relations of attraction and of justice is that which drives us in and beyond speech, and that in this eros we are iterating and exercising the love that always already exceeds us—no paternalism of the distant and dysrelational transcendence can long remain erect upon the Neoplatonic peak.

“The impulse behind perpetual negation, then is a yearning for God that will accept no proxies—that is to say, no idols. Even our contemplations of the divine names must be sacrificed at the altar to the unknown God.”⁹⁶ The intertext of Paul’s Areopagite moment is pivotal to Stang’s project. It enfolds here the *anonymous* deity with the unnamed author, the *pseudonymous* Dionysius. Stang draws the inference that “for Dionysius the very practice of writing pseudonymously is itself a third path of unknowing God and self.” It is not a “ploy for sub-apostolic authority” but “an ecstatic devotional practice in the service of the apophysis of the self.”⁹⁷ And it is also important that he—like so many ancient thinkers—writes in the mode of relation: ‘Dear Timothy . . .’

It is in relation to the deity that the relationality boils into eros. Lest we get misled by such hot hints, Turner reminds us that “it is the ascent of the mind up the scale of negations which draws it into the cloud of unknowing.” It is the “eros of knowing, the passion and yearning for the vision of the One, which projects the mind up the scale.”⁹⁸ Yet we have seen how “mind” and “knowing” are exceeded, left behind, by the yearning itself. More sternly, Grace Jantzen, one of the first feminist scholars to read Christian mysticism closely, shows that the influence of Dionysius, especially after the ninth century, privileged a hierarchical “pathway of the intellect, even if in the end the intellect is rendered speechless and self-transcendent.”⁹⁹ And Dionysius himself (unlike Gregory or Eckhart) assumes a male-only readership: “A mysticism of the intellect, such as Dionysius bequeathed to the medieval church, was a gendered mysticism, even though that was never spelled out.”¹⁰⁰ Women found their way into mysticism along the altogether different path of an affective, intensively relational, eros. The language of the divinity tends among women mystics to be more personal—and therefore more caught in a heterosexist imaginary of God as Father, Son, Christ, Lover. (Thus I pointed in chapter 1 to Elizabeth Johnson’s feminist, if Thomist, deployment of the negative way.) These strategic complications surely call for the apophatic multiplicity of names coupled with strategies of their unnamings. In our feminist invagination of theology let us not confuse the apophatic with denigration of the desirous multiplicity of bodies.

For not only in the rabbinic Shekhinah does the cloud offer protection and tenderness to the flesh. In Dionysius we discover an *aesthetic* negating of the *ascetic* negating of the body: “and *there is no evil in our bodies . . .* If *beauty*, form, and

order [*kosmos*] could be destroyed completely, the body itself would disappear.”¹⁰¹ Belying for the moment the future stereotypes of the Neoplatonic monastic, he thus calls out not only the putative goodness of creation but the constituent beauty of all bodies, of embodiment as such. It is not just a divine artistry. Divinity itself “flows over” into everything. “This Godhead is granted as a gift to all things.”¹⁰² But that “all” need not collapse the endless differences of the many bodies, the particular creatures. Amidst the myriad self-subverting utterances there is stressed one so crucial to an apophatic relationalism as to protect it from its own version of the “logic of the One.” It picks up upon the counter-Platonic moment of Plato himself we noted earlier. This Godhead “is multiplied and yet remains singular . . . is indivisible multiplicity, the unfilled overfullness which produces, perfects, and preserves all unity and all multiplicity.”¹⁰³

In this overfullness creation comes as a great excess in Dionysius: an ecstatic overflow of divine desire into the mattering multiplicities of the world. “Creation, for Denys [Dionysius], is we might say, the divine eros in volcanic eruption.”¹⁰⁴ There is here precedent for Eckhart’s “boiling over, the ebullitio, of the inner bubbling of the bullitio, as the energy of all things. While no apophatic cosmology of affirmative interrelation appears in the cloud of the Dionysian (or the Eckhartian) darkness, the “unfilled overfullness” already activates its possibility. Does a convivial potential still wait to erupt from this monkish patrilineage and its monogendered hierarchy? Inasmuch as this divinity comes distributed in its own multiplicity, does it not desirously host the yearning multitudes, the crowding hoi polloi, of our planet?

THE CLOUD OF UNKNOWING

You are to smite upon that thick cloud of unknowing with a sharp dart of longing love.

—THE CLOUD OF UNKNOWING

From the pseudonymous to the anonymous: in fourteenth-century England the cloud condenses into the renowned *Cloud of Unknowing*. We will tarry only briefly with this contemplative text, a work free of the abstraction of its predecessors. It grants us the pause of its succinct practicality. We will consider applications of its practice both contextual and anachronistic.

Penned perhaps by a Carthusian recluse in the East Highlands, it is a direct precipitate of the Dionysian corpus. “For the author of the Cloud, Denis was one of those chosen few who saw eternity in the dazzling darkness of night.”¹⁰⁵ Already, through the translation and commentary of John the Scot Eriugena (815–877), Dionysius had affected the evolution of medieval mysticism. (The brilliant Eriugena, rumored to have been murdered by his own piously outraged students, only escapes the scope of this chapter by not featuring the image of the cloud.) But, unlike the dauntingly speculative Scot, the Cloud author teaches a very concrete spiritual practice. And unlike Dionysius, the cloud author—impatient with “the proud and elaborate speculations” of his own context, that of Catholic scholasticism—offers no apophatic theology, no panentheistic construction.

“Now when I call this exercise a darkness or a cloud . . .,” he writes, “I mean a privation of knowing, just as whatever you do not know or have forgotten is dark to you, because you do not see it with your spiritual eyes.” The exercise is therefore precisely not that of the intellect. And with his no-nonsense bluntness, he introduces the indelible phrase: “that which is between you and your God is termed, not a cloud of the air, but a cloud of unknowing.”¹⁰⁶

The text is pure *exercitia*. Nonetheless the *Cloud* author picks up right where the Areopagite left off: “For where [the practioner’s] understanding fails is in nothing except God alone; and it was for this reason that Saint Denis said, ‘The truly divine knowledge of God is that which is known by unknowing.’” The intertextual enfoldment is precise: “And now whoever cares to examine the works of Denis, he will find that his words clearly corroborate . . . But I have no mind to cite him . . .” Still, having after all translated him, he cannot resist quoting him occasionally, but otherwise rather grouchily eschews scholarly citation practice: “In another age it was humility . . . for at one time men believed that it was humility to say nothing out of their own heads, unless they corroborated it by scriptures and the saying of the fathers. But now this practice indicates nothing except cleverness and a display of erudition” (255–256). (And in our age, citing—him? Academic pretension? Or ancestral bait?)

It is the dark minimalism of the cloud that lends the anonymous Briton the starting point of his teaching, which must be read as a manual for meditation: “For when you first begin to undertake it, all that you find is a darkness, a sort of cloud of unknowing; you cannot tell what it is, except that you experience in your will a simple reaching out to God.” What “God” signifies remains opaque, always:

“this darkness and cloud is always between you and your God, no matter what you do” (120).

I confess to finding quite practicable directions in the *Cloud*. “When you set yourself to this exercise . . . then lift up your heart to God by a humble impulse of love.” God, who? What am I to conceive? Consistently this “simple reaching” practices nothing but “pure address, on the edge of silence.” So the *Cloud* author teaches us to “have *no other thought of God*; and *not even any of these thoughts unless it should please you*” (133). No other thought, only this uplift of affectionate desire: and not even that, indeed nothing the author himself might suggest—“unless it should please you.” In other words, be done with disheartening clichés and scholastic pretensions. Pleasure—as an anticipation of a greater satisfaction—provides its own criterion. Without disputing or asserting any particular theology, the author strips off the cloak of dogma with a lover’s confidence. It is the radical eros of negative theology tuning itself for another epoch. The exercise however is quite precise: “If you like, you can have this reaching out, wrapped up and enfolded in a single word. So as to have a better grasp of it, take just a little word, of one syllable rather than of two; for the shorter it is the better it is in agreement with this exercise of the spirit. Such a one is the word ‘God’ or the word ‘love.’ Choose which one you prefer, or any other according to your liking—the *word of one syllable that you like best*. Fasten this word to your heart, so that whatever happens it will never go away” (134).

A single syllable (elsewhere on the planet *om* had been suggested) focuses the meditation. It enfolds its outreach. Such a one-point exercise may better protect against the chatter of distractions and abstractions than a pure silence, yet without (as for example in the use of a whole verse of scripture or a verbal prayer) imposing any propositional content. In practice, a single syllable works very much like a mindful breath. Yet this exercise breathes with a quite Western and tempestuous affect: “With this word you are to beat upon this cloud and this darkness above you.” Not to push the darkness away, not out of fear or hostility, but—“with a sharp dart of longing love”—in order to enter its desirable darkness (134).

This chosen monosyllable will help you, he writes, resist the specific thought provoked even by its own meaning: “If the thought should offer you, out of its great learning, to analyze that word for you and to tell you its meanings, say to the thought that you want to keep it whole, and not taken apart or unfastened” (134).

A gracious way to talk back to one's own distractingly critical mind, no? It is in this way, he writes, "when all things are done away with, that you shall be carried up in *your affection* and above your understanding . . ." And it is to "the radiance of the divine darkness" that we are thus carried.¹⁰⁷

Does a deconstructive reading of negative theology, as well as its identification with a speculative neoplatonic mysticism, occlude this motif of affect, indeed of affection? Yet we discerned from the start of the Plato-Mosaic hybrid an eros irreducible to intellectual striving. As Jantzen further shows, the distinct strands of affective and speculative mysticism "were fruitfully combined" in writers such as Bonaventure and the Cloud author. "In *The Cloud*, in particular, the 'unknowing' of Dionysius is itself a term for love, and is contrasted sharply with knowledge."¹⁰⁸ This sharp opposition may be most strongly the case, in our cloud lineage, with the Cloud author, the one most impatient with the philosophical Neoplatonism that first yields the unknowing. But if this identification of the apophatic with the erotic holds, we have a fresh clue to a theological crossover between the negative and the relational. We have already seen eros appear for Dionysius as the very engine of unknowing. Indeed his identification of *divine* love with erotic yearning—of *theos* with *eros*—does not appear in *The Cloud*. But of course the Cloud author consistently does not *know* his God.

However, the anonymous author does read Moses' process of ascent as a model for "purifying yourself of all worldly, carnal and natural love in your affection."¹⁰⁹ Once, I stopped reading right there. So the rest of the sentence did not register: and "of everything that can be known according to its proper form in your intellect." However leary of the distracting attractions of the world, however sternly Augustinian in prioritizing the one great love over all the others, the cloud simply does not harbor any intellectualism of Platonic forms or of scholastic knowledge. It represents as radical a teaching of nonclinging to things, ideas, or self as does Buddhism; but the exodus from attachments is driven not by the overcoming of desire but by desire itself.

Nonetheless, a possible fold from the apophatic to the cosmological remains even more "unknown" than in our two earlier cloud-teachers. The erotic relation does not transfer from God to any other. So it is all the more surprising to find certain eco-material potentialities precipitating recently from this very author. I note two examples. First, the historian Nicola Masciandaro, in a deft essay called

"Unknowing Animals," brings animal theory, indeed a Deleuzian-Guattarian theory of "becoming-animal," to bear upon the Cloud. "Contrary to the general elision of the animal itself within mystical discourse . . . the Cloud-author gives animal consciousness the surprising task of exemplifying what he considers to be the essential faculty of contemplative work, the ability to experience, not only *what* but *that* one is."¹¹⁰ And, in an explicitly ecological reading, Gillian Rudd finds the *Cloud* referring directly to "the one in which Moses dwelt for six days on Mount Sinai." Rudd then tracks how "the Cloud author drew wittingly or otherwise on the way scientific understanding of clouds was expressed in the popular books of his day."¹¹¹ Based on these not-metaphorical cloud allusions (to darker-lower and higher-brighter "clouds") she stirs an ecological resonance favorable to the im/possibility of the present *Cloud*: "The combination of personal observation, traditional association, metaphor and empirical science found in popular science books of all ages, and, as I hope I have shown, also in *The Cloud of Unknowing*, reveals a longstanding inclination for the kind of interconnectedness advocated by greens, be they environmentalists, or ecologists."¹¹² The clouds thus serve transdisciplinarily—and transcontextually—"as vehicles for a text which seeks to expand the mind of its readers beyond the limits of the physical world, without denigrating that world."¹¹³

Still, even if we might from such an incongruously current perspective recharge the apophatic cloud with the matter of the nonhuman universe—do the socioethical resonances of Exodus find any audible echo? Here another recent fan of the cloud, one indeed who practiced the politics of liberation from oppression at least as rigorously as she studied Christian mysticism, delivers the needed tip-off. Dorothea Soelle deliberates on *The Cloud's* exposition of two distinct clouds. We only attain to the cloud of unknowing by way of another one. It is called "the cloud of forgetting." The cloud author instructs us to push all that distracts us into it. We are thus invited to ply the atmosphere between these two epistemic clouds: "If ever you come into this cloud, and live and work in it, as I bid you, just as this cloud of unknowing is above you, between you and your God, in the same way you must put beneath you a cloud of forgetting, between you and all the creatures that have ever been made."¹¹⁴

In her passionate (and yes, late) work, *The Silent Cry: Mysticism and Resistance*, Soelle argues that this forgetting signifies that "sensations, problems, and thoughts are to fall from us like ballast."¹¹⁵ Yet the whole meditative exercise is set

forth in its monastic context in defense of the “contemplative” over the “active” life, of Mary over Martha. Is this not precisely detachment from all worldly relations? Soelle immediately addresses the relational consternation that such counsel cannot fail to provoke among current readers:

The cloud of forgetting, to be spread out like a cover, is perhaps similar to what Jesus repeatedly expressed in the words, “do not be anxious.” What to eat? What to wear? The cases and anxieties of everyday toils and troubles belong, together with our endeavors to understand them, under the cloud of forgetting. That cloud is not a luxury for people without material cares; on the contrary, it makes it possible for the poor to find joy in life, music, laughter. Without the cloud of forgetting, which always and above all is one of self-forgetting, we remain in bondage to heteronomy, to the rule over our lives by powers such as hunger, cold, age, and illness.¹¹⁶

The activist Soelle not only disarms a predictable reaction but offers wisdom to any current politics of resistance. It is not then that we ought to reverse the medieval priority of contemplative over active practice. But might we rather practice their coinciding, in a contemplative activism that also activates contemplation? Such a performative chiasmus would answer to the present exercise in apophatic entanglement. For it teaches a connectivity filtered through this “forgetting,” a mindful relationality that does not leave us passive recipients of any and all. The cloud of forgetting might then suggest its own exodus, kin to Moses’ mountain retreat, which provides release from the status quo and a chance to recode the relations that constitute us rather than to merely repeat them. Such liberating nonattachment then coincides with a transformed and transforming desire. The teaching of the double cloud—of release and desire—puts me in mind of Holly Hillgardner’s comparative theological study of two medieval women mystics, one Christian, one Hindu, in both of whom she discovers a “passionate non-attachment.”¹¹⁷ Again the point of contemplating such texts would not be a return to their versions of ascetic retreat. But if the cloud of the impossible—not the same as either the cloud of unknowing or of forgetting—offers an apophatic hospitality today, it will partake of the atmosphere of this liberating love.

“With a devout, pleasing, impulsive love strive to pierce that darkness above you,”¹¹⁸ we are counseled. Freedom from delusion and distraction demands an active intensity of eros—aimed right at the dark cloud, in whichever form of

unknowing it occupies for you now. “You are to smite upon that thick cloud of unknowing with a sharp dart of longing love. Do not leave that work for anything that may happen” (131). Does the cloud-writer himself finally leave the work to foreclose on the unknowing? On the contrary, its object morphs along the way not into a divine thing but into no thing, into the Eckhartan and Eriugenan nothingness. In the interest of our own shared contemplation (which I hope retains some spirit of the *lectio divina*), consider a bit more of the text, toward its end, and lacking any theological closure: “Never mind at all if your senses have no understanding of this nothing; it is for this reason that I love it so much the better. . . . This nothing can be better *felt* than seen; it is most obscure and dark to those who have been looking at it only for a very short while” (252).

The affect, or feeling, feels a nothing, yet one “calls it All.” So our cloud writer would rather be “wrestling with this blind nothing, than to have such power that I could be everywhere bodily whenever I would, happily engaged with all this ‘something’ like a lord with his possessions” (252). Neither a little lordly ego nor a great Lord God enthroned with “his possessions” survives the cloud text. It is Michael Sells’s apophatic performative at its most mystically practical. Its God-talk never congeals, settles, answers. And perhaps for that reason something in this unknowing, in this radical and serene uncertainty, still offers itself as a gift (I write this on Christmas Eve). Particularly it offers itself to anyone for whom now the God-syllable is in question and in play.

“But now you put to me a question and say: ‘How might I think of [God] in himself, and what is he?’ And to this I can only answer thus: ‘I have no idea.’ For with your question you have brought me into that same darkness, into that same cloud of unknowing where I would you were yourself” (130).

So he answers the old question about the being or essence of God. No idea. Wish you were here.



*Somebody turn the lights out
there's so much more to see
in the darkest places.*

—CLOUD CULT, “EVERYBODY HERE IS A CLOUD”

The trail of clouds has traced a textual history whose density remains dark and whose exodus is incomplete. Its narrative of ascent only plunges us more deeply into unknowing. The needful forgetting and the mindful unknowing can never with certainty be distinguished from an ideologically convenient ignorance. I am, however, hopeful that the remembering of these ancient and medieval practices stirs current possibility: active—even activist. In our more world-tangled contemplations we may not resemble these ancestral cloud writers so much as love them. I no longer know how not to love their love of a love that exceeds anything you can name and that appears epiphanically almost, almost, as nothing—no Person, Being, One, God, no idea. But it *is* no more nothing than it *is* everything.

We have read in its sharp negations the opening of a luminous space where everything might find itself. In Gregory we hear not of a disentangled transcendence, nor of an invading omnipotence, but of a pervading infinity. Its Unbegotten does not flee relation but begets it eternally and unfolds it boundlessly. In Dionysius the iconoclasm becomes a self-implicating procedure: negation goes all the way up and comes down in the countless creaturely names of an Eros beguiled by the innumerable creatures. An apophatic panentheism suggests itself as effect of this *panonymous* (not) God. And the anonymous British monk will help us to forget all that distracts—from the affect, the practice, the present tense of the amorous cloud.

Yet this genealogy of the brilliant darkness remains alien, as does the whole of classical Christianity, to the prophetic ethos left shekhinically enfolded—envaginated—in the desert cloud. The premodern itinerary of the cloud would be one long detour from a just ecology of the future, were it not for the sites of resonance between the mystical ecstasy and the ethical exodus. And those resonances register in our bodies, in our densely interactive flesh, mired in the intra-relations of a planet: if their possibility is now to be activated, if abstract possibility is to become actual. The great movements of nonviolent engagement characterizing the end of the modern era have tarried at those sites. Fully material, fully spirited subjects have come into focus against the cloudy background: they ply the relations of the concrete contexts, forgotten and remembered, of their struggles. Theologically, however, we are still missing along the apophatic trajectory the theory of a panentheistic embodiment, of a theos related to a cosmos in such a way as to bring the relations between creatures into prominence: into *theoria*, into view.

And so in the interest of the chiasmic movement of this project, we witness in the next chapter and in another reader of Dionysius, the fifteenth-century Cusa, how an apophatically entangled cosmology, dense with the interrelated bodies of the world, comes into its own. If only for its fleeting moment. In the robust panentheism of a divine *complicatio*, the asymmetrical interplay of apophasis and kataphasis precipitates for the first time in Christian thought an infinity explicitly unfolded, *explicans*, *in and as* the manifold world. When at the earliest dawn of the Renaissance the darkly glowing cloud reappears in the Cusan epiphany, then, it will have enfolded in its meditation the whole ancestry of negative theology. Which will unfold otherwise.

three

ENFOLDING AND UNFOLDING GOD

CUSANIC COMPLICATIO

I am not hereby giving my final endorsement to the learned ignorants of the Cusanus philosophism.

—JAMES JOYCE, FINNEGANS WAKE

FROM HIS TROUBLED EPISCOPAL SEAT IN BRIXEN, Nicolas of Cusa composes in 1453 a letter to his friends, the monks of Tegernsee, over in Bavaria. It takes the form of *De visione Dei*, his major book since *De docta ignorantia*, written thirteen years earlier. In the parcel he includes a painting as a gift, meant for the brothers to use as a “sensible experiment” (*sensibile experimentum*). In his preface he introduces the painting to them as an instance of a genre he identifies as “the all-seeing image.” “Through the painter’s subtle art its face is made to appear as if looking on all around it,” he writes. “Many excellent pictures of this kind may be found, such as that of the archeress in the forum of Nuremberg; that of the great artist Rogier in the very valuable painting which hangs in the court at Brussels; that of a Veronica in my chapel at Koblenz.”¹ The list bursts with the colors of the early Renaissance. Rogier van der Weyden, for instance, whose work Cusa saw firsthand in Brussels (thought to be a self-portrait of the artist, since lost), was a brilliant contemporary experimenter in the arts of perspective. And according to such diverse interpreters as Ernst Cassirer, Michel de Certeau, and Karsten Harries, so is Cusa. But what would this avant-garde perspectivism, radiant with the

positive sensory phenomena of the world, have to do with the old cloud of the imperceptible, which Cusa almost single-handedly conveys to earliest modernity?

When viewing one of these “all-seeing” paintings, you watch its figure’s eyes watching you. You “discover that the face looks unfailingly on all who walk before it even from opposite directions.”² Its eyes move with your movement. The viewer is gazing upon *its* painted gaze: the observer is being observed by the observed. Entranced by this instantaneous interrelation of seeing with the seen, Cusa has titled his book with a wordplay: *De visione Dei*, the “vision of God,” a two-way genitive—is it our vision of God or God’s vision of us?—mirrors the mirror-play of the image enigmatically. “What other, O Lord, is your seeing . . . than your *being seen* by me?”³ It is one thing to note that a seeing eye is seen; quite another, to identify the active *seeing* with the passive *being seen*. What is happening to the notion of God in the mirror of the omnivoyant image? Does it appear now as the effect of my vision, a perspectival projection? Or is my vision the effect of its gaze? It is the movement of this epistolary contemplation on the moving gaze of the immobile icon, a movement that stirs one seeming contradiction after the next, that will eventually push Cusa into the cloud. And it is in that cloud that he crashes into the “wall” of a theological “impossibility.”

In this chapter we observe an optics, a *theoria*, of the infinite. It begins in *De docta ignorantia*, where already the medieval cloud of unknowing morphs into a new perspective on the infinite and thus on perspective itself. It is not a matter of a special privilege of the sense of sight—though indeed Cusa plies throughout his works the interplay of *theos* and *theoria*, “vision.” The practice of the learned ignorance will itself provide a new lens upon the relation of the infinite that *theos* names for the unbounded manifold of finite creatures. In Cusa, as de Certeau argues in a late, loving essay, “each particular positive entity is no longer defined by its status in an ontologically hierarchized cosmos.” Each creature appears now as the “direct witness to . . . a ‘point of view’” whose relation to others “manifests infinite potentiality.”⁴

It is this early Renaissance experiment in perspective, in other words, that we will see negative theology begin to unfold the positive materiality of the universe. In this perspective the world gets recognized, *impossibly* for Christian thought to that moment, as *itself* a certain kind of infinite. We will therefore first trace the contemplative logic that moves Cusa from the painting to movement itself—and into the cloud: a cloud painted with the dark brilliance of the Dionysian lineage.

But this is another epoch, and in Cusa a deep resistance to the regnant Aristotelian logic of the scholastics kicks in, along with fresh readings of classical, hermetic, and apophatic texts. Layers, strata, striations of tradition and innovation fold with an eerie succinctness into Cusa's pages, in the cloudy precision of the learning mindfully "learned in its own ignorance."

The present Cloud's own inquiry can then push forward only by reaching back into the cosmology of the 1440 *De docta ignorantia*. For in Cusa, as I hope to show, the knowing ignorance discloses not just an apophatic panentheism, but the holographic vision of a radically interrelated universe. Here, in other words, appears for Western thought the deep fold between nonknowing and nonseparability. It will be important to notice how his mindful nonknowing yields—in terms of the material universe of physics—a quite impossibly prescient *knowledge*. The earth moves.

I have suggested that Cusa performs for this project the chiasmic crossover of the mystical cloud into a full-orbed relationalism. His historic antecedents press God beyond God into an amorous infinity. But in Cusa the divine all-in-all yields the *creaturely* each-in-each. It was he, not any of the others, who presented himself (uninvited) as an ancestor for a theology of apophatic entanglement. Thinking with him as much as about him, yes, entangled, entrained before I knew it, I will be asking: what is in Cusa the relation of the infinite to the mattering multiplicity of perspectives? As complication becomes explicit, does the relational darkness of the world bring new possibilities to light?⁵ Do we witness here the birth of a modernity that might have, but failed to, unfold?

THE PAINTED FACE

There is only a perspectival seeing, only a perspectival "knowing"; the more affects we are able to put into words about a thing, the more eyes, various eyes we are able to use for the same thing, the more complete will be our "concept" of the thing, our "objectivity."

—FRIEDRICH NIETZSCHE, *GENEALOGY OF MORALS*

Cusa meant his exercise, his *sensibile experimentum*, to supplement the brothers' reading of his book, to illustrate and test it in experience. They are to hang the painting up, stand around it equidistantly, as along the periphery of a circle, and notice that "from whatever place one observes it the face will seem to observe

oneself alone.” Thus “you are present to all and to each . . .”—he frequently transposes his text into prayerful address—“as if you had concern for no other.”⁶ Then they are to move about. And its gaze will move with each of them as they move, with all of them simultaneously, no matter where in the room they walk, even as it remains fixed in the immobility of the iconic surface. As the boundary between subject and object kaleidoscopes and blurs, the vision itself comes into focus: “while I look at this painted face from the east, it likewise appears that it looks at me in the east, and when I look at it from the west or the south it also appears to look at me in the west or the south.”⁷

Cusa had considerable experience with the cardinal directions. As a German student emigrant to Italy, he was eventually as a canon lawyer tangled in the great turmoil over papal power at the Council of Basel; later he rejoins the papal party to be dispatched East on the great ecumenical journey to Byzantium of 1437. The breakthrough of *docta ignorantia*—that idea, that key—had come to him in the night “at sea en route back.” He would for the rest of his life be constantly in motion through Europe as a papal legate, reformer, and cardinal. And somehow he is finding time to enfold the mobile perspective in writing as well.

Cusa would have encountered the contemplative use of icons during the expedition to Constantinople. Indeed the Eastern church, when not in the throes of iconoclasm, also reads its icons of Christ or other sacred figures as mysteries of reciprocity. “Whoever sees it sees himself or herself. Whoever sees it is seen.”⁸ Thus the art historian Marie-José Mondzain interprets the icon’s gaze. “Christ,” she writes, “is not in the icon; the icon is toward Christ, who never stops withdrawing.” An icon effects an apophysis of the eyes. The silent image escapes not only speech but gaze.⁹ The icon, contemplating us, becomes in its turn “God’s gaze at the contemplator’s flesh, which gets caught in an informational and transformational circuit of relationships.”¹⁰ In this Byzantine medium the epistemic and the ontological flow nonseparably, even as the seen is also always already seeing. Yet Cusa has in view works of fifteenth-century Europe, very different—precisely in their three-dimensional perspective—from the flat, symbolic surfaces of medieval art, Eastern or Western. The omnivoyance has reappeared in new form. It now grips the viewer in the intensified point of view of a radiantly worldly spatio-temporality. And the paintings let Cusa bring to view point of view as such.

Jean-Luc Nancy writes of the very medium of painting: “The self-coincidence of the image in itself excludes its conformity to a perceived object or to a coded

sentiment or well-defined function. On the contrary, the image never stops tightening and condensing into itself. That is why it is immobile, calm and flat in its presence, the *coming-together and co-inciding of an event and an eternity*.¹¹ This language of condensing inadvertently echoes the Cusan “contraction,” and indeed *coincidentia* of movement and stillness, in which, later, in *De visione*, that very coinciding becomes event, incident—the co-incident. Even or especially in its performance of the illusory art of perspective, the painted icon marks its point of view as such and thus distinguishes its simulacra from conformity to objects.

For instance, in a painting I have enjoyed at the Boston Museum of Fine Arts, Rogier van der Weyden paints the apostle Luke sitting across from Mary and sketching her portrait while she gazes at the baby she is feeding. Thus citing the tradition of Luke as patron saint of painters, the artist foregrounds painterly perspective itself. The columnar architecture of the painting opens out onto a veranda and into the infinite horizon, at which another couple, their backs to us, gazes, preventing our own gaze from reifying the iconically lactating Madonna. Our own gaze is conducted through the circuit of relations away from idolatrous fixations. It is possible in historical context “to interpret the attempts of painters such as Rogier van der Weyden to grasp something of the infinity of space as a symbolic activity, analogous to our attempt to grasp God.”¹² The lost painting that for Cusa was an event, a bit differently, represents a genre whose subjects’ gazes fix our own and so provoke the synchronistic circuit between fixity and mobility, passivity and activity, being seen and seeing.

Fascinated with Cusa’s “perceptible experimentation,” Michel de Certeau finds him in this epistolary work “dislodging its addressees from their prejudicial position.” It thus “makes way” for the entire Cusan theory. “It is a question of an ‘exercise’ (praxis). A doing will make possible a saying. This propaedeutics is moreover customary in spiritual development and in the relations between master and disciple: ‘Do it, and you will understand afterward.’ It also has the import of a laboratory observation whose theoretical interpretation will come later. It plays on the double register of a ‘spiritual exercise’ and a scientific experiment.”¹³ Indeed, given the astrophysical breakthrough we will witness unfolding in Cusa’s cosmology, this doubling also registers the emergent interplay of apophysis and cosmology (neither of which occupy de Certeau, who focuses on the breakthrough of perspectivism in the 1453 text). Yet in the opening address to the “dearest brothers” the exercise is prescribed precisely as a practice of the negative strategy that we

have tracked through the last chapter: “by means of a very simple and commonplace method, I will attempt to lead you experientially into the *most sacred darkness*.” The cipher of the dark cloud is luminously clear.

In this text of “the painted face” as the “icon of God,” and so as the visible image of the invisible God, Cusa alludes to the Pauline figure of the face: that face seen in Corinthians “in a mirror, an enigma.” But here *every* face comes into play and into question: “*In all faces* the face of faces is seen veiled and in an enigma.” Thus distributing, disturbing or diffracting any face-to-face imaginary of God, Cusa proceeds to paraphrase the hymnic opening of Dionysius’s *Mystical Theology*: “It is not seen unveiled so long as one does not enter into a certain secret and hidden silence beyond all faces where there is no knowledge or concept of a face.”¹⁴ Then Cusa condenses our long historical trail of clouds into one metonymically overloaded sentence: “This cloud, mist, darkness, or ignorance into which whoever seeks your face enters when one leaps beyond every knowledge and concept is such that below it your face cannot be found except veiled.”¹⁵

To push into this cloud is to leap through the veil. The nebulous veil does not pose any rigid boundary. The seeker does not remain passively content with not-knowing but is driven forward by an ardent desire to know more, to see more. But the knowing will not be satisfied by any object, not even a divine one; and the seeing sought “knows that so long as it sees anything what it sees is not what it is seeking.” Within this self-subverting discourse, it is again a Neoplatonic eros that energizes the leap: “your seeing inflames me to the love of you and through inflaming feeds me.” No reifying knowledge but an intimate knowing (*yada*) is sought, by a desire inflamed by tantalizing glimpses, and in the interstices of a mathematically rigorous speculative capacity, fed not by lack but by love.



The precise truth shines forth incomprehensibly in the darkness of our ignorance.

—NICHOLAS OF CUSA, *DE DOCTA IGNORANTIA*

In recapitulating the cloud lineage, Cusa presumes his own earlier explication of negative theology in the culmination of part I of *De docta ignorantia*. Its “sacred ignorance” is never a matter of pitting negation against affirmation but of affirm-

ing that “in theology negations are true and affirmations are inadequate.” Logoi about theos are not therefore false, but prone to idolatry. It is worth returning often to the following crystallization of the precise relation of the apophatic to the kataphatic, with its ironic allusion to the *eidolon* of Caesar: “Therefore the theology of negation is so necessary to the theology of affirmation that without it God would not be worshiped as the infinite God but as creature, and such worship is idolatry, for it gives to an image that which belongs only to truth itself.”¹⁶

The problem is not the image—not even “the painted face”—but the gaze that turns it to idol. Theology itself is never not tempted to idolize its own propositions, its “affirmative names” (such as, he avers, the “Father,” “the Son,” and the “Holy Spirit.”) In his exposition of the relation of affirmative and negative theologies, Cusa does not seek a balance of the two or a *via eminentia* beyond both, but rather their mutual enfolding in the *coincidentia oppositorum* he has coined in the same text. And in the context of the *docta ignorantia* the co-incidence of negative and affirmative theologies answers precisely to that of the infinity of the all-enfolding *complicatio* and the unfolding, *explicatio*, of all finitudes. For “according to the theology of negation, nothing other than infinity is found in God. Consequently”—as in Gregory of Nyssa’s *epektasis*—“God is unknowable either in this world or in the world to come, for in this respect every creature is darkness, which cannot comprehend infinite light” (34). The infinity is itself paraphrased throughout part 1 as the *complicatio*, the divine folding-together, or enfolding, a concept drawn from the twelfth-century Thierry of Chartres. If the infinite folds together as Godself all the finite creatures, the creation will itself therefore no longer count as finite. The cosmology of part 2 will thus leap beyond the prior negative and affirmative theologies.

It is precisely the separability, the divisibility, the oppositionalism of creaturely affirmations—the names that creatures give and the names of creatures—that breaks down vis-à-vis the divine: “Since, therefore, no such particular, no such discrete thing, which has an opposite, could apply to God other than in the most diminutive way, affirmations, as Dionysius says, are unsuitable” (122). But God is not one thing as opposed to another, not an entity transcendently separated from other entities: “But because God is not a substance which is not all things and to which something is opposed and because God is also not a truth which is not all things without opposition . . .” (122), the affirmative names (always picking out a

being, an essence, an entity) remain inadequate. For God, as infinite, “is not any one thing more than God is all things.”

Pantheism panic alert? It may sound throughout Cusa: this God “unfolds in and *as* all things” (135). But “the panic is as predictable alarm as it is misplaced”: God *is* not all things, any more than God *is* any thing.¹⁷ God is not a substance including all or excluding all. God is not such a One. Nor such a many. Indeed—hear again the echo of an autodeconstructive Platonism—“from the standpoint of infinity, God is neither one nor more than one.”¹⁸ Each of these “conjectures”—and that is his word for what theology may do; it may not “know” but conjecture—is uttered in the tone of a loving contemplation, strangely nondefensive. It is the early Renaissance, a moment relatively free of the inquisition.

Has Cusa’s nonknowing nonetheless rendered theology meaningless—no logos left for theos? His answer brings a fresh twist to the conversation: “if affirmative names apply, they apply to God *only in relation to creatures*.”¹⁹ For we take any attributes—creator, justice, father, son—from creatures and so “transfer names to God.” He is trying to say something about metaphor. But something more radical than a mere transfer of human qualities to “God” is at stake. By insisting that anything we “may say about God is based on a relation to creatures,” he undoes any claims of theology to transcend its perspective, the sociocreaturely context of its relations.

Let me suggest that from this apophasis unfolds, becomes explicit, a radical relationality, and so the relativity of perspectivism, that was gestating in apophatic theology all along. For perspective is nothing other than a *view*. A point of view only exists as one among many. So it may affirm its own perspective only relatively, only in relation. Perspective casts the shadow of its own possible negation. Affirmative relationality unfolds from negative theology as the fold, angle, or—in Cusa’s language—contraction, that is perspective itself. As Karsten Harries, for whom the Cusan infinite is key to the emergence of a modern or indeed post-modern perspectivism, argues, the “doctrine of learned ignorance—on which, as he himself says, his cosmological speculations depend—is inseparable from this principle of perspective. To become learned about one’s ignorance is to become learned about the extent to which what we took to be knowledge is subject to the distorting power of perspective.”²⁰

Indeed the learned ignorance opens with an appeal to a method of perspective, by which one compares what is relatively known to what is relatively unknown.

“Every inquiry is comparative and uses the means of comparative proportion.”²¹ Hopkins translates this helpfully as “comparative relation.” But as for Cusa the infinite escapes all proportion (*ratio*)—and therefore comprehension—one wants the allusion to a scholastic debate. Cusa in fact departs here from the tradition of the Thomistic *analogia entis*, by which we are enabled to know God not univocally but proportionally. For Cusa the boundless excess of the infinite at once exposes the finitude of our perspectives—which are always comparative relations—and enflames our relation to that very infinity. Perspective escapes both the univocity and equivocity that worry Aquinas, without resolving itself in the eminent way of analogy. More simply, it can be said to open a third way, that of a participatory ontology indebted to Thomas but radicalized, open-ended, and so precisely infinite, a way between relativism and certainty into a modernity that never quite was.²²

YOU ARE MOVED WITH ME

To return to the “icon of God”: if the image eludes idolization, it also destabilizes vision, putting perspective itself in view and in motion. In this it differs from the emergent figurative art, which anchors its angle of perception in a fixed and external perspective.²³ De Certeau admires the rendition of the “movement . . . that does not offer any object to be grasped,” that is caught up “in the relations of *subject to subject*.”²⁴ He captures in Cusa’s style and content an “excess without object, an ‘impossible’ that one can ‘grasp’ in itself only by believing it also of another.”²⁵ It is then the existential interplay of shifting, contracting perspectives with the “you” of this discourse that produces this enigmatic insight: “Your vision, Lord, is your face.” This “you” refuses to behave as an object of vision; it appears in its nonseparability from the perspective, the “face,” by which it is viewed. And, as the following meditation demonstrates, the perspective is not a mere angle of vision but a feedback loop charged with any manner of passionate affect: “Consequently, whoever looks on you with a loving face will find only your face looking on oneself with love. And the more one strives to look on you with greater love, the more loving will one find your face. Whoever looks on you with anger will likewise find your face angry. Whoever looks on you with joy will also find your face joyous, just as is the face of one who looks on you.”²⁶

Like all apophatic thinkers, Cusa exposes to view the anthropomorphism that infects our theologies. But with him it is not just a matter of projections of the human face onto the divine. For when “a person attributes a face to you, one does not seek it outside the human species since one’s judgment is contracted within human nature.”²⁷ *Contraction* here signifies the way in which an individual *enfolds* the potentiality of its species. Contraction and fold are closely allied notions in Cusa. So contraction produces perspective: “if a lion were to attribute a face to you, it would judge it only as a lion’s face; if an ox, as an ox’s, if an eagle, as an eagle’s.”²⁸ God appears back to us in our various images, personal, lionese, ox- or eagle-like, in a relation that relativizes any theological image. The perspectival God, however, is not identified with any point of view. God enfolds all and unfolds within all, but, as Cusa puts it splendidly, “is not contracted, but *attracts*.” This power of attraction, like Whitehead’s Divine Eros, does not control but lures.

If contraction effects the illusions of perspective, it also makes a perspective *possible*. Cusa is leading the brothers along the outer edge of perspective, where a viewpoint not only frames but partially, in a proto-Kantian sense, constructs its other. Is he leading them to reflect upon that dynamism that Feuerbach would much later call projection? From his point of view one might read projection not as mere delusion but as necessary contraction. Of course one might infer from our inevitable projections the divine nonexistence. Cusa, with greater nuance, demonstrates the nonexistence of any representable God-object, any discrete divine being. But that unknowability remains the function of its indiscrete *infinity*; it effects here not atheism (though Rosenzweig suspects it of such) but *relation*.

Reflecting on the philosophical implications from a neo-Kantian point of view, Ernst Cassirer discerned in this Cusan relationality a “pure interpenetration,” anticipating the best of modern epistemology. Like Harries half a century later, Cassirer reads the painted face as “a sensible parable” of a new perspectivalism. “The true sense of the divine first discloses itself when the mind no longer remains standing at *one* of these relationships, nor even at their simple total, but rather collects them all in the unity of a vision.” Then, continues Cassirer, “we can understand that it is absurd for us even to want to think the absolute in itself without such a determination through an individual point of view.”²⁹

The individual viewpoint, however, only takes place in its interdependence with the others: the “more eyes,” the more vision. All perspectives—in the “free

will” of their individuality the early modern Cusa builds always in—remain relative to each other and simultaneously to the encompassing infinite.³⁰ Cassirer, who in 1921 offered perhaps the first major philosophical interpretation of Einstein, was rocked by Cusa’s anticipation of special relativity.³¹ The question of movement relative to a standpoint, to what appears to be standing, had occupied Cusa in *De docta ignorantia*, in a passage that does eerily read like Einstein.³² “How would a passenger know that one’s ship was being moved, if one did not know that the water was flowing past and if the shores were not visible from the ship in the middle of the water? Since it always appears to every observer, whether on the earth, the sun, or another star, that one is, as if, at an immovable center of things and that all else is being moved one will always select different poles in relation to oneself, whether one is on the sun, the earth, the moon, Mars, and so forth.”³³

As Harries comments, “the poles by which we orient ourselves are fictions, created by us. As such they reflect what happens to be the standpoint of the observer, his particular perspective.”³⁴ (He thinks it not accidental that the learned ignorance to which Cusa attributes his cosmology came to him on the long journey by sea.) We will soon return to the astrophysical meaning of this parable with which Cusa is making his impossible leap beyond the medieval certainty of an earth fixed at the center of the universe. Here let us take in the movement of his thinking on this momentous question of “being moved.” From the materiality of the cosmos unfolding out of the apophatic theology, it turns to the painting as a material parable of the apophatic relation. Here the meaning of “being moved” registers in a more humanly relational key. “You . . . are my journey’s companion; wherever I go your eyes always rest on me. Moreover, your seeing is your moving. *Therefore, you are moved with me* and never cease from moving so long as I am moved.”³⁵

We see again that this “being moved” carries both the sense of an affective passion (you move me, I am moved to tears) and of a spatial relation. Indeed this relationality that relativizes knowledge oscillates tonally between the poles of the cool cosmological speculation of the polymath and the heat of apophatic eros. But the co-incident of intimacy and infinity in the God-relation, in, that is, the finite viewpoint as address of the infinite as You, cannot then settle into an authoritative theology, cardinal appropriate.

Instead, the exercise in relational perspective releases a cascade of conceptual folds, problems, and contradictions. It moves the contemplation of the icon to a

climactic crisis, an aporetic event of movement itself. It is precipitated by the following recapitulation: “You, Lord, see all things and each single thing at the same time. You are moved with all that are moved and stand with all that stand.”³⁶ This apparently innocent theologoumenon releases the discursive turbulence of something which “seems wholly inaccessible and impossible.” It will require, beyond any calm unsaying (let alone any placed feminist horror), “courage to do violence to myself.”

ENTER THE CLOUD

The conceptual crisis must be read against the background of the long dominant classical theism. Its God moves the world but is never *moved by* the world. As the Unmoved Mover “He” cannot be “done unto,” affected, altered. Indeed the God of the Aristotelian-Thomist *actus purus* cannot take the passive voice. *From a Broken Web* had noted how Aristotle, and following him Thomas, identified the masculine with the rational and the active, the act alone worthy of the image of God and capable of the separative transcendence of its absolute; the feminine (no coincidentia here) is linked to passive matter and reactive affect and reads as “the category of monster.”³⁷ It happens that Cusa humorously identifies his own learned ignorance (and its awkwardly Germanic Latin) with “the unusual, even if monstrous.”³⁸ I do not suggest that Cusa is directly challenging orthodoxy, let alone its gender. He was the most diplomatically nuanced of monsters. He presumes a classically changeless absolute, even as he questions its terms. For “you neither are moved nor rest, since you are . . . absolute from all these things that can be conceived or named.”³⁹

Gazing all the while at the painted face, Cusa probes on: “you stand and you proceed and you neither stand nor proceed.” And so he refuses—even if the immobility of the “icon of God” and his own scholastic reason demand it—to grant “rest” its classical privilege. For “motion and rest and opposition and whatever can be expressed” are all “subsequent to this infinity” (you).⁴⁰ Here he may be following a gesture of Plotinus. If the absolute is the infinite, it cannot be identified with immobility, changelessness, rest. For these signify nothing but opposition to motion and change. And the optics of the infinite brooks no opposite, no over-

against. The divine boundlessness, in other words, belies the boundary formed by classical theo-logic: of mover versus moved, active versus passive, aseity versus affect. By way of this specific instance of “being moved,” it is the root epistemology of opposition, based on Aristotle’s law of the excluded middle, that Cusa confronts—as he acknowledges “the coincidence of opposites, above all capacity of reason.”

And now the cloud: “Hence, I experience how necessary it is for me to enter into the cloud and to admit the coincidence of opposites, above all capacity of reason, and to seek there the truth where impossibility confronts me.”⁴¹ The cloud lies above, always overhead. But we completely miss its meaning if we coat that “above” in the stale associations of a mind above a body or a truth transcending its world. This reflects the Dionysian darkness above the light in which the cognitive verticalism of the classical ascent is itself suspended. “And above reason, above even every highest intellectual ascent when I will have attained to that which is unknown to every intellect and which every intellect judges to be the most removed from truth, there are you, my God, who are absolute necessity.”⁴² The most removed from truth. At least from the truth of pontiffs, professors, pundits—of those who are in the know. But Cusa does not leave us in mere darkness: “And the more that cloud of impossibility is recognized as obscure and impossible, the more truly the necessity shines forth and the less veiled it appears and draws near.”⁴³

The cloud of impossibility is emitting its epiphanous luminosity. In an earlier chapter he has explicated this cloud, or darkness, as an optical effect: “for that cloud in one’s eye originates from the exceeding brightness of the light of the sun. The denser, therefore, one knows the cloud to be the more one truly attains the invisible light in the cloud.”⁴⁴ Not by overcoming its darkness, but through the frightening entrance into it. In distant memory Sinai rumbles.

Does the language of “the necessity,” however, reinscribe metaphysical certitude at a higher level? Is it another ontotheological reappropriation, foreclosing on the unpredictable? Or, by contrast, does it here signify the very condition of its possibility—the perspective of the “impossible possibility of the im-possible”? Its necessity would then coincide with that impossibility which, according to Derrida, “is also the condition or chance of the possible.” To it testifies the “must,” for example, of the gift: “therefore giving, if there is any, if it is possible, *must* appear

impossible.” Or, regarding forgiveness, “this impossibility is not simply negative. This means that the impossible *must* be done.” If this ethically eventive discourse appears incommensurate with any Neoplatonic ascent, perhaps this semblance of mere contradiction emits its own cloud. Derrida in this late conversation describes negative theology as “a non-knowing that is not lack, not sheer obscurantism, ignorance, or non-science, but simply something that is not of the same nature as knowing.”⁴⁵ And now, as we noticed in chapter 1, crediting Cusa’s *docta ignorantia* with this alternative possibility, Derrida voices carefully “a certain impossible possibility of saying the event.” This speech will not trade surprise for knowledge, but “produces the event beyond the confines of knowledge. . . . This kind of saying is found in many experiences where, ultimately, the possibility that such and such an event will happen appears impossible.”⁴⁶

In other words what appears impossible, what takes place beyond knowledge, may become—in the event, in the place, of the cloud—not only possible, but actual. From this perspective the Derridean necessity of what “must appear impossible” resonates with the Cusan necessity of impossibility across the great gap of historical incommensurability. The indeterminacy upon which poststructuralism, like process thought, insists, is hardly formulable in Cusa’s context. It finds an antecedent, however, in his radical avowal of freedom. So if we let Derrida supplement Cusa’s necessary impossibility with the event of the indeterminate, Cusa may simultaneously deepen Derrida’s impossibility with its own apophatic potentiality. And Derrida gently magnifies the ethics beyond the mystical intimations. The hospitality of Derrida’s political notions, the attractive power of the “democracy to come,” of a more democratic democracy, the “indeconstructible justice” of the more just justice, may paradoxically become, through the ancestral hospitality of this cloud, *more actually possible*. For the cloud anticipates what Derrida has called the “ordeal of undecidability” to which their apparent impossibilities, the planetary crowd of them, subject us—while not for a moment sparing us the necessity of deciding.

If the rhetoric of the impossible is not to paint a quixotic face upon postmodern hopelessness, it *must* not muffle our attention to what may really—against the odds of habit, against the determinations of power—be *possible*. Indeed, of the word *possible* Derrida insists that it “is not simply ‘different from’ or ‘the opposite

of' impossible, [which is] *why in this case, 'possible' and 'impossible' say the same thing.*"⁴⁷ If here the logic of the coincidentia oppositorum seems to haunt deconstruction, perhaps through its countercultural European reverberations via Giordano Bruno, it *must* be heard also in its originaive context, still unencumbered by absorption in Hegelian dialectic or Jungian individuation. Then the seen seer, the moved mover, and, as we will soon discuss, the created creator, may approximate the "nondialectizable contradictions" for which Derrida gives the examples of "the 'maybe,' the possible-impossible, the unique as substitutable, singularity as reiterable"—contradictions that for Derrida "constitute so many challenges to traditional logic."⁴⁸ Caputo has now unfolded an entire theology of "maybe" from the aporetics of the impossible.⁴⁹ Indeed he notes that "the oppositions and conflicts we everywhere encounter" send us "hurtling into dialectical opposition, into war, only if we do not look up and see these opposites in their point of 'coincidence' (Eckhart and Cusanus—whom Milbank pits against Scotus as the beginnings of an alternate modernity)."⁵⁰

The event of the aporia—the thwarting of our presuppositions, our reason, our best reasons—drives deconstruction even as it socks Cusa into the cloud. The desired co-incidence happens not without *incident*. The slap and slam of contradiction serve Cusa as the price of admission to the cloud. The impasse of the impossible in this passage of *De visione* turns into *passage* itself. In a dreamlike conflation of word-pictures, a wall suddenly appears in the cloud. A hard obstruction within the misty uncertainty. The wall is said to be "girded about with the coincidence of contradictories," formed or woven of these apparently exclusive polarities—apparent, because here they materialize as inseparably interwoven. "This is the wall of paradise, and it is there in paradise that you reside."⁵¹ Not a glimpse of heavenly afterlife, but of an almost accessible ecstasy, the holy of holies where "you"—the infinite interlocutor—are ever immanent.

If any polar logic slams right into the wall, we read next that "the wall's gate is guarded by the highest spirit of reason, and"—transgressively—that "unless it is overpowered, the way in will not lie open." Is Cusa advocating confrontation with the angelic gatekeeper of Eden, Gabriel himself? Or does this highest spirit perhaps symbolize the whole theological legacy? The Angelic Doctor? The tutelary spirit of scholasticism, Aristotle? Or Cusa's rationalist superego? This, at any rate,

is the boundary-violation that Cusa marks with “the courage to do violence to *oneself*.” This is not some variation of Medieval self-flagellation. For Cusa—perhaps the finest reasoner of his epoch—such challenges to traditional logic hurt.

We have to do here with existential contradiction, oppositions that pinch and paralyze, not with an abstract dialectics of preestablished opposites. If the text time-travels, it has us ask: What impossibility do you crash against now? Which cloud of intensified uncertainty must you enter? What contradiction between immobility and movement, paralysis and action, realism and hope, love and responsibility, justice and forgiveness, ultimacy and doubt? What transgression might see you through?

CREATABLE CREATOR

*For I am confronted by the wall of absurdity, which is the wall of the coincidence
of creating with being created, as if it were impossible.*

—NICHOLAS OF CUSA

After the glimpse through the wall, the author’s perspective is carefully marked: “when I am at the door of the coincidence of opposites . . .” (252). The teaching of the image, whose seeing is its being seen, now bursts into a theo-optics that—far from merely privileging sight as a predictable critique must presume all along—collapses every convention of vision, physical or spiritual. “For you are there where ‘speaking, seeing, hearing, tasting, touching, reasoning, knowing . . . are the same’ (253).⁵² In one way this pansensorium makes explicit what is implied by the traditional unity of divine attributes. But something else is going on in the crisis, the epiphany, of this synesthetic cascade.

Here seeing “coincides with *being seen*, hearing with *being heard*, tasting with *being tasted*, touching with *being touched*. . . .” This series comprises a disclosure of divine *passivities*, each correlated to an activity. And each is “impossible,” forbidden by the Aristotelian logic “guarded by the angel stationed at the entrance of paradise.”⁵³ But Cusa, in this thinking, this sensing, this writing that hurts, resists particularly the angel of *actus purus*. The invisible one whom he “sees” in this vision, still unfolding the “sensible experiment,” he addresses thus: “You are visible

by all creatures and you see all. In that you see all you *are seen by all*.” We have to do not with the privileged vision for the mystagogue. This is a sight utterly available to all—invisible not because of its distance but because of its proximity. “You, therefore, my invisible God, are seen by all and in all sight you are seen by everyone who sees.” But this intimacy does not flatten into pure immanence. “You who are invisible, who are both absolute from everything visible and infinitely superexalted, are seen *in* every visible thing.”⁵⁴ It is the “in” of a panentheism, still clothed in an absolute—but one that with Cusan irony can be kept outside nothing at all. It is absolute not as separate from all things, but as less separable than anything else and therefore different from everything.

In this passage there occurs a yet more dramatic co-incident of the activity with the passivity of God. “But this wall is both everything and nothing. For you, who confront *as if you were both all things and nothing at all* dwell inside that high wall which no natural ability can scale by its own power.”⁵⁵ So the freedom of a gift, undaunted by the boogymen of an atheism of nothing, or a pantheism of everything, presses on: “For I am confronted by the wall of absurdity, which is the wall of the coincidence of creating with being created, *as if it were impossible for creating to coincide with being created*.”⁵⁶

And yet apparently it does. The “as if” already puts a crack in this impossibility. But how can God the Creator also *be created*? How can the uncreated be also creature? Truly an absurdity for any received theology. For “creating and being created alike are not other than communicating your being to all things so that *you are all things in all things* and yet remain absolute from them all.” This divine in-and-as-all is the very being of creation. The divine “all in all” is not eschatologically deferred. Yet difference is not collapsed. Immanence then would not undo the distinction of God and world but their division. That it remains so nearly impossible to put this “you” into *theos logos*—without indulging in wasteful polemics or evasive abstractions—is a symptom of the cloud. And elsewhere Cusa thematizes that nonseparability of God from the world *as* the apophatic: “we see most truly this indivisibility is not apprehensible by any name nameable by us or concept formable.”⁵⁷ On the other hand, it is exactly what he does name—as a conjecture, not a comprehension—*non aliud*, not other: than itself or than any other. “Non aliud” is another discursive apophasis, which is at the same time another experimental kataphasis.⁵⁸

Nonetheless, this theos calls, it communicates, it seeks to be communicated—and so to *be created*: “to call is to create, and to communicate is to be created.” To communicate is to be created: yes, surely any event of dialogue, of significance conveyed and received, does constitute me anew. Yet it is *God* being created in this communication. At a certain point Cusa seems to solve the absurdity thus: the infinite God is “beyond this coincidence of creating with being created” and is “neither creating nor creatable.” Has apophysis just restored orthodoxy? If so it is restored only in being simultaneously transgressed—for he then immediately refuses to rank creating above creatability. This is indeed apophatic discourse, an unsaying that unsays even its prior unsaying—only to say something unpredicted. “So long as I conceive a creator creating [*creatorem creantem*], I am still on this side of the wall of paradise. And so long as I imagine a creatable creator [*creatorum creabilem*], I have not yet entered, but am at the wall.”⁵⁹

In other words the “creatable creator,” while coming apophatically unsaid, comes closer to paradise than does is the “creating creator”! The infinite—what seems all or nothing—will in knowing ignorance escape “anything that can be named or conceived.” Creator is such a name. But inasmuch as we are going to name (you) “God”: “You are *not therefore creator but infinitely more than creator*, although without you nothing is made or can be [*possit*] made.”⁶⁰

In other words, there is no restoration of a proper creation from nothing *non de deo sed ex nihilo* (Augustine). No representation of a transcendent creator unilaterally creating from a nothing outside of Himself [*sic*] can withstand the perspective of this doubly affirming and negating coincidentia. If I were to press again the perspective, the conjecture, of the *creatio ex profundis*—and so also of the infinity, where there is no boundary between the divine infinity and the *tehom* of creation—I would point to the relational creativity of Genesis as the code of a communicative creation radical in its reciprocations. I might direct the reader to a passage of the Zohar where Elohim is called a palace. “The secret is: ‘With Beginning, [*blank space*] created Elohim.” “The ‘secret’ message is urgently doubled. Elohim now signifies a created place, a palace (*binah*, womb) not ‘the Creator.’”⁶¹ But here instead, in the cloud rather than the deep, let us ask: what does the impossible figure of the creatable creator make *possible*?

The very grammar of *creatibilem*, the *creatable*—that which “can be created,” which it is *possible* to create—functions for Cusa almost indistinguishably from that of the “created” (*creatur*). In other words, the divine *passive* that has shad-

owed the entire argument signifies divine *possibility*: the *ability to be created*. The creature is the creatable, as the creator is the one who creates. And in the acute paradox, the aporia of their unexpected co-incident, the familiar image of the creating creator is unsaid (deconstructed, not destroyed) by the unpaintable icon of the creatable-creature-creator, as truly creative as it is communicative. In other words the *ablility* to be created signifies *potentiality* in God—a notion just as impossible for classical doctrine as is the divine *passivity*. In fact it is the same impossibility: for—and here we are up against the wall of ontotheologic—*possibility is to actuality as passivity is to act*.

If God as pure act suffers neither potentiality nor receptivity, this metaphysically guarantees that He [*sic*] suffers not at all. Suffering means not only the lack of negative affect, but of being affected, influenced, “moved,” in any sense. The divine *impassivity* really does classically mean *no passivity*—which in this logic means precisely no potentiality. What is already perfect, fully actualized, cannot by this logic be altered. Change would entangle God in the time of creatures, in finitude. As the Angelic Doctor sums it up unambiguously: “The being whose substance has an admixture of potency is liable not to be by as much as it has potency; for that which can be, can not-be. But, God, being everlasting, in His substance cannot not-be. In God, therefore, there is no potency to being.”⁶²

This absolute priority of act over possibility does not intend to demean the potentialities in the world. But its dichotomy functions hierarchically, with or without God. We noted earlier its echo even in a strand of Derrida, in a reduction of “possibility” to the predictable, a nonevent, a non-act. Cusa might, with no infidelity to the old “not-being,” agree with Aquinas that God cannot *not* be. But he transgresses the angelic prohibition to announce: “absolute possibility is God.”⁶³

COINCIDENTIA AND CONTRAST

It is as true to say that God creates the world, as that the world creates God.

—A. N. WHITEHEAD, *PROCESS AND REALITY*

What then shall we make of the resemblance of Cusa’s creatable creator to Whitehead’s proposition, formulated half a millennium later? It occurs as the final “contrasted opposite” in the series of six chiasmic antitheses that lend a liturgical

ring to the conclusion of *Process and Reality*. He calls them “apparent self-contradictions.” An apophatic reserve is in play: it is “just as true to say” functions like Cusa’s “as if.”⁶⁴ Whitehead nuances the crucial twist: “in each antithesis there is a shift of meaning which converts the opposition into a contrast.”⁶⁵ Might we collate Whitehead’s technical use of “contrast” with Cusa’s *coincidentia oppositorum*? The latter wraps apparent contradictions, seemingly impossible to reconcile, into the enfolding complicatio. Similarly, Whitehead’s notion of contrast encodes the root dynamism of his vision. It is by virtue of the conversion of “incompatibilities into contrasts” that complexity arises, that becoming is embodied in process, that difference is gathered—we can say enfolded or contracted—in the concrescence of the actual occasion. Each actual occasion is a space-time perspective, as indeed “each actual world is relative to standpoint.”⁶⁶ The indeterminate becoming of each perspective receives considerably more emphasis in the twentieth-century model, to be sure.

It is not for the sake of an iconoclastic inversion that Whitehead can from one perspective call God “the first creature of creativity.”⁶⁷ He is emphasizing over against classical notions of changeless and impassive omnipotence a divine becoming “not *before* all creation, but *with* all creation.”⁶⁸ When he writes that God “does not create the world, he saves it,”⁶⁹ he is undoing every imperial notion of all-determining power. Cusa, so many centuries earlier, never denies the divine omnipotence, only its standard meaning. For both, the agency of no creature is constrained by divine influence. And, also for both, “without you nothing is made.” In Whitehead it is the creative process, everlastingly *infini*, unfinished, that gives rise to God and world: the ultimate contrast. God mediates, as the principle of concretion, that creativity. Creativity drives God’s becoming—never from nothing—in response to the becoming of the world.

If the startling apophatic signifier of a creatable creator in Cusa resonates with Whitehead’s figure of the creature-God, the latter was not aware of the antecedent. His becoming, creatable, deity is signified as “the consequent nature of God.” It is a compassion for the world, a feeling-with, a place of passion or passivity, the receptive medium of the universe. One may compare it with the divine enfolding, the complicatio. In Hartshorne’s rendition, God becomes “the Most Moved Mover” unfolding in a universe that can be called “the body of God.” As it turns out, Cusa (without the benefit of critical animal theory) also approved Plato’s

trope of the universe as an “animal.”⁷⁰ This animal-cosmos is one living organism or body animated not just by a secondary *anima mundi* “immersed in it”—but by “God as its soul.”⁷¹ Within it the perspectives of particular animals come into their own, we noted earlier, as cosmological contractions, seen by and seeing the creature-creator.

In Whitehead’s own strong divergence from the Aristotelian-scholastic *actus purus*, the creative aspect of God is distinguished from the receptive, or consequent, nature. It is called “primordial” and is eternally initiating, creating through the *eros* of the “lure.” But in this activity it remains in itself “deficient in actuality,” its content being that of pure possibilities abstract in themselves. They become active potentiality, pressing for incarnation, only in the self-creative process of the world. That world remains different from God and yet as intimately *non aliud*, not other, as her own body. It is in the coinciding consequent character that the divine is *becoming*. Hegel, who drew from Bruno and from Schelling in this, if ambivalently, had been perhaps the first to think systematically the divine self-actualization as a becoming. For Whitehead, however, that becoming is the actualization not of a determinate dialectic but of the indeterminate creativity: “the many become one, and are increased by one.”⁷² That *one*—unlike Cusa’s still Neoplatonic One, however prone to redistribution—is just one among many momentary ones, unfolding as a singular event by enfolding, or “prehending,” its universe.

In other words, across a world of divergence, both thinkers keep in play—in experimental conjecture—a nonoppositional binary dynamic of the creating and the creatable God. One can say of both that the creating is by “attraction” or by “calling,” therefore by communication rather than manipulation, and that the being-created of God is the event of being-moved by the moving manifold. The implication would be that all those iterating passives, suggestive of divine receptivity, mean that in our feelings of God God is feeling us. This reciprocity of prehension is little more than the claim that in seeing the “face of God” what we see is God’s vision of us. But Whitehead draws the explicit inference: therefore we make in that moment a difference to, and so in, God. And it remains impossible for Cusa to infer that the divine would *receive* something from the creatures. They are “unable to impart anything to God, who is the maximum.”⁷³ We add nothing to God, as already the infinite contains all that is or can happen.

Yet as we are enfolded, *complicans*, in God we creatures—each already in Cusa “a finite infinity or a created god”⁷⁴—are not identical with but nonseparable from the maximum.⁷⁵ That enfolding resembles the integration or re-membering of all—“a tenderness which loses nothing that can be saved”⁷⁶—in the consequent nature of Whitehead’s God. The actual occasion perishes and is “objectively immortal,” received in the divine. But its *subjective* immediacy happens in its actual world. Creaturely difference remains for both thinkers free and irreducible. But in process theology it *does* add something: not the classically primordial possibilities but their actualization, the endless random and free variations of actuality. In other words we the creatures *impart everything*—all the things that exist—to God. Who otherwise would not exist as a God, a relation to the world, but would remain a bodiless not-thing, condition of the possibility of everything, but truly absolute of all relation. That is the infinite—closer to Whitehead’s creativity than to his God—as abstracted from the creation.

In Cusa human freedom breaks, prayerfully, into its earliest Renaissance exuberance: “Sweetness of every delight, you have placed within my freedom that I be my own if I am willing. Hence unless I am my own you are not mine . . .” (I am oddly reminded of the feminist insistence on my finding the self before losing it again to any dominant “you.”) “You do not constrain me, but you wait for me to choose to be my own.”⁷⁷ And if this human capacity to “listen to your Word” and be “free and not the slave of sin” emerges from facing the Face, let us note that it cannot be read as humanist (let alone feminist) defiance; nor as an early modern intensification of the privilege of Man as *Imago Dei*. It bursts in context out of a contemplation of the *nonhuman plenary of creatures* enfolded in God. The sense of reasoning freedom here comes always apophatically entrained in a cosmos of relations.⁷⁸

“And then in the cloud I find a most astonishing power.” . . . This cloud-power turns out to be the “principle that gives being to every power both seminal and not seminal,” unfolded as “that power in which it virtually enfolds a tree, together with all the things that are required for a sensible tree and all that accompany the being of a tree.” Note again the empirical specificity. And it leads Cusa to realize that “thus in *you my God the tree is you yourself*.”⁷⁹ This is the work of divine explicans, unfolding through the contraction—“that power of seed, which is contracted” to its species. The divine *potentia* unfolds as the virtuality (no abstract

but rather an active potentiality) of the seed. And then we encounter in this text that leaves implicit the astrophysics of *De docta*, this cosmological optic: “O God, you have led me to that place in which I see your absolute face to be the natural face of all nature.”⁸⁰

No wonder he could say above that “you are seen by all and in all sight.” Far from privileging an anthropomorphic face, the icon of God has radically distributed itself across the face of the universe, across the surface of all materialities. The contractions of perspective iterate through the creation: “if a lion were to attribute a face to you, it would judge it only as a lion’s face.”⁸¹ Mystical vision becomes what Latin American thinkers such as Sylvia Marcos call “cosmovision”: a contextual embodiment of the particularity of perspective.⁸² In its cloud epiphany, the face of all creatures, here seen as “the art and the knowledge of all that can be known,” opens right out of the practice of learned ignorance. And it effects not a mystical indifference to the world but the flourishing of its manifold arts, sciences, and practices of conviviality.

The unfolding, enfolding soul of the world becomes in process-relational cosmology receptive to affect and impact and—consequently—open-ended in its infinity. Of course any coinciding of Cusa and Whitehead plies its own theopoiesis, its own cloudy construction. For it is not a matter of simply updating a half-millennium old figure by breaking nonknowing into the overt indeterminacy of all becoming. The apophatic relationalism also supplements process theology, so as to check the latter’s particular temptations to objectification. At any rate the affinity of these perspectives only comes to fruition by way of the mutual attraction of their cosmologies—and this only for the sake of the possibility of a convivial ecology now, of the painfully attractive possibility that we “can do,” are yet “able to do,” *posse*, life together.

POSSIBLE GOD

Overcoming the angel of reason, Cusa does not back out of the cloudy co-incident of the creating with the creatable, the lover with the lovable, the actual with the possible. Yet he is up against a wall of self-contradictions not to be resolved in one book. His thought betrays a wobble, a “violence” to himself, even in the play

of its experimentation. At one point he exacerbates the Aristotelian view of possibility: “the dark chaos of pure possibility.”⁸³ Yet later in the same book we read that “all possibility exists in absolute possibility, which is the eternal God.”⁸⁴ That is a dramatic difference: from a hell of mere possibility, merely unactualized—to the heaven of absolute possibility. The possibility of breaking open the impossible and therefore the project of this book is at stake! He clarifies: “in God absolute possibility is God, but outside God it is not possible; for nothing can be found that would exist with absolute potentiality, since all things other than the First are necessarily contracted.”⁸⁵ This distinction anticipates Whitehead’s primordial nature, comprised of the “eternal objects” as “pure possibilities,” abstract from their actualization (contraction) by creatures.

In *De visione* we saw Cusa make explicit an illicit grammatology of divine potentiality. Soon thereafter, preoccupied with the coincidentia of possibility and actuality, he coins *possest*, fusing *posse* and *est*, as a new name for God, possi-being. Yet, as Peter Casarella argues, this term still does not represent a complete break from the Thomist sensibility. “Even when he terminologically drifts away from the Aristotelian-Thomistic doctrine of God’s pure actuality, Cusanus is still in fundamental agreement with many aspects of the theory.” For “he is not claiming that God’s actuality is mixed with the potency to develop into something other than God.”⁸⁶ As Casarella stresses, actuality and potentiality “coincide” in God, for God, as Cusa reiterates in *De Possest*, “is free of all opposition.” God’s explicatio “in and as all things” may or may not be read as the potency to develop into something “other than God,” inasmuch as the creation is indeed different from God. And yet it is “other” in a limited sense. The text titled pointedly *De Non Aliud* offers, by way of an abstruse apophatic dialectics that engages Dionysius intensively, “Not Other” as the name of God, as God is not the Other of any others: “Not-other is not other than anything, it does not lack anything, nor can anything exist outside of it.”⁸⁷ So then we must infer that the possibilities that compose God do not actualize something “other than God” inasmuch as there is no such other. But as the world is “not other than other”—a nonseparable other, a *difference*, to add our less paradoxical supplement—divine possibility does (impossibly for Thomism) find actualization in the world of others.

The situation becomes even less apologetically salvageable in Cusa’s last piece of writing. Here Cusa, just weeks before his death, declares with “delight” that *posse ipsum*—translatable as possibility itself—is now his favorite name for God.

For nothing that *is* can be—without first being *possible*. And nothing that one does can be done unless it is *possible* to do it. The argument is disarmingly practical: “What young boy or young girl, when asked if they could carry a stone and having answered that they could, when further asked if they could do this without *posse* [being-able], would deny it emphatically?”⁸⁸ *Posse ipsum* thus names the ultimate condition of the possibility—of *any activity*. If we identify that *posse* as “God,” then there is no doubt of its reality: not that he means to offer a proof of God’s existence so much as a resignification, another experimental name made possible by all the negations.

Nor is he at this point concerned to harmonize the breakthrough with his prior thought, which he blithely unsays: “*Posse ipsum*—that than which nothing can be more capable, prior, or better, and that without which nothing can be, live, or understand—is a far more suitable name than *possest* or any other.”⁸⁹ *Posse*, related to *potentia* as either potentiality or power, a nominalized verb meaning more literally “being able” or “able to do,” doesn’t translate neatly. It suggests Gayatri Spivak’s reading of Foucault’s *pouvoir/savoir*. “*Pouvoir* is of course ‘power.’ But there is also a sense of ‘can-do’-ness in ‘*pouvoir*,’ if only because, in various conjugations, it is the commonest way of saying ‘can’ in the French language.”⁹⁰ This can-do energizes Cusa’s last pass at the possible. But it is crucial that one not misread it as *God’s ability to do* this or that. He is speaking of *our own* ability, of what the girl or the boy—the creature—*can do*. Once we admit that our every free action is preceded by the possibility of that action, we are living evidence of that *posse ipsum*—the power of our ability, which is being offered as the name and utterly visible sign of God. Of what was darkly invisible, Cusa now says that, like the figure of Wisdom, she “shouts in the streets.”⁹¹ He exuberantly unsays his lifelong preference for the unsayable darkness, an apophysis that of course is serving as the *sine qua non* of this moment of illumination. I will not say that all that unsaying of the God of power and might has cleared the space—within the formidable patriarchy of Rome itself—for this apparition of Sophia, she who does not do to or for but empowers us. No I will not.

In this last text, as Casarella concedes, the lines of continuity with Aquinas “are severed, once it is maintained that in God possibility itself is prior to actuality.” Potentiality for Cusa did not earlier signify a lack or a predictability, inferior to actuality and extrinsic to God. But now it has become the privileged signifier of divinity. This “God who may be”—in Richard Kearney’s “poetics of the possible

God” and his critical supplementation of Cusa—makes possible, but does not itself make happen. Otherwise, as Kearney rightly worries, a crisis of theodicy looms.⁹² Of course we creatures are never separate from that enfolding infinity, but that does not render us its pawns. No more are my cells, organs, or even quanta controlled by “me.” If *posse ipsum* unfolds or contracts in actualization, it is we ourselves who *do* it. Who *ply*, who layer, fold, and do it. We might not. But we *can*. Every historic irruption of the “yes we can” is, of course, likely to disappoint. But we do not have God to blame.

The indiscrete infinite can no longer be mistaken for a sovereignty manifesting its power over the world. The eternally possible is becoming actualized—here, now—through the decisions of creatures. Christian theology did not follow Cusa either to or through this cloud. Indeed, soon after and to the north, it turned sharply toward the all-determining and predestining God, whose grace is all that counts. The incomprehensible infinity became the inscrutable will. But the path not taken may open differently in the present darkness.

Now we hear of the theology of maybe, of perhaps, of divine weakness—calling us to do what we “can do.” But if a discourse of mere powerlessness seems (when for instance we feel helpless before corporate depredations) to waste too much potential, let us summon our cloud power. We might even in certain contexts translate the divine power, in fidelity to the Latin *omnipotentia*, as divine *omnipotentiality*. It would unfold indeterminately in all creatures, in a perspectival one by one—“as if directed just to me.” It is truer to say that this *posse ipsum* is actualized than that it acts: it does not make, but makes *possible* the actual creature, the actualization of the creature. Therefore each creaturely contraction expresses not the act of the creator but the agency of the creature. Theology haunts each of us with the gift of our own ability, our responsibility. But really, now, never mine alone but widely and wildly “ours.”



Every person, place and thing in the chaosmos of Alle anyway connected . . .

—JAMES JOYCE, *FINNEGANS WAKE*

It is with Cusa that the apophatic divinity undergoes its supreme complication. Here the ancient cloud breaks into the endless crowd of folds: “*God, therefore,*

is the enfolding (*complicans*) of all in the sense that all are in God.”⁹³ The negative infinity—the *maximitas*—folds together everything in itself and so *as* itself. So Cusa’s panentheism destabilizes any picture of a container-God: the “all in God” is not that of all the finite others lodged within a bigger One. Its “in” signifies precisely enfolding, not enclosure. For the linguistic ambiguity between folding *in* and folding *together* is not just translational. The infinite *is* the enfolding of all finitudes, it *is* (in this perspective) the *complicans*, the com-*pli*-cating itself. And the complicating means a folding together of all in all. Is it the ultimate entanglement, in a smoother imagery of folds? At the same time, in its chiasmic crossover, the complication performs its own explication: “and God is the unfolding (*explicans*) of all in the sense that God is in all.”⁹⁴ This much was nebulously implicit in certain emanations of Neoplatonic panentheism, especially in Thierry of Chartre’s earlier use, probably derived from Boethius, of the explicatio/complicatio as metaphor of God.

We turn however with Cusa to the crystallized texture, the atmospheric density, of the “all.” In the complicatio, the cosmic many that compose the all fold into a coincidentia with the divine one. For all things in God are “without diversity.” He does not contradict the presumption of divine simplicity. Yet that simplicity now hardly resembles the classically simple One. (After all, even simplex has its fold. Consider Heidegger’s *Ein-falt*.) Does the togetherness of a one that is “not the opposite of a many”—a plurisignality, as I have translated *Elohim*—here produce a different consistency of the singular God? Cusa, by way of Eriugena, partakes of the apophatic reading of the same second hypothesis of *The Parmenides* noted in the last chapter, according to which “unity itself is parceled out by being, and is not only many but indefinitely numerous.”⁹⁵ In Cusa the possible God unfolds from an unknowing that coincides with theological wisdom. Mystery is not traded for mastery. For if theologians transcend our nonknowing, in the name of Jesus, revelation, or even justice, we practice Christian idolatry. We observed in Cusa’s exercise with the icon the breaking up of the face of God across an endless cosmic surface of faces. God does not vanish into a void but evaporates into the impossible cloud—of possible perspectives. Of possibly infinite perspective(s).

However, it is something different from God as such that comes, at a definite swerve of Cusa’s writing, into view. That difference is—everything. From the cloud perspective of the present book, the everything that is the creation bursts

with book 2 of *De docta* into a radically new visibility. It is here that the fold between apophatic theology and an affirmative cosmology materializes. As Mary-Jane Rubenstein enfolds his achievement in her splendid *Worlds Without End*: “What Cusan cosmology comes down to, what it opens up, is something like a ‘perspectival multiverse.’”⁹⁶ Not a bunch of separate universes, but the multiplicity of a boundless materialization, boundlessly interactive—or, in Karen Barad’s posthumanist sense, to be considered in the chapter to follow, intra-active.

In other words, in the excess that overflows from the negative infinite, a paradigm of radical relationality now reveals itself. Chiasm within chiasm: its explication comes in succinct and unmistakable code: “In the First Book it was shown that God is in all things in such a way that all things are in God, and now it is evident that God is in all things as if by mediation of the universe. It follows, then, that all are in all and each is in each.”⁹⁷

Has this intuition of “all in all and each in each” come so explicitly into any texts of the Christian West before this? Cusa attributes the phrase to the sixth-century Anaxagoras, a protégé of Pericles. And indeed, that ancient idea of an original multiplicity did not make it into mainstream Greek, or subsequent European, thought. Hoping that his readers might grasp it “more clearly than Anaxagoras himself,” Cusa offers the following condition of radical interrelation as an inference from the God-world relation: if God is unfolded in everything and everything enfolded in God, then the “everything” of the universe as a whole is the way God is in every thing. This is important: there is no chance here of a standard pious interiority of “God within,” as there might be in the icon’s reflected and refracted gaze “as if on me alone.” That would be a misreading, as the perspective of the icon precisely exposed that one-on-one relation as shared by every creature in the universe. If God is in me, it is me-with-the-whole-universe attached. “As if by mediation of the universe”: but that is the universe from the point of view that “I” signify. If “I” am not wiped out by the cosmic immensities—and just *how* immense, collapsing the entire medieval framework, is what comes to light in this very book—it is perhaps because that entire pluriverse contracts itself to me. In me. As me. As you.

“In each creature, the *universe is the creature*”: a thought of such luminous darkness that it is still hardly thinkable. “And each receives all things in such a way that in each thing all are contractedly this thing.”⁹⁸ So creation at large is contracted

in each creature, as possibility is contracted in its actualization; as unity “is contracted through plurality, just as its infinity is contracted through finiteness, its simplicity through composition.”⁹⁹ In other words, it is as if the universe is what it is only in the perspective of each and all of its creatures. But each creature is its perspective on its universe. And that thought invites Whitehead: “Each actual creature is a locus for the universe.” In other words, in a unremarked affinity with the Shekhinic tent of dwelling, “every actual entity has to house *its* actual world.”¹⁰⁰ As he renders Einstein: “the principle of universal relativity directly traverses Aristotle’s dictum, ‘A substance is not present in a subject.’ On the contrary . . . if we allow for degrees of relevance, and for negligible relevance, *we must say that every actual entity is present in every other actual entity.*”¹⁰¹ This being-present-in—whether in God or in another actual entity—signals the direct contestation of the substantialist metaphysic of an entity, as a bounded being externally related to all its neighbors, contained within a bounded universe, contained within an external God (whose unboundedness is thereby assumed and contradicted.) It is an answer to the so-called metaphysics of presence, not its reprise.

The Whiteheadian concrescence—becoming concrete, actual—performs its own version of a contraction into a particular space-time standpoint. Because “everything is in a certain sense everywhere,” each creature composes itself of its universe at that moment. That “certain sense” refers to the way each creature is a potentiality for all future ones. Therefore it is as active possibility, not as concrete actuality, that each is in each. And the universe from the perspective of one creature is no more the same universe as that of another, than one creature is the same as another creature. The multiplicity of perspectives diffract the cosmos not as a mere plurality of worlds but as an intertwined multiverse. Rubenstein, writing the history of the astrophysical multiverse, adds this luminous optic: “Creation is the expression of God, the contraction of God, the holographic dwelling-place of God, and yet creation is not God . . .” Cusa will often express this difference as a matter of number: whereas God is unity itself, the universe is unity “contracted in plurality.”¹⁰² If, however, Cusa began the pivotal passage by inferring that all-are-in-all from God-is-in-all, the reasoning now doubles back and inverts itself: “Since the universe is contracted in each actually existing thing, it is obvious that God, who is in the universe, is in each thing and each actually existing thing is immediately in God, as is the universe.”¹⁰³

This is a yet more radical formulation: *because* the universe is in each, God is in each. *From our own entangled relations, we may infer an infinite complication.* What has shifted in this chiasmic inversion? From the world summed up in me, or in that irksome fly, we sense, by this alter-knowing, the entwining infinite. Now “it is obvious” that each thing—as the universe that each thing contractedly is—is “immediately” in God. Yet Cusa had just written that God is present as if (*as if*) by mediation of the universe. So God, by the mediation of the universe that *is* that creature, is immediately present to all creatures. In other words, the immediacy of God to each creature is mediated by the universe *as* that creature. By a simple analogy, I sip, in the immediacy of this coffee, the world. That sip mediates the unfathomable manifold of contracted, compacted, relations (chemical, economic, ecological, affective.) (*As if* I do—for most relations to the universe blur into the cloud—and into irrelevance.) What experience of immediacy is not highly mediated?

We may sense what is at stake for Cusa: medieval theology, like its cosmos and its church, is wrought of great hierarchies of mediation. The hierarchies convey divine revelation to limited and sinful human capacities; they protect the mystery, provide institutional discipline for the multitudes. Cusa conjectures at once a mysteriousness transcending any authorities and more intimately *present*, available, than those mediators permit. The intensive complicatio of the infinite is now folded into every finitude. The very order, kosmos, of reality is by this gesture dramatically complicated—made at once much larger and much closer. The cloud has precipitated the whole cosmic crowd. Cosmos becomes chaosmos (and coincidentally Joyce did muse over Cusa and Bruno, and we will see how Deleuze, who loves the Joycean chaosmos, embraces the figure of the fold in cognizance of these theological origins). In the third book of Cusa’s *De docta*, Christ comes as the name of the mediator of the immediacy of the infinite to the finite. But then he appears against the background of a radically reconfigured theocosm. The relentless work of the coincidentia of the infinite and the finite brings the whole ladder of mediations down. Mediation plies the immediate: you the universe.

In context Cusa is explicating the arcane medieval conundrum that he probably found cited in Meister Eckhart. Attributed to Hermes Trimegestus, the purported author of the Hermetic Corpus, and probably formulated in a twelfth-century pseudo-Hermetic text (the pseudonyms of the nameless mystery con-

tinue), it famously reads thus: “God is an infinite sphere, whose center is everywhere, whose circumference nowhere.”¹⁰⁴ Cusa had already developed its theological meaning in his first book’s conjectures on the circling infinity. Indeed in the opening of *De docta ignorantia* Cusa intensified the logic of infinity through his mathematical analogies. As the circle expands to infinity, it coincides with a line (imagine looking at one segment of a circle, which, as it expands, seems to be straightening): so opposites coincide in infinity. “Infinite unity, therefore, is the enfolding of all things,”¹⁰⁵ For nothing can be outside of what is infinite. It has no boundaries to be outside of.

“Taken seriously,” as Harries notes of the sphere without boundary, “the metaphor threatens to shatter every hierarchy.” It yields a world in which God cannot be separated from anything anywhere. It is however in book 2 of *De docta ignorantia* “that Cusa makes the unprecedented move of applying the Hermetic formula to the universe itself.”¹⁰⁶ If an apophatic cosmology can be said to billow out of this mystical underground—alter-knowledge indeed—what possible relevance to what later science would call “knowledge” could it have?

EARTH MOVING

As a historian of science, Alexander Koyré captures the novelty thus: “We cannot but admire the boldness and depth of Nicholas of Cusa’s cosmological speculations which culminate in the astonishing transference to the universe of the pseudo-Hermetic characterization of God.”¹⁰⁷ Suddenly an impossible expanse of world—hardly more comprehensible half a millennium later—bursts into view. Here Cusa passes from his meditation on the negative infinity that is God to his “corollaries for inferring one infinite universe.” He makes the move as follows: “the universe is limitless, for nothing actually greater than it, in relation to which it could be limited, can be given.”¹⁰⁸

With this leap to a boundless universe, Cusa becomes “the thinker who is most often credited or blamed for the destruction of the medieval cosmos.”¹⁰⁹ Bruno follows in his cosmological footsteps two generations later. Bruno, in a discourse lacking all apophatic reserve, multiplies the infinity of the world into an infinity of actual worlds. Cusa, differently, never simply identifies this illimitable

multiplicity of the world with the divine infinity. He unsays the infinity of the universe even while saying it experimentally. A certain *neti neti* nuances his discourse: the world is a “contracted infinity,” not a negative or absolute infinity, and “in this respect it is neither finite nor infinite.”¹¹⁰

The contracted infinity does not take the place of the negative infinity, but, as it were, gives it place: it *materializes* it. Indeed from the perspective of *posse ipsum*, the universe may be said to actualize this God’s possibility. It is the whole universe, not the little human speck of it, that is made in *imago dei*. And so the startling riff: “every creature is, as it were, a finite infinity or a created god. . . . It is as if the Creator had spoken: ‘Let it be made,’ and because God, who is eternity itself, could not be made, that was made which could be made, which would be as much like God as possible.”¹¹¹ God is not creatable—but asymptotically close to it. But if we then imagine a creator God here, facing a universe “in his image” we have of course backed away from the wall and lost the glimpse. “Cusa, in other words, is shattering the simple mirror-game between God and the universe by folding God *into* God’s own image, as its omnicentric center. The universe does not resemble a God who stands outside it; it resembles God only insofar as it embodies God, everywhere in the universe, equally.”¹¹² Thus Mary-Jane Rubenstein interprets this historical moment of the holographic multiverse. We have to do with a ubiquitous embodiment, a pan-carnation of God equally distributed. And indeed precisely that equality in fact is the second (non)person of Cusa’s trinity, as *aequalitas*, a Christic equality that is “the enfolding of inequality.”¹¹³

We have however yet to consider the most dramatic cosmological yield of the application of the learned ignorance to the infinite sphere. This conjectural application happens just after the disclosure of the all-in-all and each-in-each. “The world, whose center and circumference are God, is not understood,” he writes. The unknowable infinite has lent its incomprehensibility to the world: an apophatic cosmology indeed. This lets him infer that though the world is not negatively infinite, “it lacks boundaries within which it is enclosed.” If it lacks boundaries, that is, some sort of definite perimeter, it follows that it lacks also any “*fixed and immovable center*.” And therefore: “*The earth, which cannot be the center, cannot lack all motion*.”¹¹⁴

There, he said it: a then impossible truth steps forth with no fanfare or dread, so mildly that again one might miss it, as apparently almost everyone did. Yet

there is no vagueness in this reasoning. "Therefore, just as the earth is not the center of the world, so the sphere of fixed stars is not its circumference, even though, by comparison of earth with the sky, the earth itself seems near the center."¹¹⁵ He has thereby demolished—as an illusion of geocentric perspective—the entire medieval Aristotelian conception of the fixed earth surrounded by a sphere of fixed stars. Thereby he is anticipating by a century Copernicus's infinite universe and moving earth. Copernicus's revolutionary model is heliocentric. But Cusa continues: "there are no immobile and fixed poles in the sky."¹¹⁶ There is no fixed center at all. As Koyré says of Cusa's conception, "it goes far beyond anything Copernicus ever dared to think of."¹¹⁷

Yet Harries judges it symptomatic of modernism that even Koyré remains reluctant to dub Cusa a precursor of modern science. For his cosmology "is not based upon a criticism of contemporary astronomical or cosmological theories, and does not lead, at least in his own thinking, to a revolution in science."¹¹⁸ An oddly anachronistic dismissal, as there was not yet the notion of a science separate from the other disciplines. Cusa was quietly perpetrating a revolution, without a history of such revolving models, tested by experiment, to build on. And, as Harries stresses, he was a polymath engaged in the technology and science of his age, even as he remained a hard-working ecclesiastic. He was a lifelong friend of Paolo dal Pozzo Toscanelli, the leading mathematician of the period.

Cusa's uncannily correct astronomy takes place, however, as the contraction of a revolutionary theology. And it remains monstrous not only to such a heresy hunter as the Heidelberg John Wenck, who failed to make his charges stick.¹¹⁹ In its transdisciplinary theological speculation it is abandoned by the science for which it prepares the way. Secularist science prefers, not surprisingly, to begin its own salvation history with an inflammatory, though no less mystical, sixteenth-century martyrology. The fact that the flamboyant heretic Bruno derived his major ideas from the more circumspect and diplomatic Cusa remains largely buried in those coals. Cusa died of old age as an admired cardinal. The trauma of the Protestant heresy was still in the future. The spirit of Renaissance rather than inquisition prevailed through much of the fifteenth century. And, given Cusa's explicit influence also upon Copernicus and Descartes, one may concur with Harries's suspicion that God is the obstacle to Cusa's acknowledgment in the history of science.

During the intervening centuries the bifurcation of science and religion produced the modern world. With it came the civilizational specialism that rips fact from value, cosmos from ethos, finitude from infinity. The decentered earth, circling within an illimitable universe, spun free not only of the divine infinity but of any sense of human limits. In a mindless parody of the lost divinity, we are to grow infinitely, exploiting the planet as limitless resource. But then how can Cusa help? Does he not foster—nay, launch for earliest modernity—the celebratory freedom to be “my own” as a “created god, a finite infinity” within a boundless cosmos? Won’t this cosmotheology only give spiritual sanction to our now deadly expansiveness? Might not standard theologies of creaturely limitation, divinely supervised, work more practically to urge upon religious populations the necessary limits to growth? And, for the rest, why not just leave science and its secular allies to reveal the impending ecological catastrophe?

MATERIALIZING THE FOLDS

I hope the exercise we have undergone so far suggests that, to the contrary, we must now as a species face the wall of our self-contradiction. It is our entrainment in an unfathomably crowded cosmos that calls us each and all to account for ourselves. We are immensely gifted, and our cooperative creativity backed by survival skills yields also unrivaled competitive aggression. Our great gift turns to poison. It is backing up on us, turning our home toxic. In our finite infinity, our responsibilities for the creation are inescapable: there is no separate reality to which we can flee. Our entanglements may be communally enlivening or systemically unjust, lovable or lamentable, but never erased. And within the cloud we face as a species it is that fold of infinite possibility that makes possible—and deeply uncertain—our potential to actualize that other, more convivial, world. Create world together we will, willy-nilly, we “created gods.” *Posse ipsum*. Yes we can. The question is what world it will be.

Reading Cusa is an exercise in speculative despecialization. One returns in his cloud not to a prescientific and interior mysticism but to the rigorous contraction, which is at the same time an expansion outward, of negative theology as relational cosmology. If there is in our civilization now also some spreading openness to the

intuition of interconnection, perhaps we should not too brusquely write it off as pop spirituality or neoromanticism. Perhaps instead we should lend it the historical depth of the luminous darkness in which another modernity could have unfolded. I find myself walking a few steps here with Milbank when he suggests that “in Eriugena, Eckhart, and Cusanus, we catch a glimpse of a road not taken.”¹²⁰ It is specifically in the Renaissance transdisciplinary of Cusa that the natural science of that alternative modernity burst into materialization—by way of the darkly infinite relationalism. The darkness therefore signifies also the mourning for lost possibility. We cannot go back and pick up the path not taken. And in some ways we would not want to.¹²¹ But we can follow its trail of clouds across our own landscape. More practically, I am saying that, in order to cultivate what Connolly calls a “positive resonance machine,”¹²² an efficacious network of social response to the crises of a planetary interdependence, we will need a more learned ignorance than we have yet collectively been able to muster. Only some pragmatic coincidentia of spiritual and secular perspectives can set such a change in motion. Can move the earth.

To such planetary resonance, the name of God need not always pose an obstruction. What unfolds in the cloud-space of the Cusan God is a multiverse of perspectives, proliferating holographically, irresolvable into any fixed proposition. If we move to stabilize the image—it has already moved with us. A bit like the quantum uncertainty the next chapter will consider. For, says Cusa, “our eye must turn itself toward an object because of the quantum angle of our vision.”¹²³ What, do I now claim him also as precursor of quantum mechanics? No. Quantum here simply means a quantity or minimum. And he goes on to say: “But the angle of your vision, O God, is not quantum but infinite.”¹²⁴ This is theology, not physics. The God Who May Be, God perhaps, the perspective of the enfolding infinite, will no more do our physics for us than fix climate change. Or throw a rock.

For that reason theology in the perspective of the cloud cannot *unfold*, it cannot *explicate* itself to the world at large, without current entanglements in natural science—in the disciplines of the material world. Theology, especially Protestant, cut off its own cosmological potentiality early on and inspired materialism of the capitalist sort. So we may need something like the new materialism.¹²⁵ And the rising influence of the Deleuzian chaosmos, key to Connolly’s world of becoming, and also of the “vibrant matter” of Jane Bennett or the divinalanimality of Derrida,

suggests a rhizome early entrained in both the Neoplatonic complicatio and the Whiteheadian God(as we shall see in chapter 5). The fresh attention to a livelier matter signals a new relationalism, rigorous in its attention to its bodies. Bodies sensuous, disabled, queer, vital. Not just fellow human ones, not even just fellow mammals, but bodies all the way down. Process theology is thus based on an originary engagement of physics and evolutionary biology.

Yet theological experiments in direct response to very recent science must take continually new form. So, in the next chapter, in the interest of the positive resonance, we will examine the apophatic entanglement of quantum entanglement itself. We will then ask with what sort of coincidentia we have to do, when, for example, a theoretical physicist speculating on the missing link between quantum and relativity physics proposes an “indivisible universe” based on the simultaneous interplay of “enfolding and unfolding” at every level of reality? As we move from this part’s theological Complications to the next part’s entangled Explications, we also break into a more radical uncertainty, and, which is not the same thing, a more pronounced indeterminacy, than Cusa ever anticipates. This lets us raise questions of contemporary planetary ethics to which Cusa may provide certain interreligious clues but no answers in theory or practice acceptable in our time.¹²⁶ The historical crossover from the luminous darkness to the embodied relationality patterns for us the chiasm of an apophatic entrainment that happens, if it happens, only in the present.

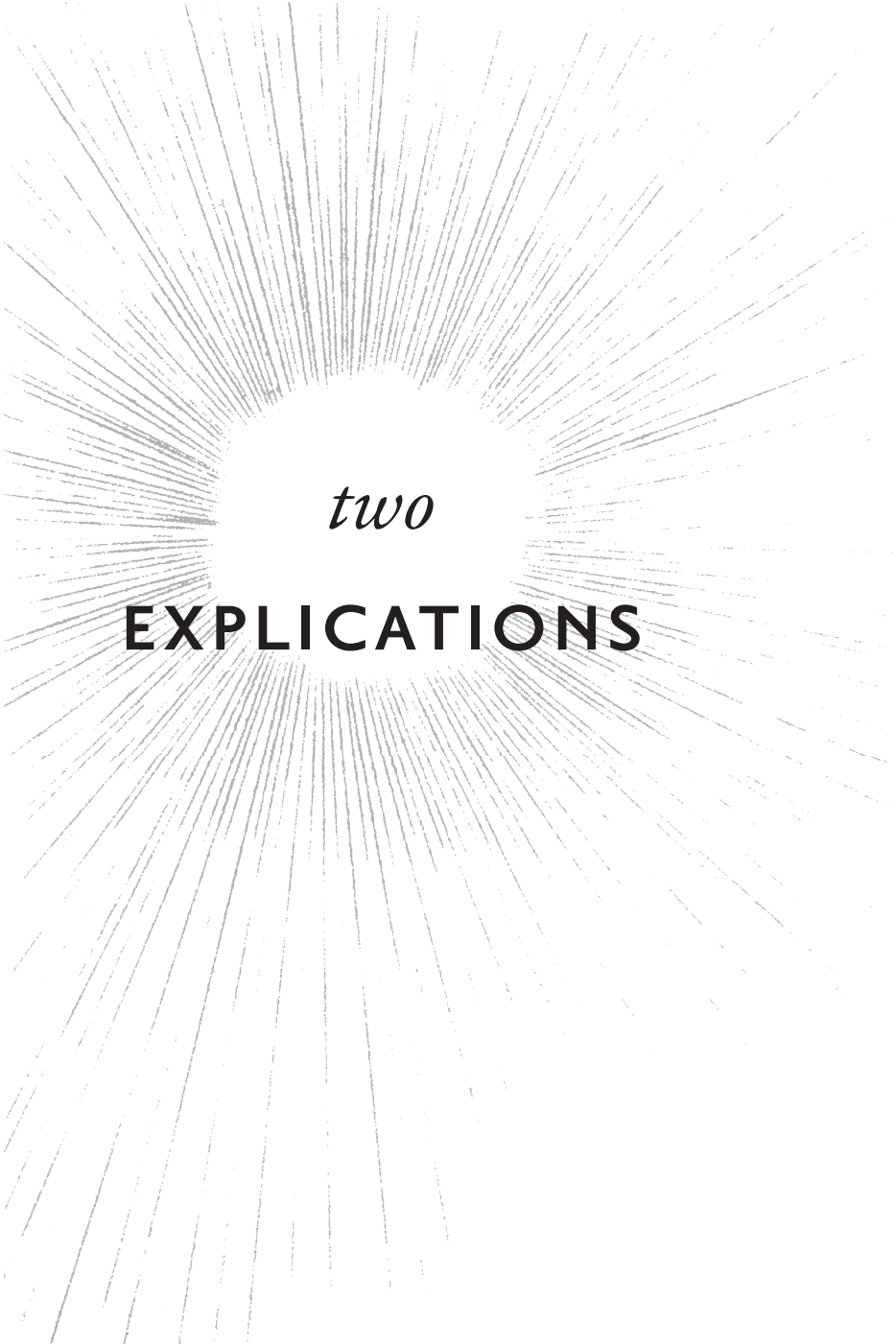
If we shift now from the ancestral theology of clouds to more recent materializations, folds that have appeared in this chapter will come into sharper focus. The quantum angles multiply along with the crowds they entangle.



The iconic surprise for Cusa of the moved and moving God followed, as we have seen, the cosmological surprise of the moved and moving earth. In the contraction of his vision, a whole chaosmos of intra-active movement is set in process, a perspectival multiverse of process. Its possibilities become active, they become new, only as we realize what we—each in each and all in all, in utter limitation—can do. Infinite possibility breaks in each actualization into its finite embodiment, its fragile difference, its peculiar perspective upon all the others. If the eye of a

fifteenth-century icon has followed us this far, perhaps it mirrors, or rather diffracts, now a new complicatio: where the maximum coincides with the minimum in an entangled materialization that offers another nickname for the Name—the Infinite Complication. And in its name we continue to contemplate its infinite perspective, which, altogether unlike our own, “sees all things simultaneously around and above and below. Oh, how wonderful to all those who examine it, O God, is your sight, which is *Theos!*”¹²⁷ But the wonder falls flat if we read his “all things simultaneously”—or indeed that of some quantum superpositions—as a holistic determinism. The nebulous nonknowing perhaps only now floats into the turbulent atmosphere of an irreducible indeterminacy—the implication not yet explicate of the infinite as the unfinished. Observed and observing.

At this rate, the negative theology that also negates itself will never, not even in the dregs of the postmodern, achieve a purely materialist *theoria*. Something of this cosmic voyeurism, this always already reciprocating gaze, will peek through. The glimpse of it may make for a better materialism. As the minimum with the maximum, so each contracted viewpoint—when examined—may coincide with what infinitely attracts it.



two

EXPLICATIONS

four

SPOOKY ENTANGLEMENTS

THE PHYSICS OF NONSEPARABILITY

Now, more than ever . . . our place in the universe and the place of the universe in us, is proving to be one of active relationship. That is more than a scientist's credo. The separateness of our lives is a sham. Physics, mathematics, music, painting, my politics, my love for you, my work, the star-dust of my body, the spirit that impels it, clocks diurnal, time perpetual, the roll, rough, tender, swamp-ing, liberating, breathing, moving, thinking nature, human nature and the cosmos are patterned together.

—JEANETTE WINTERSON, GUT SYMMETRIES

Intra-acting responsibly as part of the world means taking account of the entangled phenomena that are intrinsic to the world's vitality.

—KAREN BARAD, MEETING THE UNIVERSE HALFWAY

IN JEANETTE WINTERSON'S NOVEL, the romance of two physicists morphs into a ménage à trois and ends in lesbian love: the sham of separateness yields to the vibrancy of an entangled indeterminacy. "Instead of a hoard of certainties, bug-collected, to make me feel secure, I can give up taxonomy and invite myself to dance: the patterns, rhythms, multiplicities, paradoxes, shifts . . . worked out over time."¹ We stumble or we dance under quantum conditions writ large. Our plot lines unfold precariously across the inhuman scales, enfolding minimum and

maximum. “In terms of the implicate order one may say”—according to one scientific story—“that everything is enfolded into everything.”²

With that language, the quantum physicist David Bohm was developing his choreography of the explicate and the implicate orders, his paradigmatic account, that is, of an enfolding and unfolding universe. Apparently not unaware of Cusa, he was creating vocabulary for a stunning phenomenon that physics has revealed over the course of many decades. It was a discovery ironically *reveiled* for much of the last century; indeed mainstream physicists often reviled colleagues who sought to understand it. I am referring specifically to the phenomenon of quantum entanglement, also signified as nonlocality, as superposition, and as nonseparability. It was early dubbed by Einstein—in shocked disbelief, not pneumatological reverence—“spooky action at a distance.” Bohm, his younger colleague, followed him in investigating nonlocality, but was then ostracized for his findings by the U.S. physics establishment until this century. We will return to that story, as it illumines the relation between the mindful and the willful nonknowing. The latter was formulated as “shut up and calculate.”³ But Bohm’s story, and that of its not unproblematic physics, matters only as part of the story of the quantum of matter itself. Just why (you might well ask) does *that* matter to theology, and particularly to one not anchored in the formal interdiscipline of science and religion? Sure, we may agree with Karen Barad’s opening salvo: “Matter and meaning are not separable elements.”⁴ But we theologians can take it (up) from there.

Of course. But this spooky action kept haunting me. It joined ancestral forces with old Cusa. For in the unfolding of the quantum narrative, as its explicatio in theory and in experiment, the entangled nonknowing we followed through much earlier clouds reappears: as, for instance, the “poorly defined cloud” that we will see is each particle of matter itself. For the very precise uncertainty besetting the atomic particle will reveal for our purposes a new register of apophatic nonseparability—of entanglement now in its most technical sense. This ghost story exposes, and in broad scientific daylight, the minimum unit of the universe as “a place of active relationship.”

In the pursuit of a fold between negative theology and affirmatively embodied relation we have so far followed the canny unknowing, which is an uncanny knowing, up to the point (1440 to be precise) of its sudden unfolding as a cosmology of “each in each and all in all.” We now contemplate the technical meaning, half a millennium later, of entanglement in physics. It is not that from now on I shall

only speak of entanglement in ways that physicists would certify. The apophatic entrainment will continue—more or less by definition—sliding between multiple disciplinary registers and temporary nicknames. I hope readers cool toward natural science and allergic to new age cliché, yet intrigued by questions of the non-human, the chaosmos, vital matter, and the new materialism, will bear with this exercitia in the spirit of the last one. But this one takes place not in the transition into but out of modernity such as it has been. For the mysterious materiality disclosed by quantum mechanics (no math, I promise) does offer a new language—perhaps too new quite to speak—of the living crowd texturing our epistemic cloud.

If the separateness of our lives is a sham, then the work of our civilization to produce us as discrete subjects vying to emulate, master, know, and consume external objects succeeds only through its systemic repression of that site of active relationship. All the way down. No one puts this better than Barad. Thus we begin with the climax of *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, her magnificent meditation on quantum entanglement, “If we hold on to the belief that the world is made of individual entities, it is hard to see how even our best, most well-intentioned calculations for right action can avoid tearing holes in the delicate tissue structure of entanglements that the lifeblood of the world runs through.”⁵

The holes are growing. They have the size of melting glaciers, methane holes, unthinkable income gaps. We now ignore the microcosmic matter of the universe at peril of what matters maximally to us. Even at the scale of the teeny tiny quantum, we witness how the material effects of common belief and presumptive knowledge tangle with our ethics. Does that tissue structure or quantum field of infinitesimal relations begin to take on the feel of an infinite body? To imagine its lifeblood flowing through a boundless organism may tempt us with theopoetics. With Kabir, for instance: “everything is swinging: heaven, earth, water, fire—and the secret one slowly growing a body.”⁶ For this chapter, however, it will not be a theological maximum but a physical minimum that swings into play, demanding narrative time and contemplative space.



*We live on an island surrounded by a sea of ignorance. As our island
of knowledge grows, so does the shore of our ignorance.*

—JOHN WHEELER

Let this parable of the highly quotable John Wheeler, one of the last great twentieth-century quantum theorists, expose the apophysis of physics itself. The sea of our unavoidable ignorance does not inhibit knowledge; knowledge is growing all the time. *Knowledge* of this ignorance forms its growing edge. Like the Hebrew *tehom* of creation, the enfolding ocean may support or menace. Science—like theology—may respond tehomophobically or in entangled fidelity to its own style of “learned ignorance.”

Of course I do not suggest that the growing shoreline of scientific ignorance—even among those rare physicists able to think about the conditions of the possibility of physics itself—runs parallel to that of ancient islands of theology. The very dynamism of the *growth* of the “island of knowledge” was won against the resistance of the Christendom that went (not long after Cusa) into lockdown against its own scientific potentialities. Does the very opposition of scientific and theological perspectives—replicating all the dreary walls between matter and spirit, flesh and meaning, creation and creator—perhaps begin, in this nascent millennium, to yield to some new coincidentia of its own?

As a theologian intensively involved in dialogue with the natural sciences, Philip Clayton calls for a discussion generated “by questions that science raises but cannot answer using its own resources.”⁷ So Clayton calls theology to participate in the “movement from science to ‘something beyond’”—something that scientific theories as such cannot express or test—a movement that is “motivated not by religious experience but by the scientific questions themselves, which lead one to, and beyond, the limits of decidability from a scientific perspective.”⁸ He is not thereby suggesting that theology will then offer, à la Tillichian correlation, the answers. This call to “something beyond”—a suitably apophatic signifier—mirrors his invitation to theology, noted earlier, to consider its own “possible impossibility.” What remains impossible for scientists might then generate new possibilities for theology. In this chapter however we eavesdrop upon scientists themselves reacting with apophatic intensity, whether in shock or wonder, to the questions raised by quantum mechanics, particularly by its nonlocal entanglements.

The new form of theology, or indeed of metaphysics, “that comports with science” must, Clayton argues “be hypothetical, pluralistic, fluid in its use of empirical conceptual arguments, continually open to revision.”⁹ Inseparable from the relational traditions shaped by feminist, ecological, and process currents—the lat-

ter two themselves composed in dialogue with science from the start—the theological experiment we foster has always recognized separateness as a sham.¹⁰ But to comport is not to conform. Indeed standard theological engagements with science, no doubt concerned to avoid any taint of new age mysticism, can become more conservative in their use of science than the key scientists. Of course one attempts to use the best science, and to navigate the conflicts within science, so as to engage responsibly with an alien discourse rapidly shifting.

This chapter, however, attends to how scientists become engrossed in questions that deposit them at the outer edge of those “limits of decidability”—right on the cloudy threshold of theology. For instance, how is the quantum phenomenon of entanglement itself entangling physics in questions beyond its ken? Needless to say—but I had better say it—this does not mean that theologians have the answers to *those* questions and are just waiting for the gaps in the armor of science to appear. So that we may shoot “God” into them. Theology, too, and only under pressure from a wide transdisciplinary of intersecting differences, is still learning to think the impossible complexity of our relations. The unquestionable God has blocked out the Infinite Complication—the possible divinity revealed in our nonseparable differences—much as physics masked the phenomenon of entanglement. Science, after all, inherited from theology the metaphysics of separate substance, supernatural and natural. If the first part of this book deconstructed from within the theological classicism of a separable transcendence, we will notice that it is the classicism of a separable objectivism that poses the key problem for physics itself. Of course, by the same token, modern science is inexplicable apart from medieval theological presumptions of a creation good and open to reason.¹¹ Therefore it is not so surprising that those physicists advancing a paradigm shift in their field have recourse to some discussion not only of cosmology, but of “metaphysics” or “ontology.” Otherwise, the mirror play of discrete observor and discrete objects—once divine, now material—will continue to obstruct the observation. But the mirror itself is coming enigmatically into view.

And in the mirror the matter that matters to quantum physics hardly resembles matter at all, if matter means the inert stuff divisible into indivisible atoms, building itself up into the meat of our bodies, which are themselves incoherently related to the mind inhabiting, observing, plying our bodies. The quantum event of an actual particle that is at the same time a wave of potentiality has made its

appearance. Indeed in current experiments photons are shown to be wave and particle at once.¹² Contradiction, paradox, or complementarity—does physics, at its root, find itself beclouded by a coincidence of opposites?

“We choose to examine a phenomenon which is impossible, absolutely impossible, to explain in any classical way,” writes the physicist Richard Feynman. And this phenomenon contains “the heart of quantum mechanics.”¹³ Might we glimpse in such im/possibility the sign of possibility itself—*posse ipsum*? In this new physicality the apophatic relationality finds not only its minimum but also, from the bottom up and out, a certain maximum embodiment. As Cusa put it: “it is obvious that the minimum coincides with the maximum. This becomes clearer if you contract maximum and minimum to quantity.”¹⁴ We experiment now with such a contraction from and to the quantum point of view. We may only hope to find in this dark and murky undecidability of physics another example, one important for the acuteness of its material minima and the maximizing of cultural influence, for the becoming theology of apophatically nonseparable differences.

The physics of quantum nonseparability will not produce empirical proof of any kind of God—and by definition not that of negative theology. No. It may, however, be offering material evidence of a universe so apophatically entangled as to escape the rival classicisms that pit science and theology against each other in the first place. But it will be to a profound tension, a wall within the cloud of physics itself, that we now turn.

THE APOPHATIC QUANTUM

For more than half a century—even in the midst of some of the greatest scientific achievements in history—physicists have been quietly aware of a dark cloud looming on a distant horizon.

—BRIAN GREENE, *THE ELEGANT UNIVERSE*

Has physics been confronting—and evading—its own cloud of impossibility? “Calling it a cover-up would be far too dramatic,” writes physicist Brian Greene. But since the mid twentieth century it has been evident that the “two pillars” of modern physics, Einstein’s special relativity and quantum mechanics, “*cannot both*

be right.”¹⁵ Both theories—the first a revolution in conceiving of the maximum, the other, of the minimum—continue to be confirmed within their frameworks with “unimaginable accuracy.” Their respective precisions only thicken the cloud of their contradiction.

John Bell, after whom is named the theorem that has been called “the most profound discovery of science,”¹⁶ sought to expose the evasion in a 1989 book called (with no allusion to negative theology) *Speakable and Unsayable in Quantum Physics*. Physicists, he warns, remain “sleepwalkers” avoiding the profound obscurity of quantum mechanics and the “incompatibility, at the deepest level, between the two fundamental pillars of contemporary theory.”¹⁷ So a billowing, doubling cloud appears: that of the contradiction, “impossible” for physics, between its two major theories, and, at the same time, the obnubilating obscurity of quantum mechanics itself.

Right in the midst of the unsurpassed success of quantum calculations, physicists variously emit a language of apophatic affect: darkness, cloud, weirdness, impossibility, spookiness, mystery, unknowability. Indeed, as we shall see, the varieties of apophasis previously distinguished come into play: epistemic uncertainty, ontological indeterminacy, rational contradiction, repressive unspeakability, unknowable infinity. In the metaphor of the two pillars, we might also (recalling the Sinaitic genealogy of the “dark cloud” to which we traced negative theology in chapter 2) notice the reflection, like a desert mirage, of an ancient impossibility: “a pillar of fire by night, to give them light, and a pillar of cloud by day.” Almost like Einstein’s speed of light, shooting absolute and steady through the dark space of the relativities, while the cloudy quantum enigma displays in broad empirical daylight. The indubitably brilliant darkness emitted for a century by the quantum “phenomenon which is impossible” does seem to demand a twenty-first-century coincidentia.

And here too, as in Cusa’s “doing violence” to himself when pushing through the wall, one encounters an affect of crisis. It is hard to overemphasize the psychic stress that physicists suffered on account of the innocent little quantum. The great pioneer of quantum mechanics, Niels Bohr, wrote to a friend in 1918 of his mood swings: “I know that you understand . . . how my life from the scientific point of view passes off in periods of over-happiness and despair, of feeling vigorous and overworked, of starting papers and not getting them published, because all the

time I am gradually changing my views about *this terrible riddle* which the quantum theory is.”¹⁸ As in the fifteenth-century cloud, the riddle (*eneigma*) encodes both mental suffering and moments of “paradise.”

Einstein also took part in the emergence of quantum theory. Against the prevailing assumption that light, unlike the rest of matter, consists in waves, he argued that it exists in bundles—in what Max Planck had just before named the “quanta.” The quanta of light had entered the scene. Einstein found the massless photons moving always at the same speed—the speed of light. Yet toward the end of his life he is said to have confessed the following: “Fifty years of intensive brooding did not get me closer to the answer to the question: What are quanta of light? Today, every rascal thinks he knows it, but he is in error.”¹⁹ Given Einstein’s iconic stature as the apotheosis of scientific truth, his repeated confessions of unknowing appear all the more revelatory. Indeed, in a conversation with an astronomer on a train to Paris in 1924, Einstein said of the quantum problem (not intending any allusion to Cusa’s wall): “That is a wall before which one is stopped. . . . The difficulties are terrible; for me, the theory of relativity was only a sort of respite which I gave myself during their examination.”²⁰ Only a respite, that gigantic achievement, enfolding all space and all time together inseparably with all matter and energy? He took personally, and not altogether humorously, the quantum’s defiantly indeterminate behavior: “I find the idea quite intolerable that an electron exposed to radiation should choose of its own free will, not only its moment to jump off, but also its direction. In that case, I would rather be a cobbler, or even an employee in a gaming house, than a physicist.”²¹

The apophatic affect we are tracing in this book—whether more akin to pain, wonder, or sheer puzzlement—remains still sharp among leading physicists. Feynman, for instance, has distinguished the comprehensibility of our two pillars thus: “There was a time when the newspapers said that only twelve men understood the theory of relativity. I do not believe there ever was such a time. . . . On the other hand, I think I can safely say that *nobody understands quantum mechanics*.”²² Feynman echoes Bohr’s famous exclamation: “Anyone who is not shocked by quantum theory has not understood it.” And Feynman slips in a warning characteristic of the movement: “Do not keep saying to yourself, if you can possibly avoid it, ‘But how can it be like that?’ because you will get ‘down the drain,’ into a blind alley from which nobody has yet escaped. *Nobody knows how it can be like that*.”²³ Avoid the watery abyss, flee the impassible impossible? How can such

learned ignorance—knowing that “nobody knows”—fail to question the operative unquestionables?

Physics addresses only things we can measure. Limiting the claim of physics to descriptions of our own measurements, to accounts of what it is we can predictably know, establishes a clear boundary between epistemology and “reality.” This distinction at once counteracts the naive realism of scientific common sense and supports experimentation, i.e., the mathematics of measurement. Wolfgang Pauli, with characteristic sarcasm, put the epistemological limit this way: “one should no more rack one’s brain about the problem of whether something one cannot know anything about exists all the same, than about the ancient question of how many angels are able to sit on the point of a needle.”²⁴ The medieval riddle quaintly mocks metaphysical futility. But the dismissal of mystery does not quite capture the fuller intellectual life of Pauli himself. Beset as a prodigal young scientist by personal trauma, alcoholism, and paranormal phenomena (“the Pauli effect”), he fled to Zurich for psychoanalytic help. His symbolically dense dreams appear anonymously in Carl Gustav Jung’s psychological investigations of medieval alchemical symbols. The caustic Pauli in fact secretly collaborated for years with Jung to develop the theory of synchronicity, an “acausal connecting principle” in which quite a host of angels, or are they archetypes, coincide . . .²⁵ Again, that wall between knowledge and the unknown gets unexpectedly wrapped in cloud.

Contemplating the limit of knowability, Bohr drew upon another spiritual conundrum: “Trying to use physics to analyze a ‘deeper’ reality, one beyond what we can know through measurement, is like asking physics to analyze the sound of one hand clapping.”²⁶ Is this deployment of the Zen koan a dismissive slap or an apophatic clue? Certainly the Copenhagen orthodoxy he fathered gets routinely characterized as the imposition of an epistemological limit, kin to Kantian antirealism, incompatible not only with classical physical realism but also with any attempt to ask what the world is really like. If, however, the questions cannot be asked, then the habits of thought, the common sense of Western modernity and its separable particles independently observed, will not be altered. So would this not keep the paradigm of naive realism in place—the paradigm that quantum theory itself rejects?

Recently, Karen Barad has demonstrated that the merely epistemological reading of Copenhagen “orthodoxy” misconstrues Bohr. We will return shortly to her

reading of his theory of complementarity. But note in the meantime that Bohr is not flippant in his evocation of Asian imagery. When knighted after World War II this Dane chose as his coat of arms the icon of the yin/yang. This is before the casual Western proliferation of Eastern spiritualities. And he had it inscribed with the motto *contraria sunt complementa*. The Cusanic allusion seems unmistakable.

To read the apophatic affect among physicists, with its alternately repulsive and attractive nonknowing, does not imply that the state of quantum knowledge and of its interplay of uncertainty and indeterminacy has remained static. It may, however, help to undo the stereotype of the unaffected observer—correlate to the fallacy of the separate observer that lies at the heart of the classical theory. It is now time to clarify how the posture of separability comes undone at the very heart of matter. Here we enter the riddle that threatened to send Einstein—for whom “God does not play dice with the universe”—to the gaming house.

INDETERMINATE INTIMACIES

Do you really believe the moon is not there if nobody looks?

—ALBERT EINSTEIN

If you are driving, you see the rainbow moving. If you stop it stops. If you start again, so does the rainbow. In other words, its properties partly depend on you.

—BERNARD D'ESPAGNAT, ON PHYSICS AND PHILOSOPHY

Einstein was only holding the line at basic scientific “separability”—a “shorthand term for the ability to separate objects so that what happens to one in no way affects what happens to others.”²⁷ Anything else—any “influence” besides physical forces—would be “spooky actions” and “voodoo forces.”²⁸ This was the great debate with quantum physics, which was discovering, much to the shock of its own proponents, that reality at its base does not conform to the presumption that a particle must have a separate reality independent of the measurements. On this the debate is over. The unprecedented predictive and productive success of quantum mechanics stands. And with it, more recently, “spooky action.” As two physics professors put it: “that our actual world does not have separability is now

generally accepted, though admitted to be a mystery.”²⁹ Is it that there is no moon existing apart from your gaze? Is the rainbow not there if you are not looking? Why is it that the observation—indeed the measurement—cannot be made without influencing that which it measures? Are epistemological and ontological non-separabilities getting confused?

To back up a bit: Werner Heisenberg formulated the uncertainty principle in 1927. You cannot simultaneously measure both a particle’s location and its momentum (its mass multiplied by its velocity). Spatiotemporal location and speed factored by mass are the most rudimentary requirements of measurement, applicable to any rolling ball or strolling couple. But at the microcosmic level a different reality shows its face (or sticks out its tongue). The better you pin down the location, the less you know about the momentum, and vice versa.

“‘Wait a minute,’ you exclaim with indignation. ‘How can this be?’” So the physicist Marcelo Gleiser captures the affect of the fact. “‘Certainly, if we have more accurate instruments, we can always improve our measurements of a particle’s position and velocity. Right?’ Wrong. The problem is that the very act of measuring disturbs what is being measured.”³⁰ There is a disturbance, an impact, what Schroedinger called an “impression,” not just from the observed upon the observer—but *reciprocally*: “the observer makes an impression upon that which she is trying to observe. The object I am trying to observe refuses to behave as an object; *it won’t stay still*.” The object, in other words, no longer permits objectivism. It simply will not make its appearance *outside of its relation* to its observer. Worse, after all these decades, we still do not know just what *exists* apart from the operative reciprocity. What is at stake in this matter of knowledge versus unknowing is not just certainty but—the discrete classical object, the *thing, itself*. Not that there is nothing there. But the indiscrete quantum has forever “disturbed” the independent subject and his [*sic*] object.

As Heisenberg eventually put it: “The common division of the world into subject and object, inner world and outer world, body and soul is no longer adequate.”³¹ Such early, trembling steps of recognition retain their revelatory ring: “Physical action,” wrote Schrödinger, “always is *inter*-action; it always is mutual.”³² Friendly as this mutuality might sound, the strange jumps of the quanta that punctuate it once put Schrödinger to bed for days in depression. For this instantaneous interactivity was mucking up not just scientific certainty but the

felt beauty of a lawful universe; that it was happening between two world wars did not help. It was what made Einstein waver and wonder if perhaps the “Old One” was not malicious after all.

Bohr liked to quote William James: “You can’t turn the light on quickly enough to see how the darkness looks.”³³ The uncertainty principle thus sets a certain absolute limit to our capacity to know the thing itself. If, of course, there is such a limit. Quantum physicists appear here trapped in epistemology. They reduce with dogged honesty the microphysics to *statements about measurements*—since they cannot *know* the virtually instantaneous interactions in which they are themselves implicated. Yet the point is that the phenomenon cannot be known—totally, transparently—by a knower who *participates* in its very taking place. But is this because of the limits of my human capacity to know? If so, then it might just be that there are classically determinate little objects there but that we cannot perceive them. Or is it because of something *inherently indeterminate* in the matter to be known? Does this relational, participatory, and spontaneous character of the phenomenon signify an irreducible—an *ontological*—indeterminacy?

Karen Barad’s new formulation of the problematic of quantum relationality offers an important rereading of this originary tension. She positions her theory as a posthumanist development of Bohr’s quantum theory of complementarity. Against the standard reading of Copenhagen “orthodoxy,” she finds Bohr pushing the epistemic envelope of the uncertainty principle itself. “The primary ontological unit is not independent objects with independently determinate boundaries and properties but rather what Bohr terms ‘phenomena.’” And phenomena, she continues,, “are the ontological inseparability of agentially intra-acting components.”³⁴ In this “intra-action”—interaction rewritten to resist the presumption of subjects and objects preexisting each other—“distinct agencies do not precede, but rather emerge through, their intra-action.” Those agencies may be humans or their measuring instruments. In any case we have to do, she says (in response to Schrödinger’s epistemological solution to the measurement problem), with the “entanglement of our knowledge.”³⁵

The notion of entanglement that Schrödinger coined originally (in English) has since taken on a significance beyond his wildest worries. We will consider its mounting revelation of “ontological nonseparability” later in this chapter. But it never loses its epistemological fold. The human observer, along with her measur-

ing device, can be said to be enfolded precisely in the intra-action in which both observer and observed emerge as “distinct” agencies. We could say then that epistemology is unfolded from an ontology that enfolds it: as we observed the cycle of information and transformation in the icon’s reciprocal gaze. Barad’s strengthening of an ontology of relation radicalizes for the present experiment in nonseparable difference the cloudy conditions of our every materialization. The apophatic density of an uncertainty folding into participatory indeterminacy will haunt every effort to cut impatiently through the haze.

It is not that at the quantum level the distinctness, the particularity, of a creature gets dissolved into relation.³⁶ Rather, the creature emerges within the relational field that it differentiates—by its very becoming. The actual occasion, as we heard in Whitehead, is found “in a certain sense everywhere.” And this does not sacrifice the nonsubstitutable singularity of its own becoming. We read the attributes that make one creature, one particle, different from another as acts of differentiation rather than as inherent properties of a discrete substance. So to return, with the French physicist Bernard d’Espagnat, to the quantum: “Its properties partly depend on you.” Partly. This is not to say that you produced its qualities. It is not to say that you create *ex nihilo* a world that otherwise does not exist. It *is* to say that what exists apart from being “observed” does not look anything like what it looks like to whoever is looking.

“The fuzzy and nebulous world of the atom,” writes physicist Paul Davies, “only sharpens into concrete reality when an observation is made. *In the absence of an observation, the atom is a ghost. It only materializes when you look for it.* And you can decide what to look for. Look for its location and you get an atom at a place. Look for its motion and you get an atom with a speed. But you can’t have both. The reality that the observation sharpens into focus cannot be separated from the observer and his choice of measurement strategy.”³⁷ Matter—at least at the quantum level—undergoes a deconstruction. Indeed the operative ontology of elemental physics suggests the specter of Derrida. His “hauntology,” however disengaged from physics, signifies an alternative to the substance ontology behind materialism and idealism, a trace, and a *triton genos* to being/not being kin to negative theology.³⁸ Rather than a solid material foundation, physics presents the atomic ghost.

Or, as David Bohm put it felicitously, an atomic particle may “best be regarded as a *poorly defined cloud*, dependent for its particular form on the whole

environment, including the observing instrument.”³⁹ For the quantum theory has shown the futility of analyzing any particle of so-called matter in “precise detail,” which is to say, in terms of the context-independent objectivity shared by classical physics and relativity theory. The Newtonian atom—“that God in the beginning form’d Matter Beginning in solid, massy, hard, impenetrable, moveable particles”⁴⁰—has morphed into the nuanced materiality of the quantum. Matter itself turns woozy, wavy, wayward. “And everybody here is a cloud.” Your “million little pieces” are not gritty bits but micro-clouds.⁴¹

With this indefinite haze, we have to do not only with the indeterminate relation of observer to the observed quantum but at the same time with the relation of the *wave-form* to the *particle-form* of that one quantum. This is the province of Bohr’s theory of complementarity. It turned out that while light waves were really appearing as particles, particles were also really appearing as waves. But *what* then is appearing, within these contradictory appearances? Something appears, something actualizes—indeed materialization may better name the “it” than matter.

And just here another apparent impossibility has constellated: the same element will appear either as a wave or as a particle. It depends on how you measure it.⁴² In other words it depends upon your *perspective*. That means here—and as the basis of Barad’s posthumanist performativity—that it depends upon the experimental setup, what you measure and what you do not measure. But, no matter how you measure, the wave behavior can now be ignored but not canceled. The rippling energy may materialize as the discrete particle—but only if thus viewed, addressed, interpellated. Waves, by their nature, however, are not encountered singly but in their lapping, their overlapping each other. These are not alien metaphors to a theology of genesis pulsing from the watery tehom.

In overlapping, which is to say “disturbing” one another, waves add together to form “superpositions”—structures transcendent of classical “positions.” These overlaps, or “interferences,” transcend classical “positions.”⁴³ When Feynman hyperbolically announced “the only mystery,” he was referring to superposition. Again, the mystery is not merely epistemological. To the question “Do superpositions represent our ignorance?” Barad responds, “no,” not in the sense of our failure to know a classical object that is somehow hidden from us. Rather, “superpositions represent ontologically indeterminate states—states with no determinate fact of the matter concerning the property in question.”⁴⁴ To repeat: the mystery

lies not in unknowability alone, but in the intra-activity—the constituent relationality—that suspends the very notion of a “thing” as bounded body or classical object. The epistemic uncertainty expresses, explicates, an ontological indeterminacy. In other words, relation does not indicate causal closure. We have to do with an open-system relationalism.

Einstein’s wider concern to conserve the moon can in other words be met without compromising the quantum revolution: a moon is there when we are not looking at it. But not as exactly the same moon, not as “the moon”; not as the self-identical, simply located substance possessed of its properties. Without observers it is a ghost of itself. Or a cloud of its endless possible selves. Like d’Espagnat’s rainbow, its properties depend partly upon you. Zen again: “scoop up the water and the moon is in your hands.”⁴⁵

MINDFUL UNIVERSE

Superposition, in its indeterminate cloud of relations, is inseparable from “interference.” It was the famous double slit experiment that first allowed the unexpected wavelike character of the elementary particle to become measurable through patterns of interference—showing the way wave patterns rippling through the water or the wind interfere with one another. Henry Stapp, who studied quantum physics with Pauli and Heisenberg before joining the Lawrence Berkeley Laboratory, finds this interference, or superposition, “not at all mysterious or strange if one accepts the basic idea that reality is not made out of any material substance but rather out of ‘events’ (actions) and ‘potentialities’ for these events to occur.”⁴⁶

That “if” marks the paradigm shift. Let me suggest that such an alteration of perspective overcomes contradiction and shock—but not mystery. In the paradigmatic transition from substance to event, he is developing the ontological—not merely epistemological—approach to quantum theory. For “science encompasses cosmology, and also our attempts to understand the evolutionary process that created our species.”

If the particle is read as event, the wave signifies its potentialities. Those quantum potentialities have a “wave-like nature, and can interfere like waves.” In a

familiar metonymy, Stapp describes this nature as a “*cloudlike spatial structure*.”⁴⁷ This cloud is not merely epistemic; it is ontological, it is what materializes. Each cloud or wave spreads literally everywhere. It is, in effect, infinite, boundless. It comprises mathematically the probability of finding, or, as he says, “experiencing,” a particular actualization at a particular point in space-time. The wave spreads continuously but heterogeneously. And its potentiality is not merely a mathematical abstraction. It exists, as making possible particular existences. It is not that he jettisons what he calls the “Copenhagen pragmatic stance.” But, in order to come to terms with ourselves and with our actions, we need to “see this pragmatic anthropocentric theory as a useful distillation from an underlying non-anthropocentric ontological structure.” Such an ontology “places the evolution of our conscious species within the broader context of the structure of nature herself.” He calls for “a fundamentally non-anthropocentric ontology” in which to embed our pragmatic realities. With subdued drama he announces that “there already exists such an ontology. It is the ontology proposed by Alfred North Whitehead.”⁴⁸ In Stapp’s terse rendition, “The core issue for both Whiteheadian process and quantum process is the emergence of the discrete from the continuous.”⁴⁹

We have been considering here the event by which the wave potentiality materializes as a particularity—that is, as any quantum particle. Such a “discrete” emergence instantiates Whitehead’s ontological unit, the “actual occasion of experience.” The actual individual—yourself or one of your innumerable electrons—takes place *as* an actualization: there is not an enduring identity of matter or of you; there is a materialization in this moment. And the next moment. And the next. And at each moment we can say that you enfold the prior moments, and the great manifold of events—electronic, molecular, genetic, social—making up your universe; and in that moment unfold it all otherwise. So does the electron, with a vastly simpler perspective upon its world. Each particularity is a distinct re-composition of its world. For Whitehead there is thus “a becoming of continuity, but no continuity of becoming.”⁵⁰

The continuity of such a process is not then that of a substance but of the past flowing in waves of potentiality—potentiality out of which this present becoming actualizes itself. The past is comprised of our relations to what has already become, and so becomes potentiality for future becomings. As the bottomless process rela-

tionalism haunts the present book, its entanglement not just in Whitehead's own mathematical physics but in the subsequent history of physics is noteworthy. It delivers a potentiality for certain physicists—there at the edge of their own “limits of decidability”—to philosophize.

In developing what he calls his “Whiteheadian quantum ontology,” Stapp quotes the later Heisenberg: “the transition from the ‘possible’ to the ‘actual’ takes place during the act of observation.”⁵¹ The actual entity is not already there: it happens, it is an event, an incident of materialization—not a chunk of enduring matter: the blow to commonsense essentialism is acute. In other words, the interference of an observation *provokes the actual*: it effects what is often called the “collapse of the wave function.” But then—and this is a move perhaps impossible without Whitehead—the “observer,” Stapp avers, may not only be the human.⁵² If it were, the material world would be nothing more than human construction—a solipsistic idealism certainly available to quantum theory in its epistemological radicalism. Then the moon disappears as soon as I blink. He seeks to conceptualize, instead, the efficacious embeddedness of conscious human activity in our universe. Without it, he argues, we are left in a dangerously numbed state of detachment from a blindly running matter machine.

This insight resembles that of Barad, who draws not upon Whitehead but upon a feminist poststructuralism and who strongly prefers Bohr to Heisenberg. She too frees a nonanthropocentric sense of responsible agency from a determinist heritage. For her, scientific practice in the quantum paradigm reveals not “what is already there; rather what is ‘disclosed’ is the effect of the intra-active engagements of our participation within and as part of the world’s differential becoming.”⁵³ Not preexistent but dis-closed, opened into its concrete actuality: a *coincident of becoming*. Human or quantum. Matter seems to be coming subversively to life. “Matter feels, converses, suffers, desires, yearns and remembers.”⁵⁴

A cosmology of intra-active becomings seems on several fronts to offer itself as a transhuman (not posthuman, though posthumanist) model. Potentiality, read as the past enfolded in its relations to the emergent event, becomes actual only intra-actively. By Whitehead's rendition, all actual occasions, as the particular creatures that *are* the actualizations of the potentiality in that moment, may indeed be said in a certain nonhuman and metaphorical sense to “observe” or

take the measure of their world, for no creature exists that does not experience its world. The vast majority of events are too simple for what we mean by consciousness, self-awareness, psyche (let alone scientific observation). We have discussed earlier how each actual occasion “prehends”—enfolds with awareness, with feeling, *with mentality*—its world. Hence Stapp’s risky title: *The Mindful Universe*. Any creature can on principle “observe” in this cosmologically broadened sense—and therefore “collapse the wave function.” Stapp elsewhere argues that the orthodox version of quantum mechanics “incorporates mental aspects into the process of the creation of reality.” With the help of Whitehead’s vocabulary, he extends this view to include the “physical and mental poles” of every actual entity—hence every electron.⁵⁵ This signifies for him that the universe in which the observer participates is itself thoroughly “*psychophysical*.”⁵⁶ Leaving aside terminological quibbles in the face of the apophatic and extradisciplinary overreach of language—what an im/possible claim for a physicist to make.

Stapp argues that in the transition from the cloudy potentiality to actuality there is a direct causal action to effect novelty: the novel event. But there takes place, at the same time, also an “indirect effect”: “these ‘indirect changes’ produce the ‘faster-than-light’ effects called by Einstein ‘spooky actions at a distance.’”⁵⁷ It is here, in his incorporation of the Whiteheadian metaphysics in the framework of physics, that Stapp inscribes the phenomenon of quantum entanglement. It is not a direct causal effect, but an operation of the literally boundless relations that form the potentiality of the momentary event. The potentiality in its indirection exercises *influence*, but not mechanical or determinant *causation*. The cloudy nuance of each relation thus registers as a condition of the becoming of the novel actuality. The quantum theory thus leaves “an essential gap in physical causation.”⁵⁸

In this cosmological opening Stapp situates human responsibility. He offers the following packed and game-changing proposition: “with our physically efficacious minds now integrated into the *unfolding of uncharted and yet-to-be-plumbed potentialities of an intricately interconnected whole*, the responsibility that accompanies the power to decide things on the basis of one’s own thoughts ideas, and judgments is laid upon us.”⁵⁹ The interconnectivity of the whole demands and supports the mindfulness of agents whose freedom is neither absolute nor escapable. Without the causal gap—Whitehead’s “elbow room in the universe”—relationalism would mean determinism. In indirect solidarity with

Winterson's place of "active relationship" and with Barad's "right action," Stapp thus deconstructs the classical barrier between science and ethics, between positivist value-neutrality and moral responsibility. His evocation of the "power to decide" echoes Whitehead's cosmologically redistributed sense of "decision." This power to decide is at most partly conscious, as the action by which the occasion—as the particular space-time perspective—selects among its codeterminant potentialities.

Indeed there shows itself for a moment a rare insinuation of theology: "even if we discount the gods of various religions, it seems difficult to imagine how ideal-like realities could emerge from a world completely devoid of *any such aspects*, and how physical laws could come to be fixed by a purely physical mindless universe."⁶⁰ For good reason Stapp only hints at what Whitehead calls the "divine element in the universe," itself limitlessly prehending all creatures who themselves prehend, from their limited spatiotemporal perspectives, their limitless universe.

I hear a faint "aha—the God of the gaps after all"! But a theology of apophatic entanglement would not be able to insert its God into this particular quantum opening even if it wanted to. What kind of congealed God-entity plugs gaps anyway? Only an idol steps in as the explanation of the inexplicable and the determiner of the indeterminate. But I would ask this much, even in this chapter: is God one beclouded name for an infinity enfolding it all psychosomatically together—and simultaneously provoking all its open actualizations? We might then imagine the Old One observing our decisions. Does She play dice? Is the creation a gaming house—a Las Vegas universe? But, metaphorically speaking, gambling is not the only alternative to determinism. What about figures of jazz improvisation,⁶¹ a child's spontaneity, the freedom to differ, the exodus against the odds, chancy evolution, complex emergence? Of course the causal gap can yawn open in existential nothingness or postmodern relativism: an empty abyss no more inviting than a locked-down machine. Upon closer investigation, however, the no-thingness appears to be the very site of the "intricately interconnected whole." (Zoom in on the cloud and the folds appear.) Here the very *indirection* of quantum entanglement begins to demand its own story, its own unsaying of what could heretofore be said, its own current definition. Indeed this spooky action at absolutely any distance demands at this moment another loop through the quantum narrative.

THE THUNDERCLAP OF ENTANGLEMENT

I would not call that one but rather the characteristic trait of quantum mechanics, the one that reinforces its entire departure from classical lines of thought.

By the interaction, the two representatives have become entangled.

—ERWIN SCHRÖDINGER

In 1935 Einstein, together with two younger colleagues at Princeton, Boris Podolsky and Nathan Rosen, set out to exorcise “spooky action at a distance.” The series of thought experiments known as EPR were all attempts to save the rationality of physics from quantum weirdness. They managed to raise the issue of nonlocality, writes Brian Greene—riffing on Bohr’s bit of Zen—“in such a forceful and clever way that what had begun as one hand clapping reverberated over 50 years into a thunderclap that heralded a far greater assault on our understanding of reality than even Einstein ever envisioned.”⁶² As Timothy Ferris defines (sans apophatic drama) the phenomenon: “interfering with one part of a quantum system alters the results observed in another part, even when the system has been enlarged to enormous dimensions.”⁶³

It is that *enormity*—now perhaps as large as the universe—that only over decades became explicit. The earlier reflections on “entanglement” were attending to interference patterns (Schrödinger’s “impressions”) *within* a single atom. And those were enormous enough to spook its observers. For they displayed from the start an effect not brought about by local causes. But classical physics requires “local realism”: the condition that material interactions are based on contiguous causes, whose effects gradually diminish and disappear over distance. On this realism Einstein never wavered. The EPR team was struggling to save the honor of physics from the joint incoherence of nonlocality—and of the contradiction of the two pillars. Focused on the atomic scale, EPR hardly imagined the scale of the weirdness soon to be revealed.

“Hints of entanglement’s spooky presence go all the way back to the springtime of the quantum theory, in the first third of the twentieth century. But it was Bell . . . who laid open the central paradox.”⁶⁴ By mid century most physicists were carefully ignoring the weirdness. John Bell, a North Irish physicist, sounded

the wake-up call. “It may be,” he wrote, “that a real synthesis between quantum mechanics and relativity requires a radical conceptual revision.”⁶⁵ He picked up where after Einstein’s death EPR had left off. Indeed he was seeking to verify Einstein’s intuition that quantum theory must be “incomplete,” that there must be “local hidden variables” that make its math work and that these could be made to surface and rule out the nonlocal spooks. But Bell came before most to recognize what in *Speakable and Unspeakable in Quantum Physics* he called the “unspeakable”—that which would require a radical shift of presumptions—in this fully established new science. The 1964 Bell Theorem made *mathematically* possible the later empirical testing of the theory of nonlocality or entanglement. It does not resolve the contradiction of special relativity and quantum mechanics. Bell’s great breakthrough comes down to (this will sound anticlimactic) the measurement of the particles’ angle of spin. “By using axes at three angles,” writes Greene charmingly, “Bell provided a way to count Pauli’s angels.”⁶⁶ Bell proved that even if you cannot measure features obscured by quantum uncertainty, their existence does make a difference, “a difference that can be checked experimentally” (112). It is this difference that, when tested, would confirm in one fell swoop Einstein’s haunting fear: the universe is spooky.

So what is the gist of this “earth-shattering result”? (113). In one sentence: when two particles originally linked and then experimentally separated fly off in opposite directions, they remain *immediately* responsive to one another—*no matter what the distance*. They remain “entangled.” The EPR experiments that Bell had set out to verify presumed that “*an object over there does not care about what you do to another object over here*” (113). What Bell found instead, by carrying through the very logic of EPR, is that, to the contrary, “the experiments lead us to conclude that *an object over there does care about what you do to another object over here*” (113).

Those of us committed to an ethics that exceeds concern for the ones near and like us need not repress the wider resonances of Greene’s metaphor of “care.” But we stay for now with the quantum. “Even though quantum mechanics shows that particles randomly acquire this or that property when measured, we learn that the randomness can be linked across space. Pairs of appropriately prepared particles—they’re called entangled particles—don’t acquire their measured properties independently” (113–116).

In terms of Bell's Theorem, which Barad dubs honorifically an instance of "experimental metaphysics," the math had yielded a "stunning result": the *locality* condition could not obtain simultaneously with the *reality* condition. Any hidden variables that would account for the faster than light influence would have to be *nonlocal*.⁶⁷ As Greenstein and Zajonc put it, "the experimental tests of Bell's inequalities . . . go so far as to change the very way we should think of physical existence at its most fundamental level. . . . We must think in terms of nonlocality, and/or we must renounce the very idea that individual objects possess discrete attributes."⁶⁸ If attributes are not discrete properties, then they must be called "relational attributes." Here we see the language of a relational ontology—as the systematic alternative to substantialist objectivism—increasingly infiltrating the language of physics. What a creature *is* cannot be determined in separation from its formative relations. And the quantum indiscretion apparently works at any distance whatsoever.

And the interlinkages take place with an immediacy across any distance that evokes just what Einstein mocked as telepathy. These particles, continues Greene, "are like a pair of magical dice, one thrown in Atlantic City and the other in Las Vegas, each of which *randomly* comes up one number or another, yet the two of which somehow manage always to agree. . . . *Entangled particles, even though spatially separate, do not operate autonomously.*"⁶⁹ It seems we cannot escape the gaming metaphor: chance runs too deep. But this is not mere randomness. This is *indeterminacy enfolded in interdependence: nonknowability and nonseparability conspire*. Instantly at any distance.

One might think that the particles are somehow coded or preprogrammed to react as though they are still connected—something like DNA causing twins to have the same color eyes. No, it is something more like twins living in different cities both jumping up and yelling "abracadabra" at the same moment.

Is the impossible *proving* to be the case?

It took several years for the technology to be developed that could test Bell's Theorem empirically. "The results were unchanged. On the microscopic scale of the photon's wavelengths, 11 kilometers is gargantuan. It might as well be 11 million kilometers—or 11 billion light-years."⁷⁰ In the meantime, entanglement has been tested at 500 miles in the southern USA. There is, as I write, overwhelming and ever growing proof of the quantum indiscretion.⁷¹

If then two photons are entrained, the measurement of either photon's spin about one axis somehow provokes the other, faraway photon to "snap out of the haze of probability and take on a definitive spin value—a value that precisely matches the spin of its distant companion. And that boggles the mind."⁷² These entangled particles do not come *untangled* at any distance at all. And keep in mind that the entangling unfolds precisely as the twin actualization—or collapse of wave function—encoded in the "measurement problem" of which Bell wrote, "Observations not only disturb what is to be measured, they produce it."⁷³

The productive quantum boggle, observed first at the microcosmic level, has gone macro—not just spatially but spatiotemporally. For in the mutuality of an interrelated system has been coming to light a *speed* of relation, faster than the speed of light, that may be no speed at all or may be an infinite speed. Therefore literally—by the letter of general relativity that, over and over, proves the speed of light to be the outer limit of all velocities: impossible, by any meaning of measurable "speed" science knows. How can the entangled particles communicate?

According to Greene, "their *history entwines them*; even when distant, they are still part of one physical system. . . . The two photons are so intimately bound up that it is justified to consider them—even though they are spatially separate—as parts of one physical entity."⁷⁴ Their history binds them together: in other words a certain temporality, indeed an irreversible historicity, belongs to this new glimpse of our indeterminate interdependence. So the all-in-all takes place not in the abstract but from particular perspectives of becoming. Let us read this spatiotemporal historicity as characterizing the "contextuality" into which Barad has translated complementarity.⁷⁵ And let that context signify at the same time the active possibilities, or *potentiality* with which Whitehead identifies the sum of the past as prehended by the actual occasion.

In *Nature Loves to Hide*, yet another philosophically attractive work by a quantum physicist influenced by Whitehead, Shimon Malin makes a case for the more-than-scientific shift that the encounter with Bell's correlations provokes. "It feels as if the ground is slipping under our feet, and we are not sure where we will land. *This puzzlement and this feeling are characteristic of the first stage of a paradigm shift.*"⁷⁶ Here the apophatic affect is made explicit, in learned ignorance of the uncertainty as to the meaning of uncertainty itself. This is not altogether coincidental, given the role of Plotinus (rarely coupled with Whitehead) in

Malin's text. Indeed he lets that originaive apophasis, as "its vision baffles telling," interpret Bohr's repeated citation of Schiller, "Only wholeness leads to clarity / And Truth lies in the Abyss." Plotinus also provokes for Malin this language concerning complementarity: "Discovered as a result of an attempt to describe quantum systems in plain language, it is precise expression of the *impossibility* of such a description."⁷⁷ What began with quantum physics is leading by way of entanglement not for the next exchange of mystery for a new certainty but to an apophatic intensification of both the knowledge and, as we see again, the *affect* of interdependence.

"Even when the events take place very far apart they seem to be 'entangled,' they seem to 'feel' each other. It has been suggested that such a connection takes place because *both events form a single creative act, a single 'actual entity,' arising out of a common field of potentialities*."⁷⁸ The relation is not a matter of a "signal" but of an "influence." He offers a figure to clarify the relation of the two events within the single act: "Think of a dancer in the act of performing. The single creative act . . . corresponds to the dancer gracefully lifting her left leg and right arm in one harmonious movement."⁷⁹ (The fold, *pli*, appears as a balletic *plié*.) Malin, like Stapp, depends upon Whitehead's nonanthropocentric extension of feeling as prehension to make sense of the eerie scale of the faster-than-light relationality. The actual occasion enfolds its universe as potentiality. It is the event here and now, the "collapse"—or unfolding—of its potentialities into *this* creature, experiencing *this* world, at this moment and this place: *the local becoming of the nonlocal*. He has been anticipated by Winterson's fictional physicist, who "instead of a hoard of certainties" invites herself "to dance."

Yet that which is becoming locally—what *is* it? Its cloudy potentiality extends *everywhere*. And I and my particles each emerge from it *somewhere*. As d'Espagnat puts it—speaking of the stone we all mistake for solid, filled out, truly discrete: "its 'quantum state' is 'entangled' (this is the technical word) with the state of the whole Universe."⁸⁰ For this entanglement he, along with a growing number of physicists, prefers over *nonlocality* the term *nonseparability*. If each actual localized entity is understood to be entangled in its virtual quantum state with "the whole universe," then we verge again upon Whitehead's ontological principle: "everything is positively somewhere in actuality and in potency everywhere."⁸¹ And it is almost—almost—as though Cusa's theological conjecture—as the mini-

mum coincides with the maximum, so the universe as a whole is contracted to each creature—is materializing under laboratory conditions.

Of course there remains this nagging voice: outside the lab (or various increasingly lucrative new technological deployments, like unbreakable quantum codes) does such science humanly matter? Might its mind-boggling drama prove in the end to be merely an effect of “piddling lab measurements”? Barad says not. The “congealing of agency” in “intra-active becoming” reinterprets matter itself—and therefore everything.⁸²

If “a *measurement is the intra-active marking of one part of a phenomenon by another*, where phenomena are specific ontological entanglements, that is, specific material configurations of the world, then there is nothing inherent in the nature of a measurement that makes it irreducibly human-centered.”⁸³ In this becoming of the creature in its entanglement with the state of the whole universe, the so-called collapse of the wave function does not read as a kind of disentanglement (as most still presume), producing at least for the perspective of the observer the nice normal matter of separable things. It may be, in that sense, no collapse at all but, as Barad puts it, an “ontological indeterminacy resolved or extended through measurement intra-activity.” In other words there would not be an event “that transfers a superposition or entanglement that exists before measurement into a definite state upon measurement.”⁸⁴

An entanglement, we noted, is a superposition involving two or more particles. In what Malin calls the “creative act,” the entanglement does not go away. It yields in Barad’s language to an “agential cut within the inseparability of entanglement.”⁸⁵ Such an agential cut does not cut the bond of entanglement but, we might say, makes decisions—*de/cisare*, incisions, tattoos—*within* it. Such a nonanthropomorphic decision unpredictably selects from amidst an inescapable potentiality. Inasmuch as the term *cut* threatens to reinscribe the imaginary of separation, we might sometimes rather call it the actualization—a *perspectival selection* or fold that may come sharply pleated. We do not have to do, then, with a collapse that severs the actual entity from the quantum potentiality. The event of becoming, in its fold, its contraction, does not disentangle the particle or particular from everything else. We might say instead: in *enfolding* its tangled potentiality the creature *unfolds* as actual.⁸⁶ And is again enfolded in the field, which is thereby altered.

D’Espagnat’s state of the whole universe approximates Malin’s “common field of potentialities.” In the mysterious quantum field is a ground of being—or is it closer to Eckhart’s *Ungrund*?—that wants further explication. In *The Entangled God*—to shift briefly to the perspective of a theologian trained in physics—Kirk Wegter-McNelly elegantly portrays the relationality of the quantum field. He attends to its implications for the creatures who inhabit it. He has been ramifying the recent sense of “decoherence” as a designation for what happens in quantum measurement. Rather than a “collapse of the wave function” in which the “bond of entanglement” would be cut, it seems instead “that the object and the environment become entangled!” Notice again the pressure of a new contextualism: no interpretive perspective, no context, can be separated off from the context of contexts, that of the universe itself.⁸⁷ “One potentially significant implication of this line of thought is that the world of our experience, the universe we inhabit that is full of distinct and separate physical objects, including ourselves, might be continually emerging out of what is otherwise a cosmically and quantumly entangled reality. This is a dizzying thought, to say the least.”⁸⁸

In other words the moment to moment becoming of each creature, each actual entity, suggests something quite other than the creation of increasingly beefy beings from an original void who then move discretely about within a relative emptiness. The dizzying—chaosmic—alternative might translate poetically into the *creatio ex profundis* in which every creature emerges moment by moment from a wavy boundlessness. Not surprisingly, the cosmically and quantumly entangled plenum of what is called “the quantum field” sounds like the contemporary rendition of the biblical *tehom*. Epistemically the ontology of the waves recirculates and crystallizes as the perspective of the cloud.

For Wegter-McNelly the current physics of decoherence, or of “diffusion” (into the environment) of coherence, gives “evidence of the entangled state of the overall system.”⁸⁹ That is, as complexity increases the entity is “rapidly driven into a superposition state that is indistinguishable from a classical one.” Thus one may account for how classical objects *appear* to be locally independent while never ceasing to be nonlocally entangled. Here a relational ontology may find its balance between “uncountable instances of separation and distinction” and their “relational togetherness.” The fulcrum or “Goldilocks point” between holism and multiplicity provides entry into the cyphers of Wegter-McNelly’s theol-

ogy of the entangled Trinity. If now the metaphor of divine entanglement in the world begins to arise in the intersection of theology and science, it is only because the very matter of the world takes on a new meaning through the quantum lens. “Quantum entanglement,” he announces, intending no echo of our cloud lineage, “points to the ecstatic character of creation at the level of physical existence.”⁹⁰

The present book opened with the possibility of a panentheism in which the mystical *ekstasis* finally floods into the relationality of the material universe. The excess or eccentricity of the explicatio overwrites both the Aristotelian and the modern universe of concentric enclosures. A universe of unbounded, decentered connectivity cuts or contracts perspectively into each creature. Each creature is a fold, an actualization itself enfolding and unfolding its own relations. A fold becomes a tangle when it doubles: in the quantum register entanglement happens when at least two particles interact. “It takes two to tangle.” (Jason Starr). Any such pair appears to be an unfolding of the quantum state of the whole universe. But how are we to think the relation of each particular explicatio to the cloudy All being explicated? Here we cannot avoid the uncanny proximity of David Bohm’s key metaphors to Cusa’s implicatio-explicatio theocosm.

AN ENSEMBLE OF EVERYTHING

“Everything interpenetrates everything,”

says Bohm.

Sighs are air and go into the air,

but the oxygen molecule in your sigh

did it cease to live as it left you?

Living and non-living matter are the same thing.

Just as there’s also no emptiness, there is no empty space

and the entire universe is energy

which sometimes takes the form of matter.

—ERNESTO CARDENAL, “THE WORD”

It may seem odd that the great Nicaraguan poet, liberation theologian, and pastoral leader of the legendary peasant community of Solintiname enshrines in

verse—and not only once—the quantum physicist.⁹¹ But Bohm is a haunting figure within the physics community as well. John Bell found his work crucial to cracking the EPR paradox: “I saw the impossible done. It was in papers by David Bohm.”⁹² The scientific repression of Bohm’s theory counted for Bell as prime evidence of the “sleepwalking” of mid-century physicists. In the pragmatism of postwar United States, physicists did not want the peculiar obscurities of quantum theory brought to light. That the historical context can never be factored out should come as no surprise to physics, if complementarity signifies contextualism. But in this case, with its particularly dense entanglement of science and politics, the context wants narrating.

Bohm had studied in Berkeley with Robert Oppenheimer, later the director of the Manhattan Project, who based on Bohm’s Ph.D. research tried to hire him. Due to Bohm’s leftist political associations, the government denied him security clearance but appropriated his research. He had begun his landmark work on plasmas, finding to his amazement that in these high-density gasses “electrons stopped behaving like individuals and started behaving as if they were part of a larger and interconnected whole.”⁹³ (Perhaps that does sound socialist.) At Princeton he pursued his fascination with the collective movements of electrons—whose apparently random activities somehow produce high levels of organization. This is not a situation of two particles behaving as if each knows what the other is doing, but of “entire oceans of particles, each behaving as if it knew what untold trillions of others were doing.” As he later wrote, electrons in such states “are not scattered because, through the action of the quantum potential, the whole system is undergoing a co-ordinated movement more like a ballet dance than like a crowd of unorganized people.” And such collective coordination is closer to the organization of a “living being than it is to the kind of unity that is obtained by putting together the parts of a machine.”⁹⁴

Because physicists were not addressing the implications of such radical interconnectivity, Bohm was worried by the claim of Bohr’s followers that the quantum theory was “complete.” He questioned the assumption that any single theory could be complete, since nature, he suggested, may well be infinite.⁹⁵ Einstein, we recall, was also challenging that completeness, if for different reasons, and engaged his young colleague in dialogue. But in 1949 Bohm was called to testify before the House Un-American Activities Committee—against Oppenheimer. The

McCarthyites had zealously sniffed out the Berkeley socialist past of the father of the bomb. Bohm pleaded the Fifth and was immediately fired by the president of Princeton. He fled the country (to teach physics in Brazil).

Bohm continued to research the interconnectivity, or “wholeness,” of the quantum potential. The most surprising feature of its dissident dance was its non-locality. In his work on “hidden variables”—variables in addition to those that everyone knew about—he was hoping to overcome the contradiction between deterministic relativity theory and quantum indeterminacy. When, however, Bohm’s work was presented *in absentia* at the Institute for Advanced Study, none other than Oppenheimer denounced it as “juvenile deviationism.”⁹⁶ Without having read the paper, Oppenheimer delivered the edict: “If we cannot disprove Bohm, then we must agree to ignore him.”⁹⁷ Willful ignorance inevitably takes on an odor of betrayal.

Accused of communism earlier and of mysticism later, Bohm’s work continued to unfold, if not without bouts of severe depression, until he died in 1992. He had on the day of his death finished *The Undivided Universe*, a massive text cowritten with the mathematician Basil J. Hiley. Bohm had lived to see a certain vindication of his research as Bell’s Theorem began to make waves. The story of those waves is grippingly told by the MIT historian of science David Kaiser in *How the Hip-pies Saved Physics*. Around 1970 amidst a sudden glut of physics Ph.D.s, several made their way to San Francisco. Pursuing their interests in the quantum implications that had originally led them into physics before they learned to “shut up and calculate” they banded together in merry deviance as the Fundamental Fysiks Group, reading Eastern mysticism, practicing meditation, researching the paranormal, and asking forbidden questions. Why haven’t they been erased from the pages of any respectable reading of physics? The problem is that they did serious work. Stapp was part of the group. And it was their journal publications that led to the reception of the now normative Bell Theorem and so to the empirical testing and irrepressibly mounting success of the concept of quantum nonlocality or entanglement. Bohm, though not part of this collective, was, as Kaiser shows, indispensable to its thinking.

Bohm’s specific deviancy lay in his insistence from the start upon the coinciding of contradictories. We do not need here to track his early essays on “pilot waves” and hidden variables, which retain, in his attempt to break the contradiction of

special relativity and quantum theory, a certain Einsteinian causal realism with its determinist residues. In the eighties his attention shifts to the problem of the logic that maintains the contradiction of the two pillars. As he was still asking in his last work: “Would it not be possible that the present contradiction between the basic concepts of relativity and quantum theory could . . . lead to a qualitatively new idea that would open the way to resolve all these difficulties?”⁹⁸ Now he was insisting—as d’Espagnat, Stapp, and more recently Barad would also argue—that only a philosophical paradigm shift will make such resolution possible. For this shift quantum theory would count as the most radical indicator, but not the complete or final truth. The shift requires “a qualitatively new theory, from which both relativity and quantum theory are to be derived as abstractions, approximations and limiting cases.”⁹⁹ These two theories that had come about almost simultaneously are both “indicators of a new order for physics.” Despite the advances made by “relativistic quantum field theory,” fundamental difficulties remain.

The logic of his next step —offered as part of a speculative, not a proven or factual, description—will I hope now seem familiar: “An important light can be thrown on these difficulties by noting that the basic orders implied in relativity theory and in quantum theory are qualitatively in complete contradiction. Thus relativity requires strict continuity, strict causality and strict locality in the order of the movement of particles and fields. And . . . in essence quantum mechanics implies the opposite.”¹⁰⁰ Like Cusa, Bohm plunges directly, and not without pain, into the cloud: and there appears the wall woven of the coincidence of opposites. “As a clue to what this new idea might be, we could begin by asking, not what are the key differences between these concepts, but rather what they have in common.” Where might they in fact already coincide, in their very opposition? “What they have in common is actually a quality of *unbroken wholeness*.”¹⁰¹

In recognition of the struggle for language within the specific cloud of scientific unspeakables, let us suspend for a moment the current disdain for any language of holism (as though it must mean a totalizing or enclosed unity). If we let the nuance of Bohm’s insight come through, we see that he means quite the opposite of a homogenous totality: for him an electron is not one thing but an “ensemble” enfolded throughout the whole of space. In terms of relativity, undivided wholeness means that there exist no permanent and separate particles,

but rather space-time points in a field. Each such point is either “a singularity in the field” or “a stable pulse of finite extent.” In relativity theory however, the indivisibility is “still of limited applicability . . . because the basic concept is that of a point event which is distinct and separate from all other point events.” And so also strictly *local*. In quantum theory Bohm and Hiley discern “a much more thoroughgoing kind of unbroken wholeness. Thus even in the conventional interpretations, one talks of indivisible quantum processes that link different systems in an unanalysable way.”¹⁰² If the world of general relativity is simply and smoothly continuous, this “unbroken wholeness” actually appears as an effect of the discontinuous quantum jumps and jitters. The jumps that *yield* the continuity (Whitehead’s quantum-based extensive continuum is thus “a becoming of continuity, not a continuity of becoming”).

In this analysis of the “unanalyzable,” we find ourselves at the material base of apophatic entanglement. “In principle these links should extend to the whole universe, but for practical purposes their effects can be neglected on the large scale.” That would be the practicality of scientific pragmatism. But “there is also the fact that because the quantum potential represents active information, there is a *nonlocal connection which can, in principle, make even distant objects into a single system*.”¹⁰³ This indivisibility remains invisible, he argues, unless we “drop the mechanistic order”—that still largely dominates the imagination of scientists. “A centrally relevant change in descriptive order required in the quantum theory is thus the dropping of the notion of analysis of the world into relatively autonomous parts, separately existent but in interaction.”¹⁰⁴ Bohm emphasizes the indivisible field, “in which the observing instrument is not separated from what is observed.”¹⁰⁵ Each part or particle dissolves into what he called the “poorly defined cloud.” Bohm reads its microtexture as “indivisible and unanalyzable”—composed, we might add, of waves of apophatically interpenetrating relations. So whether moving upward and outward into ever wider fields, or down into “smaller and smaller units, we do not come to fundamental units, or indivisible units, but we do come to *a point where division has no meaning*.”¹⁰⁶

In that indivisibility is manifest the mysterious character of the quantum field. Bohm calls it “the implicate order.” “Now, the word *implicit* is based on the verb *to implicate*. This means ‘to fold inward’ (as multiplication means ‘folding many

times'). So we may be led to explore the notion that in some sense each region contains a total structure 'enfolded' within it."¹⁰⁷

As a parable for this enfolding process, the then new technology of the hologram was helpful to Bohm. "Each region of the hologram makes possible an image of the whole object. When we put all these regions together, we still obtain an image of the whole object, but one that is more sharply defined, as well as containing more points of view."¹⁰⁸ Might we glimpse here a descendant of the exercise of *De visione Dei*, in which the proliferation of perspectives in an interpenetration of the viewer and the viewed made visible something imperceptible to normative perception? "The hologram seems, on cursory inspection, to have no significant order in it, and yet there must somehow be in it an order that determines the order of points that will appear in the image when it is illuminated. We may call this order implicit. . . . So in some sense the whole object is enfolded in each part of the hologram rather than being in point-to-point correspondence."¹⁰⁹ Wholeness here emphatically does not signify a one, a fixed, perfect, or homogeneous totality. Its elements are ensembles, not ones. Like a hologram, the implicate order multiplies diffractively, endlessly. Mentioning his allegiance with Whitehead's concept of process, he proposes a *rheomode*, a *flowing* mode. And since a hologram suggests static images, he also coins the term *holomovement*. The universe itself is describable as a holomovement. Accordingly, "each relatively autonomous and stable structure (e.g. an atomic particle) is to be understood not as something independently and permanently existent but rather as a product that has been formed in the whole flowing movement and that will ultimately dissolve back into this movement."¹¹⁰

In other words the quantum waves here appear implicated, enfolded, in an oceanic plenum in which particularities materialize temporarily, like evanescent fish, with divergent degrees of stable repetition and complexity. The relatively stable bodies of the world—that of an atom or of a person—remain from this point of view not independent but *differentiated*: from each other and from the rheomode, from which they "unfold."

"The process in which the order becomes in the hologram manifest to the viewer in an image will be called *unfoldment* or *explication*."¹¹¹ In Bohm's theory the implicate and the explicate orders complement one another at every level. Indeed the relation between the explicate and the implicate strongly ontologizes

Niels Bohr's original complementarity principle—*contraria sunt complementa*—of the particle and the wave. As to the startling echo of the enfolding and unfolding God, Bohm does refer in an interview to Cusa and the complicatio/explicatio language. In his texts he derives the explicate and the implicate right from the etymology of the fold.

As in Cusa, the explicate order signifies the manifest multiplicity of the universe. In it takes place the particularity of its differences and the localization of its waves. For purposes of individuation, stability, and efficiency, various degrees of abstraction of each actual occasion from every other and from the plenary flux are inevitable. Such abstractions drive and are driven by language. And given the “masking effect” of decoherence mentioned in the last section, we could not operate in plain sight of the “cosmically and quantumly entangled universe.”¹¹² But our discourse will be complicit in interpreting the apophatic effect of the mask or ignoring it.

Beyond the necessary explication (decoherence) that lets the finite creature unfold, Bohm recognizes that something else has taken place on our planet. Human civilization seems to be based on an intensification, creative and destructive, of the explicate order. In the West it hardened into what Bohm calls “the Cartesian grid.” Often writing as a public intellectual, Bohm addressed the brokenness dangerously normalized as the very structure of our minds, communities, ecologies. The grid not only masks the rheomode, it *obstructs its unfolding*—and, ironically, in the name of progress. If modern science presumes the Cartesian order, it remained riveted to “the order of separate points,” within which the enfoldings appear as “only particular cases of movements of fields.” Bohm—moving well beyond the language of scientific decidability—is proposing “to turn this notion upside down and say that the implicate will have the kind of general necessity that is suitable for expressing the basic laws of physics, while the explicate order will be important within this approach only as a particular case of the general order.”¹¹³

The explicate will be, consonantly, an expression of what is otherwise enfolded. He asks rhetorically how to justify “such a radical change in our point of view.” The answer is strong: “basically all the laws of movement in quantum mechanics do correspond to enfoldment and unfoldment. Waves from each point unfold. But at the same time waves from many points are enfolding to give rise to a new wave front.” In this churning ocean of interfluent energies, “the one process

includes both enfoldment and unfoldment. It is only when we focus on a part that we are led to talk of these as distinct.”¹¹⁴ As in Cusa the unfolding coincides with the enfolding. This theory explains how the quantum can materialize either as a particle or a wave. For “both aspects are always enfolded in a quantum’s ensemble, but the way an observer interacts with the ensemble determines which aspect unfolds and which remains hidden.”¹¹⁵

Bohm offers pleasing heuristic devices. Consider, he says, “how on looking at the night sky, we are able to discern structures covering immense stretches of space and time, which are in some sense contained in the movements of light in the tiny space encompassed by the eye.”¹¹⁶ So the night sky with its visible immensity is “enfolded” in the eye. Or in music: “At a given moment a certain note is being played but a number of the previous notes are still ‘reverberating’ in consciousness. Close attention will show that it is the simultaneous presence and activity of all these reverberations that is responsible for the direct and immediately felt sense of movement, flow and continuity.”¹¹⁷ It is not that one is simply remembering a series of notes strung out in time mechanically impacting the ear in sequence. In this sensory perception of the holomovement one hears “how a sequence of notes is *enfolding into many levels of consciousness*, and of how at any given moment, the transformations flowing out of many such enfolded notes interpenetrate and intermingle to give rise to an immediate and primary feeling of movement.”¹¹⁸ In listening to music, “*one is therefore directly perceiving an implicate order.*”¹¹⁹

Using painting rather than music as the aesthetic device, Cusa was also leading his friends at Tegernsee to perceive the infinite complicatio unfolded in their perspectives. We observed his observing himself observing the seer and the seen mutually interpenetrate. “The observer is the observed,” writes a commentator on Bohm’s holomovement. “The observer is also the measuring device, the experimental results, the laboratory and the breeze that blows outside the laboratory.”¹²⁰ That observer-ensemble would constitute what Barad calls the phenomenon.

If Bohm links the ensembles of our quotidian sensorium to the microphysics of “electrons and neutrons, each of which has its own implicate order,” he also implicates human consciousness in the matter of physics. Consciousness is an especially subtle, “*sub-textere*, finely woven,” rhythm of unfolding and enfolding; it weaves the flowing plenum into thought, feeling, and physical reactions. If one asks what is the “relationship between the physical and the mental processes,” he

answers “that there are not two processes.” Getting off the Cartesian grid means that what “we experience as independent, in its movement through various levels of subtlety, will, in a natural way ultimately move the body by reaching the level of the quantum potential and of the ‘dance’ of the particles.”¹²¹ Again we witness the stretch to find language for a mind/matter nonseparability that, like Stapp’s “psychophysical” quantum event, reaches from the heart of physics—beyond the reductions of mechanism and the incoherence of dualism—all the way to a humanly conscious agency embodied responsibly in its world. Again we glimpse the cosmological redistribution of subjectivity. Of course the reader might reasonably wonder—why do we need a quantum scientist’s reflections on “mind”? Why wonder around in the cloud of the questions science cannot answer when we could select our discursive partners from among philosophers? I would reply that such a division of labor only replicates the familiar binarism of mental subjects vis-à-vis their brains, bodies, worlds. I am finding some dark and dancing brilliance in the apophatic overreach of scientists.

In the choreography of the implicate order “it is thus implied that in some sense a *rudimentary mind-like quality* is present even at the level of particle physics, and that as we go to subtler [*sub-textile*] levels, this mind-like quality becomes stronger and more developed.” The model with its nuance, its cloud, thus evades a dualistic relation or a materialist reduction. This subtler texture—like Barad’s delicate tissue-structure and Stapp’s psychosomatic cloud—implies a suffusion of the universe with animated awareness (not the same as consciousness). Bohm then describes the essential mode of relationship of all these as “*participation*, recalling that this word has two basic meanings, to ‘partake of’ and to ‘take part in.’ Through enfoldment, each relatively autonomous level of mind partakes of the whole to one degree or another.”¹²² What Wheeler calls the “participatory universe” finds here better company than he might have acknowledged. As we noted in the discussion of panentheism, participation models the nonseparability of difference.

We find ourselves woven not into a homogenizing holism but an ontology of active participation. Again let us not confuse the language of the “whole”—an answer to the divide-and-conquer rationality of the separable—with closure, sameness, or determinism. Participation refers to the interactive events that Bohm compares to Leibniz’s monads for their mirroring of the whole, though they differ

in this way: “Leibniz’s monads had a permanent existence, whereas our basic elements are only moments and are thus not permanent. Whitehead’s idea of ‘actual occasions’ is closer to the one proposed here.”¹²³ Bohm’s view of this constituent interdependence is strengthened by Whitehead’s sense of the spontaneous incorporations of mutual immanence. Though the emphasis upon free decision is much stronger in Whitehead (and in Stapp’s use of him), the *determinations* of the past do not in Bohm’s books yield to *determinist* analysis of any occasion. The process folds the fluid plenum into every local event. In Bohm’s writing the notion of enfoldment tends to take the place of the earlier “nonlocality” for which he had been such a dissident witness. The felicitous shift in more recent physics to “non-separability” strengthens the tendency of Bohm’s thinking, which similarly never envisions a “collapse of the wave function” such that the entanglement gets cut. Rather the connectivity is unfolded nonseparably from all that comes enfolded in each particular fold, each particle, each singularity.

It is within the implicate field of this holomovement that Bohm proposes to relink the two pillars. One can hardly speak of posting or planting them there, in such a flux. As in the exodus, they stay in motion. Whether he will have helped mainstream physics through its crisis of contradiction remains uncertain. Whether the more creative voices in its midst will prevail over Bell’s sleepwalkers is unpredictable. But the holomovement of these metaphors surely prepares the way. Our bodily ecology vibrates into consciousness from within a materiality irreducible to any known and reified matter: “we see that each human being similarly participates in an inseparable way in society and in the planet as a whole.” For, as Barad puts it insistently—and with no shadow of determinism: “questions of ethics and of justice are always already threaded through the very fabric of the world.”¹²⁴

THEOPHYSICS OF ENTANGLEMENT

What of the specifically *theological* implications of the avowedly speculative reaches of quantum relationality? When Bohm indicates a possible participation in some “yet more comprehensive mind going indefinitely beyond,” does that “beyond” not ripple through the tissue of the minimum, into something very like the

Cusan coincidentia with the maximum? “But there may be a further unknown set of entities, each having its implicate order,” writes Bohm, “and beyond this there may be a common implicate order, which goes deeper and deeper without limit and is ultimately unknown.”¹²⁵ What “may be” unsays any knowable totality. We have—as though directly echoing the Cusan complicatio—a paramount contemporary case of apophatic entanglement. Like the theocosmic infinite unfurled in the *docta ignorantia*, the implications of the implicate order know literally no limit: “What may be suggested further is that such participation goes on to a greater collective mind, and perhaps ultimately to some yet more comprehensive mind in principle capable of going indefinitely beyond the human species as a whole.”¹²⁶

Deeper and deeper, fold after fold, the implicate order from which all things are explicated folds together into an unknown, but perhaps not unknowing, plenum. This implicatio of quantum physics has been present from the start. The discoverer of the quantum, Max Planck, would say (typically, toward the end of his career): “I regard consciousness as fundamental. I regard matter as derivative from consciousness.” At that point *matter* still carried heavily substantialist meanings. Nonetheless, consciousness may be overstating a more diffuse awareness. And it may mask and subordinate its own materializations. But Bohm, as well as Stapp and like Barad—each differently—overlap in their insistence upon discerning a responsiveness, or mindfulness, at the base of things.

Of course disclosures of mentality by physicists at the minimum and perhaps therefore also maximum scale (a) do not count as empirical science, (b) do not signify “God,” and (c) can only irritate thinkers, relational theologians among them, who for the sake of a body-affirming materialism scorn any such enlargement of mentality. I would just note that any materialism that does not get beyond the modern derivation of mentality from insentient matter is hardly new. But Bennett’s “vibrant matter,” Barad’s feeling, conversing, desiring matter, or Connolly’s reading of quantum entanglement via Whitehead for the sake of a new—and spiritually electrified—materialist politics release the subversive aliveness of matter itself.¹²⁷ They form a fresh ensemble with Whitehead’s prehensive universe, as it implicates each momentary actual entity in a rudimentary mentality by which it physically feels its universe. The actual entities, of course, do not add up to God. It is, however, the case that the pan-experientialism of process *ontology*

comes enmeshed in the panentheism of process *theology*. For once one glimpses the mindful animation of minimal creatures, the plenum of creation itself comes alive. And then how do we name that life? To proscribe the metaphors of *anima mundi*, of spirit, of ultimate concern, or to simply discard their metonym, God, would seem arbitrary. Especially once quantum physicists themselves can be heard conjecturing—not proving—a “comprehensive mind.”

Only under certain theophysical circumstances might one call it God. Field of fields, ground, *Ungrund*, abyss, negative infinite, Hashem, possibility itself, the superimplicate or the supreme complication: it *is* not, cannot be identified as the personal God. Indeed it cannot be identified, only darkly suggested, with nicknames that widen the apophatic opening. Especially in the hazy fold between physics and theology, any language of God the Person, the Being, will shut down conversation. Nonetheless, in the apophatic opening we do relate as *persons* to—that all-in-all. And by quantum logic it would already be relating to us—personally. If after all it enfolds all, its infinite impersonality includes the personal that it embodies. It would come entangled from the get-go in all that would eventually evolve us persons. The quantum enigma offers one opportunity among many to narrate afresh what matters ultimately. If our very electrons now undo all straight materialism—matter breaks open from below, far from straight: indeed in what Barad calls its “queer performativity.”¹²⁸ “Matters of fact, matters of concern and matters of care are shot through with one another.”¹²⁹ If care turns ultimate in theology, God the symbol of that mattering, however heavy-handed and over-abstracted, cannot be dislodged from matter. Never could be: narratives of creation, incarnation, bodily resurrection did not await science to conceptualize their own spooky actions. And if theology is offering so many queer performances, indecent exposures, erotic ecologies, and “promiscuous incarnations” (Laurel Schneider) of its own in recent decades, it did so with little help from quantum mechanics.

But oddly, the quantum relationality turns the creation into such a mysteriously relational field as to make *credible* again—right amidst the impossibly dehumanizing and ballooning immensities of the multiverse—an intimate relation to its source. If that creative source is no longer conceivable as omnipotently producing a world and directing it to its End, it may be imaginable (theologically speaking) as unfolding *in and through* that world, as in its own flesh. And more: as hospitable to the indeterminate emergence of finite bodies with creativities all

their own. In a creation in which the boundary between inside and out is never more than an abstraction imposed—whether for care, for convenience, or for conquest—the difference between creator and creation must remain a nonseparable relation.

Bohm suggests that the subtler, mental aspects of the observer mirror her back to herself “in the larger setting of the universe as a whole.” And further: “one could say that through the human being the universe is making a mirror to observe itself.”¹³⁰ Theos, vision, is one antique icon of that long act of observation. “Nor is your being seen other than your seeing one who sees you” (Cusa).¹³¹ The seeing of God is not the seeing of the universe, but since God is not an object of vision, the universe seeing itself in our eyes may signify just what in our verbal icons we call the “vision of God.”¹³² “Or vice versa,” continues Bohm, “the universe could be regarded as continuous with the body of the human being.”¹³³ And Cusa put it without anthropocentrism: the universe in each creature *is* that creature.

In the mirror of quantum entanglement, in a boundless universe of nonseparability at any distance at all, I predict we will see more and more theological questions irrupting at the cutting edges of science. The conversations will continue to teeter on the brink of the impossible, as the contradictions of method, specialization, and sensibility will not soon soften. At the same time, the subtle texture of this universe electric with instantaneous relation, like one boundless body of feeling, is disclosing itself in a new vocabulary, in meticulous tests, among new ensembles of participation. Its very novelty forms a chiasmic coincidentia—nothing like an identity—with the ancient mirror, the enigma.

QUANTUM CONVIVIAM

This could be the purpose of it all: an infinite conviviality tuned at every level and in every galaxy to its minimal participants and its maximum creativity, calling forth observantly ever fresh performances of relation. S/he/it, the enfold-ing place, *Makom* of it all, would be enjoying the drama, suffering the tragedy, amorously entangled in every body everywhere all at once. But of course we do not know what the purpose is, or if there is one. We tell our parables in mindful ignorance.

Theology, in its own temptation to a Theory of Everything (TOE), is mirrored back to itself in the certainties and teleologies of Western civilization. Yet there appears in cloud perspective no lack of purpose, but rather a myriad of purposes, often cross-purposes, including the purpose to counter teleological presumption. Such purposeful multiplicity offers no omega point, closure, final eschaton. The rudimentary agency, the feeling pervading all things, seems instead to move and to be moved in an energetic dance inviting our improvisational contributions. As Malin said of entanglement, the events far apart “seem to ‘feel’ each other.” Their connection takes place, he suggests, “because both events form a single creative act, a single actual entity, arising out of a common field of potentialities.”¹³⁴ potentialities enfold infinities, within a field that is itself infinite. As Barad has put it recently, reflecting on the so-called quantum void: “Ontological indeterminacy, a radical openness, an infinity of possibilities, is at the core of mattering.” She comes very close here to the mysticism of an infinity enfolded in each creature: “The presumed lack of ability of the finite to hold the infinite in its finite manifestation seems empirically unfounded, and cuts short the infinite agential resources of undecidability/indeterminacy that are always already at play.” Her relational ontology unfolds in the face of these “im/possibilities” always an ethical response, here indeed with Derridean messianicity appealing to the “justice to come.”¹³⁵

With such agential resources in play, old parables of an implicate infinity and an explicate finitude can materialize in new ways. Between the common field of potentiality and the intensification of particular agencies, called forth everywhere under any circumstances, we may have the chances we need to effect the planet we desire. And in the failures, there may still be purpose enough to live through tragedy or die in grace. Neither the universe nor some figure of its authorship can be blamed for the particular horrors. But any persona of the infinite may be questioned—Job-like—for the conditions that allow inanimate and animate life here and there to explode into ever riskier complexities. It may not so much answer as bounce the question back: “Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth?”

“The secret one slowly growing a body” will not cease to be, openly, a secret. D’Espagnat’s “veiled reality,” like the God of negative theology, reveals without coming unveiled. But the apophatic opening may widen suddenly, unimaginably, and sometimes scientifically. Field of fields, fold of folds: we may only offer

back—in the very enigma and darkness of a boundless indeterminacy—a fresh unfolding. Within the ontology of the cloud there is no theism or atheism that excuses us from our becoming, together, now. “We are of the universe—there is no inside, no outside. There is only intra-acting from within and as part of the world in its becoming.”¹³⁶ Separation is a sham. It tears holes in the “tissue the life-blood runs through,” driving our relationships to unbecoming dependencies and our differences to desperation.

And so we swerve next into questions of its philosophical, its poetic, and its ethical becomings. “Meeting each moment,” continues Barad, “being alive to the possibilities of becoming, is an ethical call, an invitation that is written into the very matter of all being and becoming.”¹³⁷

May the quanta say amen.



five

THE FOLD IN PROCESS

DELEUZE AND WHITEHEAD

Rather, in a constant and sometimes contradictory mobility, the enfolding is also an unfolding, and inside and outside approach infinitely in their proximity. This odd doubleness is characteristic of language and body alike.

—KARMEN MACKENDRICK, WORD MADE SKIN

We are discovering new ways of folding, akin to new envelopments, but we all remain Leibnizian because what always matters is folding, unfolding, refolding.

—GILLES DELEUZE, THE FOLD

IT COMES DOWN TO FOLDS. Wave folding into particle, breath into body, hand into hand, melody into ear, seed into dirt, earth into human, violence into trauma, carbon into atmosphere, climate into climatology. Word into world, world into word. Outside in, inside out, the edge turns to layer, to tissue, complicating, pleating. The folding shapes, it limits, it may pleat sharply. We select, decide, make some cut between possibles, *decisare*; or else we dissolve into the manifold that *we* already are and “I” don’t happen. But the cut is never clean. It only exposes more folds. All the way down and out. And the vertical axis is itself twisting, bending into spirals diffracted by everything they transverse. The complication extends, explicates. Each one of its folds does the work of the world. In word or body.

The language in English that puts the fold literally into action has almost died: the verb *to ply*, as in *apply*, is now in common use only in a degraded sense—"to ply with alcohol"—yet it meant first of all "to work diligently" as "to ply a trade," as "the artist plies her brush passionately" or, in a semantically archaic mobility, "the sailor plies the seven seas." Folding signified the movement and agency of a *practice*. The noun has suffered an even sorrier abjection: we no longer think of a "ply" in its original sense as a fold or layer, as in the plies of a brain or of a project: "two-ply" now labels your toilet paper. Nonetheless, etymologically, not to mention in the chapters of this book, the fold still secretly labors within every multiplicity. Even *simplicity* provides complexity with no opposite, no mere One: it involves its single fold, its doubling.

If the fold repeats, layers, and *supplies* the actual world, it plies the open sea of its own potentiality. Then application no longer means the deployment of possibilities to predictable outcomes. But how does the fold escape the determinism of its doubling—one folds at least in two—its *repetition*? How might it work as the unit of an apophatic entanglement: the unit that is not one, in which the folding of the past world into a becoming present retains its edge of indeterminacy? Can the new unfold from its constituent relations? Does it not just happen—as *the event*? A coming rather than a becoming? The messianic, not the mess of tangles?

These questions expose again the dense web of issues, impossibly crowded in their politics and their materialities, and just as maddeningly abstract: for the *implications* precipitate dense explications. They demand new conceptualizations even before we have understood the old ones. And the tissue of folds between word and world, every last quantum of the cosmos, is precisely what demands and escapes every philosophical meditation on the relation of the knower to the thing known. It drives the noble attempts to sail past the Scylla of a cutting dualism and the Charybdis of a naive realism.

Thank goodness we ply theology here, and need not rehearse the whole onto-epistemological journey from Plato to Kant, from Hegel to . . . whomever floats our method. Our vessels in this century are less stately but no less dependent upon philosophy. This one is built for the waters of chaos. It is the concept of the fold, best articulated in the avowed chaosmos of Gilles Deleuze, that occupies the present chapter. And indeed it is the explicit enfoldment of Whiteheadian thought in the Deleuzian opus that will lend a current philosophical frame or "plane of

immanence” to this *theos logos* of apophatically entangled becomings. I am hoping that this apparent doubling of abstraction will pry open, not further cement, the wall of the current worldview.

We have in the first part of this book contemplated an Infinite Complication. Following its ancient darkness glowing in language, we read in Cusa the simultaneity of its enfolding in its unfolding in and as the material multiplicity of the world. So the theological coincidentia of the maximum with the minimum invited comparison with the current science of minute quanta entangled with each other at an apparently maximum scale. But most of us do not, most of the time, feel ourselves swirling between infinities and infinitesimals. Whatever we enfold in physics or metaphysics, our lives unfold, refold, and fold down at the human scale. The human finds itself (coincidentally) in the exact middle—once geocentrically, now smack between the Planck scale and the galactic superstructures. Cusa already replaced the fixed center of ourselves, our planet, with a mobile relativity of perspective. We contract it to the shifting perspective that we are. But what are “we”? Are we cut out crisply from the universe like da Vinci’s drawing, *Vitruvian Man*, separate, geometrically immobilized, supremely self-knowing? Or more like a Klee abstraction (in the traumatized generation between Whitehead and Deleuze), an eye and a heart cut lyrically into a landscape of moon, stars, roofs, star of David, cross—no less human in scale and perspective? What colors, cultures, creatures, compositions *ply the human*? If we are to mind the folds of the human in and out of the other bodies of its world, our difference from them remains—entangled.

So I am not now asking: what generically distinguishes us as a species? (Language, intellect, spirit, politics, the ability to ask these questions or to sneer at them . . . the question is premature, and stale.) I am asking: how do we unfold ourselves? How do we compose ourselves out of the folds, human or not, that already enfold us? It has been suggested as the basis of the operative chiasm of this book that these folds, known and unknown, represent our constituent relations to the world and to ourselves. But then how do we mark our difference from other humans no less than from all the nonhumans? *If the fold is the relation, it is also the difference.* It makes or plies the difference between any two humans, any two creatures, which is to say inhabitants of the unfolding creation or indeed of each other. And if so, we are thinking—humanly—the nonseparability of the human difference from all that is maximally or minimally nonhuman. Not, then, as an exercise

in the posthuman, but as a human exercise kin to the transhumanism gathered already from Barad in chapter 4's intra-activity. This chapter is then literally "after the physics," *meta-ta-physika*,¹ not in the sense of a transcendence of the physical, but in following it (not unlike Derrida's feline "following" of the animal, *L'Animal que donc je suis*, "'I am' or 'I follow'").² The physics hosted by this cloud already folds decisively beyond classical materialism and puts in question such notions as "physical," "matter"—along with the meaty or the mental "human." We are observing these solid words for solid bodies all clouding into varieties of relational ontology. I am confessing to metaphysics? Perhaps in the sense of following/being the *physical*—but differently. In a difference that comes always, no matter how abstract, *with* body. *Meta* means both "after" and "with." And, of course, in language and in bodies, every perspective is both after and with the folds that compose it, that *are* it. The folds, we will see, repeat and so follow the prior becomings. And so the new becoming is not *one* with what it enfolds—but *with* it. But to call the perspective that embraces that becoming "metaphysical" gets us stuck in a logos of the same or a debate about it that does not edify. Yet much that unsays the metaphysics of substance and its ontotheological God takes place in the name of metaphysics—as in Whitehead, as, indeed, in Deleuze.

Whitehead plied a kind of constructive imagination he could call metaphysical in its exodus from any scientific or religious positivism, that is, in his rigorous attention to the mentality of what we call physical. He is effortlessly absorbed by Deleuze at key moments, to be considered in this chapter. This is a rarity in Continental discourse. For the relentlessly anthropocentric (not therefore humanist) Foucault, Lacan, and earlier Derrida, had so successfully mobilized attention to human structures of language and power that any cosmological experiment such as the Whiteheadian seemed archaic. I was utterly unprepared to discover the Whiteheadian intertext in Deleuze. But, with the rise of interest in Deleuze, dynamic syntheses of process cosmology with Continental thought, in its more constructivist rather than deconstructive vein, are appearing. In Europe it is the philosopher of science Isabelle Stengers who has advanced this interchange.³ And working across the continents, Roland Faber has been advancing a great philosophical entanglement of Whitehead and Deleuze.

Deleuze makes Whitehead audible to an interdisciplinary readership otherwise selectively deaf to cosmology, to ontology, to physics, to theology—in other words, to the entanglement of the human in the nonhuman. He not only adds

an updated lexicon to Whitehead's little known vocabulary: he fiercely intensifies the becoming multiplicities of the process universe—in which Many already precede One and increase it. But the multiplicities already billow in full eventiveness in Whitehead. The wild connections across difference—of scale, of species, of planetary history and its human civilizations—are already categorically unfolded in and from the actual occasion. Of course in Whitehead there is not just the dipolar creature, always at once mental and physical. There is also the dipolar deity. God is not dead but becoming. Within the ontology of the cloud, however, the generative atheism of Deleuze, close to pantheism, may not so much contradict as *darken* the panentheism of Whitehead. But it is their joint decomposing of the anthropocentric perspective—for both a work less of critique than of creation—that will, in what follows, help us to ply the human otherwise.

FOLDING PHILOSOPHY

In *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque*, written, yes, toward the end of his life, Deleuze returns to an early fascination. The book is not just a dazzling rendition of Leibniz. Leibniz lets him pick up the figure that lay concealed for two decades amidst the layers of multiplying concepts—deterritorialization, the assemblage, the rhizome, nomadology, bodies without organs, becoming-imperceptible, the movement-image. The figure of the fold had come into play doubly in the early sixties—in his major *Difference and Repetition* (1968) and, in that same year, *Expressionism in Philosophy: Spinoza*.

In the latter he pursues a great early work of resistance to the Cartesian *dichotomos*, the cut-in-two. But the concept of the fold works also in double, as a nondualist binary articulating the play of enfolding and unfolding. Its dynamic range surfaces in an extraordinary series of doubles: “*implicatio* and *explicatio*, enfolding and unfolding, implication and explication, implying and explaining, involving and evolving, enveloping and developing.”⁴ Riveted to the idea of “expression” as the *modern* equivalent of the *explicatio*, he had traced the explication/complication pair to its Neoplatonic and, indeed, however fleetingly, its Cusan underground, a tradition (he says admiringly) “always subject to the charge of pantheism.”⁵ Inasmuch as “one may speak of the Anticartesianism of Leibniz and

Spinoza,” it is “grounded in the idea of expression.”⁶ He paraphrases Cusa thus: “Immanence corresponds to the unity of complication and explication, of inherence and implication. . . . It is a complicative God who is explicated through all things.”⁷ And this logic of inherence and implication “will dominate Deleuze’s systematic expositions of immanence,” from *Difference and Repetition* to *The Fold*.⁸

In *The Fold*, Deleuze examines the alternative advanced by Descartes’s other seventeenth-century contemporary, Leibniz. “Descartes believed that the real distinction between parts entailed *separability*. . . . According to Leibniz, two parts of really distinct matter can be inseparable.”⁹ So here the distinction becomes explicit—argued from within the presupposition of substance—of the *distinct* from the *separable*. Separability “in fact applies only to a passive and abstract matter.”¹⁰ In other words the nonseparability that we observed blowing the minds of physicists extends its philosophical lineage. As Whitehead insists, the notion of separate bits of matter or mind, externally related, is a product of abstraction. It becomes a fallacy only when the abstract is mistaken for the concrete.

If Deleuze comes to the fold early and late in his thinking, he generates language all along the way for the differential connectivity of the world. It is a language as resistant to a unifying One, as to a mere collection of many ones. “Don’t be a one or multiple, be multiplicities!” It is the *pli* that makes the difference. A jaunty imperative for any relational pluralism, any polydoxy. For the many come folding in and out of each other. His collaboration with Guattari performs the multiplicity they write: “The two of us wrote *Anti-Oedipus* together. Since each of us was several, there was already quite a crowd.”¹¹ (And we will find much more crowd than cloud in this chapter.) The politics of their books together with their nomadic war machine, would deterritorialize the empires of the One. It invites resistance to the vertical hierarchy at the root: become a rhizome! The orchid and the bee form a rhizome—an incarnation of the fold. Unlike the root, the rhizome spreads like grass, like a democratic multitude, like Whitman’s *Leaves of Grass*—just below the earth’s surface. Its geopolitical “lines of flight” would mobilize a manifold solidarity in place of the solidified powers.

The connective energy of their concepts of deterritorializing multiplicities has stimulated its own rhizome of political philosophies. Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, in a comparable double, have deployed Deleuze and Guattari to theorize a radical mobilization of multiplicity, as *The Multitude*, against the One—above

all the new global Empire of corporate capitalism. Their work reverberated in the short-lived but explosive promise of the Occupy movement, in the potential of the planetary crowd of the 99 percent, enfolded in a theological future by Joerg Rieger and Kwok Pui-lan.¹² William Connolly, with his pragmatic, Jamesian, and now Whiteheadian Deleuzianism, plies a more ecologically and biologically materialized, more cosmopolitically democratic pluralism.¹³ These political unfoldings refract the nomadic exodoi of the desert cloud.

In the Deleuzian work concepts themselves are multiplied and mobilized. They do not reflect, mirror, or subserve the real; they participate in its becoming. They do not cut the world into abstractions. They ply the world; they apply themselves to its practices. Yet not in the sense of some scientific or ethical determinism, for concepts themselves are “centers of vibration, each one in itself and each in relation to all the others.”¹⁴ Linguistic centers are vibrating in sync—very differently from the poststructuralism of the time—with the rhythms of becoming bodies. In *Thousand Plateaus* he and Guattari ply a transformative language of *symbiosis*, of “life together,” where biosis implies not a biological entity but a process, a becoming: “It is already going too far to postulate an order descending from the animal to the vegetable, then to molecules, to particles. Each multiplicity is symbiotic; its becoming ties together animals, plants, microorganisms, mad particles, a whole galaxy.”¹⁵

“Too far,” they mean, along a hierarchy. Instead this symbiosis spins open the meaning of *bios*, as the multiplying life that lives only in the plies of interlinked relations: not many creatures along a vertical or side by side but nonseparably linked. The symbiosis of mad particles with a galaxy by way of everything between, as we saw in the last chapter, is not just a Parisian poeticism. Deleuze evidently caught quantum entanglement on his radar already in the sixties, well before physics could cope with it. While contemplating the relation between successive present moments he refers quite precisely to “non-localizable connections, actions at a distance, systems of replay, resonance and echoes.”¹⁶ This takes place in the context of the great chapter of *Difference and Repetition* where, paraphrasing the Victorian Samuel Butler, he asks, “What organism is not made of elements and cases of repetition, of contemplated and contracted water, nitrogen, carbon, chlorides and sulphates, thereby intertwining all the habits of which it is composed?” And then he quotes—relishing the irony of all this matter—Plotinus: “all is contemplation!”¹⁷ Deleuze knows of the Neoplatonic background of such

contraction—as in Cusa’s contraction of the universe in and as each creature. In the each-in-each there is no space for inert, lifeless matter; the mad particles are folded into contemplation, which surely resonates with the observant quanta of Stapp, with the elemental. The present cloud contemplation circulates through the endlessly nonhuman constituency of contemplation itself.

The polymath Deleuze thinks in coordination with, and often in advance of, a wide range of scientific symbioses. For example, the biologist Lynne Margulis, first hereticized, now honored by her peers, later demonstrated the elemental relationalism of microorganisms. She exposed an interactive tissue of microbacteria covering the planet in a heretofore unknown layer of symbiosis. They may possibly explain the evolution of life as an original, cooperative act of mutually constitutive relation that she called “syntrophogenesis.” It is a relation of feeding; but the imbibing of a single cell by another did not kill the first but enfolded it in a new creation—and so gave rise to *complexity*: the organism. Recall that symbiosis translates into Latin as *convivium*, “living together,” the first meaning of which is “feast.” The primal eucharist of life seems to find its genesis less in competition than in collaboration. This theory of life at the microscale of the organism also drove her coauthorship with Lovelock on the Gaia hypothesis (also initially shunned), modeling the earth as a complex system on the macroscale. Neither the minimal microorganisms nor the maximum planetary organism map onto any traditional sense of the body; and so we may read the Deleuzian “bodies without organs” not as hostility toward organic life but toward its hierarchies of bounded organs. The phrase means to expose the nonseparability of concrete lives across “the whole galaxy.” (I am especially partial to Jea Sophia Oh’s postcolonial paraphrase: “becoming the Other: body without organ of Man.”)¹⁸

Alfred North Whitehead’s philosophy of organism, the most developed pluralist alternative to any dichotomy of organic and inorganic, let alone of mental and physical existence, reverberates in the background. As in Deleuze, nearly four decades later, the alternative to the stasis of dualism or monism is the process of multiplicities: “Every actual occasion exhibits itself as a process: it is a becomingness. In so disclosing itself, it places itself as one among a multiplicity of other occasions, without which it could not be itself.”¹⁹

Whitehead’s actual occasion transmutes the substance—*res cogitans* or *extensa*—of separate individuals into the moments of becoming. Just as in Deleuze the becoming links together any scale and sort of creature, in Whitehead

any ontological individual—particle, molecule, cell, each animal composed of them—is read as an actual occasion constituted of its relations to all its others. The actual occasion is a contraction of its universe from a unique perspective: it enfolds its universe and unfolds it differently. Whitehead does not use the language of folding; but it is his concept of the momentary occasion that Deleuze features in the climactic chapter of *The Fold*, “What Is an Event?” For both thinkers the event is as such a multiplicity, whose members come variously enfolded, pleated, engaged in each other already—and then get wrapped, cut together differently in the one now becoming. The many become *that* one, whose pleats of difference do not iron out but wrinkle all the way through. No chance to become a self-knowing or self-identical substance: that moment of becoming unfolds into the future “as potential for the becomings of future occasions.”

Whitehead and Deleuze are not one. But it is still too little noted that in *The Fold* the *pli* of multiplicity comes into its own as a rhizome of Deleuze/Whitehead/Leibniz. Indeed Deleuze draws upon Whitehead prominently in *What Is Philosophy?* (1991). And at the end of *Difference and Repetition* he proclaims *Process and Reality* to be one of “the greatest books of modern philosophy.”²⁰ He praises Whitehead, for “notions which are really open and which betray an empirical and pluralist sense of Ideas.”²¹ Or perhaps there would have been too little resonance. Aside from Jean Wahl, whose attempt to introduce James and Whitehead into the Parisian scene in the mid thirties—as avatars of “the concrete”—seems to have been thwarted not only by the war but by the linguistic gulf, Whitehead was in general ignored on the Continent and also (aside from a mainly theological subculture) in the U.S. and England. The focus on sociolinguistic structure eclipsed interest in anything but the human world. And as deconstruction came to the fore the work of difference—“that difference is not, does not exist, is not a present being (*on*)” did also expose the dualisms and the monisms of substance metaphysics.²² However, Derrida did not move toward the embodiments of the multiple and its interlinked relations, let alone toward any relational theology (such as was being born as process theology during exactly the same period). At one level the impossibility that taunts the present project is just the possibility of an apophatic entanglement of difference in such a theology. And yet ironically it is Deleuze—the other great thinker of difference, one perhaps even more rigorously faithful to the Nietzschean death of God than Derrida—who may articulate

such a link for us. Or rather Deleuze may serve as what he calls a “dark precursor” for an integration that may yet happen, but, if so, “in reverse,” like “thunderbolts exploding” due to the preceding pressure differential.

Clayton Crockett explains that the dark precursor is the “differentiator, and it is also what later becomes the plane of immanence or plane of consistency.”²³ In grappling with Deleuzian difference as an operational differentiator—not a static distinction—Crockett lifts into relief a point of importance to our inquiry. Deleuze inserts an odd little summary of Heidegger early in the book. “1. The not expresses *not* the negative but the difference between Being and being. . . . 2. This difference is not ‘between’ in the ordinary sense of the word. It is the Fold, *Zwiefalt*.”²⁴ Difference as the ontological difference between Being and beings,” comments Clayton, “is not simply a negative relation, a ‘Not,’ but rather the fold between Being and beings.”²⁵ Perhaps here we have a dark precursor for the fold this book seeks, between negative theology and ontological relationality: when we say not God, are we saying—not a negative relation but the fold between what is called God and the relations of the world: the *en* of panenthism?

This *Zwiefalt*—the twofold—opens for Deleuze a passage from “difference in itself” to “repetition for itself.” By distinguishing the “not” from mere negation, the not-this of every difference comes into its own, not as a nothingness, a Sartrean *néant* or hole, but as an affirmative “fold.” Thus Crockett disagrees with the standard interpretation according to which “Deleuze lacks a theory of relations. This is wrong.”²⁶ The fold signifies for Deleuze what we have been calling a non-separable difference, a relation of difference: the differential relation is not a resemblance or a similarity, not a slide toward sameness. But relation does require a repetition—a doubling, or fold, of the one in the other. Deleuze uses the language of repetition, in other words, to keep relation temporal, rhythmic—differential. Indeed it is perhaps above all his attempt to redeem Nietzsche’s concept of eternal recurrence from any onus of fatalism, of mere iteration of the same, that drives the book.

The thesis of *Difference and Repetition* may thus be summarized in the words of Deleuze: “difference inhabits repetition.” A repetition is not the same as what it repeats but is already another. So we see that repetition in Deleuze takes the place of the continuity of an essence, a substance, and yet performs such continuity as there is (of the one who reads this sentence, for example, enfolding in sight and

mind a repetition of the words I write). By repetition the past is thus enfolded in a present. But for Deleuze there is a triple repetition: a second repetition contemplates that past as a becoming present (you make sense of these words), and then a third repetition yields the “future as such”: “it is itself the new, complete novelty.”²⁷ (You will make your own meaning of the words.)

I cannot help but hear an echo, perhaps even a repetition, of the triple repetition in this passage: “that *experience* involves a *becoming*, that *becoming* means that *something becomes*, and that *what becomes* involves *repetition* transformed into *novel immediacy*.”²⁸ Here Whitehead pits repetition against Cartesian substance and its “presupposition of individual independence.” Whitehead seems here to be the dark precursor. One can say that the actual occasion as an event of interdependence *enfolds* the differences of its predecessors as its past. So the “public” repetition that is “causal efficacy” is the actual occasion prehending or enfolding in feeling its past world. The “private” repetition, internal to the moment, is the concrescence of creative contrasts. In this becoming concrete, difference indeed inhabits repetition. For that repetition yields the novum—the immediacy of experience. But in the third fold the occasion “perishes”—just at the point of its “satisfaction” or actualization. It doubles as an “immortal” influence in the world, rippling through the prehensions of future occasions as a potential for their *possible* actualizations. Not endless return of the same event, but the entanglement of the new event in all subsequent relations. The novelty, the crisp bite of the first apple, will repeat itself endlessly.

And the human? It emerges like every other creature in this triple folding. In the creative contrasts by which we compose ourselves, consciousness emerges—as a contrast of contrasts, never a given. It does not distinguish us from other animals. The degree of complication may. It allows us to entertain propositions, “lures to feeling,” with a perilous freedom of selection—Whitehead derives consciousness specifically from an “affirmation-negation” contrast. The past and future, enfolded as potentiality, now invite the peculiar spatiotemporal range of the human, with its contrast of memory and futurity making possible—*posse*—the self-conscious novelty of the human perspective. Contrasts of contrasts, folds within folds: consciousness emerges, if it does, late in the nontemporal sequence of the concrescence. Not that I ever know myself directly, as a Cartesian mind could. In the concrescence I remember and forget what has been, even as I antici-

pate or ignore possibility for what may be. But “I” am always only now becoming and therefore never available for pure self-knowing. “I” am already a crowd—of past selves and future possibilities. “I” happen at the same time as the perspective enfolding them all. So the “I” seems to be a peculiarly human device: it renders my perspective, entangled in all those others, singularly repeatable—and therefore responsible. We are able to respond to the other before us, and so to decide, to cut between possibilities—mindfully. Or not. The other may be first of all human, mirroring me to myself, but only first of all, and only late in history did the human get abstracted and extracted as ego from all the nonhuman selves folding in and out of it. Still we humans know ourselves cloudily as complex compositions of our relations human and otherwise, called to create something new of them—of ourselves. Together, in any event.

“A fold is always folded within a fold, like a cavern in a cavern. The unit of matter, the smallest element of the labyrinth, is the fold, not the point which is never a part, but a simple extremity of the line.”²⁹ Thus Deleuze traces the entangled difference of a multiplicity in the shape of the labyrinth. And his folds precipitate events, they ply the actual. “We must hold on to our awareness of this eventfulness, of the fold as an act, ‘to fold’ as a verb,” explains Karmen MacKendrick.³⁰

Toward the end of *Difference and Repetition* comes an extraordinary passage, one that sprang out at me once when I was sniffing around for the lost chaos of Genesis. Here suddenly he calls upon Leibniz for a notion of multiple perspectives that “unfold simultaneously,” then he invokes the chaos of James Joyce’s stream of consciousness “as itself the most positive,” as “indistinguishable from the great work which contains all the *complicated* series, which affirms and complicates all the series at once.”³¹ If this figure of the complicatio sounds familiar, the following sentence, veiled in parenthesis, renders the genealogy explicit: “It is not surprising that Joyce should have been so interested in Bruno, the theoretician of *complicatio*.” Bruno, we have noted, drew his visionary vocabulary of cosmic folds directly from Cusa. “The trinity complication-explication-implication accounts for the totality of the system—in other words, the chaos which contains all, the divergent series which lead out and back in, and the differenciator which relates them one to another.”³²

It is not the same triple repetition but an esoteric modulation at the scale of the universe. To translate the enfolding of all as the chaos is hardly Cusan, let alone

divine; but it does open up from below the infinity of unformed—unbounded—possibility. The same trinity recurs again toward the end of the book, in the same passage where he invokes Whitehead. Again complication signifies “the state of chaos which retains and comprises all the actual intensive series which correspond to these ideal series, incarnating them and affirming their divergence.”³³ This convergent divergence—certainly no mere disorder—describes the first fold or integration. Explication is the next, where a solution to the problems is traced out. Implication signifies the persistence of the problems and of the values that explicate them. If we intensify its resonance with the infinite complicatio, which may be called chaos only in the profound sense of *tehom* or the apophatic deep, and from which the “God” problem cannot be washed out, we diverge from Deleuze in the direction of his much older sources.

During the same period Deleuze wrote *Expressionism in Philosophy*, in which he traced with admiration the Neoplatonic lineage of the unfolding and the enfolding. As Joshua Ramey has invitingly demonstrated, the hermetic tradition as it is funneled through the Renaissance Neoplatonism of Cusa, Pico della Mirandola, and Bruno provides Deleuze with the “dark precursors” of a spiritual legacy.³⁴ When he returns late in his life to the figure of the fold, then, it is no casual assemblage of concepts that accompanies it.

OPEN MONADS

So then when he ensconces Whitehead as the subject of the pivotal chapter of *The Fold*, a book on Leibniz, it is because he finds with him the question—“What Is an Event?”—echoing for just the third time (the first time among the Stoics, the second with Leibniz) in the history of philosophy. As we have seen already, there is no easy coincidence of fold and event; one must provoke a co-incident. The relationality might otherwise lie neatly folded in a demobilizing drawer. There is no more mobile thinker, releasing less predictable lines of flight, than Deleuze. Nonetheless, the problem of the relation of the nonseparability to novelty, in other words of fold/repetition to unpredicted event, persists. The terms in which he returns to it seem at once overdetermined and surprising. I do not mean that there is some teleological necessity to this recurrence. Divergent lines

of thinking persist, as in *Cinema 2* and 2, with their politically charged vocabulary of movement-image and then time-image. Indeed his return to the fold expresses something of the force of novelty in repetition that the “eternal return” signifies for Deleuze.

He sets Leibniz in the architectonics of a “Baroque condition” surrounded by gilded drapes, whorls, and pleats. All these luminous folds might appear to the jaded eye as the effulgence of seventeenth-century power. But here they yield a code of infinite connectivity. Thus Deleuze paraphrases Leibniz: “a continuous labyrinth is not a line dissolving into independent points, as flowing and might dissolve into grains, but resembles a sheet of paper divided into infinite folds . . . each one determined by the consistent or conspiring surroundings.”³⁵ The division of the continuous, in the words of Leibniz, “must not be taken as of sand dividing into grains, but as that of a sheet of paper or of a tunic in folds, in such a way that an infinite number of folds can be produced, some smaller than others, but without the body ever dissolving into points or minima” (6).

We recall that Heisenberg’s “smaller and smaller units “bring us not “to fundamental units, or indivisible units,” but to that “point where division has no meaning.” The simplest minimum that measurement can reach never proves to be the smallest (candidates have been the fermion, the Higgs boson, the superstring). They come folded with partners or superpositions (the wino and the bino—so physics names the nameless—are superpartners of certain bosons). The minimal one is *Einfalt*, one fold, simplicity. “The unit of matter, the smallest element of the labyrinth, is the fold, not the point which is never a part, but a simple extremity of the line” (6). (Cusa had already tracked the fold of point into line, the line into the circle, the circle Hermetically losing its circumference.) Unlike the point-grid of Cartesian or Newtonian space, the universe as a whole, Leibniz wrote in 1696, resembles “a pond of matter in which there exist different flows and waves” (5). Leibniz already anticipates, a bit spookily, the quantum field.

“Particles,” continues Deleuze, citing Leibniz, “are ‘turned into folds’ that a ‘contrary effort changes over and again.’ Leibniz “brings the fold or the variation to infinity. . . . The model for the science of matter is the ‘origami,’ as the Japanese philosopher might say, or the art of folding paper” (6). One could in this context consider the Asian philosophies of flow, in for instance the microprocesses of *pratityasamutpadha*, the Buddhist flux of events interdependently co-arising. Or

in the flowing mutual enfoldment of the yin and the yang, whose chiasm does not diminish their difference. A human alter-knowing of nonseparable difference has been breaking through here and there for millennia.

Deleuze turbocharges relations comprising the Baroque origami. Its complex spirals follow a “fractal mode by which new turbulences are inserted between the initial ones” (18). He draws upon the mathematical breakthroughs of the 1960s, coincidentally Parisian, the hallucinogenic geometry of chaos of Benoit Mandelbrot, and the catastrophe theory of René Thom, with its elementary fold-events. Complexity theory and its notion of emergence “at the edge of chaos” provide another scene, largely biological, of the nonreductionist relationalism unfolding at the shorelines of science itself. In this holographic iteration at multiple scales, one can imagine Baroque design merging with postmodern geometry. “Growing from other turbulences, in the *erasure of contour*, turbulence ends only in watery froth or in a flowing mane.” Here lines do not draw boundaries between substances but fractal nonlinearities that “open onto fluctuation” (18). Fluctuation in chaos theory registers in a hallucinatory, computer-simulated iconography of novel repetitions, of iterative sensitivity across divergent scales and between dimensions. We may then not be surprised that Ilya Prigogine, the Nobel laureate and pioneer of chaos theory, writing with Stengers (who soon emerged in her own voice as the Deleuzian-Whiteheadian philosopher-physicist), uses Whitehead to interpret complexity in their *Order Out of Chaos* (1984).

Leibniz proposes the monad as the unit of enfoldment. The monad is a microcosm of the world, which it mirrors in itself. The monad *is* its perspective upon the world. The point morphs into the “*point of view*” (20). It is in fact Leibniz’s *perspectivism* that offers Whitehead, in *Science and the Modern World*, the clue for the critique of “simple location.” Simple location names scientific materialism’s doctrine that “material can be said to be here in space and here in time, or here in space-time, in a perfectly definite sense which does not require for its explanation any reference to other regions of space-time.”³⁶ Whitehead had developed a modal geometry in which no point can be pinned down; here he discusses “the prehensive unity of volume.” This is the way the different points of view—not *points*—comprised by prehensions together form a volume. A volume, as the most concrete element of space—such as a room—can of course be reduced to “a mere multiplicity of points.” But such a room is then nothing but “a construction of the

logical imagination.” The actual room is experienced as a prehensive unity, formed by the way each part is what it is only from the standpoint of every other part. Whitehead thereby performs an “erasure of contour” of the boundaries of discrete subjects and their separable objects.

Unaware of Whitehead’s discussion of Leibniz, Deleuze exclaims: “How remarkable that Whitehead’s analysis, based on mathematics and physics, appears to be completely independent of Leibniz’s work even though it coincides with it!”³⁷ Whitehead had in fact written that “it is evident that I can use Leibniz’s language, and say that every volume mirrors in itself every other volume in space.”³⁸ In Leibniz the *mirroring* of the universe in each monad is the reflection of the universe from—indeed *as*—a particular point of view, in space as in time. So Whitehead lends Leibniz a hint of Bergsonian *durée*: “Each duration of time mirrors in itself all temporal durations.”³⁹ It is this mirroring that will then in *Process and Reality* find explication in the double repetitions of prehension and of concrescence. Whitehead attends with special care to the concrete materialization of the microcosm: “in being aware of the bodily experience, we must thereby be aware of aspects of the whole spatio-temporal world as mirrored within the bodily life.”⁴⁰ The animal body is the community of repetitions inhabited by human difference; and it receives for its period unusual emphasis. The “withness of the body” enfolds the whole speculative width of his cosmological speculation. “The body, however, is only a peculiarly intimate bit of the universe.”⁴¹

Leibniz perhaps wrote the first full-scale metaphysical holography, much more developed in its analysis of the particular event than that of Cusa or Bruno. But the monad comes with a cost. Leibniz argued that “as this world does not exist outside of the monads that express it,”⁴² the monads have *no direct connection with each other*. Leibniz may thereby rescue the insight of the all-in-each from the aggressive Cartesian separation of each from all. If Leibniz resisted the dualism of substances through the infinite multiplicity of folds, Spinoza resisted it concurrently through an enfolding single substance. And there was Anne Conway as well, also provoked to write—in a period particularly repressive of female intellect—her own alternative to Descartes. She was inspired by her in-depth engagement of Jewish Kabbalah with a mystical and simultaneously naturalist animism: no creature lacks life and movement. Again the boundary between the animate and inanimate dissolves; the microcosm is a contraction of

universe. But in Conway the folds of multiplicity take the form of a direct and porous interdependence between creatures: “A creature, because it needs the assistance of its Fellow-Creatures, ought to be manifold, that it may receive this assistance.”⁴³ Through her friend van Helmholtz, Leibniz knew of and admired her book.⁴⁴

In Leibniz, however, the waves or folds of connection do not flow *between*, only harmonically *within*, his indubitably animate monads. The “each-in-each” gets trapped as he encloses the universe in windowless monads. They must run, therefore, on an interior determinism (infamously coordinated by what Whitehead called “the audacious fudge” of the best of all possible worlds). The determinist relations between monads display again the risk—not the necessary implication—of holism. So there is irony in the derivation of the *event*, which in the twentieth century signifies novelty, from Leibniz. And it is in order to ply this event-fold in its chaotic indeterminacy that Deleuze opens “What Is an Event?” thus: “Whitehead is the successor, or *diadoche*, as the Platonic philosophers used to say, of the school’s leader. The school is somewhat like a secret society.”⁴⁵ He is framed thereby as the third great thinker of the event.

Because in Leibniz “the world is submitted to a condition of closure,” Deleuze now deploys Whitehead to pry open the Leibnizian hologram without losing its fractal *microkosmos*. “Prehension is naturally open, open onto the world, without having to pass through a window.” Rather, writes Deleuze, “a condition of opening causes all prehension to be already the prehension of another prehension” (92). In this way he can affirm the fold not only of all in each but of each in each other. This is the immense difference from “Leibniz’s Baroque condition. For Whitehead it involves prehensions being directly connected to each other, either because they draw on others for data and form a world with them, or because they exclude others (negative prehensions), but always in the same universe in process” (91). Negative prehensions, which constitute the vast majority of relations, are nonetheless “perfectly definite” connections. Rethinking the fold between creatures as direct connection is an event in itself. For, without this chaotic entanglement in its universe, the event is—as we see in the pluralist event-ontology of Badiou—prone to balloon into one great revolutionary exception surrounded by a void.

Unlike the borders between impossible worlds, dividing the wholly excluded from the wholly included, “bifurcations, divergences, impossibilities, and discord belong to the same motley world.” That world “can only be made or

undone according to prehensive units and variable configurations or changing captures. In a same chaotic world divergent series are endlessly tracing bifurcating paths" (92). In other words, it is through Whitehead's philosophy of organism that Deleuze recuperates the microcosmic enfolding of the universe as an open system: "The monad is now unable to contain the entire world as if in a closed circle. . . . It now opens on a trajectory or a spiral in expansion that moves further and further away from a center" (157).⁴⁶

Deleuze then entangles the radical multiplicity of the microcosmic *monadology* with the elemental *nomadology* of his chaosmos. With the Deleuzian nomadology do we receive an echo—inadvertent, irreverent—of the Exodus? Certainly one could develop all manner of disturbing correlations with the nomadic warriors of *A Thousand Plateaus* and the tribal violence celebrated at the battle of Jericho. At any rate *The Fold* thankfully leaves the "nomadic war-machine" in the garage. Of course the chaosmos has not and will not unfold without violence, never far removed from vibrancy. But the vital seeds of nonviolent resistance to the ordered hierarchies of violation lie also amidst the nonseparable difference, repeated with fierce mindfulness.



The figure of complicatio-explicatio-implicatio releases a theological cloud of connections: folds all the way down, out, and up. So we must ask if the relentless connectivity has, after Deleuze, anything more to do with the deity of which the complicatio is an apophatic nickname? We might then ask, not does God live, but what kind *could*? The Sovereign of Separation—or an Infinite Complication? Or does the question presume too much? Does the boundary of the most modern assert itself here after all? When "God" gets eliminated, the cut must be clean. The only fold remaining would then be the history leading to "His [sic] death." His is not the Lutheran or Hegelian version of His Death, but the Nietzschean; God, repeated—eternally returned?—in the animated moments of God's death, would then be purged of all those countertraditions complicating and challenging the Judeo-Christian trajectory. Is this how "pure immanence" is to be achieved after all—by acts of allergic simplification?

Yet one must ask: if the cosmos in its chaos always refuses the boundary of inside and out, then how exactly does "pure immanence" remain pure? Does such

purity not erase the chaos? Or perhaps “purity” is the wrong word, a misleading hyperbole. Perhaps what is at stake is really a boundless or *infinite* immanence.

From Spinoza Deleuze took early the notion that “the substance contains within itself the infinity of its points of view upon itself.” The substance, *Deus sive Natura* (God or nature), has infinite attributes, which are all, *pan*, the creatures. But then this is no pantheism of identity, of God = world. Deleuze captures its ultimate thus: “in the absolute limit, these properties take on an infinite collective being.”⁴⁷ Neither the difference of theos nor its unfolded multiplicity as cosmos is reduced to a One. *An infinite collective being*: here flashes again the obscure intuition emitted when Cusa rules out any opposition of the divine One to a many. It occurs in the democratizing heresies of Spinoza, Schelling, and, in a different way, of the Whiteheadian consequent nature. I do not want to replay the dreary theological pantheophobia—a fear of the very logic of the infinite: no outside. Neither do I want to erase the difference between panentheism and pantheism. That little *en* encodes the difference of *pan* and *theos* and so, by a certain theological, difference itself. I want to smudge it apophatically. The world-all, as such, remains as unknown (consider dark energy) as any deity that could enfold it. In other words, the *en* is nothing other than the fold. In the *en*, theos is then not the same or similar to the all, but nonetheless its repetition. The pan repeats the theos that unfolds it. Theos is the repetition and thus the inhabitation of pan—the envagination of difference itself. This is to be sure a deterritorialized and deterritorializing deity—entangled in a spatiotemporality that, at any point, clouds into the infinite. This being would be of little use to those who do not occasionally need to wrap their minds around it All. In time.

Deleuze does not avoid the All.⁴⁸ He requires “a symbol adequate to the totality of time.” This symbol is here the all-involving temporality of the “eternal return,” which he redeems (in the third repetition) as the very site of the new. It may be “expressed in many ways: to throw time out of joint, to make the sun explode, to throw oneself into the volcano, to kill God or the Father.”⁴⁹ What philosopher has better cadenced his explosions? And feminist theologians might find here more solidarity than with any Father. But does Deleuze threaten to slash from the other side the fold that the Father would cut from Himself? The fold that might otherwise host the novel event? Is this not the danger of an oedipal repetition: of liberation from a prior violence by a violence that will father new exclusions?

In the womb of repetition and the laughter of its chaosmos, however, I am wondering: how could the Deleuzian immanence purify itself of that infinite collective being that for Spinoza was, after all, *God*—hardly less than was the (not) God of the apophatic tradition?

There remain, indeed there may increase, the becoming theologies, neither monotheist nor polytheist, worshipping neither the One nor the Many but perhaps finding already in scripture a plurisignularity (*Elohim*) or in Tertullian's trinity of "different not divided" already a triple fold. Would one silence the faint echo of Sinaitic thunder in every liberation movement or in any mystical cloud? Or might its preceding lightning flash expose the dark precursor of what follows? Would we purge—in the interest of purity—the name God not only from its own complicatio—and then also from the "One-All" Deleuze invokes in another late work? I ask these questions on behalf of theologians who find treasure in the Deleuzian immanence, but do not rush to sell off theology itself in order to afford it. We will get no permission from true Deleuzeans for even the entangled apophysis of the present cloud. But theology would have had nothing to say if it waited for the blessing of even those philosophies it finds indispensable.⁵⁰

The One-All, the *complicatio*, the infinite collective being, univocity, pantheistic affirmation—these are among the theologically charged names mobilized by Deleuze to banalize and supersede any transcendence. This not to say that he unsays the names of God. Rather he marks negative theology as a haven of transcendence, of the unsaying that unsays itself and yields analogy, likeness, resemblance. As indeed it does. His critique is part of an erudite appreciation of the complicatio/explicatio oscillation that, as he reads it, will finally work its way free, in Ockham but especially in Spinoza, of the false problem of affirming or negating the names of a transcendent Creator. Yet the complication in its infinite condition does not cease to repeat what its theistic lineage has meant by *God*.

If the purity of pure immanence is not a purge but an indeterminate infinity, then we must continue to ask: how would one put boundaries around it, excluding its own deep past and unknown future? Wouldn't one want rather to let that infinity undo the separative transcendence from the inside? If I ply here an apophatically panentheist argument it is neither for the existence of God nor for the compossibility of Deleuze and any theism. Rather it is that the coinciding of his particular atheism with a process theism provides a particularly compelling

impossibility for theology and so an all the more rigorous test of our apophatic opening.

GOD PROCESS

It happens that *The Fold* offers a rare moment at which Deleuze nods almost appreciatively at God: “Even God desists from being a being who compares worlds and chooses the richest compossible. He becomes Process, a process that at once affirms impossibilities and passes through them.”⁵¹ The affirmation of the impossible performs an infinite symbiosis. For the God in Whitehead does not operate by a dialectical negation of conflicting possibilities. If in Leibniz the impossibles—possibilities impossible to actualize in the same time frame—required separate worlds, in Deleuze impossible ensembles are a mark of “the Open.” “Nothing prevents us from affirming that impossibles belong to the same world,” he has argued elsewhere.⁵² Their joint belonging is a sign of the Joycean chaosmos.

We might say then that the prodigal possibilities of the world here pass through the impasse of the impossible: another sign and mobilization of the *coincidentia oppositorum* in which the oppositions do not cease to diverge even as they converge. Process is infinite. But is Process—God? In fact Whitehead does not identify Process with God but with Creativity, his “Category of the Ultimate.” He is at pains to distinguish his ultimate from his God, who mediates creativity to every becoming creature. The process God is not process itself, which, if named God, might again take command of all the becomings in process. God is *in* process *with* them. Negating divine ultimacy, Whitehead is resisting the imaginary of a changeless Lord omnipotently presiding. To collapse God into the sheer impersonality of Process might undo the anthropomorphism, but it is not Whitehead’s solution. God is rather a metaphor of the *relation* to the infinite process. And God thus provides a primordial locus of all possibilities, which begin to lose their sheer abstraction already by being housed, tabernacled. The nonlocal possibilities thus become available for local actualization. They become its lures.

The actual occasions materialize, however, through the agency of their own response. And God in consequence feels, internalizes, *em-pathos*, each becoming

as though in Her own body. The one who entangles us in new possibilities is thus entangled in their spontaneous actualizations.

God does not make the differences; but makes possible—*posse ipsum*—the difference actualized by every finite creature. The possibility of the lure or “initial aim,” repeated differently in the creature’s “subjective aim,” provokes the creaturely creativity from within.⁵³ Which might be just to pulse electronically or to take a breath. To jump into the volcano. Or to kill an idol. In this sense God has become Process—has unfolded in it, as it. And the process, as such, is certainly related to the Deleuzian immanence: “the philosophy of organism is closely allied to Spinoza’s scheme of thought,” Whitehead clarifies. “But it differs by the abandonment of the subject-predicate forms of thought.”⁵⁴ Like Spinoza, and more kin, as Whitehead signals, to “some strains of Indian, or Chinese, thought, than to western Asiatic, or European thought,”⁵⁵ it does make process—rather than fact, entity, a being—ultimate.

God is process, but not the only one. The process God, then, is neither transcendent Creator nor indifferent Creativity but a consequence of creativity, its “first creature.” An infinite creature to be sure, preceding and exceeding the creation collective, which it collects in and as its own becoming. Admittedly this solution yields its own problems, as I have stressed earlier. The language of God as “actual entity” at this point seems to cry out for an apophatic negation: not a being, not an entity, not a one. And surely *not* a creature. When Cusa considered the “creatable” God, we noted, he did then also unsay both creator and created—yet not without subversively privileging the latter. In cloud perspective we need not underwrite the process God’s tendencies toward a straightforward ontological identity—especially after decades of pedagogical repetition in U.S. process theology, beneficial in its ecclesial contexts. The benefits of the Deleuzian tonic in its philosophical ones thus work apophatically in the interface with theology.

The cloud of the impossible has promised no merely negative theology—only an exposure of the constructedness, never hidden by Whitehead, of metaphysical affirmations. God the mediation of groundless creativity and manifold creatures is not only rendered composite, collective—but infinitely so. In a heritage in which the authorities were always hunting down any insult to the Creator’s transcendence, any identification of God with creation as a whole (pantheism) or a particular creature (the Arian heresy of Christ as created), it is transcendence

that has been bounded and reified. God the creature: that phrase is an answering iconoclasm. It suggests in passing the exorbitantly embodied relationality of this process: incarnation multiplied beyond all knowing. In other words, it names the most apophatic of entanglements. But only if we also say—an actual entity *is* not God, a creature *is* not God, as God remains apophatically tucked among Whitehead's "metaphors mutely appealing for an imaginative leap."⁵⁶ Then we gladly tarry with this experiment in which Deleuze, impossible with theology, helps us darken the *en* of panentheism.

Process, not God, is the solvent that democratizes all processes as its instances. And therefore Whitehead's deity does not dissolve into the univocity of being but resolves into the solidarity of becoming: as the "prime exemplification" rather than "the exception" of creative flux. (Political theology of the sovereign exception will get no comfort from this God.) What Deleuze wants from ontological univocity Whitehead gets from his "ontological principle," defined thus: "all real togetherness is togetherness in the formal constitution of an actuality."⁵⁷ Actualities are the "only reasons"—God is not the first cause or the hidden reason behind what happens. But "God's immanence in the world . . . is an urge towards the future based upon an appetite in the present." God as this appetite, this eros, makes possible and urges the actualizations of possibilities but does not actually *perform* them. "The whole world's a stage" from its omnivoyant perspective. The individual occasions are improvisational events in a collective becoming—which may or may not constitute any kind of progress. Each actual occasion reconstitutes willy-nilly "the obvious solidarity of the world."⁵⁸

God as consequent nature, however, signifies no detached observer: s/he/it absorbs and integrates the whole collection in a process that can be called an infinite collective being. Such a being resembles no essential substance so much as one distributed infinitely among all as possibility—and actualized selectively, according to the limitations and deformations of each. For the present perspective the collectivity of the divine being is the complicatio itself—and so can only be distinguished from the creativity this way: as our relation to it. To it All. For the All of the world also oscillates between the collectivity of the particular creatures and the field, ocean or cloud from which and in which they unfold. God signifies the particular relation of particular creatures to the infinity of the world. All, pan, can be said to be "in God" because all is enfolded, complicated, in and as God, in the

consequent nature—and unfolded, as God is in all, in and as the creaturely decisions. But the creativity as such is a bottomless flux, an infinite abyss, a grounding *Ungrund*. The ultimacy itself, as perpetual genesis, may be called *tehom*. But then that deep is also the deep *of* God. “Your waves and your billows pass over me.” This chaos that surfaces in Whitehead’s “motley world” of “prehensive units and variable configurations” marks precisely the point where Deleuze salutes God as Process.⁵⁹ The *en* of panentheism remains a relation, a fold: it marks the difference precisely *as* the nonseparability of *pan* and *theos*. The *en* is, of course, the prefix of *immanence*. And it remains smudged, obnubilated, internal to the *relata* it relates.

Thus Whitehead: “it is as true to say that the world is immanent in God, as that God is immanent in the world.”⁶⁰ The chiasmus signifies a *chaosmos*: for immanence operationalizes nonseparability as relation. The relation is a motion, not a place. And so it is “as true to say that God transcends the world as that the world transcends God” (348). This transcendence is no entity, no Being, but movement beyond: not beyond, to another ontology, but beyond the given, to the new. Transcendence then will not serve as the foil of immanence: it is rather the dynamism of the folding, inasmuch as we have no longer to do with closed wholes but disenclosed becomings. Nancy’s transimmanence hints at such a crossover. Immanence without the movement beyond, the self-exceeding, is mere containment. In what is repeated “in” another—even as that other emerges—the boundary of the in and the out, the immanent and the transcendent, cracks right along with the wall between world and God. And then the creativity cascades through, washing out every substantial individual. In a world of separations it will feel like the primal flood. The difference that is relation rather than separation, however, is not threatened but intensified, multiplied, by the luminously darkened panentheism.

Intriguingly, Whitehead also moves to a third repetition in God. It is reflective of the trinity of *complicatio*, *explicatio*, *implicatio*, which is the Deleuzian Bruno’s supplementation of the Cusan binary. The *complicatio/explicatio* coincidentia can be correlated with the dynamism of the consequent and primordial in *Process and Reality*. As the consequent nature enfolds all that becomes as its own becoming, so the primordial nature unfolds its possibilities in and as the multiple actualizations of the world. But why then a *third*? Without indulging in a speculation on the Christian trinity, it does seem that the double gesture of the fold generates its own third, as mediation, as though to keep itself in chaotic motion.

So as a cosmology the *complication* of all in God can be fruitfully distinguished from the *implication* of God as possibility—*posse ipsum*—in the world, in the creatures, each in each and all in all. This bears then upon the move that Faber notes has been underassimilated because of its arrival so late in Whitehead's *Process and Reality*.⁶¹ Now—"for the kingdom of heaven is with us today"—what has been incorporated into God passes back into the world. "By reason of this reciprocal relation, the love in the world passes into the love in heaven, and floods back again into the world" (352).

So this third repetition is an implicated love. We can read it as the consequence of the consequent nature, linking its receptivity back again, which is to say forward, to the primordial filter upon creativity; the *complicatio* back to the *explicatio*—but only by the *implicatio* of the God-process in the active possibilities and multiplying impossibilities of the world. In this sense, then, we repeat the game-changing figure: "God is the great companion—the fellow-sufferer who understands" (352).

The amorous flooding comes darkened on its face, tinged with unknowing. For all that is folded together remains abysmally infinite. That does not signify indifference. Superposed with every difference, self-implicated, this love can only surpass human understanding. Even in moments of delight or trust, the God unfolding and enfolding us mirrors back not only our own personality but at the same time the whole elemental impersonality of the universe. Yet even there, with our quantum relationalists, we traced a hint of pervasive responsiveness, if not prior consciousness.

Repeated this often, the God in process turns impossible with the Deleuzian project. And surely the mutual embrace of earth and heaven, of *theos* and *pan*, rings too compassionate, with its "tender care that nothing be lost" (346). (Of course my theological occupation of Deleuzian space may trigger his war-machine in reaction. *Oy vey*.) It is nonetheless with the help of Whitehead, indeed for the sake of a new introduction of Whitehead, that the Leibnizian/Spinozist Deleuze returns to ply the convergent divergences, the iterative origami, of the *chaosmos*. At a certain point in that return Deleuze links Whitehead's God-process to a modern mathematical version of the opened microcosm, "a fibered conception according to which 'monads' test the paths in the universe and enter in syntheses associated with each path."⁶² Those very fibers had crossed *A Thou-*

sand Plateaus as the links, threads, or folds that connect everything but do not enclose anything: “A fiber stretches from a human to an animal, from a human or an animal to molecules, from molecules to particles, and so on to the imperceptible. Every fiber is a Universe fiber.”⁶³ With apophatic warrant in hand, we might leap to name the imperceptible, minimum or maximum, God. Not.

What matters is the creaturely thread. The fabric of the earth is perceptibly fraying: we humans now ignore the imperceptible at our peril. For the possibilities that may conspire with us amidst our impossibilities are encoded, enfolded, in those fibers. We always enfold the universe: but we can only unfold some sharply limited patch of it. The perspective will be human, but the content vastly other than human. If we still ply the human in the cloud-covered image of God, it has already reciprocated: in its dark mirror the sharp focus of the humanist hope, the One, Man, the discrete being of the human has dissipated. Instead a whole ensemble of creatures, elemental, vegetable, animal, and uncomfortably human, crowds the frame. It is not that the human perspective loses its focus, its I: rather, I lose my focus on myself. Self opens into the imperceptible. And so it perceives itself, *aesthesis*, differently: as in Frida Kahlo’s painting, *The Love Embrace of the Universe*, the fibrous, layered visages painted in an erotic multiple of cacti, species, colors of skin and atmosphere, herself, in Pieta-like embrace of her three-eyed lover, enfolded in the arms of an Earth embraced by an almost imperceptible goddess of cloud.

With or without God-talk, “and so on to the imperceptible,” designates the precise implicatio we can neither comprehend nor sanely ignore. Along its fibers we unfold a collective future of unspeakable destruction or unpredictable creativity. An apophatic cosmology suggests itself right at the intersection of process and French constructivism that Stengers plies in her *Cosmopolitiques*: “the cosmos refers to the unknown constituted by these multiple divergent worlds, and to the articulations of which they could eventually be capable, as opposed to the temptation of a peace intended to be final.”⁶⁴ We have to do here with “peace-making propositions,” not the proposal of an end of struggle. Elsewhere cosmopolitics defines—co-incidentally in an essay on Leibniz—“peace as an ecological production of actual togetherness, where ‘ecological’ means that the aim is not toward a unity beyond differences.”⁶⁵

Then it must be said that the divergence affirmed is that of an apophatic entanglement. And so it only intensifies the fibrous togetherness of active possibility: of

what might flash or rumble from the cloud. So, in answer to the earlier question, the ontology of interlinked becomings in this reading does not forfeit the radical surprise of the to-come (whether in Moltmann's eschatology or Derrida's messianicity—the impossible);⁶⁶ it does not guarantee the justice or sustainability of what will come. The repetition of becoming intensifies the difference it unfolds. Perhaps, though, it shakes, it complicates, it enfolds some impossible it insists on resisting. For what is impossibility but the impatient contraction of impossibles? Sometimes it is possible to shift impossibility into contrast. To crack im/possibility becomingly open. Some unexpected contraction of the infinity of possibility *becomes* this momentary body—and not without the sense of beauty, as in “that color becomes you.”

The lure to actualize new contrasts implicates us in the cosmopolitics of an ecology where language breaks in horror or in awe. Or in contemplation. “If the desire proper to the fold is, as Deleuze claims, the desire to go on unfolding, small wonder the desire to articulate should be so intense at the edge of silence, where utter frustration is at the same time an infinite space of possibility.”⁶⁷ Thus MacKendrick, an apophatic philosopher of deep folds, reminds us then also—not meaning to paraphrase Whitehead's lure—that “God does not say but calls.” And we see that the problematic of that name has not neatly disentangled itself from philosophy, at least among the relational infinities: “The name is called out, and in it every possibility is called out too, affirmed by its naming. And the name calls to all that is possible.” Possible here and now as we ply our worlds of speech and body? Holding close to Deleuze, she has written of the “odd doubleness” that is the fold of word and body. It is the human mindfully emerging in that fold, that contrast of contrasts, but differently. In the next chapter (speaking of the body), Walt Whitman makes his appearance, articulating a transgressive body of words or word of the body.

It is with the help of Deleuze that we have drawn Whitehead into a language of apophatic entanglement that diverges from both. The impossible elements in each do not excise the livelier complicities of their difference. And so we read this fold of process thinking, as it unfolds with new intensity in the twenty-first century, as an exuberant explicatio of the Infinite Complication. Its voices may or may not conjecture with theology any folds of theos. By whatever name, however, they will contemplate an Imperceptible in which we might together—we the

ensemble of the earth—improvise more becomingly across our impossible simultaneities. They will repeat, differently, the possibility with which Deleuze, citing the friend who set *Pli Selon Pli* to music, concludes *The Fold*: “from harmonic closure to an opening onto a polytonality or, as Boulez will say, a ‘polyphony of polyphonies.’”⁶⁸

six

“UNFOLDED OUT OF THE FOLDS”

WALT WHITMAN AND THE APOPHATIC
SEX OF THE EARTH

*My voice goes after what my eyes cannot reach,
With the swirl of my tongue I encompass worlds and volumes of
worlds.*

*Speech is the twin of my vision, it is unequal to measure itself,
It provokes me forever, it says sarcastically,
Walt you contain enough, why don't you let it out then?*

*Come now I will not be tantalized, you conceive too much of
articulation,
Do you not know O speech how the buds beneath you are folded?*
—WALT WHITMAN, “SONG OF MYSELF”

“WALT YOU CONTAIN ENOUGH . . . ”: and for all his apophatic irony, who more than he has ever “let it out”? His single volume, *Leaves of Grass*, composed and recomposed over the voluminous decades of his poems, enfolds “worlds and volumes of worlds.” A multiverse of multiplicities,¹ seduced, contracted, enfleshed in language: “the amplitude of the earth, and the coarseness and sexuality of the earth,” as he chants in one of its poems, “other globes with their suns and moons,” “races, eras, dates, generations, / The past, the future, dwelling there, like space, inseparable together.”²

Whitman described his style as "fragmentary, spontaneous," reflecting the "convulsiveness" of his context. Deleuze, in his last published writing, reflects with him on that America of the mid nineteenth century, "America itself made up of federated states and various immigrant peoples (minorities—everywhere a collection of fragments, haunted by the menace of secession, that is to say, by war)."³ Whitman grows an immense rhizome from the fragments, its elements bursting, unfurling in the unrhymed, incantatory series, forming "a whole that is all the more paradoxical in that it only comes after the fragments and leaves them intact, making no attempt to totalize them."⁴ Nonseparable difference had found its epic expression in "a nomadic, rhizomatic poetry." Grass is of course the great example of a material rhizome.⁵

Whitman's poetry conforms to no established form: it performs an entire exodus from any prior style, more or less inventing what would be called free verse. He shares with Emily Dickinson the moment of radical poetic experiment, as well as "a certain fragmentation of thought" evinced in all of the American romantics (Melville, Emerson).⁶ Materializing in what he called his "prophetical screams," his voice was welcomed, notably by Emerson, when *Leaves* was first published in 1855.⁷ But soon it was denounced as "stupid filth," "a heterogeneous mass of bombast, egotism, vulgarity and nonsense."⁸ Whitman pushed dauntlessly forward: "After this day I take my own modes of expressing love for men and women."⁹ "The expression of love" (close to the Deleuzean expressionism of the explicatio) would, as Martha Nussbaum puts it, trigger in him a "poetry of equality" both radically democratic and—in its gender egalitarianism and in its same-sex desire, "frankly sexual."¹⁰ And we will find the sexual politics of *Leaves of Grass* planetary in scale.

I hope this interlude with Whitman offers a cloudburst of poetic relief from the density of theory. I hope especially that his specific articulation of folds, the folds of flesh and of language, will lend sense and affect of the apophatic entanglement of the earth. We will follow the folds across a series of scales, senses, bodies, practices.

ENDLESS UNFOLDING OF WORDS

From the opening "Song of Myself," perspective convulses or undulates between the cosmic and the proximate—"I believe a leaf of grass is no less than the

journey-work of the stars”—and still abides always, in “myself,” at the intimate scale of the earth: “Far-swooping elbow’d earth—rich apple-blossom’d earth! / Smile for your lover comes.”¹¹ (We will return to that planetary love, and to its apophatic sex: “O unspeakable passionate love.”)¹² Calling into new relation, entraining, interpellating every class and species of creature, the series push on for verses, sometimes pages . . . “And the pismire [ant] is equally perfect, and a grain of sand, and the / egg of the wren . . .”¹³ And always the great crowd of humans entangled in the multiplying words:

Endless unfolding of words of ages!

*And mine a word of the modern, the word En-Masse.*¹⁴

In Whitman’s voluminous explicatio, the convulsions of a new, still (then) hope-charged democracy, effect in his free verse the fragmentary whole of a human multitude. This human en masse then presents itself as the name of the author himself:

Walt Whitman, a kosmos, of Manhattan the son,

*Turbulent, fleshy, sensual, eating, drinking and breeding*¹⁵

Utterly material and common and irreducibly singular: Walt Whitman names at the same time the endless multiplicity of a “kosmos.” We have earlier considered a “doubleness of language and body,” an enfolding of all things that is a unique unfolding, the singular event of the assembled, the ensemble. For Whitman, “All truths wait in all things.”¹⁶ The repetitions considered in chapter 5 reappear. They multiply, amplify, explode as this kosmos-persona. In an earlier version it read “Walt Whitman am I, a Kosmos . . .”¹⁷ This appearing and disappearing “I” reverberates with the world it encompasses. It does not enclose it in a monad. It composes itself of world and reveals itself to its world.

Whitman plies his Kosmos-humanity in entanglement with the nonhuman. The relation to other animals, the relationality of other animals, rings particularly vivid: “I think I could turn and live with animals . . . So they show their relations to me and I accept them.”¹⁸ In this nonseparability of difference, Whitman anticipates Whitehead: “we find ourselves in a buzzing world, amid a democracy of

fellow creatures."¹⁹ As Nussbaum puts it, Whitman works "to create a democratic countercosmos." He situates himself thus "in the tradition of the cosmological writing of both Greek and Christian philosophy."²⁰ Cosmology always reorders its social world. But here, as Deleuze says of Whitman, "Nature is not a form, but rather the process of establishing relations . . ."²¹ This nature, like its prophetic poet, "invents a polyphony: it is not a totality but an assembly, a 'conclave,' a 'plenary session.' Nature is inseparable from processes of companionship and conviviality."²² In this life-together, or symbiosis, of the universe itself, an ecological democracy, an egalitarian cosmopolitics, begins to materialize. It reassembles the human. Thus Deleuze highlights "the society of comrades" of a "Body/Politic" that was Whitman's dream, channeling that of revolutionary America, for a "new democracy."²³

As Whitman, in other words, bursts free of the almost unbroken Western history of anthropocentrism, he does not dilute interhuman relations. He instead articulates the relationality of "an inescapable network of mutuality (King)"—and his language not infrequently carries a biblical inflection: "Whoever degrades another degrades me . . ."²⁴ He assumes here the voice of the Christ of Matthew's parable: "what you do to the least of these you do to me." Is this an instance of the megalomania he was accused of? Or is it quite the contrary? He finds himself nonseparable from—"them the others are down upon."²⁵ They will be all the stragglers, the strugglers, the laborers, experimenters, Native Americans, slaves and ex-slaves, who run through the fibers of his kosmos-persona. Its convulsive condition of opening expresses an egalitarian potentiality that would be traumatized by the Civil War and numbed by the betrayals ever since. The impossibilities of an ecodeмократic justice with a capitalist economy only makes the history of this convivially assembled future all the more prophetic.

Prophecy, however, does not mean prediction. The affirmative excess of Whitman's bold vision grips the reader only because it is punctuated by suspenseful negations. He mocks the voice of his tempter, the know-it-all: "Walt, you contain enough" (or, in a prior edition, "you understand enough . . . Get thee behind me: You conceive too much of articulation"). The unsaying of his kosmos is precise. "Do you not know how the buds beneath are folded?"²⁶

Buds beneath the tongue suggest taste buds. Whitman's metaphors pulse in and out of his body, his flesh made word. When these buds metonymically resolve

into folds, we take the hint. We taste the whole cosmological lineage of folds: the worlds fold into a voice. The voice avows the silence, the unspoken, the unknown, as the site of further possibilities of articulation: for what is folded “beneath” speech signifies at the same time the potentiality of future understandings. Then in the next verse the buds morph into bulbs or seeds in the wintry earth: “Waiting in gloom, protected by frost, / The dirt receding before my prophetic screams . . .”²⁷ Still barely possible, hardly articulable, these folds of future.

If speech “is unequal to measure itself,” Whitman minds in its ecstatic excess that which exceeds it. Whitman’s irrepressible, oversized articulation is syncoated by its own unsaying:

*Now I will do nothing but listen,
To accrue what I hear into this song, to let sounds contribute
toward it.*

*I hear bravuras of birds, bustle of growing wheat, gossip of flames,
clack of sticks cooking my meals,
I hear the sound I love, the sound of the human voice,
I hear all sounds running together*²⁸

In the contemplative practice of this listening, the moment is enfolded in the flesh of an ear; and all the fragments of sound run together, gathering in sense, to be heard, repeated—“bravuras of birds”—in language. . . . Language at this level of prehensive affect creates fresh planetary ensembles. Would this be the triple repetition we considered in the last chapter, whereby something new takes place? Or, as Deleuze says of Whitman, “The relations between sounds or bird songs, which Whitman describes in marvelous ways, are made up of counterpoints and responses, constantly renewed and invented.”²⁹ This subject composed in these relations, this kosmos-persona, *is* only in its becoming. Enfolding its world, it unfolds it differently. Running together, its sounds do not smooth into unity; they unfold explosively even as they fold into a new multiplicity. A more convivial world finds—still?—in this listening a chance.

Here let us mark this *listening* as apophatic discipline. To listen: not yet to know. “In the beginning was the hearing.”³⁰ This audible unsaying is interwoven

with upheavals of touch, smell, sight, in what we might consider an apophatic synesthesia, a sensory practice of the *docta ignorantia*; interrupting kataphatically, emphatically, in planetary affirmation.

We listen now for a series of specific folds, each doubling language and body—folds of the flesh of the brain, as it folds into gender, of gender folding into sex, of sex into the earth, of earth into the orbs, of orbs into theological non-knowing.

UNFOLDED OUT OF THE JUSTICE OF THE WOMAN

*The brain in its folds inside the skull frame, the curious sympathy one feels
when feeling with the hand the naked meat of the body.*

—WALT WHITMAN, "CHILDREN OF ADAM"

The hand prehends. With it one feels with the body, here the exposed brain, naked meat, of another. Here the folds of brain remind us that Whitman, who volunteered as a nurse in the Civil War, felt not only sensuous flesh but also catastrophically exposed, often dead or dying, bodies. The frequent anatomical correctness of Whitman's imagery expresses also his fascination with new scientific research, which he sought out hungrily in lectures and libraries in Manhattan.³¹ Twenty-first-century physiology is still at pains to decode the functions of the folds comprising the brain's physiognomy: "This *intricately folded outer layer*, known as the cerebral cortex, is one of the brain's most noticeable features. But it's also one of the least well understood."³² The folds, because of the labyrinthine economy whereby they contract maximum surface space within a compact skull, characterize animal intelligence: the more folds, the more intelligence. Human brains are the least smooth among known species.

The brain folds recur in another poem incorporated into *Leaves*. "Unfolded out of the folds of the woman's brain come all the folds / of the man's brain, duly obedient . . ." The poem is called "Unfolded Out of the Folds." Here, in a ceremonious sequence, the fold comes into its own—and with it a dense entanglement of gender and sex, of biology and culture. Each of its first ten lines begins with the word *Unfolded*. It opens: "Unfolded out of the folds of the woman man

comes unfolded, and is always to come unfolded.” Here there may be an organic translatability from brain to womb. In his fascination with the folds of brains and wombs, is Whitman performing the “body without organs”?³³ “Unfolded only out of the perfect body of a woman can a man be / form’d of perfect body . . .” Conventionally read as a maternalist eugenics, this celebration of woman—like many of his utterances on sex or gender—has been criticized by feminists such as Alica Ostriker for its essentialism.³⁴ Such celebration might reduce woman—even “the superbest woman of the earth”—to a biological role in the production of the “superbest man of the earth.” But then we dismiss the next verse: “Unfolded only out of the inimitable poems of woman can come / the poems of man, (only thence have my poems come).”³⁵

Here body has folded explicitly back into language. Of course even poetic maternity might shift importance to the poems of the son. There are feminist arguments on the other side, however. “Although Whitman insisted on the superiority of the mother, he did not limit the female to a maternal *role*, or trap her in what Simone de Beauvoir would later call biological ‘immanence.’ . . . Whitman sought to revive the mother not as a biological function only but as a creative and intellectual force.”³⁶ Vivian Pollak finds Whitman’s poetry “shaped by his gendered ambivalence to personal, political, and literary history. The effect of such deeply disturbed, creative ambivalence on women readers, including women poets, has been far from uniform.”³⁷ He famously writes:

*I am the poet of the woman the same as the man,
And I say it is as great to be a woman as to be a man,
And I say there is nothing greater than the mother of men.*³⁸

Does the third verse take away with one hand what he offered with the first two? Certainly so, read with inevitable anachronism. Yet in an epoch where maternity, not poetry, was the given of women’s lives, he did not need to persuade women to become mothers. He is not announcing that the best a woman can be is a “mother of men”: but that there is nothing *greater*—among men as well—than she. Recall also: “a leaf of grass no lesser than the journey-work of stars.”³⁹ Such cosmic egalitarianism does not readily contract into the literalizing purposes of a single and single-minded political movement. But that does not make Whitman’s

gender folds apolitical. Even Alica Ostriker acknowledges that Whitman's worst utterances on gender "are revolutionary compared to the sentimental conventions of his own time."⁴⁰ Feminist criticism need not flatten the folds of a deeper, and as we will see, queerer complexity. We choose to repeat the utterances of certain male ancestors and we unfold them otherwise.

Having just credited his poetry to preceding women—not woman as muse or anima of male poetry, but as *poet*—he releases this line:

*Unfolded out of the strong and arrogant woman I love, only
thence can appear the strong and arrogant man I love,
Unfolded by brawny embraces from the well-muscled woman I
love, only thence come the brawny embraces of the man*⁴¹

Exploding every stereotype of femininity or the Good Mother, this strong, haughty, muscular woman he loves now makes possible the *man* he loves and the love of that man. What is happening here? Is she the mother or the lover of the poet, or of his male interest? Are her embraces maternal or erotic? However ambiguous the folds, it is clear that his love of this brawny woman "mothers" his male lover. This complex entanglement is no incestuous confusion. Her unfeminine strength somehow makes possible his unmasculine love. Her queer embraces have given rise to his.

This may be an autobiographical clue to the source of his desire for men. The love of women made love itself possible and therefore the love of men. It also in its ambiguity may (prophetically screaming) anticipate Judith Butler's deconstruction of the gender/sex binary as it structured feminist thought. Gender formation and sexual practice, discursive formation and bodily passion, fold convulsively in and out of each other.

And most importantly here: how would this celebration of "male-male desire" be in Whitman's time anything but the impossible, the unspeakable? As to sexual practice, Whitman may have plied quite a fluid multiplicity. Before, however, we follow the same-sex fold a bit further, let us note its simultaneous superposition with the radical transcoding of gender:

*Unfolded out of the justice of the woman all justice is unfolded,
Unfolded out of the sympathy of the woman is all sympathy*⁴²

Tenderness only with justice—like that of the hand prehending the naked meat, unsqueamish, fierce—a polyamorous potentiality issues fluidly through all of our issues, drawing and drawn by eros toward a radically egalitarian democracy. His pleasure in women and their multivalent embodiments, like his unsqueamish delight in all things fleshly and physical, may point less to bisexual performance than to the identity-queering envaginations of justice we still seek. But it is also because of a peculiar entrainment of sex and earth that we need him now more than ever.

O EARTH MY LIKENESS

Earlier in *Leaves* Whitman offers a novel displacement of the creation of the human in the likeness of God. It is the Earth mirroring the poet back to himself—but also, in a planetary chiasmus, the reverse. The globe’s appearance of smoothly known, spherical insentience falls away. Something altogether different insists itself:

Earth, my likeness,

...

I now suspect there is something fierce in you eligible to burst forth,

For an athlete is enamour’d of me, and I of him,

*But toward him there is something fierce and terrible in me eligible
to burst forth,*

I dare not tell it in words, not even in these songs.⁴³

This stanza enacts a potent moment of apophatic entanglement. For its revelation comes unsaid—“I dare not tell it in words”—even as it is said. Or conversely, we may say it is spoken by speaking its unspeakability. What has been spoken, however elliptically, is first of all the enfolding of two men in love. Utterly unspeakable, illegal—this is the apophatics of abjection. Yet the love is nonetheless proudly signified, right there where the buds beneath speech “are folded,” right there where articulation, tantalized, collapses. One has for decades been able to smile knowingly at this something not yet known, this something “eligible to

burst forth." It whispers the potentiality of full erotic love between two men. An active, virtual possible, eligible, "fit to be chosen." The eerie exuberance—"strong and arrogant," "terrible"—with which Whitman embraces his own sexuality bubbles up in several poems. In a pre-identitarian period, where the only names were pejoratives, his erotic ambiguity suggests something approximating the apophatic indeterminacy of what now names itself "queer."⁴⁴

How does he find that courage to choose, to *become*—himself? Is "eligibility" here more than code for a forbidden act? What potentiality is signified by this culturally and religiously impossible possibility *able*—but not certain—to burst forth?

A precise repetition structures this brief poem. It opens as an address to the planet as his "likeness," his double. What is it that in the earth is "eligible to burst forth" in concise analogy to the unspeakable "something fierce"—in himself? Rather than the globe known and dominated, he conjures an erotic ferocity, roiling with potentiality. This bursting forth may be matrimorphic, the organic life of a Gaia, from whose womb are born all new species; from whom come unfolded this Walt and his brawny athlete. (As we will see in chapter 9, Gaia would then signify neither then nor now a safe mother earth.) And at the same time the virtual burst may signify the sheer unrealized power of the new about to break out, no less seminal than vaginal in its volcanic flow: the unfolding that is the unknown, unpredictable event. In its eligibility he assembles his own.

How is the earth eligible, "fit to be chosen," however? Neither term of this analogy evidently clarifies the other: the something fierce in the earth, the something fierce in the poet. It is a double-X. We might explicate it thus. The planet is about to burst forth in a new unfolding of its long, iterative, and productive history. Considered as a living system, however, an organon of organisms, the earth's own productivity bears no resemblance to the dimorphic mechanism of sexual reproduction constituent of much *bios*. Gustav Fechner, father of experimental psychology and ancestor of the hypothesis of the earth as complex system (Gaia), was a contemporary with Whitman, mentioned by him. Later championed by William James, he had advanced the image of such an animate earth, greater in sentience than the sum of its human or animal parts. It was a theory eligible to break forth; that it failed to is just one chapter in the tragedy of a religion/science/business positivism.⁴⁵ Amidst current emergency, does it still *emerge*?

That the “mandate of the sexual closet” remains strangely parallel to the mandate of the climate change closet may not be accidental.⁴⁶ The disclosure would be then double: the new human sexuality will reveal something about the earth, and the earth something about our sexuality. Something imperceptible, “fierce and terrible,” terra-ble. Sex outside of heterosexuality lacks reproductive justification: it exposes sexual pleasure as an end in itself. If it thus reveals the inherent vitality of our bodied relations, might a certain queer register—across all our practices—not be key to our evolution as earthlings in our own century? The affirmation of queer love, along with other nonprocreative practices and systemically mindful reproduction, might—in tandem with the sustainable economics that good sex (which is free) can nourish—make us eligible to unfold beyond this century.⁴⁷ In this vein, Daniel Spencer, author of *Gay and Gaia*,⁴⁸ has thus sought “to develop the basis of an ecojustice ethic of right relationship by reclaiming and revison-ing both the erotic and the ecological at all levels of our lives—from our deepest, most intimate relationships with self and other to our location in an evolutionary, expanding cosmos.”⁴⁹

More recently, in a fresh vocabulary, Whitney Bauman announces the “poly-amoury of place.” Here the range of “transgressive love in the planetary erotic sense” is mobilized “for the health, well-being, growth, and continual evolution of an embodied other.” Indeed Bauman recognizes the apophatic nuance of love as an *ecological* imperative: “Such an other can never be possessed or fully known, for he/she/it is always in the process of becoming.”⁵⁰ Mindful of the unknown possibilities for not just each others’ but—wonderfully—“earth others’ becomings.”

The Earth apophatically inscribed appears in its nonhumanity nonseparable from human process. Not without irony does the unspeakable entanglement in Whitman echo the *imago dei*. When the poet addresses “Earth, my likeness,” he is calling forth a new self of the human in the image of the earth—rather than in the image of the patriarchal deity who created the heterosexual pair as His counterpart. The mirror-image bounces back and forth: Whitman is simultaneously calling out a new earth in his own image. Again, is this megalomania? Or is it an answer to the civilizational anthropomania that has developed in the name of dominion? Whitman seems to channel a Genesis inaudible in its mainstream reception. In that ancient text, after all, the plurisingular Elohim twice calls Earth itself to “bring forth” a manifold of creatures. It is not only the humans who participate

in the creative process and thus mirror—in enigma—their invisible source. Whitman's earth-likeness magnifies not human domination over the earth but its cure.

Whitman's amorous intensity mirrors intensities of the earth, convulsions, vulnerabilities, and sensualities from which we have cut ourselves clear and clean at unspeakable cost. But we gain from Whitman and his proudly gay and gaian heirs a spirit more of evolutionary affirmation than of apocalyptic threat. But, how, I still wonder, could Whitman say this impossible *yes* to his own body? Whence this courage, this joy?⁵¹ Is it because he calls in the universe? Because he wraps himself in the earth? In the poem placed just after "Unfolded," called "Kosmos," he again applies the name to a human like himself. Kosmos is the one, he says,

*Who includes diversity and is Nature,
Who is the amplitude of the earth, and the coarseness and sexual
 quality of the earth, and the great charity of the earth, and
 the equilibrium also*
...
*Who contains believers and disbelievers, who is the most majestic
 lover*
...
*Who having consider'd the body finds all its organs and parts
 good,
Who, out of the theory of the earth and of his or her body under-
 stands by subtle analogies all other theories*⁵²

Theoria indeed! But I have not commented yet upon this "his or her" that runs throughout his poetry, this "man *and* woman"—which we learned to repeat from the late 1960s on. This spooky hundred-year prescient inclusion perhaps was more possible—among vying impossibilities—to a man who had accepted his own dissident, defamed sexuality as "majestic," a person therefore capable of every diversity, an earthling who has enfolded the earth. Become Kosmos—who can shame and defeat you? The Earth's own sexuality, coarseness, charity, and equilibrium will be yours. The ecology of Whitman's countercosmos spans the disciplines and the issues (which is why the present perspective, containing believers and disbelievers, resorts to poetry). He continues:

The theory of a city, a poem, and of the large politics of these

States . . .

Who believes not only in our globe with its sun and moon, but in

other globes with their suns and moons,

Who, constructing the house of himself or herself, not for a day

*but for all time, sees races, eras, dates, generations*⁵³

This glimpse of the sturdy construction of a self—himself or herself—suggests not substantialization but actualization. The constructedness of the human is displayed rather than hidden behind an essence. To become your own house (*oikos*, *eco-*) is to make yourself at home in the earth—despite every force of normalization that would exclude or evict you. “For all time” hints at the ripple effect of what Deleuze sought from eternal recurrence, of what Whitehead named objective immortality. The nomadology does not slow to some timeless end. Rather—at what Deleuze called “infinite speed”—the kosmos-persona unfolds the particularity of its perspective in a spatiotemporality without bounds, *epektasis* cosmopolitically rewired.⁵⁴ In this genre of sophic utterance Whitman anticipates and enfoldes the entangled issues—race, sex, gender, class, and ecology—of a future epoch. In a new language of unspeakability it performs a provocative not-telling of a sexuality abject in his time. And much more: in the sex of his earth there unfolds an apophatic polyamory. It aches with the enfolded impossibles of our own planetary future.

VOICES OF SEXES AND LUSTS

The multiplicity of voices yearns to be *listened* to, heard to speech, to unfold at last in the justice of an *apokalypso*, an “unveiling”:

Through me many long dumb voices,

Voice of the interminable generations of prisoners and slaves,

Voices of the diseas'd and despairing and of thieves and dwarfs,

. . .

Voices of sexes and lusts, voices veil'd and I remove the veil,

. . .

*I do not press my fingers across my mouth,
I keep as delicate around the bowels as around the head and heart,
Copulation is no more rank to me than death is.*

*I believe in the flesh and the appetites
Seeing, hearing, feeling, are miracles, and each part and tag of me
is a miracle.⁵⁵*

I am excerpting from a long biblically scaled series: these voices of "sexes and lusts" shut down by Christian morality here burst forth. Contracted in Whitman's kosmos, folded together with the multitudes of the oppressed, the disabled, the victims of empire, racism, class—panoramas of the "least of these my siblings." They pulse on and on, repetitions of an unredeemed past. Fold after fold. Unfolding here a great exodus ensemble. He weaves these human subjects right into a cosmopolitics in which of course they already come entangled: "And of the threads that connect the stars, and of wombs and of the father-stuff."⁵⁶ These threads in a fine web of nonseparable difference link the outer galaxies to the intimate folds of human sex, to the wombs and semen of the generations—an impossible chaos for any identitarian politics, an im-possibility for new ecodemocratic identities. Recall Deleuze: "Every fiber is a Universe fiber."⁵⁷ And then disruptively again, in a rough American dialect: "the rights of them the others are down upon. . . . Voices indecent by me clarified and transfigur'd."⁵⁸

The poet becomes voice of the voiceless, the downtrodden, the indecent—those whose sexual deviance keeps them off the standard democratic lists of the oppressed and puts them repeatedly on Whitman's.⁵⁹ He would not save them from their lusts, but rather grant their sexuality the dignity and the luminosity here signaled by his revealing "I." In the blessing of the flesh in its most abject, most ungodly social status, the voice blazes with a startling authority: "Divine I am inside and out, and I make holy whatever I touch or am touch'd from." Poetry becomes theopoiesis ("becoming God").⁶⁰ Incarnation becomes in-carnality. But it is already distributed as inter-carnality: the divinity not of exception but of one touched and touching. "Glowing with the touch of transcendence" (Rivera).⁶¹

Whitman's kosmos-persona comes often close to the biblical Christ-figuration. Of course then readers may still wonder if the I of this affirmation is really just

an outrageously engorged American ego. Does he now supersede Christ? Indeed such a misreading might obstruct the very verse with which he begins the impossibly titled “Song of Myself.” In a context of Puritan piety, where self-assertion means sin, there can hardly be a more explosive iconoclasm than this opening burst of self-affirmation:

*I celebrate myself, and sing myself,
And what I assume you shall assume,
For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you.*⁶²

In this self-celebration what “I *assume*” must not be read as meaning what I *presuppose*. It has the prior meaning of “taking up,” as when I assume responsibility, an office, or a burden. But whatever I take up—so now do you. So the affirmation does not inflate, it radically redistributes, itself, its very matter. . . . The poet performs—across any space and time—an intentional entanglement with the reader. And the radicality of the gesture is immediately revealed: it goes down to the atomic level. So this action at a distance quite spookily anticipates another epoch of physics, where the nonlocal superposition of every quantum of my matter with that of yours becomes physically thinkable. And, by dipping down to the minimum, Whitman projects his perspective of the maximum: a relationality of such constituent interdependence that there is no escape from each other. So the very frame of *Leaves* captures the human in its transhumanity—and precisely as a *humanizing*, an ethical, gesture. If we share our atoms, what do we not share? But then we may “assume” responsibility for our imperceptible relations, our emergent ensembles, our unfolding rhizomes. Or we may deny the whole process.

In Whitman’s milieu this celebratory assuming apparently echoes a precise theologoumenon: the incarnation is traditionally referred to as God’s “assumption of flesh.” In the language of the Cappadocian Gregory of Nazianzus “what is not assumed is not healed.” Human redemption occurs through participation in the body of the incarnate one: if the divine assumed the human body, as human it assumed the cross of human anguish. By this entanglement anyone may be healingly assumed. So the becoming-flesh of Whitman as a body of work may be read as an iteration of the ancient Christological assumption. But he expands

it in his kosmos-persona to contract, to incarnate, the material universe, minimal and maximal, as himself. So what he has assumed—presumptuously?—as his self-celebrating “I” is thereby offered through this sacramental poesis to every reader.⁶³ Orthodox interpreters of the incarnation may protest that it is the “absolute unsubstitutability” of the one Incarnation that secures the possibility of Christ’s infinite substitution for every other. But one could argue—if a christological account were to construct itself within this nondogmatic interlude—that Whitman is not playing Christ but “taking up” the love path. A Christ not severed from the gospels invites the fullest mutuality of participation—even, especially, of the “veil’d” underclass of the poor, the prostitutes, the marked sinners. Not Christ alone but all are called to redistribute our matter, properties, our very identities, in the limbs of the vine or the body in which we have been freshly entangled. His difference—that of the Nazarene Jesus from that of the New England Walt, remains irreducible but nonseparable, and just so opened into the voices, threads, sexes, and lusts, of all the wronged others.

Whitman, in other words, is neither taking the place of Jesus nor worshipping him. He partakes of a then fresh national experiment in freedom of and from religion. In cloud-perspective, however, he apophatically unfolds, *explicans*, a “prophetical” enfleshment of the word: the logos of a love out of bounds, infinite, assuming any, forcing none. Inasmuch as Christianity in its exclusivist presumption had degenerated into competition for a final truth, he can only provocatively, fleetingly, ply its language. What matters across our entangled difference—of belief, of epoch—is what “as good belongs to you.”

UNSPOKEN MEANINGS OF THE EARTH

If the human is not traded against the maximum or the minimum, but unfolded from its folds, so in the next fold we consider Whitman poses an unabashedly eschatological question:

And I said to my spirit When we become the enfolders of those
orbs, and the pleasure and knowledge of every thing in
them, shall we be fill’d and satisfied then?⁶⁴

In other words, in the ecstatic future of some unknowably evolved condition in which we *knowingly* enfold the entire content of the galaxies—will that be it? Heaven and done? “And my spirit said *No, we but level that lift to pass and continue/ beyond*.”⁶⁵ Here Whitman almost seems to pick up the ancient theology with which this cloud itinerary began. Gregory of Nyssa had likewise averred that there would be no eschatological closure, no *fin* of the infinite. There will be pleasures and revelations taking place along the way of the epekstasis, an infinite journey toward the infinite. In the meantime the contemplation of that amplitude lends composure, as we have seen, in the face of more or less anything. “And I say to any man or woman, Let your soul stand cool / and composed before a million universes.”⁶⁶ You are after all in some spooky way, in a way that matters, composed of them all. And like the entangled minima, the orbs of the maxima have in the meantime become both more and less knowable. His poetry loops between known and unknown just as it spirals between the multitude and the multiverse—and back through the cool self-composition of this kosmos-persona (surely an ancestor of the slang meaning of *cool*).

In another unintended resonance with negative theology, Whitman performs an apophatic unsaying of the divine itself, immediately following that multiverse of composure:

*And I say to mankind, Be not curious about God,
For I who am curious about each am not curious about God,
(No array of terms can say how much I am at peace about God and about
death.)*⁶⁷

This noncuriosity signifies a kind of nonattachment. Cool indeed. Whitman shares the contemporary Feuerbach’s insistence that preoccupation with God has sucked life and interest out of the world. It has left it flat, unjust, and dispirited, projecting all interest beyond itself. And Feuerbach also found, by losing God, a radical relationality: in thinking, he wrote, “I am bound together with, or rather, I am one with—indeed, I myself am—all human beings.”⁶⁸ Yet the result of the nineteenth-century unsayings of God—variously critical and romantic, pantheist, atheist, Marxist—may be the space of a renewed interest. Living after the time

of hegemonic Christianity, indeed anatheistically "after God," I remain curious about *theological* sources of the cosmological relationality. This God after God has perhaps become more interestingly entangled in everything *else*. And it seems not alien to Whitman's God. He was no atheist. His moment of apophatic panentheism is unmistakable: "I hear and behold God in every object, yet understand God not in the least."⁶⁹

Again the unknowing of God energizes an alter-knowing of the world. This revelatory incomprehension unfolds along the diagonal of a universe so internally entangled as to demand a poetry of its own unsaying. A cosmological apophysis was, we saw, already anticipated in Nyssa and explicated in Cusa—and never without the boundless eros to "know" the other. But in Whitman this desire at the edge of the unknown is steeped in sex and earth. For it is to the earth and our soulful embodiment of its crowds, its masses, to its concrete evolution in our own convulsive becoming, that he turns always again. After and with God. But it is not that God's incomprehensibility is the foil for a comprehensible Earth. On the contrary: the unsaying of the known Earth resounds through his opus:

*All merges toward the presentation of the unspoken meanings
of the earth,
Toward him who sings the songs of the body and of the truths
of the earth,
Toward him who makes the dictionaries of words that print cannot touch.*⁷⁰

Will those meanings then be spoken, those dictionaries finally printed—the negative gesture finally negated? Or is this apophatic body of bodies inexhaustible? Even when it comes to our own bodies, "The love of the body of man or woman balks account, the body / itself balks account."⁷¹ If we would cease to mind our ignorance, if we would some day announce a full account of these bodies—nothing more lying folded beneath the tongue—would we not be balking the love itself? What the indecent apokalypsis unveils is no fixed and known object but an erotic apophysis of the planet.

In Whitman's poetry, as in the philosophies of becoming, the unspoken and the unknown tilt from the hierarchical verticality of the Neoplatonic being beyond being—toward the horizon of our collective convulsions.

What is known I strip away,

I launch all men and women forward with me into the Unknown.⁷²

Stripping us to our naked unknowing, this “I” plies relentlessly the mystery of a planetary eligibility. The Unknown was and is yet still to come. It never was a predictable future, nor an accidental one that leaves us passive and ignorant before the deterioration of the earth's very life. From within the perspectival limitations of a time and place, it invites what any God worth our curiosity and any theology worth our apophysis also desires: “the Expression of love for men and women.” That love—in full explicative force—finds in Whitman the queer father of an ecological humanity. What is folded under the tongue unfolds, if it does, in the bodies and words, sexes and species, atoms and orbs of our unknown becoming.

seven

UNSAYING AND UNDOING

JUDITH BUTLER AND THE ETHICS OF
RELATIONAL ONTOLOGY

*In the Infinite
I reach
for the Uncreated
I have touched it,
it undoes me
wider than wide
Everything else
is too narrow
You know this well
you who are also there*

—HADEWIJCH II, “ALL THINGS”

*Let's face it. We're undone by each other. And if we're not, we're
missing something.*

—JUDITH BUTLER, *PRECARIOUS LIFE*

LEE, WHO SOMETIMES SETS UP outside my yoga studio and chants “can you spare a quarter,” squeezes my hand, catches me up on how he’ll take a bus down south to visit his daughter who is afraid to tell him she is marrying a woman; it hurts him that she doesn’t know he knows and is so glad she has found love. He recommends ginseng for my cough, he brings it for himself in soda, it keeps him awake and doesn’t send him to the toilet like coffee, he explains—a serious

issue for one appearing disabled and dark and homeless in this neighborhood. He never lets go without a Godblessyoubaby that works.

Some, exposed to the elements and the exclusions, reveal in their flesh what others succeed at concealing: the unspeakable width of our precarious interdependence. Issue after issue, we fold in and out of the imperceptible. When, for example, the thirteenth-century Hadewijch (one of the beguines, the movement of women persecuted for their uncloistered streetwork, their female insubordination and suspect theology) finds herself reaching for the uncreated, “wider than wide”—is this the mysticism of escape?¹ Or another poetic embrace of the unmanageable infinity of relation?

On the whole we must leave the width to work unnoticed. We focus on a particular fold of relation, a specific entanglement with a specific other: *this* other, facing me in a specifiable context of other others—not just every other. We face this one, at this moment, Hadewijch, Lee. Some care, some fidelity holds me accountable to that other, that Other trying to name its singularity through so much theory, so much ethics. Through so many—others. *Tout autre est tout autre*, every other is altogether other. Not wholly or absolutely Other, but *all-together* other. Every other, which is to say, every self, has gathered into itself a crowd. We face always more than we can face: in the mirror, enigmatically.

In this part we have watched unfold in theology, philosophy, poetry the expanse of nonseparable difference tangled into every event of becoming. The multiplicities come attached systemically, perspectively, with interests conflicting—even as they fan out into the collectivities that every other incarnates. Into those classes, sexes, genders, religions, races, species, elements again. The ministry of multiplicity is infinite. Loving thy neighbor will take thee into strange neighborhoods.

It seems that the question can only continue to press: is all such talk of multiplicities still another way of avoiding commitment? These far-flung rhizomes of grass, nomads, atoms, and orbs may escape not only knowability but also *responsibility*. Where does human—yes, human—ethics find a dwelling in this cloudy chaosmos? Really the human perspective explicated so far—of apophatic mysticism, quantum entanglement, Whitehead, Deleuze, or Whitman—has sought to complicate the human with its nonhuman implications rather than to cash out human difference.² But that complication—however infinitely pre-, post-, or in-human—has been motivated from the start (of this book, at any rate, if not of

Genesis) by the jeopardy of which, in the condition of willed ignorance, we fail to give an account. In other words, to ply the specifically human in this context is to unfold ethics. Not because only humans can behave ethically and not because only ethics makes the human. But because our species poses the main jeopardy—truly a “divided game,” *jea parti*—for itself and, by the same token, for the nonhuman.

The tarnished rule unfolds here, in other words, between nonseparable differences; as in Whitman’s kosmos-persona: “who degrades another degrades me.” That is not an instrumental logic as in: eventually my unsustainable lifestyle, degrading of endless human workers, will so damage the planet that I might lose my air conditioning. The degraded other already implicates me. For any other before me, any human other I face, confronts me with its own logic of the infinite—and so with an infinite alterity: “infinity in the face of the other.” Levinas radicalizes its otherness in a language of “exteriority” and “separation.” While avowing the infinity effected in the face of the irreducibly singular, we instead explicate it as a relation of nonseparable difference. I am composed and so in part degraded in and by my relations. And just therefore does the singular confrontation *concern* me—it directly involves, enfolds, implicates me. And so it has its chance of stimulating (beyond the quarter on the street) the wider, indirect implications. “The question of ethics is always a question of an ethical *relation*.” It is Judith Butler who now puts this relation with inescapable clarity: “it is precisely because I am from the start implicated in the lives of the other that the ‘I’ is already social, and must begin its reflection and action from the presumption of a constitutive sociality.”³

The cloud perspective locates each face, with its own point of view, within the penumbra of its planetary sociality. The face of the neighbor, the beggar, the stranger may at any moment ethically stand forth. But the crowd of others do not therefore become void of ethical significance. Connection effects action willy-nilly; but it calls—“because I am from the start implicated”—for *right* action. The proximity of relational ontologies to process, feminist, and ecological theologies has been amplifying that call from the start. They do so here and often as Christian self-critique. For Christian morality, funded by theocratic powers, went to hell, *ad literam*, trading the golden rule of inextricable relation for the threat of final separation. But even Dante’s poetry of the damned is one long *relation* to the immortal repetition of consequences.

What makes action ethical will not then be the imposition of a law or application of a code, however uprightly progressive. It will be the self-implication of the agent in the act itself. The ethical action requires an actualization of *ethos* as attention to the sociality, human and not human, that constitutes you. Doing unto others what you would want them, under comparable circumstances, to do to you, lacks deontological or legal purity. For in its cultivation it does not deny or master the self's desire. It *widens* it. "Everything else is too narrow."

At a certain pitch, then, the ethical connectivity appears nonseparable from the expansive unfolding of a singular self: "I am large, I contain multitudes." Or as Hadewijch puts it, in the prior stanza of the poem cited earlier:

*All things
Are too small
To hold me.
I am so vast.*⁴

Only the infinite envelopes her own impossible immensity. (Really impossible this is a thirteenth-century *woman*.) But then the apophatic affect of the poem immediately deflates—or dispossesses—any ballooning ego: "*it undoes me, wider than wide*." The very width that expands me undoes me. At first I worried that this medieval subject coming undone-in-relation might be a trick of contemporary translation—an effect of reading Judith Butler. But no, the old Flemish reads *ont-daen*.⁵ Simultaneously "undone" and "so vast," the medieval Beguine's perspective opens across an impossible width.⁶

Elsewhere Hadewijch refers to "a great stress of love," like a terrible pregnancy in which she felt she would "split in two," so *gruelic wid* did she grow. The gruesome width of planetary perspective today picks up her apophatic echo.⁷

Undone by the immensity—but not done in—we ply the ethics of our boundless and barely knowable entanglements. The cloud that obscures the planetary crowd of systemic interdependencies yields no excuse not to act. And we do act, we actualize willy-nilly. Before unknown constituents and unknowable outcomes, we try to act responsibly, responsively, actively receptive (no *actus purus*) to the other before us. But the agent-I is already an intra-active we. Already I am an ensemble, tuned to the pluralities, the assemblies, the social systems, that amplify or muffle my action. If the apophatic infinite complicates it, enfolds it all, it is not to

provide a theological simplification. Its cloud provides no escape from actualization, but may offer retreat from wasteful action or numbed inactivity. But what is the cloud of unknowing if not at the same time the cloud of undoing?

Is this space, where the doer herself comes undone, the place where the boundaries of a discrete subject acting on its object falter and fail? But then does it not expose the specific vulnerability, the jeopardy of the self and of her world? To *do* here—however decisively—cannot then mean to deny the uncertainty that always threatens to undo both the doer and the deed.

In other words, it becomes clear that we will need the help of Judith Butler, who has theorized an indelible new sense of “undoing” for contemporary ethics. She simultaneously undoes any certainty of action and of knowledge. Indeed I know of no other current thinker who so explicitly captures the relation between unknowing and relationality itself: the fold that, from another perspective, plies the present book. In her hands a relationality of unknowing signifies a human ethics. She proceeds with little—but, as we will see, no longer negligible—attention to the nonhuman. And she attends minimally to theology negative or positive. At the same time, like Deleuze, she is one of the rare philosophers of the continental tradition to take account, only quite recently, of Whitehead. It happens that in the same period she has solicited a language of “social” or “relational ontology.” It will then be fruitful to pull Butler and Whitehead into more explicit relation in this chapter. But we will particularly meditate on the interplay of unknowing and relationality in her philosophical ethics, which will I hope stimulate another bud still “folded beneath” the tongue of apophatic entanglement.

SUBJECT TO REPETITION

The power imposed upon one is the power that animates one's emergence, and there appears to be no escaping this ambivalence. Indeed, there appears to be no “one” without ambivalence, which is to say that the fictive redoubling necessary to become a self rules out the possibility of strict identity.⁸

—JUDITH BUTLER, *THE PSYCHIC LIFE OF POWER*

The identity of the author of the poem with which we opened the chapter is actually a bit unclear: she is thought to be the disciple of the first Hadewijch, and is

sometimes referred to by scholars as Hadewijch II.⁹ We might also distinguish between Butler I and II. The doubling of Judith Butler can be neatly marked by the turn of the millennium. It is the twenty-first-century Butler who breaks into an overt discourse of ontological relationalism. Yet, as noted earlier, there had been within poststructuralism little interest in relationality as such, in how, that is, we construct ourselves of and in our relations. Focus was rather on our constructedness by language and culture. Social power appears as the productive dominion of culture disguised as “nature”—a hegemonic framework more than a multiplicity of interactive becomings. It is the regulatory force of sociality more than its ontological complexity that the earlier Butler, following Foucault, invaluable brought to the fore. Butler has also worked in critical proximity to the psychoanalytic drama of our most intimate formation and so our interpellation as properly gendered/sexed humans.

In one sense, there is nothing more hotly “relational” than these Freudian, Lacanian, Kristevan, and Irigarayan investigations, all operative in Butler I, of the prelinguistic constituents of the subject. An indeterminate *khora*, a formless matrix of affection and abjection, can be said to name an unconscious relationality (and so its own version of apophatic entanglement). The sense of a substantial ego is already produced or ruptured, or both, by our earliest, largely parental, relations. In its poststructuralist life psychoanalysis directly deconstructs the metaphysics of substance. Yet, according to one line of feminist critique, psychoanalysis in its phallographic ancestry actually shores up a discretely bounded self, more knowing of its own unconscious as such, but hardly conducive to a radical relationalism. I had, for instance (in that last millennium), staged a convergence of Whitehead’s vastly nonhuman cosmology with object-relations and Irigarayan feminisms, articulating an alternative, connective self, neither separative nor soluble.¹⁰ The universal materialization of mutual immanence, disrupting the narrowness of the psychologies, theologies, and philosophies of Man, was, at the same time, resonating, at least in theology, with the currents of an emergent ecofeminism.

Inspired by Jamesian pluralism and early quantum event theory, Whitehead, as we have seen, was undoing the Western presumption that reality is divided into essentially separable and self-identical substances, mental subjects, or physical objects. The mutual participation of becoming creatures belies the metaphysics of substance. His “principle of universal relativity” displaces Aristotle’s dictum that

“a substance is not present in a subject.” We noted how his philosophy “is mainly devoted to the task of making clear the notion of ‘being present in another entity.’”¹¹ So while a cosmology of process finds little affinity with a philosophy of a sheer alterity, of difference separate rather than participatory, Whitehead’s negative commitment, his anti-essentialism, can be read as deconstruction *avant la lettre*.

Butler contributed indispensably (already in the twentieth century) to the dismantling of the metaphysics of substance. The game-changing accomplishment of *Gender Trouble* is the desubstantialization of sex itself: for “sex appears within hegemonic language as a *substance*, as, metaphysically speaking, a self-identical being.”¹² Her deconstruction of the standard human *being* unraveled its artificially substantialized identity along the edges of sex and/or gender. Building on Irigaray’s notion of sexual difference, itself a canny critique of the patriarchy of substance, Butler showed that this appearance is produced by “a performative twist of language and/or discourse that conceals the fact that ‘being’ a sex or a gender is fundamentally impossible.”¹³ For if being means the self-identical, enduring being of classical metaphysics, then sex (which must be “done” or “performed”) can’t be said just to “be.” Two formidable binaries were thus revealed as joint effects of the artifice of power rather than of the necessity of nature: the opposition of “male” to “female” and of “sex” to “gender.” The prior feminist distinction of “gender is to sex as sex is to nature”—so helpful for a while and, after a while, too neat—collapsed. With it dissipated the presumption that masculinity and femininity comprised natural sexes preceding culture, essential givens upon which culture, including feminist culture, could inscribe its varying interpretations.

These deconstructions are history. The hesitation and slash of sex/gender has injected a permanent indeterminacy into theories of either. What guarantees Butler’s status as the Kant of Queer Theory, however, goes further: it lies in her analysis of the condition of the possibility of the substantial subject. Undoing the genders that pose “as the foundational illusions of identity,” Butler shows that gender is “the *repeated stylization of the body, a set of repeated acts* within a highly rigid regulatory frame that congeal over time to produce the appearance of substance, of a natural sort of being.”¹⁴ She thus is able to account for the potency of the delusion of this solidity that she deconstructs. Repetition is mistaken for sameness. We have read, within the process-Deleuzean fold, another account of how repetition produces the relative continuities of subjects and objects in a world of process.

Repetition grants human identity adequate stability and, at the same time, permits the destabilization of any identity. To put it more critically, repetition is “how social power produces modes of reflexivity at the same time as it limits forms of sociality.”¹⁵ Repetition can, in other words, serve the numbing reenforcement of the Same; but a repetition is not the same but something—other. In the interval of the iteration, the space for an unpredicted possibility opens. Christina Hutchins early captured the remarkable affinity of Butler’s notion of repetition with that of Whitehead. “The necessary, inescapable repetition of becoming, for both Whitehead and Butler, carries in itself hope of and for the future, because repetition is the way in which novelty (Whitehead) or subversive resignification (Butler) can enter into the ongoing processes of discourse in the world.”¹⁶ Hope already imports ethics into the open interval.

The parodic performances of drag queens provided Butler’s famous example of how stylized repetitions may tease open the space of subversion. Their festive mockery of the heterosexual absolute let her intensify the reading strategy of Irigaray’s ironic mimesis of authoritative philosophers. Butler’s theory of parodic repetition would be in turn enfolded not just in the varieties of queer theory but also in postcolonial theory. “The iterative ‘time’ of the future as a *becoming* ‘once again open,’ makes available to marginalized or minority identities a mode of performative agency,” writes Homi Bhabha, “that Judith Butler has elaborated for the representation of lesbian sexuality: ‘a specificity . . . to be established, not *outside* or *beyond* that reinscription or reiteration, but in the very modality and effects of that reinscription.”¹⁷ Oddly neither Butler herself, nor the Deleuzian feminist Rosi Braidotti, crediting Butler’s account of Foucault, note Butler’s echo of Deleuzian repetition as the habitation of novelty. Braidotti reads Butler as a melancholic deconstructor, preoccupied with a Hegelian negativity and a Lacanian originary loss of the maternal body—thus an overwhelmingly mournful negative.¹⁸ Hutchins, differently, lifts up “Butler’s sense of the trouble and the pleasure of working with and from identity categories.”¹⁹ A resonance with Whitehead’s category of “enjoyment” lets Hutchins emphasize the positive political potentiality of Whitehead’s creativity doubled by Butler’s performativity: “We live with both the risks and the promise, as well as the relief, of not being able to control the unknowable reaches of our resignifying activities of creatively subverting the hegemonic norms, the novelty of our becomings entering the world.”²⁰ That

unknowing will only deepen in Butler, who in her 1995 response to Braidotti acknowledges an affinity to negative theology: “My sense is that it would be right to say, as Braidotti does, that I sometimes stay within the theology of lack, that I sometimes focus on the labor of the negative in the Hegelian sense, and that this involves me in considerations of melancholy, mourning, conscience, guilt, terror, and the like.”²¹ An accusation lets her avow as a commitment the “labor of the negative.” This avowal helps protect the affective darkness that is neither identical with the apophatic cloud nor rightly divided from it.

At the same time Braidotti’s fiercely positive rendition of Deleuzean materialism does also lend feminist intensification—to the Deleuze/Leibniz/Whitehead fold, where matter and mind are joint effects of rhythmic repetition. This fold may supplement the reading of the repeated acts of a performative agency, which then materializes “as a vibration with an infinity of harmonics or submultiples.”²² At any rate one cannot picture the drag performance without the beat and strut of its playful mimicries. Yet the dissolution of substance into “stylized repetition” does not in itself yet entail any affirmative relationalism or systemic change—let alone a polyphony of polyphonies. Retrospectively, however, its rhythms anticipate precisely the relationality of a social ontology branching through and beyond its gender into a future to which we now turn.

THE SOCIALITY OF SELF-COMPOSITION

Or does it turn out that the “I” who ought to be bearing its gender is undone by being a gender, that gender is always coming from a source that is elsewhere and directed toward something that is beyond me, constituted in a sociality I do not fully author?

—JUDITH BUTLER, *UNDOING GENDER*

Speaking of authoring: there is of course no supersession of an earlier by a later Butler, no pivotal conversion. Yet the millennial impact of the 9/11/01 event occasions Butler’s *Precarious Life*, a meditation on mourning and the ethics of the distinction between those who count as grievable and those who do not. Here the psychic space of loss, indeed a breathing room granted for and by mourning, hosts the emergence of an explicit and widened relationalism. That width yields

the avowed social ontology. Her theorizing of the work of mourning had been ongoing, building on her earlier psychoanalytic account of grief as incorporation. But Butler II explicates a logic of constitutive relations. Even the communicative directness of her prose seems now to perform its relational ethic. “It is not as if an ‘I’ exists independently over here and then simply loses a ‘you’ over there, especially if the attachment to ‘you’ is part of what *composes* who ‘I’ am. . . . Who ‘am’ I, without you? When we lose some of these ties by which we are constituted, we do not know who we are or what to do.”²³

Here the resonance with Whitehead’s counter-Aristotelian “being present in another” becomes vivid. *Process and Reality* is one long meditation on “actuality” as “the fundamental exemplification of composition.” Creatures actively compose themselves of one another. If you are part of what composes me, then what and how I am is nothing in abstraction from you—and from all the other constituents of my being.²⁴ By contrast, substance metaphysics renders all composite characters inessential. It defines the really actual as simple and independent, supremely exemplified in the Being of the One. Ontotheology protects God, and all God-like essence, from both composition and decomposition. Whitehead was arguing *ontologically* that our being—and by the same logic God’s—is never seamless unity, our doing never purely active. Never immune to you, or to the loss of you.

Precarious Life is haunted by the exclusions, the losses. So Butler does not want now simply to reincorporate “the excluded into an established ontology.” She proposes “an insurrection at the level of ontology, a critical opening up of the questions What is real? Whose lives are real? How might reality be remade?”²⁵ She thus backs into an ontology of constituent relations through the contemplation of the ethics, loss, and of the political “derealization” of countless lives. In this meditation on a specific, collective trauma, grief “furnishes a sense of political community of a complex order, and it does this first of all by bringing to the fore the relational ties that have implications for theorizing fundamental dependency and ethical responsibility.” The following might be read as humanizing the Whiteheadian sense of constituent relations: “If my fate is not originally or finally separable from yours, then the ‘we’ is traversed by a relationality that we cannot easily argue against”—not, that is, without “denying something fundamental about the social conditions of our very formation.”²⁶

As Jean-Luc Nancy puts it in *Being Singular Plural*, “‘one’ or ‘it’ is never other than *we*.”²⁷ In this formation of the “we” something delicate, weblike, is unfurl-

ing, irreducible to a mechanism of social power. It makes no reference yet in Butler's vocabulary to the nonhuman constituents of my becoming—particle, pet, or planet. Yet it explicates a language of relationality itself: "At another level, perhaps what I have lost 'in' you, that for which I have no ready vocabulary, is a relationality that is composed neither exclusively of myself nor you, but is to be conceived as *the tie* by which those terms are differentiated and related."²⁸

That is one disarmingly packed proposition. Relationality is not just the sum of *relata*. The "you" and the "I" can be differentiated from each other only in their relation. The joint of relation appears here again as the very fold of difference—difference not as separation but as process of differentiation. We may repeat then here that *difference is relation*. It is difference that the tie that binds is binding. The difference of one from another is an effect not of its independence but of its *interdependence*. In process thought the difference is not thought so dyadically, with such a Hegelian or indeed Levinasian echo, as a relation of self to an Other, human or divine. Yet process thought, were it not for its theological translations and its pastoral practices, could lose touch with the grief, the mourning, perhaps implied but systematically depersonalized in its cosmological perspective. (I am here responding to a question that Butler herself will ask of process thinkers.) In the avoidance of the standard anthropocentrism of Western philosophy and theology, the incorporative losses that, if Butler is right, make us human, remain undertheorized. And reading Whitehead through Deleuze will help on this level not at all.

"Perpetual perishing" in Whitehead does however undo the momentary subject, indeed all subjects: for every actual occasion, because it is an event of becoming and not an enduring being, "perishes" in its immediacy almost as soon as it is born. What endures is its repetition as potential ("immortally") for the future. I am not the "same" as the I who started the sentence—however linked and similar. We noted the role of perpetual perishing in the third repetition. This undoing of the immediate subject carries the beat of the rhythmic, affective repetition that has taken the place of inert "matter." We might say, then, that "undoing" as ontological may mark the gentlest pulse of time, or it may mark time as crisis. The composition of the subject of relation is then always already beset by *decomposition*. Loss belongs to the ecology of becoming. Perhaps it is only in the cosmically rare instances of animals, perhaps only some animals, those with more conscious emotions, that what we call *mourning* plays a role. Yet, conceptually speaking, the

entire cosmology of mutual composition—far from freezing out human compassion—aims to override the Western ideal idolized as the transcendently dispassionate One. Hence the key role Whitehead plays in Brian Massumi's recent work and that of the other affect theorists. But the feeling that tones our relations is nothing other than the prehension of perishing others as they pass into us. Thus we compose ourselves of each other's pasts.

Butler, in a recent conversation, puts this mutuality more straightforwardly: "In other words we are interdependent beings whose pleasure and suffering depend from the start on a sustained social world, a sustaining environment."²⁹ We compose ourselves, nurtured or degraded by our relations, indeed by whole systems, families, groups, and institutions of relations, as best we can. And however well or ill sustained I am by my world, no "I"—albeit perishing—is a mere function of its environment. And, in ways never fully predictable, that social world will be affected—if only in a minor fold, a hidden nuance—by each momentary act of self-composition. Still, from the perspective of any relational thinking, the relationality does not become ethical unless in some way acknowledged. With whatever stylized repetitions we perform ourselves, our sex/genders, our ethnicities and economies and species, we may veil or reveal our interdependence.

THE ETHICS OF RELATIONALITY

*And is the relationality that conditions and blinds this "self" not, precisely,
an indispensable resource for ethics?*

—JUDITH BUTLER, *GIVING AN ACCOUNT OF ONESELF*

Preoccupied by the question of moral responsibility as it extends indefinitely through and beyond sexuality, Butler II contemplates anew the conditions for the emergence of the "I." She is concerned with its accountability, that is, with its capacity to combat "moral nihilism" by acknowledging the norms through which it interacts with others. "When the 'I' seeks to give an account of itself, it can start with itself, but it will find that this self is already implicated in a social temporality that exceeds its own capacities for narration."³⁰ This account-ability is in other words tantamount to responsibility, not to self-transparency. Reminiscent of Whitehead's radical spatiotemporalization of every event of compositive becom-

ing, and yet presenting its human face, her social temporality stretches beneath memory and beyond narrative. Thus implicated, the self “is always to some extent dispossessed by the social conditions of its emergence.” But this dispossession does not obliterate the “subjective ground for ethics.”³¹ On the contrary, it offers “the possibility of hope.”³² It makes possible a new moral agency that is neither a mere function of its social field nor a transcendent creator of new norms.

Hope, as all receptions of the progressive heritage of messianic eschatology presume, provides the *sine qua non* and lure of social transformation. In other words we sense here how an *ontological* widening of the *ethics* of alterity, extending it beyond the I-thou or I-Other relation into a temporal field of interdependent subjects, may be opening a fresh possibility for the *political*. Our mutual participation—beyond and before our mutual obligations—draws us into an ever wider, perhaps infinite, field of accountability. Of course this width of relationality, poorly understood, also traps us in hells like 9/11 and its aftermath in Afghanistan, Iraq, Pakistan... And it may be, as Butler argues, the preemption of mourning by antagonism that twists loss into a spiral of violence. But, as Mary-Jane Rubenstein clarifies, in a superb juxtaposition of Augustine and Butler: “Grief therefore runs us up against a kind of relational ontology, exposing the extent to which I am exposed to others. To be clear, grief does not perform this ontology; it uncovers it. Mourning hits me over the head with the extent of my heteronomy, but it does not put it there to begin with.” Here Rubenstein captures the ontological gesture: “I do not start out complete and then end up fractured as I lose the ones I love. Rather, grief reveals the ego as dependent and undone because, in Butler’s words, ‘it was already the case with desire.’”³³ Being “undone” by relation comprises, for Butler, “a primary necessity, an anguish, to be sure, but also a chance.” It is an opportunity to change, to “be moved,” above all to “vacate the self-sufficient ‘I’ as a kind of possession.”³⁴

To “be moved” is a welcome inversion of the Unmoved Mover. Yet one may worry about the slide of deconstruction, or of dispossession, when it makes such ethical turns, into a Levinasian *subjection* of self to “the Other”—whichever Other. One may further worry that the more ethically sensitive, historically vulnerable subjects will be overpowered rather than empowered. But precisely because Butler’s ethics has not (unlike Levinas) banished ontology, the dispossession of a self-sufficient ego through grief need not imply a complete breakdown of whomever I had been being. “To question the subject is to put at risk what we

know, and to do it not for the thrill of the risk, but because we have already been put into question as subjects.”³⁵ She has us question a *style* of subjectivity, repeated as though it is the essential core of a particular subject and thus concealing repetition itself.

Our repetitive congealings may be, under normal, sub-zen circumstances, very close to inevitable. But there remains amidst them the possibility that I might not narrow in defensive unification. Casting ego on the waters, I flow forth manifold, a plurisignularity.³⁶ Not because I have captured the other as my own self, not because I have discarded myself, but because myself, replete with others, becomes more: “I am so vast.” Butler puts this widening with care: “I do not augment myself with my virtuousness when I act responsibly, but I give myself over to the broader sociality that I am.”³⁷

That breadth that I am—a vastness after all—so far from inflated, is that of a self dispossessed of the unitary ego. Perhaps this very overreach of outreach will render my undoing an opening. At any rate this is not—even at some crucifying intensity—self-destruction. It is self-unfolding, as the indeterminate explication of a self that enfolds but cannot enclose a world.

In Butler the radical relationality has emerged by routes foreign to the Whiteheadian rhythm of becoming and perishing in which each momentary concrescence is a self-composition out of the demanding influx of the past. I hope I have shown—in the reverberation of “Walt, a kosmos”—how the repetition of those relations in both thinkers empties the subject of swollen masteries. But the emptying is not characterized by a void. This undoing produces no *nihil*.

Relation is appearing as tie or fiber in a network whose edges fade not into a void but into nonknowability. To come undone is to come into question—to come unknown, “blinded,” even to ourselves. But the nonknowing that at that moment displaces any cozy core of “self” marks not only identity loss but the enlivening glimpse of an alternative. The ties of relation form the potentiality that offers itself as a gift, amidst the very losses relations themselves repeatedly inflict.

NONKNOWING RELATIONAL ETHICS

I cannot muster the “we” except by finding the way in which I am tied to “you,” by trying to translate but finding that my own language must break up and yield if I am to know

you. You are what I gain through this disorientation and loss. This is how the human comes into being, again and again, as that which we have yet to know.

—JUDITH BUTLER, *PRECARIOUS LIFE*

The “yet to know” marks for the present project the opening of the cloud into a hope and of its hospitality into an ethic. Here the *undoing knowingly becomes unknowing*. As was the case along the whole apophatic route, it is an unknowing open to transgression by new knowing, not the property of a self-same substance. But here we recognize an ethically humanized fold of apophatic entanglement. When Butler catches the wider connectivity as it escapes the net of language, its excess registers first of all as what she calls opacity, indeed in a self-opacity. “Moments of unknowingness about oneself tend to emerge in the context of relations to others, suggesting that these relations call upon primary forms of relationality that are not always available to explicit and reflective thematization.”³⁸ By these “primary forms” Butler means especially those past familial relations rendered partially conscious in psychoanalysis. We—we humans at least—emerge complicated by a past that we cannot fully know, implicated in its distortions, its pathologies intimate and collective.

And yet for its still unknowable future we are nonetheless responsible. Our relations deliver also an ability to respond, to be moved and so to move otherwise than before. But this *interdependent* ability to respond remains ever *undependable*. As Butler rues whimsically: “That we are compelled in love means that we are, in part, unknowing about why we love as we do and why we invariably exercise bad judgment.”³⁹ Sometimes we call this original sin, as the Augustinian love gone wrong; for the love-compulsion has also the inflection of grace. In love as in loss the ego comes undone, facing an interdependence that at one moment swells up in pleasure and in another bursts in anguish.

The fold between our nonknowing and our nonseparability is sticky with feeling.⁴⁰ Hadewijch found here “the great stress of love” in its impossible overreach and its disappointed hopes—intimate, planetary, infinite. An irreducible uncertainty, sometimes turbulent, occasionally serene, interrupts any reflexive self-knowledge. In any case this opacity gives no comfort to irresponsibility. To the contrary, it is what renders the relationality an indispensable “resource for ethics”—inasmuch, we may add, as the self becomes *knowing* of its ignorance, *docta ignorantia*.

“It may be that what is ‘right’ and what is ‘good’ consist in staying open to the tensions that beset the most fundamental categories we require, to know unknowingness at the core of what we know, and what we need, and to recognize the sign of life—and its prospects.”⁴¹

Far from being further dissipated by a widened sociality, and paralyzed by its implicate undefinabilities, the subject mindful of its unknowing *minds* the world afresh. It minds, it is bothered by, the deformations of powers and knowledge, it minds oppression. For it recognizes also the signs and eligibilities of its own largest life. In this way the apophatic entanglement may empower a collaborative strength, a force not of a delusionally solid solidarity but of a coherence, from the Latin *cohaerere*, “to stick together.” According to Whitehead, the concepts operative within a nonsubstantial notion of the actual occasion require coherence in this sense: it “means that *what is indefinable in one such notion cannot be abstracted from its relevance to the other notions*.”⁴² The unknown, as the indefinable, doesn’t spring us free of relations in language or in fact. It intensifies their mutual interdependence.

In relation to sex and to gender, and in this millennium to the interplay of American empire, Zionism, and Islamophobia, Butler is unfolding a publicly powerful ethical trajectory. It resists any demoralizing relativism and any moral absolute with the agency of a democratic normativity. The norms themselves, with their universal claims, come, of course, entangled in their own ambiguous past. But, refreshingly, she reads their universality not as the problem but as the hope. The trick is to insist on concrete application and test of that universality. Thus, in Adorno’s negative dialectic, the particular resists any universal that, in fact, is not universal—that fails to account for your particular reality, that of the demonstrator wearing a chador or of Lee on the sidewalk. The norms thus require a process of continual negotiation. Adorno’s critique of abstract universals is carried forward in Butler’s recuperation of the norms at a relational width that in a certain sense undoes and redoes the universals themselves.⁴³

Though Whitehead lacks a language of negativity or dialectic, he also re-describes universals. Classical universals describe classical substances, externally related; but no postclassical actuality, entangled in the sociality of its *universe*, can be adequately described either *by* universals or *without* them. “This is the problem of the solidarity of the universe.”⁴⁴ For the participation of creatures in one

another always entails more than their generalizable characters. The universality of an ethical claim then emerges not in abstraction from its particular instances; rather, its abstractions (pure possibilities) are mobilized in the service of the concrete actuality. These include the cosmic “democracy of fellow creatures.” An ethical norm in this scheme will push its human agents toward the widest possible planetary responsibility, in which specific rights attune to an imperceptible solidarity. But the norm will not be identical to any universal, shaped into a “proposition” combining universal possibilities and particular histories of actualization. It will offer a relational coherence, “beset with unknowingness.” So the problem of false universalism lies neither with the universalizing gesture itself, nor with its abstractness, but with the fallacy of misplaced concreteness that produces the illusions of enduring substances self-consciously presiding over their properties. Such substantial subjects call down as universal their own transparent norms of the human, defined by multiple exclusions—human and animal.

The misplaced concreteness finds an analogy in the idolatry that preoccupies negative theology: the confusion of nominal abstractions such as Being, Power, Paternity with a supreme substance: abstract universals extracted from the universe and reified as God. Along this path, Roland Faber and I have in different ways sought to deepen the Whiteheadian resistance to Christian idolatry by way of the “knowing ignorance.” Apophatic mysticism is only occasionally—but not insignificantly—hinted at in Whitehead: “If you like to phrase it so, philosophy is mystical. For mysticism is direct insight into depths as yet unspoken.”⁴⁵

The unspoken may soon come speakable, or never. We may have been kept triply ignorant: by powers that manipulate our knowledge, by perspectival finitudes, and by an infinity that transgresses every context of its immanence. The point would not be then to cordon off the unknowable—for by definition we cannot know just where it begins, since we don’t *know it*—but to *mind* its impinging indeterminacies. The opening into an uncertainty at the heart of things need not then dishearten decision.

Even when internal contradictions threaten our surest impulses, some other possibility, hinting at wider relation, may be already implicated. “Process,” writes Whitehead, “is the immanence of the infinite in the finite.” Therefore “process is the way the universe escapes from the exclusions of inconsistency.”⁴⁶ In this impure immanence the universe does not settle for its own impossibles even as

it may bless them on their divergently convergent ways. For the logic of the excluded middle fails the test of a relational coherence. Butler highlights the ethical possibility at play in the agonisms of human agency; it invites resistance to “the violence of exclusion.” Both thinkers teach us to reassemble ourselves—our worlds—at the crumbly edge of the relatively and relationally knowable. For apart from physical explication through the unpredictable decisions of agents—subjects mindfully implicated in each other—how would anything good happen?

ECOLOGY OF DENATURALIZATION

Environments are poisoned, local habitats destroyed, and this means that war destroys all manner of life, showing through a via negativa that those manners of life are interconnected, interdependent, and equally precarious. I have come over time to appreciate Marx's claim in the Early Manuscripts regarding the limits of the human sciences: “One basis for life and another basis for science is an a priori lie.”

—JUDITH BUTLER, BUTLER ON WHITEHEAD

Whitehead, attending to the exclusions wrought by closed systems, hearkens to the *nonhuman* universe, alive and participant in all of our finite and human decisions. An attention to the not yet known of the entire creaturely plenum, nurtured by his mathematical involvement in the natural sciences and his love of the romantic poets of his region, now carries the force of ancestral prophecy. The ethical anthropocentrism of Butler's philosophy, even after the end of the last millennium, counts in this one way as the more traditional. So then, for those of us indebted to this tradition of queerly widening ontology, it is all the more gratifying to find her crossing the line into an ecological relationalism; indeed—and to be crossing it upon a *via negativa*! Here may be said to come to light an apophatics of ecological precarity. Not accidentally, this articulation of an environmental relationalism took place on the occasion of her explicit engagement of Whitehead.

Butler takes up Whitehead's claim that “anything is an object in respect to its provocation of some special activity within a subject.” For the object, the other, is being prehended—felt—by an actual occasion. And it folds into the new becoming actively: neither the object nor the becoming subject is inert. This is the

feeling-toned interactivity of all relation. And she pursues here Whitehead's claim that "no prehension can be divested of its affective tone."⁴⁷ As does affect theory, she takes seriously the elemental revitalization of bodies, of all bodies in their mutual implications (and provocations). Indeed it may help with the famous problem Butler I wryly confessed to, even after writing *Bodies That Matter*: of not being "a very good materialist."⁴⁸ She felt she could not extricate herself from language in the way that a full-bodied materialism requires. The affectivity of prehensions offers a third way: while we are not solipsistically confined to our linguistic constructions, neither do we get free of them: they are themselves enfolded in a wider affectivity that we variously sense, feel, infer, interpret. Language is a form of the symbolism that Whitehead maps onto the concrescence of subjective becoming as a complex, consciousness-producing contrast between more elemental feelings and highly abstract ones. We construct ourselves in language, from which we do not escape into pure cognition, pure matter, or into the certainty of our cognitions of matter. But we construct ourselves not only in language. So I am not sure that makes Whitehead a better materialist: materialism, in its scientific-mechanistic, capitalist, and totalitarian forms, equally exemplifies his fallacy of misplaced concreteness. All three mistake abstract notions of matter—as separable into independent pieces of simply located substance possessing stable properties—for the concrete life of bodies. A *really* good materialist dispossesses herself of these properties, redistributing herself in the intra-activities of live entanglements.

At this point in planetary history, however, the only good materialist is an ecological one. Butler has made that turn. Here her ethics, without forfeiting its exacting humanity, begins to enfold the earth. So here she turns her important question of grievability—the grievability of some and not others—to the nonhuman. It had been from the perspective of this grief work that she developed her contagious discourse of human "precarity." She now draws upon the possibility of "mourning the loss of non-human animals, of whole environments and habitats." We might speak then of our new *planetary precarity*.⁴⁹ Might the sense of public grief at such losses as coastlines, glaciers, polar bears help to mobilize shifts of practice that the known facts of climate change, for example, so far do not?⁵⁰ Between affect and fact, what will ply a sustainable future?

Butler has been helped in her return to Whitehead by his recent incorporation into the continental philosophy of science by Isabelle Stengers and Bruno Latour.

Their joint preoccupation with the assemblies of the nonhuman has advanced an ecopolitics that is at the same time a provoking cosmopolitics. In the interest and the ethics of that radically democratizing, empirically engaging cosmos, they expose the fallacious fixity of Western “nature.” Thus Latour undoes “nature”—that blend of Greek politics, French Cartesianism, and American parks.⁵¹ We would add the created natures of Christian scholasticism as well. This critique converges with the deconstruction of fixed sexual “natures” that drives the queer trajectory. Butler of course was there, leading a deconstruction of our sexual natures, as she recaps: “For those of you who know my work, you will see that this means that I have to distance myself from the early formulations of the sex/gender distinction in which nature was presumed to be facticity or mute materiality, and gender was the work of language, culture, and social norms.”⁵² Nonetheless, I have pled and plead again for the abandonment of casual deployments of Butler’s early term *denaturalization*. She was not intending to extricate human language from its material conditions. But its citability has reinforced the liberal academy’s habitual anthropocentrism. Nature is not the problem, but “Nature.” Materialism is not the problem, but “materialism.” The human is not the problem, but “the human.” Democracy is not the problem, but our version. Metaphysics is not the problem, but the metaphysics of substance. God is not the problem, if I may, but He . . . Language is not the problem, but . . . We can unsay reifying names (like *nature*, *matter*, or, for that matter, *God*) without erasing them.

Intriguingly, Butler draws from Stengers’s Whitehead not just an ecological but what we can only recognize as a nuance of apophatic entanglement: “Does critical thought show more than it says, and is it more profoundly implicated in a set of relations than it itself can say and know?”⁵³ In view of the provocative set of relations between human and nonhuman earthlings, the fold between nonknowing and nonseparability deepens and multiplies. The sense of my own life “constituted in a sociality I do not fully author” has exposed the sociality of all those nonhumans and the way I author only in the modest sense that I cannot help but enfold a world. Its chaosmic nonhumanity enfolds the vastly impersonal humanities that author me, with or without my authorization. Or write me off.

Therefore Butler’s challenge back to Whiteheadians and other ecological relationalists remains meaningful. “Is it possible that in our ways of reversing and displacing anthropocentrism we overlook the singularity of loss?” Even, she asks,

“if we are restored to our animality, our interdependency, and even our natural connections, are we in any sense relieved of our precarity or our apprehension of the precarity of living processes?”⁵⁴ Surely not; and so the answer to the first question must be yes, it is always and dangerously possible. Naturalist celebrations of the cycles of life and death may not support the human ethic that suffers individual losses and honors grief. And Whitehead could be, though he has hardly ever been, read—perhaps with a wolfish Deleuzean twist—as propagating a cosmological indifference. But then one would have to erase the divine heart of his universe: that “fellow sufferer who understands.” Perishing is, we noted, perpetual. Is it therefore in its humanly collected forms less grievable? Is singularity of loss at stake or rather a notion of singularity that is traded against the crowded collective of our relations? In other words if singularity is already plurisingular, already animal and animated, then the multiplicities of our relation may enfold grief in a wider context.

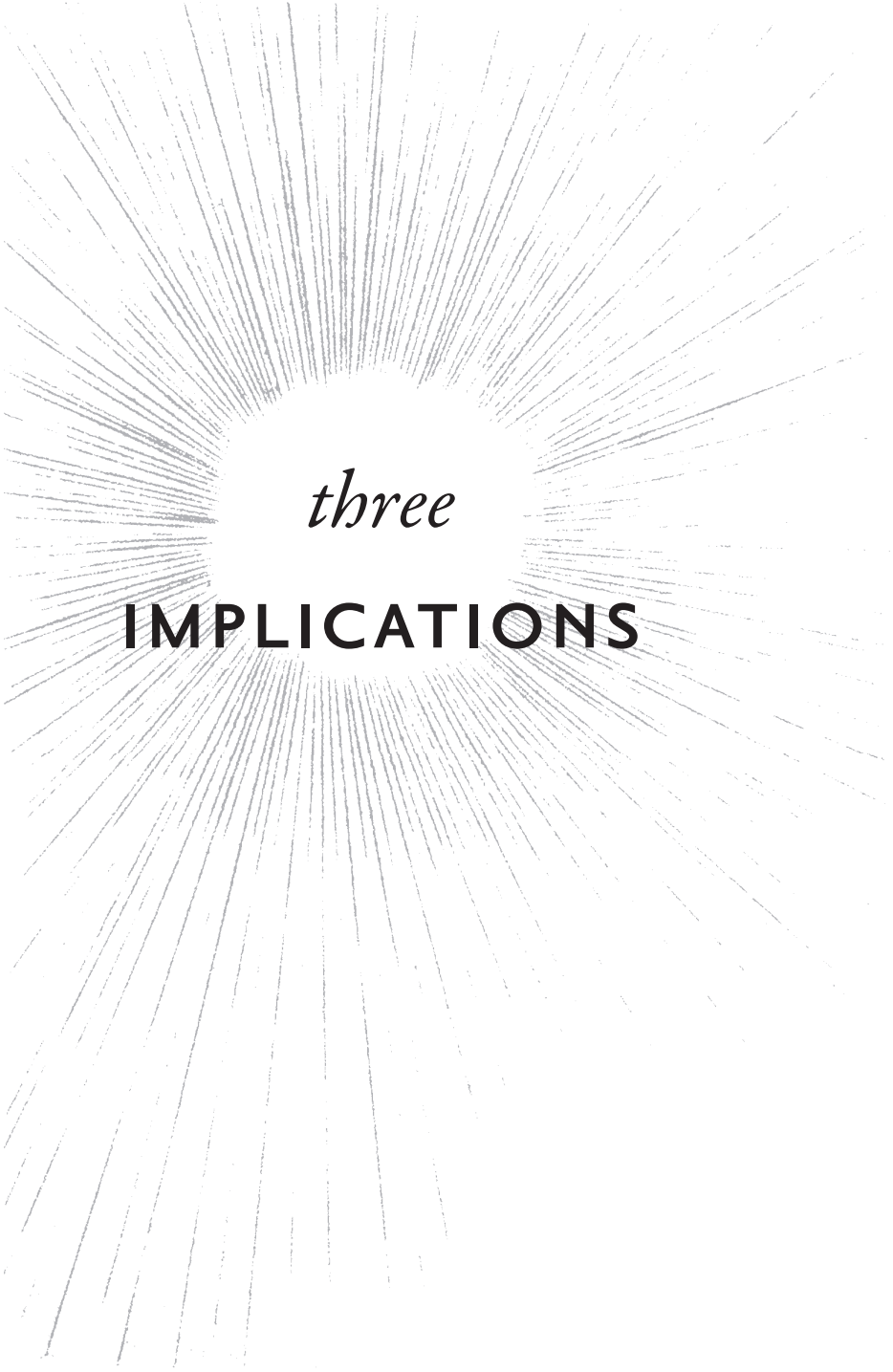
Anthropocentric individualism has accompanied the denial of mourning. Its displacement does not guarantee a mindful alternative. But it makes it possible. My sister was mourning the deaths of two dogs when our mother died. These griefs did not cancel each other. She lived them through in a vitally entwined process. And, on a larger scale, why would not the restoration of interdependence widen and enrich both the process of grieving and the sources of survival, comfort, and renewal? Moreover, the singularities of loss are not just human. An ethics of interdependence opens into the lives of untold human populations without then drawing the line at the nonhumans. We may grieve them singly or as whole environments; and they also grieve. Swans grieve their partners forever. Our singularity—in loss and in flourishing—does not depend upon the anthropocentric separation. (I think I am arguing with, not against, Butler.)

The human difference needs protecting from reductive indifference, but not from the interdependence of our animalities. Derrida (the twenty-first-century one) considered this difference as a “limitrophy” that does not efface the limit between the human and the nonhuman animal. Rather it consists “in complicating, thickening, delinearizing, folding, and dividing the line precisely by making it increase and multiply.”⁵⁵ Amidst these almost Deleuzean folds, he also invokes the apophatic vis-à-vis the nonhuman—indeed as a “negative zootheology” that he promises (not) to offer. (This is not the time to consider his encounter with his cat

and other distractingly cataphatic entanglements, categorical imperatives, etc.) Butler's and Derrida's respectful gestures toward the nonhuman count as divergent symptoms of a vital shift. Poststructuralism is pressing beyond its anthropocentrism across divergent registers, emitting puffs of apophatic cloud as it crosses. If so, it facilitates the chiasmic movement between deconstructive apophatics and planetary entanglement.

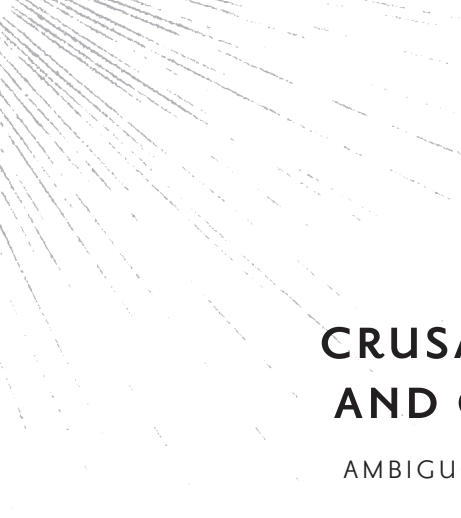
In a self undone in love and loss, this unknowing may tender the ethical valence of an ontological relationalism, open, at least in principle and in conversation, to a wider cosmos. "Everything else is too narrow." However interdependent we know and do not know ourselves to be, it will be the affect of planetary precarity that urges upon us any ecological politics with teeth, wings, and claws.

In the face of an earth in jeopardy—in play and at risk in its grossly imbalanced globalizations—the following two chapters narrate specific implications of our planetarity, historical complexes political and ecological. In each case a centuries-old historical entanglement exposes the im/possibility of a cosmopolitical unfolding.



three

IMPLICATIONS



eight

CRUSADE, CAPITAL, AND COSMOPOLIS

AMBIGUOUS ENTANGLEMENTS

*Reenact the truce, as it is commonly called, which was proclaimed
a long time ago by our holy fathers.*

—POPE URBAN II, SPEECH AT THE COUNCIL OF CLERMONT

*Consider that the West itself has produced the variables to contra-
dict its impressive trajectory every time. This is the way in which
the West is not monolithic, and this is why it is surely necessary
that it move toward entanglement.*

—ÉDOUARD GLISSANT

FLASH BACK, A MILLENNIUM BACK: Clermont, France. Here, before a great gathering of clerics and nobles, Urban II preaches the First Crusade. He is responding to the Byzantine emperor Alexius I Comnenus's plea for military support against the incursions of the Seljuk Turks. In Fulcher of Chartre's account of the 1095 speech, the pope first of all appeals for *peace*. He calls his fellow Western Christians on a continent roiling with feudal warfare to respect the "Peace and Truce of God." Barely a decade old, the truce was the product of the first organized peace movement of the continental Christian world, a barely precedented attempt by the church and grassroots leaders to limit the wars of the nobility by nonviolent means. "I exhort and demand that you, each, try hard to have the truce kept in your diocese. And if anyone shall be led by his cupidity or arrogance to

break this truce, by the authority of God and with the sanction of this council he shall be anathematized.”¹

Upon the consent of the gathered multitude to work for peace in the “provinces” of what would become Europe, the pope then calls them, however, to put that truce to work against the Turks and Arabs: “Let those who have been fighting against their brothers and relatives now fight in a proper way against the barbarians.”² The pope’s speech may count as the prototype of unity through enmity, of “peace” as the exportation of violence. Not that the church has a monopoly on this genre of political double-talk. Peace talk was subject to Orwellian impossibilities from the start, as in Aristotle’s bon mot: “We make war that we may live in peace.” The pope inverts it: make peace so that we may go to war. Peace is now the means to “proper” fighting.

If the Crusade—called, at the time, *perigrinatio*, “pilgrimage”—would advance the coherence of the Western Roman Empire and its political economy, it did so by unifying Christians against a late version of the “barbarians.” These happened to be Christendom’s most disturbing religious Other. Islam, after all, had been for centuries the only successful competitor and threat to a religion that might otherwise have traced its triumph in a great arc from East to West. Fusing pilgrimage with pillage, perpetrating in Jerusalem and elsewhere collective atrocities, and orienting Roman Christians again to the East of their origins, the Crusade arguably began to produce “the West.” As Enrique Dussel notes, “the Crusades can be seen as the first attempt of Latin Europe to impose itself on the eastern Mediterranean.”³ The attempt fails, the colonial ambition oscillates in and out of activation. Let us consider that the European West thereby consolidates itself around a *crusade complex*.

Now zoom forward, to another epoch altogether: a shocking Muslim assault on a great cosmopolitan center, an unprecedented triumph over a largely Christian land, rocks the world. Terror reverberates across nations. The call sounds from on high for a new crusade: the West must stand united against Islamic aggression.

Have I fast-forwarded you almost a thousand years, to New York, 2001? Not yet. Only halfway: to Constantinople, 1453. The Ottoman emperor Mehmet II has conquered the city and so freed Anatolia of the remnants of the Roman Empire. Byzantium is terminated. Mehmet claims the title of Caesar, and refugees from the East stream into Europe with tales of cruelty and horror at the hands

of the Turk. The humanist Pope Nicholas V wants to prevent the conquest of Europe, and not without reason. Mehmet, a sophisticated patron of Renaissance painting, envisions the eventual absorption of Italy. And the Ottomans are already making great headway in conquering Eastern Europe. The pope calls for Christians once again to get over their internal squabbles and join together in a “new crusade.” In response many prepare for a preemptive strike, but many others remain preoccupied by local crises. All are informed by the long theological tradition of polemics against Mohammed’s Satanic mendacity. Additionally, the humanists are indignant at the loss of access to the great Constantinopolitan repository of Greek learning.

At the heart of this difficult moment, we bump back into none other than Nicholas of Cusa, now a cardinal. He was rare for his firsthand experience of Constantinople: recall he had undertaken the great ecumenical journey fifteen years earlier that had brought back to Italy and to reconciliation with the Roman faith both the Byzantine emperor and the patriarch. Friendships had formed. The destruction of Byzantium was personally devastating to Cusa. Within two months of the conquest, he has written *On the Peace of Faith*. It opens with the device of an anonymous person imploring “the Creator of all things that in his mercy he restrain the persecution, raging more than ever *because of different religious rites*.”⁴ He writes of this figure receiving a vision in which multireligious plaintiffs are invited to a council convened by an archangel. In context it is strange that the book never singles out its representatives of Islam as perpetrators. Rather, with tones of great respect, he includes a disproportionate number of Muslims in his imaginary—and in his time impossible—peace conference.

This chapter pursues a multidirectional itinerary, rhizomatic rather than chronological in its historical narrative. Surfacing the crusade complex lets us air a phobia that repeats itself across the millennial formation of the “West.” In *De Pace Fides*, midway through the millennium, an apophatic theology yields a peace-making strategy for religious violence. After considering Cavanaugh’s critique of the myth of religious violence, Dussel’s analysis of the Islamophobic formation of the West leads us to the present and to the violence of a *pax economica*. How might political theology, if it plies a constructive and pluralist relationalism that is actually theological, support the religiopolitical complexity of the planet? Connolly’s sense of the cosmopolitical may offer, with Whitehead’s support and

Paulina Ochoa Espejo's panentheistic supplement, a cosmopolitics for a world of fragile becoming.

THOUSAND-YEAR CRUSADE

"Because of religion," Cusa announces, "many take up arms against each other and by their power either force men to renounce their long practiced tradition or inflict death on them. There were many bearers of the lamentations from all the earth."⁵ These fictional representatives then speak for the known faiths of the earth, voicing their complaints against one another in conversation with Peter and the Logos. Cusa here addresses head-on the question of religiously driven violence. In this he was not absolutely alone among Christians of his epoch. His old friend from the days of the conciliar debates, Juan de Segovia, wrote him in 1453 about his own lifelong interest in a nonviolent approach to Islam and a responsible translation of the Koran. They corresponded about the idea of a conference—a *contraferentia*—as an alternative to a new crusade.⁶

In *De Pace Fides* what Cusa, perhaps uniquely, does *not* seek is the conversion of all to Christianity. Rather, through "Wisdom" he calls for a peaceful coexistence of the different faiths: "one religion, multiple rites."⁷ The phrase *religio una in rituum varietate* appears indeed to be a citation of Muhammad from a text Cusa had in his possession. There the prophet answers a Medinan Jew concerning the earlier prophets. "The religion or the faith of all of them was indeed one, but the rites of the different prophets were actually diverse."⁸ Amidst a great irruption of Islamophobia, Cusa seems to be applying this early strategy for concord amidst monotheistic difference not just to Christian-Muslim alterity but to the far wider multiplicity of his time. His "one religion," not surprisingly, resembles, as we will see, his own highly abstract and apophatic version of Catholic Christianity. But it pointedly does not for him signify Christianity, which remains one among the "rites." For, as we have explored already at some depth, his notion of the "one" cannot be opposed to "many," whose variations come enfolded in and unfolded from the infinite complicatio.

The question of religious multiplicity is, of course, today posed altogether differently. It cannot begin or end with any "one religion." The pluralism both of

theology and of politics rule out any discourse of unification. After centuries of further atrocities between “rites,” and of immense political efforts of tolerance and containment, then of secularization and pluralism, the problem and the possibility of a convivial multiplicity still presses. It arises now, for instance, within a renewed discussion of the democratically appropriate role of religion in the public sphere. That sphere now envelopes the planet. And that world appears pervasively complicated not only by the troubled relations between *the religions* but also between *religion* and *secularism*. These terms themselves bear the modern symptoms of the trouble they try to cure. Scholarship in religion may unsay religion, even as secular thinkers unsay secularism. “Postsecularist” language sprouts from the negations. Its kataphases are hopeful: what, for example, Namsoon Kang names “theological cosmopolitanism” finds multiplying nontheological formulations, such as “a constitutional frame for an emerging multicultural world society” (Jürgen Habermas), “the co of cohabitation” (Judith Butler), “the transmodern project” (Enrique Dussel).⁹ Such names evoke variations of a pluralist desire, beyond relativism. It finds no equivalent in Cusa’s *religio una*, but a convivial precursor and, as I will suggest, a supplement, located just where the millennium can be folded in half.

Into our own unfolding present, marked as the new millennium, there burst an unexpected effect of the thousand-year history. For if the First Crusade defined the eleventh century, what opened the twenty-first if not another war defining the Christian West against Islam? The events of 2001, including the performative presidential utterance—“this crusade, this war on terrorism”—have already faded into a past of catastrophe tinged with national embarrassment, failure, even a certain ineptitude reminiscent of the buffoonish crusaders in Monty Python’s film *The Holy Grail*. The crusade complex might now seem to be reserved for psychotic outbursts of Islamophobia, as in the Danish episode timed as a millennial commemoration of the crusades.¹⁰ But our international agenda will for the foreseeable future have been shaped by wars and rumors of wars—with Muslims.¹¹ If we simply move on to other pressing issues (they do press) and forget again the current of Christian Islamophobia in which the modern West comes implicated, do we not repress and therefore intensify the complex?

Poised at the halfway point of this thousand-year crusade, just before the end of explicit crusading and the beginning of modernity, Cusa’s sapiential council

may offer an ancestral, if spectral, clue to the cosmopolitics we need today. The clue matters only to the extent that religious violence remains a problem insoluble by geographic or national separation.

If so it is because the complex implicates us in a wider complication and a widening precarity.

RELIGION, VIOLENCE, AND THE PRODUCTION OF THE WEST

In *The Myth of Religious Violence* William Cavanaugh argues that the idea that religions are especially or uniquely prone to violence is a “modern myth,” produced to strengthen the power of the secular state. “In what are called ‘Western’ societies, the attempt to create a transhistorical and transcultural concept of religion that is essentially prone to violence is one of the foundational legitimating myths of the liberal nation-state.”¹² He demonstrates persuasively that a “myth of religious violence” helps to construct and marginalize a religious Other, prone to fanaticism, as the foil of “the rational, peace-making, secular subject.” He was writing in the first decade of the millennium, with our wars in Afghanistan and Iraq very much in view. “This myth can be and is used in domestic politics to legitimate the marginalization of certain types of practices and groups labeled religious, while underwriting the nation-state’s monopoly on its citizens’ willingness to sacrifice and kill. In foreign policy, the myth of religious violence serves to cast nonsecular social orders, especially Muslim societies, in the role of villain.”¹³

Cavanaugh exposes the politics of a politically enshrined secularism that with dogmatic petulance mistakes the constitutional separation of church and state for a warrant to confine all religious expression to the private sphere. We are reminded that the “new atheist” stereotype of religion as the primary obstacle to a reasonably peaceful world is not new. The story of the religious cause of violence has legitimated the centuries-long political reorganization of the modern West into modern states. If one reads modernity as rational progress toward justice and peace, then the story, however simplified, has served a noble end. If, by contrast, one finds much deformation of modern democratic hope by the totalizing structures of violence and of capital, equally modern, then one surfaces the complicity

of secularism in the betrayal. In this Cavanaugh's argument supports the postsecularism that characterizes the more nuanced versions of recent political theory. Recent iterations of political theology—often by nontheistic thinkers—pursue a comparable complication of the story of religion. Indeed Cavanaugh is among those theological thinkers showing how the very notion of religion is a modern construct. But his own story in turn needs complicating. There are indeed myriad economic, cultural, and political motives involved in most apparently religious violence. (Pope Urban, we noted, used religious rhetoric to launch a crusade evidently aimed to pacify his own realm and enrich it.) But do the secular motives necessarily wash out the religious ones? Such a countersimplification may strip away the stereotype of the Dark Ages only to restore a glowing icon of medieval theocracy. Would we—even we theologians—want to relieve our own traditions of responsibility for their legitimations and motivations of violence?

Or to put the question differently: how would Cavanaugh's thesis account for Cusa, writing at the end of the medieval period and in direct response to Muslim violence? The cardinal's claim directly contradicts Cavanaugh's thesis: "*because of religion* many take up arms against each other."¹⁴ This "each other" serves in *De Pace* to distribute responsibility across the whole spectrum of religious cultures—including the author's own. In so doing it specifically avoids incrimination of Muslims—despite the evident Ottoman violence. In this early Renaissance thinker, steeped in worldly Greek thought and anticipating key elements of a much later science, do we have a secularist *avant la lettre*? (Certainly his earlier conciliarism anticipates some aspects of modern parliamentary politics.) But on Cavanaugh's thesis he would be a perpetrator of the antireligious myth.

Of course Cusa was writing right before *religion* had become the modern signifier of forms of belief and practice separable from each other and from the secular. He was questioning, as we shall see, a set of social habits. He was, however—and this seems key—making a profoundly *theological* argument. His point is neither to blame religion nor defend it, but to call it to its own best *sapientia*. The figure of Wisdom herself crosses between Socratic and biblical registers, seeking a framework of translatability between the world's religious dialects. Indeed Cobb would have us replace the term *religions* with *wisdoms*. If a nonviolent—indeed cosmopolitan—wisdom was finding Christian language in that moment, it could no more disentangle itself from its Latin cosmos than we can cut free of an

Anglophone globality. I am only insisting that the entangled difference we have examined in terms of relational ontologies also characterizes religion. So theological Wisdom will be on the lookout for the collusions of our own traditions with the powers of violence from which we also teach liberation. The modern myth of religious violence complements the perennial myth of religious purity.

There is for us, however, something more to ask of Cusa's mid-fifteenth-century context, just a generation prior to the Iberian irruption of the first modern nation-state. If the conditions for the emergence of the West were festering since the First Crusade, what emergency makes its modernity, its Europe, possible? Of this charged transitional moment, Enrique Dussel exposes a crucial spatiality: "When the Turks took over Constantinople in 1453, Europe found itself surrounded and reduced to a minimal role."¹⁵ The Ottomans were impinging from East and South. "Latin Europe of the fifteenth century, besieged by the Muslim world, amounted to nothing more than a peripheral, secondary geographical area situated in the westernmost limit of the Euro-Afro-Asian continent."¹⁶ But Europe never had been the center of world history. It "had to wait until 1492 to establish itself empirically as the center with other civilizations as its periphery."¹⁷ For, until that moment, what we call Europe "was *peripheral* and *secondary* to Islam."¹⁸ Dussel, however, is making a double argument. Against Hegel's "myopic Eurocentrism" he disputes the story of the northern, Germanic origin of the modern in the Protestant Reformation. That narrative manages to marginalize the defining events that occurred just before, on the Spanish peninsula—which, not insignificantly in its proximity to Africa, marks the *western* edge of its continent.

Dussel's argument for the *Iberian* origin of modernity then brings to light the *Islamophobic* framework of Western European identity. At the end of the fifteenth century Spain and Portugal were the first and only European powers with the capacity for external territorial conquest, as demonstrated both in Africa and in the conquest of the Islamic Kingdom of Granada in 1492. This was the final phase of the centuries-long Christian Reconquista of Andalusia.¹⁹ Modernity is forged in the iterative momentum of this particular violence. "The Iberian Reconquest, with the extreme sectarian violence it unleashed in its final stages (broken treaties, elimination of local elites, endless massacres and tortures, the demand that the conquered betray their religion and culture under pain of death or expulsion, the confiscation and repartition in feudal form of lands, towns, and their inhabitants

to the officers of the conquering army), was, in turn, *the model for the colonization of the New World*.²⁰

With this remarkable account Dussel is describing a planetary violence that is at once definitive of modern statehood and *nonetheless religious*. It repeats the conversionist misery and slaughter that Cusa was denouncing. Its brand of religion is intensified by Spain's new statist deployment of the Inquisition at home and in its New World—that supposed “East” that so inflated the West.

Dussel's thesis, in other words, lands “the modern” in the Americas. The Argentine and Mexican philosopher had articulated his model of Islamophobic modernity in response to the quintecentennial of the colonial success of Columbus (Spanish *Colon*). Columbus sailed forth, in his own words, as the emissary of the “*enemies of the sect of Mohammed*.” The Reconquista that made his journey possible had marked the end the old *convivencia*—of the dream, impossible to be sure, of the peaceful Iberian coexistence of the three Peoples of the Book.²¹ The Reconquest was not a crusade, but a new state-building deployment of Christian resentment against the Moors and the tiny, if influential, minority of Jews. Almost simultaneously with these expulsions and massacres the same aggression was applied to those new infidels without—the *Africans*, so many of whom were Muslim. (The aggression against indigenous Africa, and then America, was facilitated by the versatile logic of a faux East—the natives were branded in each case as “oriental,” as “Indians.” Dussel thus argues that as Europe “broke the Muslim siege, which had been in effect since Mohammed's death,” *it is in the conquest of Mexico* that “the European ego first controlled, colonized, dominated, exploited, and humiliated an Other, another empire.”²² The shadow of Islam explains the perplexing images in certain early colonial frescoes in Latin America of the turbaned and menacing figure of the Moor.²³

With the opening of modernity and the end of the Renaissance—extending to the Americas and only thereafter to the battle at the gates of Vienna—we can say that the explicit crusade folds into an implicit complex. The success of the new Western empires finally drives the long-central Muslim into the periphery. I am suggesting that this is a defining event, a reversal that folds history otherwise. Geopolitically reoriented European modernity largely represses its resentment of Islam and the ragged old dream of *convivencia*. Of the repression that constitutes what he calls the political unconscious, Jameson writes: “history is what

hurts, it is what refuses desire and sets inexorable limits to individual as well as collective praxis, which its ‘ruses’ turn into grisly and ironic reversals of their overt intention.”²⁴ The biblical hospitality to the stranger turns to colonization, the *pax christiana* to crusade, our planetary entanglement to global dominance: ruses of a systemically willed ignorance.

The *docta ignorantia* would be one counter-ruse, one name for attention to the unconscious complexes that metastasize in the grisly reversals. It isn’t that we could make our history transparent: our constituent entanglements will always recede into opacity. So this chapter tells one defining story, plucking a few threads stretched over a millennial arc, among many possible stories. Why this one, this implicating narrative, has insisted itself upon the present theological exercise will become, I hope, yet clearer.



“For what does the living seek except to live?”

—NICHOLAS OF CUSA, *DE PACE FIDES*

To better sense the texture of Cusa’s interfaith—indeed comparative theological—strategy, positioned on the eve of the modern, we may briefly sample the religio-economico-political complexity of his context. He lives, as noted, half a century before the Reconquista. In 1453 Nicholas V is failing to raise a crusade, the Ottomans are penetrating Eastern Europe. The year before, this pope had issued the papal bull *Dum Diversas*, granting the king of Portugal the right to reduce any “Saracens, pagans and any other unbelievers” to hereditary slavery.²⁵ While the papacy had all along supported slavery, it had qualms about institutionalizing a practice that condemned infants to be born into slavery. Nicholas V overcame that scruple and legitimized the modern colonial slave trade in Africa, and soon in the Americas, through anti-*Muslim* (Saracen) affect. Divergent Christian reactions to Islam register during this time. For example, the Transylvanian Vlad III boasts in 1462: “I have killed men and women, old and young . . . 23,884 Turks and Bulgarians without counting those whom we burned alive in their homes or whose heads were not chopped off by our soldiers.”²⁶ Most of us know Vlad as Count Dracula, whose link to Islamophobia is not usually noted. The crusader complex comes to us rich in undead symptoms.

Amidst mass enslavements, slaughters, and the call for the new crusade, Cusa's *contraferentia* signifies an impossible dream, a Christian way *not* taken. The emergent West would stay the course of the religiously sanctioned—I do not say caused—state supremacism that, beginning with Spain, produced the new empires. Against this background let us return to his vision of religious diversity. Cusa presumed and supported the Roman church. Yet his little book does not argue for the triumph or even the protection of Catholic—or Christian—civilization, but, much more basically and materially, that “the sword and the bilious spite of hatred and all evil sufferings will cease.” The means would be not *conversion* but *conversation*. Here is the surprising first step of the argument of *De Pace Fides*: “But you know, O Lord, that a great multitude cannot exist without considerable diversity and that almost everyone is forced to lead a life . . . full of miseries . . . in servile submission under the subjection of the rulers who [dominate] them. [So] only a few have enough leisure that they can proceed to a knowledge of themselves using their own free choice.”²⁷

It is not some generic sin or inferiority but specific conditions of social and epistemic oppression that keep the multitude from questioning their own assumptions about religious truth: “it is a characteristic of the . . . human condition that *a longstanding custom which is taken as having become nature is defended as truth*.”²⁸ In other words, the *social habitus* gets *naturalized*; my group's customs, endlessly repeated, are mistaken for the only truth. He is not repudiating the perspectives of specific cultures, but relativizing them by recognizing them as such. (Recall the perspectivism of *De Visio Dei*.) His Latin Christians are not excepted: they too defend a naturalized custom as truth. This evenhanded discourse, almost unheard of in the church up to that point, includes all religious traditions. “Thus not insignificant dissensions occur when each community prefers its faith to another.” But this competition, if not conducive to the truth it claims, nonetheless is read here with compassion. In each case it is a symptom of the desire for truth.

For, he writes in the mode of prayerful address: “this rivalry exists for the sake of you, whom alone they revere in everything that all seem to worship.”²⁹ That is an extraordinary concession, light years from the standard presumption of Satanic delusion or sinful culpability: “For each one desires in all that he seems to desire only the good which you are; no one is seeking with all his intellectual searching for anything else than the truth which you are. For what does the living seek except to live?”³⁰ And, if read against the background of Cusa's cosmology, we hear

the interrelated life of all creatures pulsing in this desire. Desire may expose us to dire limitation, distortion, our very undoing—but it is at root holy. Here the eros lures everyone toward the good, which he interpellates as divine, you, the life of the multiplicity of diverse lives, with their diverse truths.

In a gesture for which there is little precedent in Christian thought, Cusa next argues for the possible truth-content of all faiths. The following disarmingly plain inference may convey to some a mystical non sequitur. In cloud perspective it precipitates a breakthrough for religious diversity then or now: “Therefore it is you, the giver of life and being, who seem to be sought in the different rites by different ways and are named with different names, *because as you are you remain unknown and ineffable to all.*”³¹

Because none of us (not even a cardinal) can—*de docta ignorantia*—“know” God, no religion can rule out the truth of other religions. For in all of their difficult differences of name and way, each seeks the life that is beyond names. We have earlier witnessed the Christian negative tradition, by way of Dionysius, articulating the boundless multiplicity of the names of that which has no name. But it had not (except, and with reservations, for certain Jews and Greeks) yet signaled an opening to the unknown divinity of other “ways.”

So here again a repetition of a classical apophatic gesture effects novelty. As the negating of God lets us affirm a vast multiplicity of divine names, so now it lets us affirm the multiplicity of ways. Indeed the unknowability of the infinity *explicates* the diversity of finite *faiths*. *De Pace* represents its multiplicity with four Muslim figures, a Jew, an Indian, an Italian, a Spaniard, a German, a Frenchman, a Tartar Englishman, and others (obviously not the modern list of “the religions”). In spite of the primacy of the Ottoman crisis, Cusa’s dialogue does not limit itself unduly to the Abrahamisms. It will then specifically clarify, in answer to a worry voiced by the Muslim about idols and images, that the “Indians,” and others with their many statues, may also rightly revere divinity in multiple expressions—indeed as many gods. His presiding archangel has, startlingly, no problem with this divine multiplicity as long as each agrees—which his imaginary Indian informant assures him the learned certainly would do—that it is always *divinity* they name and they worship in each statue or god.

Cusa’s theory proves disappointing, however, if one abstracts him from his context and holds him to the criteria of current religious pluralism. As he enters

more confidently into his fantasy, with Peter, Paul, and the Logos proving formidably Socratic interlocutors for all the representatives, the Christian perspective becomes ever more explicit. He is able to persuade, for instance, the Chaldean (Muslim) and the Jew—whose commitment to the One he affirms with unqualified respect—that they are already *trinitarians*. Not in the language of Father, Son, and Holy Ghost, to be sure, which as “names which are attributed to God” are “taken from creatures”; God remains “ineffable and beyond everything that can be named or spoken.”³² This is the ecumenical aptitude of negative theology. The Word then swiftly accounts for the traditional language of the trinity as “not proper terms” but convenient ones, *convenienter*. More appropriate, he avers, would be to derive from the relation they signify terms “more suitable, such as ‘unity,’ ‘thatness’ and ‘identity.’”³³ His select interlocutors have no problem at all with these abstractions! Indeed if an Advaita Vedantan or Theravada Buddhist were among them, neither would they.

Cusa’s little peace book responds to an ethicopolitical crisis. But its terse argument is anticipated—in the language of folds—in a passage in *De docta* where he reflects on ancient pagans: “Pagans have given various names to god with regard to creatures.”³⁴ And here in his cloud encryption he already applies the Dionysian multiplicity of names to religious multiplicity: “All the names are unfoldings of the enfolding of the one, ineffable name, and as this proper name is infinite, so it enfolds an infinite number of such names of particular perfections. Although there could be many such unfoldings, they are never so many or so great that there could not be more.”³⁵ And in the following inference note the interreligious generosity of the final twist: “The ancient pagans used to ridicule the Jews, who worshiped the one, infinite God whom they did not know, while the pagans themselves were worshiping God in God’s unfoldings, that is, they were worshiping God wherever they beheld God’s divine works.”³⁶ In other words, Cusa’s apophatically entangled infinite plies what it implies: what we might call (did it not, as ever, sound too negative) a negative comparative theology.

Still, isn’t this—in terms of the methodological options for comparative theology—just Christian inclusivism? Its unifying approach, as in the theology of Karl Rahner or the comparativism of John Hick, has been—however trailblazing in their moments—largely abandoned by scholars of interreligious encounter as inadequate progress beyond exclusivism. Nicholas certainly fails to become

a postmodern pluralist. He remains a premodern and Christocentric Christian, conjecturing, in the face of the actually threatening imperial aggression of the old ethnoreligious Other, a universal alternative to crusade. And he is writing to his fellow Catholics in language that could imaginably persuade *them*—certainly not to the fantasized representatives of faiths about which so little still was known. And so of course the “one religion” of *religio una in rituum varietate*—however unorthodox, indeed Muslim—can surely be read, as can the many forms of the One, as its own subtler imposition of Christian presumption.³⁷ But his very failure in this regard retains an odd helpfulness. The fact is that today global Christianity, in its most successful, dynamic, and usually Protestant forms, is still dominated by an unapologetic exclusivism. As in much Islam, the exclusive truth claim need not produce violence against the religious other, but justifies and fuels the violence when—out of multiple causes—it arises. The imaginary of a convivial, all exceeding and enfolding Mystery may help more than mere arguments for democratic tolerance, allied with secular pluralism. It will approximate what Catherine Cornille, in the relevantly named *Im-Possibility of Interreligious Dialogue*, affirms as “open inclusivism.”³⁸ Indeed comparative theology, as for instance John Thamanil frames it polydoxically, increasingly troubles the triad of exclusivism, inclusivism, pluralism.³⁹ The apophatically entangled diversity, hauntingly prefigured in Cusa’s reach through and beyond tolerance toward a dialogical peace process, offers a needed cosmopolitical tool.

Given the precarity of planetary cohabitation, a *relational pluralism* happens not over and against the variously separative Ones.⁴⁰ It breaks through their walls of mutual contradiction from within a cloud that they may im/possibly recognize they share. And in the historic context of Cusa’s thought the identity of the One is one not opposed to any many: “Identity is enfolded difference.”⁴¹ So the Supreme Complication also enfolds—in their diversity—the multiple faith practices of the world. They cannot be forced or tricked into unity, but in conversation explicate, and in practice, unfold, the ecumenical *religio* in which they are *already* unknowingly tied together. The folds of difference, heretofore cut into a history of catastrophe, thus unfold into peaceable conversation. In theory.

In practice, however, this pacific contraferentia remained “caught up in a certain intellectual height”⁴²—and tucked into the impossible, even for its author. The book exercised minimal influence. Wars between Catholics and Protestants

would in the following century outdo violence between religions. Willed ignorance of the other ways remained fundamental and manipulable by the political theologies and economic interests of the emerging European powers. This willful—habituated—ignorance remains widespread, if mitigated by religious liberalization and secularizing education. It remains manipulable by the new forms of power. The *apophatic entanglement of religion itself*, mindfully practiced, implicates, already half a millennium ago, a planetary diversity of human rites, practices, cultures, politics, theologies. Now we add sexes, economies, ecologies. But without its corresponding Wisdom, entanglement—the same entanglement—yields not convivial complexity but global complexes. Complexes are folded within complexes. We fold now fast-forward to consider the pervasive present form and crusade of such a complex, that of the global economy.

FROM *PAX DEI* TO *PAX ECONOMICA*

The global dimension of capitalism increasingly entangles everyone with everything.

—WILLIAM CONNOLLY, *CAPITALISM AND CHRISTIANITY, AMERICAN STYLE*

The folds of human complexity have taken new planetary forms. The North American version of Western globalism envelopes South and East in the geopolitics of its markets. Amidst the smooth folds of economic transnationalism, the crusader complex remains cloaked in an aura of medieval irrelevance.⁴³ Globalization now signifies the neoliberal corporate economics in which oil—and *therefore* Islam—figures prominently. And in the wake of the nationalist world wars, Bretton Woods did disarmingly link international commerce with peace: make deals, not wars.⁴⁴ Of course, there is also the long history of big peace deals that come detached from justice and make bigger wars: we began with the *pax dei* as it was co-opted for the First Crusade; there had been long before the *pax romana* and then the *pax romana Christiana*. At the turn of this millennium the *pax Americana* declared by neoconservatives (who are economic neoliberals) proudly echoed the ancient imperial ideal. The United States version, however, comes ensconced in a capitalist world order itself religiously sanctified—unquestioningly by moderate Christianity and aggressively by the avowedly crusading evangelism

of the prosperity gospel. The new religious right was forged in an unlikely symbiosis with late capitalism: hence William Connolly's "evangelical-neoliberal resonance machine." So the religiously indifferent market absorbed the unquestionability of faith. Thomas Frank argued in *One Market Under God*, the 1990s produced a shift: there exists now, though no longer as visibly, "the general belief among opinion-makers that there is something natural, something divine, something inherently democratic about markets."⁴⁵

So now a *pax economica* is extended as the presumed condition of all political futures. Trade deals, no matter how secretive or predatory, are trusted to stabilize the world. It is faint say that "most people in the United States appear to find it easier to imagine the end of the world than the end of capitalism."⁴⁶ Indeed in the U.S. a certain Wild West nationalism, faith inflected, complicates also the wider West of our corporate internationalism. The latter is called by Namsoon Kang, who has helpfully distinguished a whole series of cosmopolitanisms, elite or market cosmopolitanism.⁴⁷ In the name of unlimited prosperity it secures relations of pyramidal dependency from the planetary majority living precariously close to creaturely limits. Those who can never hope to achieve the pale ego ideal propagated through the global media must be content that at least their own elites enjoy business-class cosmopolitanism.

Economic globalization "entangles everyone with everything." Yes. The dominance of late capitalism is not based simply on imperial aggression,⁴⁸ let alone religious collusion. Its flexible interactivity captures something of the ontological process of entanglement, of its instantaneous exchange and its productive risks. This is why any pure opposite, such as a determinist state uniformism, is doomed to lose. But of course capitalism does not advertise the all-in-all and each-in-each of our nonseparability. To the contrary it features the ego-by-ego of corporate individualism. That billboard ideal projects the smoothest uniformity *as* the new and the different: a new ruse of a separability that stays "connected." Our mutual immanence, our embodied interdependence, is systemically ignored while our external links are commodified—indeed electrified. So the cosmos-persona or undone vastness of the *mindfully* entangled subject can emerge only as alternative and antidote to this market-entangled individualism. For as the quantum parable has suggested—we cannot become disentangled again. The capitalism of entanglement is its Babylonian captivity.

So might our planetary entanglement itself ironically expose the violence of the *pax economica*, the coloniality of its free markets and the hopelessness of its triumph? This is another version of the problem of all relational thought: it is not that relation itself is good or responsible. It is *mindfulness* of relation that plies the ethical—as opposed to the corporate *mindlessness* of entanglement. In his luminous *Poetics of Relation*, Édouard Glissant, writing out of the legacy of North Atlantic slavery, supplies the missing clue to this doubling. He distinguishes two faces of our world-relation: “Worldness is exactly what we all have in common today: the dimension I find myself inhabiting and the relation we may well lose ourselves in.”⁴⁹ Such is the face of connectivity and loss of ego that he honors. “The wretched other side of worldness is what is called globalization or the global market: reduction to the bare basics, the rush to the bottom, standardization, the imposition of multinational corporations with their ethos of bestial (or all too human) profit, *circles whose circumference is everywhere and whose center is nowhere*.”⁵⁰

Glissant has inverted the hermetic trope that surfaced in Cusa: the sphere whose center is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere. Now the globe displays the ubiquitous closure of an absolute boundary, a territorialization that encloses *terra*. The sphere composed all of circumference is strangling the shared life of the creatures. What would be the alternative? Precisely a world of undone boundaries in which each of us comprises a worthy and mobile center nonseparable from all the other centers. We had observed that same enigma of the infinite sphere unfold a scientifically prescient cosmology in Cusa.

Glissant writes of a silence and indifference that he predicts will continue, for decades, to enshroud the “chaotic sufferings of the countries of the south.”⁵¹ This is the willed ignorance of planetary entanglement. And it tangles us in a chaos not of new creation but of the degradation of the multitude. The crusading capitalism of the West does not, need not, acknowledge the violence of its side effects. The cloud has become shroud, the impossibility long-term and deadly. Yet not without its crack, its possibility. Indeed by a mysterious coincidence Glissant already was channeling the quantum trope: “Consider that the West itself has produced the variables to contradict its impressive trajectory every time. This is the way in which the West is not monolithic, and this is why it is surely necessary that it move toward *entanglement*. The real question is whether it will do so in a participatory manner or if its entanglement will be based on old impositions.”

Participation names, then, the mindful alternative to the old impositions: to conquest and crusade, to slave markets and “free” markets. In answer to the stranglehold of capitalist entanglement, this participatory entanglement offers a key to inverting the inversions of each ruse of our political unconscious. It lets us comb out some snarls of Western history without pretending to have cut loose. Participation, a metaphor at once of ontological interrelation and of democratic action, lets its agents at once face the contradiction and open the wall. For what is part of us, repeating itself in us, we may iterate otherwise. The ambiguous entanglement is not severed but rewoven. The relational ontology of becoming exists to intensify that possibility: the “third repetition,” the fold into the new.

Even more coincidence: Glissant has unfolded his allusion to entanglement from the trope of “opacity”: “Agree not merely to the right to difference, but, carrying this further, agree also to the right to opacity that is not enclosure within an impenetrable autarchy but subsistence within an irreducible singularity.”⁵² Butler may not have known of this usage, but echoes it in her relational opacity of unknowingness. The nonseparable singularity in this nonsubstantial subsistence has wrapped itself in the radical poetics of Glissant’s cloud, from which it precipitates with fresh force. The participatory entanglement deepens an oceanic mystery—an “unknown we do not fear.” So here the singularity of difference has wrapped itself—in the strongest alternative to individualism—in our mindful participation in one another. “Opacities can coexist and converge, weaving fabrics.”⁵³ Is this not apophatic entanglement, Caribbean style?

The old trail of clouds could seem to be converging impossibly with present political theory. Connolly approaches the very language of negative theology: “when you encounter unfathomable mystery in your faith in the right spirit, you may become inspired to appreciate corollary elements of paradox, mystery, or uncertainty at different points in other faiths.”⁵⁴ He recommends an ethos that collects “these points of insufficiency, mystery, or uncertainty—operative at different points in each creed.”⁵⁵ Connolly is no theist, however, but a Jamesian, Deleuzian pluralist preoccupied with the field of affects that motivates political postures and policies. So he includes, among the creeds, the “existential faiths” of various kinds of “nonbelief.” (Like Tillich, faith then signifies not “belief” but “ultimate concern.”)

He is especially a nonbeliever in the “self-defeating drive to pretend that religious creeds and modes of spirituality can be quarantined in the private realm.”⁵⁶ It was on grounds of progressive coalitional politics that he wrote *Why I Am Not a Secularist*.⁵⁷ This patience to suffer the mystery of multiple faiths is hard-won within progressive political thought. It pushes the secular envelope of political pluralism into religious diversity, just there where religious pluralism must also engage irreligious diversity. A rigorously transdisciplinary thinker, Connolly enfoldes natural science as well as theology in an expansive political philosophy that abides in the perspective of a radically participatory subject: “energized complexities of mutual imbrication and interinvolvement, in which heretofore unconnected or loosely associated elements, *fold, bend, blend, emulsify, and resolve incompletely into each other*, forging a qualitative assemblage resistant to classical models of explanation.”⁵⁸ Here the fold finds a new politics. In Connolly’s rhizomatic political ethics the mutual implications enfold and unfold, form a rhizome between a Deleuzian language and an “unfathomable mystery” alien to Deleuze.⁵⁹ It may be that without mobilizing this negative capability, with its deepening of the folds of multiplicity, there will not emerge a movement strong and resilient enough to counter that resonance machine built of capitalism and the religious right. In the pluralist spirituality Connolly plies, to mind the unknown and uncertain is to make new forms of mutual participation and therefore of coalition possible.

In other words, a politics of apophatic entanglement may already be implicated in the nonviolent hope of a cosmopolitanism beyond that of corporate modernity. Dussel, for instance, after locating the birth of modernity in the Reconquista, has stressed the connection between “Descartes’s *ego cogito* and the ideal conquistador, the *ego conquiro*.” He argues that the “*I conquer*” precedes and sustains the “*I know*.” So any project of decolonization works to undo this ego—not any “I,” not the singular subject of a participatory paradigm, but the knowing subject of our West. Yet it is not the methodological doubt that is the problem, but its unambiguous overcoming. The movement from doubt to certainty also describes the formation of the *ego conquiro*; “if the *ego cogito* doubts the world around him, the *ego conquiro* doubts the very humanity of conquered others.”⁶⁰ Dussel had exposed the conquering Euro-ego spurred and shaped from the outset by self-doubt in relation to Islam. So it is shadowed by an inferiority complex that it acts out in

every phobic aggression since. The point is not that Islamophobia drives every crusading phobia—xeno, homo, gyno—but that it is implicated, requiring a millennial mindfulness. No monocausal account supports—or survives—participation in entanglement.

If the self comes inextricably entangled in its others—human and otherwise—its ego comes undone—for better and for worse. Uncertainty, we have seen, is irreducible. A subject will not be able to control and conquer even the others *within itself*, those influences that make existence coexistence from the start. A certain *convivencia*, a life-together, remains, quite apart from any mythic Golden Age, onto-poetically irreducible. It calls from the very nodes of our complexity. All the more so in a world exposed ever more to its own boundless sphere—and to the crusading religion of infinite growth that would conquer even the infinite.

If, then, as Dussel suggests, the modern certainty that doubts the humanity of others begins in a Cartesian doubt that cannot make peace with uncertainty, we find ourselves in what he calls “the transmodern project.” He intends no negation of modern reason, but of a “violent, Eurocentric, developmentalist, hegemonic reason.”⁶¹ A transmodern reason pursues “the corealization of solidarity” which he characterizes as “analectic, analogic, syncretic, hybrid, and mestizo, and which bonds center to periphery, woman to man, race to race, ethnic group to ethnic group, class to class, humanity to earth.”⁶² And surely such a corealization also ties religion to religion, thereby unpredictably altering the forms of faith, historical and existential, that seek to actualize a planetary solidarity. Does it bring with its own postcapitalist peace—a *pax convivencia*? If so, it will not resemble “its bastard substitute, anaesthesia.” For peace, pace Whitehead, “is removal of inhibition and not its introduction.”⁶³ The realization of possibilities otherwise locked into a political unconscious remains the work—always apophatically clouded—of a transreligious solidarity.

PANENTHEISM AS POLITICAL THEOLOGY

We must then ask how a theology of apophatic entanglement, cosmopolitically developed, may begin to engage the largely nontheological conversation that proceeds under the heading of the postsecular and of “political theology.” That

latter concept was notoriously relaunched under Carl Schmitt's definition: "All significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts."⁶⁴ Here I turn to the political theorist Paulina Ochoa Espejo for a crucial clue. She acknowledges that Schmitt's analysis remains meaningful in the face of the failure of the exhaustive secularization of Western public discourse. She questions, however, the *particular God* enthroned as Schmitt's secular theological power. Schmitt designated the power of decision "in the exception" as the sovereignty crucial to a head of state; civilized order depends on an unrestrained ruler who can carry the sacred justification of authority. "Even if, for historical reasons, we were willing to grant that the modern state has institutionalized the function of a God-like sovereign," she writes, "we need not accept that it corresponds to *this* idea of God: an omniscient, omnipotent, eternal and unfathomable, commanding personal deity."⁶⁵ This notion of sovereignty sits enthroned amidst the desires and ruses of the Western democratic powers. For it draws upon power-complexes predating the modern nation-states.

Here a brief thousand-year return to Fulcher's rendition of Urban's speech will illustrate. The speech performs the congruence between the power of God, the crusade, and the one who summons it. "All who die by the way, whether by land or by sea, or in battle against the pagans, shall have immediate remission of sins. This I grant them through the power of God with which I am invested. O what a disgrace if such a despised and base race, which worships demons, should conquer a people which has the faith of omnipotent God and is made glorious with the name of Christ!"⁶⁶

In other words, the divine omnipotence "invested" in the pope infused the assaults on Islam with political force—a force still feeding the crusade complex. Are these investments after all this time still yielding returns, even in secular capitalist states? Schmitt, a great admirer of certain conservative Catholic critics of the liberal state, and for a time a Nazi jurist, would want to increase the yield by returning to the sovereign his "power of the exception," the miraculous—the singular. He also drew upon Kierkegaard's sense of the miraculous exception. Secularism with some reason finds the answer only in separation from theology, hidden or overt, and its vested powers. More recently, leftist thinkers from Agamben to Žižek have in the postsecular modality acknowledged the constituent force of this theology of power: of the sovereignty of the decision maker who transcends the laws he

[*sic*] makes. Clayton Crockett argues that Schmitt's tainted critique of liberalism cannot be avoided in our period, with its dual crisis of the death of God and the disintegrating boundary between the religious and secular spheres. Of course the relational theologies that partly frame the present project all participate in some form of avowedly *theological* political theology critical of both liberalism and conservative reactions. So the conversation among political theorists is captivating.⁶⁷

The question becomes: can we have some *transmodern* rendition of political theology that does not take its cue from the militant ghosts of this *premodern* omnipotence? Ochoa Espejo, along with many thinkers of the left, including her former teacher Connolly, pursues such alternatives. But she recognizes something further: that an alternative notion of God—more than, for instance, that of the pantheism implicit in the pure immanence of Connolly and his Spinozan/Deleuzian heritage—must be discerned. Indeed, in a startling bit of transdisciplinarity, tucked away in a single essay, she experimentally offers *panentheism* in answer to what she calls Schmitt's "functional secularization." "What would a political analogy with the God of panentheism produce?" she asks. "Instead of a sovereign decision maker who is outside the state, the analogy would yield a source of political authority that is both identical to the polity, and beyond the polity. . . . In this case we can find actual views of political authority that share a common structure with panentheism. In classical democratic theory, for example, the citizens are held to be both citizens and subjects at the same time."⁶⁸

In the God who enfolds and exceeds the world she draws an analogy to a democratic polity. "In sum, a functionalist analogy using a panentheistic God as a reference yields democratic politics, rather than decisionistic sovereignty." Remarkably, she found in John Cobb's *Process Theology as Political Theology* a key to her critique of political theology.⁶⁹ But then with uncanny intuition she also dug up Cusa, who, she writes, "developed in the 15th century a conception of God as *Non Aliud*." She recognized here an ancestral panentheist whose conception of God as "not-other" well "mediates between transcendence and immanence."⁷⁰

It is process theology that features the most systematically enunciated alternative to classical omnipotence. It offers in its place not impotence—except from the viewpoint of the disappointed hope for intervention—but a contingent and vulnerable deity. It operates by invitation, not dictation. Its lure cannot be read off the surface of events. If we choose to launch new crusades we are not acting in the

image of this one, this complicity not reigning over and above the cosmos but entangled in it and host to “the democracy of creatures.” Not without political sensibility, then, Whitehead figured God as *exemplification* of the categories of process and relation—and precisely not as the “Supreme Exception.” And, instead of a Sovereign Decider, there is suggested a divine eros desirous of our diversities and provocative of our decisions—new, but not disentangled from history. The panentheistic divinity, as we saw, depends upon the solidarity of creatures for co-realization. It continues to lure me to its Whiteheadian nicknames inasmuch as they also sabotage any certainty of their own. An apophatically darkened panentheism keeps political theology *theological*—and therefore *possible*—in the face, the double face, of authoritarian exceptionalism and liberal failure.

FRAGILE COSMOPOLIS

Unfolding the political philosophy of a “world of becoming,” Connolly has in recent works been directly engaging Whitehead’s cosmology. Its matrix of intertwined spatiotemporal events is hospitable to the ecoegalitarian pluralism Connolly fosters. He notices the divinity, transcendent in its immanence, that comes attached to the model. It will not make him a panentheist, but it serves the existential ecumenism of his own resonance machine. What he wants from Whitehead is the intensification of the *time* of becoming, complicit with Bergson and Deleuze. Whitehead’s universe of “creative advance into novelty” offers a sustained sensitivity to resonances between a novel event and multiple layers of the past. It lets us come “to terms with an immanent world of becoming in which the future is not entirely implicit in the past.”⁷¹ This sense of implication is crucial: at stake is the event of the fold discussed earlier, without which relationality may holistically fold down the indeterminacy of the new. The past potentialities do not repeat as the same but are provoked into contrasts with new possibilities. And, as Connolly reads them, the “wavelengths and vibrations” that Whitehead locates as “primitive feeling” (the physical prehensions of the human and the non) are “always in play and accelerate when a novel production is in the works.”⁷² This sense of time explains my compulsion to risk the rhizomatic narrative of the present exercise. The layered resonances that may be released into awareness (by the

newly exposed and still primitive affects of Islamophobia of this millennium, for instance) might make more probable an improbably convivial outcome.

Connolly reads us all as participants “in a world of becoming in a universe set on multiple zones of temporality, with each temporal force-field periodically encountering others as outside forces, and the whole universe open to an uncertain degree.”⁷³ With attention to the affective field, we mind what is not yet known, but is nonetheless making itself *felt*. Connolly, with his propensity to stage surprising convergences of politics with natural science, solicits from Whitehead the imbrication in every becoming of a nonhuman depth of feeling. He recently pursued further this cosmological thread, following it beyond the biological layers of his previous work with the biology of self-organizing complexity into the quantum intra-actions.⁷⁴ I should not have been so startled to find him writing that Whitehead offers in the actual entity, as it comes “both enmeshed with others and metamorphizes according to the time scale appropriate to it,” not just the quantum background but “an image of multiple entanglements.”⁷⁵

Even if entanglement is not a Whiteheadian term, it supports Connolly in his unfolding of the implications of process cosmology for the politics of an alarmingly fragile world. We have discussed the fallacy of misplaced concreteness as a critique of the substance metaphysics and materialism of the West. Abstractions mistaken for the concrete (an individual through time, countable economic units, etc.) conceal the constituent relationality. I would add that mutual participation does require an interval of time, which is not empirically discernible in any measured entanglement. However, space and time are for Whitehead relations between things, not the frame of relations. Relations, one might say—as is now being speculated of entanglement at the quantum level—give rise to space and time. Then one may agree with Connolly that

for Whitehead, misplaced concreteness means more broadly the tendency to overlook entanglements between energized, real entities that exceed any atomistic reduction of them, as when a climate pattern and ocean current system intersect and enter a new spiral of mutual amplification, or when a cultural disposition to spiritual life befuddles the academic separation between an economic system and religion by flowing into the very fiber of work motivation, consumption profiles, investment priorities, and electoral politics.⁷⁶

So now we have from Connolly—who noted the capitalist entanglement of all in all—an added criterion for distinguishing the good from the bad: in the marketplace of misplaced concreteness, concrete or cosmological entanglements are masked by the abstractions that atomize, separate, and all too smoothly commodify them. So global capitalism profits from a misplaced entanglement—disguised in the disentangled relations between the personae of individualism and its atoms.

If there emerges in the cosmos of this becoming a new, radically indeterminate interplay between the quantum minimum and the complicating maximum, the human between is still cloudily emerging. No longer *ego conquirō* or *ego cogito*, but, we might say, *ego complico*: “I fold together” a world, out of its excess of impinging diversities. But the I in its concreteness already vanishes—perishes—into the we of the becoming world. The kosmos-persona evanesces and coalesces again, in the coalitions of a new politics. No one more than Connolly is teaching its terms: those of a cosmopolitics with *cosmos*. So I must cite this passage from *The Fragility of Things*, epitomizing his thoughts about “the cosmopolitical dimension,” climate change, and his interchange with “the magesterial Whitehead and the agonistic Nietzsche.” It will not only prepare us for the next chapter’s ecocosm but conclude this one’s cosmopolitics:

This, then, is a *cosmic* dimension folded into contemporary politics, in part because it speaks to a time when several planetary force-fields become entangled densely with several aspects of daily life, in part because our capacities to explore and respond politically to such imbrications with affirmative intelligence are severely challenged, in part because dangerous existential dispositions surge and flow again into defining institutions of late modern life, and in part because these very intersections convey the need to rethink the contemporary condition.⁷⁷

I know of no more direct route to the “existential dispositions” of great portions of the population than through their religion. It is responsible for some of the most dangerous patterns of history, and the hope of their cure. In the context of democratic participation, the negative capability of theology—to challenge its own presumptions and to make common cause with multiple forms of affirmative intelligence—may be of special cosmopolitical value.

COMING TO BE IN THE CLOUD

The narrative experiment of this chapter has attempted to respond to the “dangerous simplification” (Gerle) of the complex with the cosmopolitics of a complication. As the Supreme Complication, it claims some Christian ancestry. For theology, particularly in a Christian vein, will contribute to the evolving postsecular discourse of political theology only inasmuch as we bear our own baggage—or should I say our own cross? This means for example curing the crusade complex where the Western Christ became an Islamophobic warrant for conquest in the name of peace. But the only cure will come from homeopathic remedies, alternative theologies that circulate through the historical vicinity of the destruction. The ancestral Christian sources of a relational pluralism move through the cloud of unknowing—of our own and therefore of every religious or irreligious ultimate. But theological remedies matter little in our time if they do not stimulate, motivate, feed the unknown and therefore possible future—a possibility wrenched from the impossible—of a planetary *convivencia*. The diversity would be enfolded now not in *una religio* but *una terra*. Any theological perspectives that unfold loving justice for a living world will help, rather than distract from, the construction of a live answer—for the sake of the living—to the deadening faith in the *pax economica*. God: either He who blesses corporate globalism or a name for the precarious life of all who are entangled in it.

Where the apophatic entanglement comes politically into play, it will negate any name worth killing for; it will affirm all names worth living for. Sometimes it offers its gift in the name of Christ. And most often—not. Though no comparative theology, with a credible examination of other than Christian sources for a cosmopolitical theology, is possible in the present text, this chapter needs the contrast of a Muslim voice. For the healing of our crusader peace complex, the last word—by way of ritual and resonance, not argument—goes to the astonishing Iberian Muslim philosopher-poet and mystic Ibn Arabi (1165–1240). Prodigal, prolific, disciple, and caregiver of a ninety-five-year-old female teacher, he wrote when the ideal of *convivencia* still haunted the crusading present. And he wrote the cloud itself. He offers this rendition of the Quran, recognized as a stunning,

improbable, indeed apophatic formulation: “*Where did God come to be? He came to be in the Cloud.*”⁷⁸ The Cloud is “the Breath of the All-merciful.”

In Ibn Arabi’s exegesis blossoms the cloudiest of religious crowds: “God is the root of every diversity (*khilaf*) in beliefs within the cosmos.” Therefore, “the paths to God are as numerous as the breaths of the creatures.” In another instance of the path modernity failed to take, the cloud perspectives writes diversity “like the letters in the breath of the speaker at the places of articulation.”⁷⁹

The affirmation of an indeterminate multiplicity is apophatically articulated and embodied as “heart.”⁸⁰ In an ecumenical discourse aching wider and wiser than most Abrahamic practice then or now, diversity implies, it implicates, divinity. Its human persona—“my heart”—echoes the vast entanglement we have heard in other poetic incarnations. Does it still perform the nomadic way of a new convivencia, planetary in its nonviolent cosmopolitics? Beyond calculable likelihood, Ibn Arabi enfolds the amorous ecumene that ever more of us across the planet would practice:

Wonder,
A garden among the flames!
My heart can take on any form:
A meadow for gazelles,
A cloister for monks,
For the idols, sacred ground,
Ka’ba for the circling pilgrim,
The tables of the Torah,
The scrolls of the Qur’an.
My creed is love;
Wherever its caravan turns along the way,
That is my belief,
*My faith.*⁸¹



nine

BROKEN TOUCH

ECOLOGY OF THE IM/POSSIBLE

At such a juncture, what would be needed is a multiplicity of engagements and a proliferation of manners to behave as humans on Earth. This would be the only way to cope with what the multiple loops traced by the instruments of science reveal of the narrative complexity and entanglement of Gaia.

—BRUNO LATOUR, FACING GAIA

ON A BRIEF JOURNEY TO BERLIN, I had the pleasure of visiting the Pergamon Museum, built to house the monumental Middle Eastern yield of late-nineteenth-century German archeology. It was an under-researched, last-minute detour. So I was not prepared for the scale of the reconstructed Pergamon Altar, rising nearly three stories atop a great stone staircase; nor of its bas relief, a frieze that runs the size of a city block, at a length of 113 meters. I wandered as an awe-struck tourist, listening on headphones to a narrative of this remainder, built in 170 BCE, of a colonial Greek city on the coast of Asia Minor allied with an emergent Roman order. I had been ignorant of its import, beyond the faintly menacing echo of the Apocalypse, an address “to the angel of the church in Pergamum” (Revelation 2:12). This might have forewarned me.

With Athenian sophistication, the sculpture celebrates the great victory of the city over its enemies. One particularly dynamic composition rivets the gaze.

Amidst a flutter of wings, a slither of serpents, and a tangle of bodies, a naked youth writhes in defeat. The goddess Athena has grabbed him by his curly locks and is about to strike him dead. On her left another female figure rises out of the ground. Her face depicts anguish. The narrator explains that this is Gaia, the Earth, desperately pleading for the life of her child Alkyoneus. He strains to touch her even as she reaches toward him. Athena has broken his contact with Gaia. He embodies the doom of all “the children of the Earth.” In Hesiod’s account, Chaos, the first principle, produced Gaia, the first deity. She then brought forth Uranus, Sky; the Olympians, the “hills and seas,” all “without sweet union of love”; and then, with Uranus, “her equal,” the Titans and the Gigantes, including Alkyoneus. So, the narrator clarified, in the guise of these vanquished Gaians, the frieze celebrates Pergamon’s defeat of the Galatian tribes, the Celtic “barbarians” long obstructive to the expanding Greco-Roman civilization.

My relaxed holiday gaze froze into focus: *already*? So it was this explicit over two millennia ago, the breach from the earth? It is not that the Athenians were directly targeting Gaia, the earth itself. No more do we now. Their foes were the migrant interlopers who transgress and threaten their world order. Gaia gets in the way. Athena ignores her. Earth’s devastation is collateral damage.

It would seem that we have to do here with an ancient complex, one long preceding and exceeding the thousand-year crusade considered in chapter 8. Wars within wars, folds within folds. Let the Pergamon Altar stand as a metaphor not of an origin but of the specifically classical origins of the *polis*, the city, the civic order. Civilization antedates Greece, but I probe here the Western context of a complex in which I know myself, indeed, theology knows itself, to be implicated. And in its complicated Athenian legacy of slavery, philosophy, democracy, its politics transcends and haunts each subsequent empire. It forms the matrix for the much later dominion of the Christian empires and so of the modern nation state. It unfolds the temporality of what is called Western civilization, and its spatiality has enfolded the globe. It has marked as its barbarians any earth-identified populations, sedentary or nomadic; they are uncivilized, another race, fit for colonization or else elimination. The nonhumans are all fair game.

“Civilization,” with its empires, remains a conscious, if sometimes self-questioning, avowal. So it is not the name of this complex. It would seem instead that it was *oikos*, home, ecology, that went (all too literally) underground.

Relation to the earth-home is sacrificed on the altar of civilization—driven into the civilizational unconscious. Jameson's notion of the political unconscious, as it answers the "cultural logic of late capitalism," pertains: it is an unconscious produced by repressive power and maintained by fear.¹ Might we recognize here a *Gaia complex*? It lends a face to the more ancient and diffuse fear of the non-human universe from which the human is nonseparable: call it *ecophobia*. And what does the mythologized war of Pergamon against human barbarians and the earth mother herself become in our time—but the logic of late capitalism? So then, we can only diagnose the major current planetary symptom of the Gaia complex as climate change. By the same token, the systemic ruse by which our polis represses its own cosmos would be most legible in the form of climate change *denial*: that potent syndrome concocted of reactionary Christianity and neoliberal capitalism. This denial—as a complex—is not budged by the science or the facts. A new form of systemic ignorance lets us, with Athena, look the other way. As Islamophobia fueled the more parochial crusader complex, so here ecophobia energizes the civilizational Gaia complex. Then it is not hard to diagnose the great planetary effect of our entangled present tense as climate change. And so the systemic ruse by which our polis represses its own cosmos may be most legible in the form of climate change denial.

The marble gap between the hands of the youth and of Gaia may here sculpt the measure of our dissociation. We know well vis-à-vis our species' future the affect of helpless despair. The work of apophatic entanglement would be nothing but spiritual frivolity if it did not face us, in the end, with this: the possibly impossible chance of getting back in touch. Not of going back. Certainly not to a sweet Mother Earth, balm for all our matrophobias (though she has those vernal moments). We might instead engage the complex open system of systems, poised at the edge of chaos, that is the subject of the ecological Gaia hypothesis.

Really then: what practical value could any teaching of a *docta ignorantia* have in the face of climate destabilization, *when ignorance—an ignorance strategically produced—is after all the problem*? What matters here at least, and now, are surely the facts and systems of facts. They keep materializing: the predictions fulfilled, the tipping points in evidence, the solemn series of melting glaciers, deepening droughts, widening deserts, intensifying floods, raging fires, toxification of the

seas, and mounting parts per million of CO₂. But all this climate change *in flagrante* does not bridge the gap of the denial. Surely the earth in its present condition is needing to be *known*.

I will argue that the relative certainty of the climate science at this point is precisely *why* an apophatic ecotheology is needed: not to undermine the known facts and trustworthy predictions but, in *fact*, to reinforce them. To make a complex conscious is not to relieve complexity of its opacities. The entanglement of the human in the crowding nonhumanity of the species and elements of the earth will endlessly overwhelm speech—with wonder or horror. But alongside this excess of relation, there remains also the question of the certainty of *scientific knowledge*. Among climate scientists there is now consensus (at least 97 percent) that climate change is real, that it is in part anthropogenic, and that we must respond to the dangers of a warming planet. Consensus, however, does not mean simple certainty; it remains necessarily larded with different assessments of the implications of the increasing temperature and how to address it. The earth is a complex system, fraught with known and unknown unpredictabilities. But we will see that this irreducible uncertainty has been fueling climate change denial. Entanglement materializes here, it demands explication, in its double nuance—that of uncertainty and of nonseparability.

An apophatically canny ecotheology may, in other words, prove to be a useful ally of an activist cosmopolitics informed by environmental science. For it invites us to embrace, even to *feel*, the adaptive resilience of the planetary web of a living interconnectivity. It may intensify our awareness not only of our own implication in the planetary degradation but in its possibility: in that “eligibility” of the earth we heard Walt Whitman invoke. Or is that amorous nuance of *posse ipsum*—of what we yet *can do*—coming undone along with the vulnerable populations, human and not human, of the planet? There have been more interhumanly violent epochs than ours.² What we call civilization has produced more bellicose conflagrations than this imperceptible warming of the troposphere. But none has compromised the material conditions of all future human unfolding.

Has human civilization faced a more clouded atmosphere of the impossible than this—where it is still *possible* to avert unspeakable disaster, yet improbable that we will?

GALATIAN TERROR

Pergamon is just one narrative entry point to a global story. Its altar might orient us thus: Athena's Greeks brought the polis East, while from the West Rome pressed harder and simultaneously North, into a later Europe that crusaded East again, then exploded to the South in a modernity shooting transatlantically West toward Columbus's pseudo-East. Such a tale of Eurocentrism remains Eurocentric itself if we fail to note that there are other stories, ruptures, religions, empires unfolding simultaneously, with variant relations to the earth. The broken touch invites a therapeutic exercise for a peculiarly but not exclusively Western Gaia complex. By way of modern colonizations, the European empires fold eventually into the planetary neoimperialisms and postcolonialisms of late capital. And that global economy does not exhibit its entanglements, it uses them. It turns earth into globe. "The globe is in our computers. No one lives there. It allows us to think that we can aim to control it."³ The globe itself then may be said to work as what Bruno Latour calls a "smooth" rather than a "tangled object."⁴

The marble of Pergamon is not so smooth. It still glories in the struggle. The frieze is one great aesthetic display of the tangled bodies of the war. It revels in its antagonism, but does not, like later empires, deprive its enemies and its earth of iconic dignity. It makes its victory visible to a presumed long-term future. Quite unexpectedly, I learned more of the layered history of the Pergamon Altar—including its *ecological* relevance—from, of all things, a recent commentary on Paul's Epistle to . . . the *Galatians*. Brigitte Kahl follows the tracks of those Galatians to whom Paul wrote in the first century ce, residents of the Roman province of Galatia in Asia Minor, all the way back to their direct ancestors—none other than the defeated Galatians of the Pergamon frieze. At the time of Paul they still carried the onus of "a particularly hostile race who, after five centuries of godless and irrational onslaughts against the sacred shrines and foundations of Greco-Roman civilization, had at last been subdued and assigned their place within the god-willed system of worldwide Roman rule."⁵ These Eastern Galatians were actually *Celtic* migrants from Northern Europe.

Roman authors frequently use the Latin term *terror* with reference to Galatians and the other Celts, the Gauls, with whom they confused them. Julius Cae-

sar's Gallic war was "part of an ongoing, multistage Greco-Roman campaign against a Galatian 'global terrorism.'" ⁶ The global claim of Roman power required, argues Kahl, "the construction of a worldwide terrorist enemy": the *metus Gallicus*. ⁷ Here is a venerable antecedent of the political theology of Schmitt's friend/foe distinction. Kahl makes audible a timely resonance: "as we have now entered into a new era of worldwide crusading against *terror*, these historical precedents are chilling reminders of an unresolved past." ⁸ The Pergamon story thus anticipates religiously colored struggles that will emanate later from the same vicinity. Pergamon is in present-day Turkey, at the site that would be overlaid by the Roman, the Byzantine, and finally the Ottoman Empires. How odd: at the source of a later *Islamophobia* one picks up the trace of an unresolved *Celtophobia*. ⁹ The scary pallor of these primal barbarians with their blond dreadlocks (their yellow hair was made even whiter and coarser, fiercer, according to ancient accounts, by being treated like "horses manes") exposes our civilization's versatile racialization of enmity.

Here Kahl, who had taught in Berlin, describes the very panel of the great frieze that grabbed my attention: "Holding to her doomed child with the deadly wound between his ribs, the earth goddess appears as an ancient Pietà." Gaia embodies a wrenching grief. "Gaia is the only deity of the whole Pergamene pantheon," writes Kahl, "who displays the vulnerability of love. None of the fighting gods and goddesses above, frozen forever and inescapably trapped in their own confrontation with the deadly enemy-other, can show mercy to Gaia. For the battle of civilization must go on." ¹⁰ And so it has. A yet older civilizational matriphobia repeats itself, performed here by the iconic daddy's girl Athena, she who was born not from the rib but the head of the male. ¹¹ With consummate skill the sculptor captured the "petrified hopelessness that ties both winners and losers together." ¹²

Again, the shadow side of an unacknowledged entanglement?

Kahl reads Paul's Galatians, with its critique of the "works of the law," normally presumed to mean the Jewish Torah, as more of a challenge to the sacred law of *Roman* rule. In this she syncs with Jewish and secular political theologies of the messianism of the new "radical Paul." ¹³ But she adds yet another twist. She interprets Paul's theology as not only "empire-critical" but messianically gifted with "a profoundly ecological dimension." Thus she effectively distances it from the history of its interpretation as an anti-Jewish, anti-physical, anti-terrestrial mis-

sive.¹⁴ When Paul transmits the moans of creation in the birth pangs of a new creation, we may hear new valences: his Galatians live in the aftermath of an assault on the womb of their world. They aren't the only ones. Reading "with the eyes of the vanquished," Kahl's hermeneutics counters at its source the anti-ecological Christianity so key to the propaganda machine of current climate ignorance—namely, the Christianity, ever dominated by the familiar, supercessionist and flesh-despising Paul, that keeps the "evangelical-capitalist resonance machine" religiously oiled.



Woe, woe, woe to the inhabitants of the Earth.

—REVELATION 8:13

"It is time to wake up and realize that Gaia is no cozy mother that nurtures humans and can be propitiated by gestures such as carbon trading or sustainable development. Gaia, even though we are a part of her, will always dictate the terms of peace." A new story of Gaia is being narrated in our epoch. Not a heroic struggle of the progress of Civilization versus Nature and her barbaric holdouts, but also not a story of timely return to the waiting arms of Mother Earth. In *The Vanishing Face of Gaia: A Final Reflection*, James Lovelock refers to the most famous of all photographs, the image of the earth snapped from outer space in 1972. In the meantime something has gone wrong with Gaia's face: "That icon is undergoing subtle changes as the white ice fades away, the green of forest and grassland fades into the dun of desert, and the oceans lose their blue-green hue and turn a purer, swimming-pool blue as they, too, become desert."¹⁵ Along with the biologist Lynn Margulis, the chemist Lovelock had formulated the Gaia hypothesis thirty years earlier. He thanks his neighbor, the poet William Golding, for having suggested the metaphor of Gaia as an alternative to his own less catchy nomenclature: "a universal biocybernetic system with the tendency to homeostasis." Gaia names "the living planet that we inhabit and are a part of."¹⁶ It models the earth not as a ball of rock upon which the complex systems of life happen, but rather as itself a complex system, enfolding in its process all the interdependent agencies, including us, who together compose the planet and its atmosphere. If the theory was at

first shunned by the science establishment, it appears ever less controversial in the light not only of anthropogenic climate change but of the science of emergence, which “treats the biosphere as a series of systems within systems within systems.”¹⁷ Folds within folds.

With the prophetic scientists and activists, like Bill McKibben, Vandana Shiva, and Jim Hansen, who began to ply their warnings back when “the planet as we know it” might have been saved, the tone has shifted. It is getting late. Time to wake up. Not the end of time. There is still—time. Even according to the author of the *Apocalypse*. “Wake up, and strengthen what is at the point of death.”¹⁸ What is at the point of death is not the earth, is not the world—but *our* world, the planet of the ten-thousand-year stability, held within a single degree centigrade average planetary temperature fluctuation annually, of what McKibben calls the “sweet zone” where civilization evolved. The ninety-year-old Lovelock echoes the apocalypse with British irony: “like that once-heard cry of pub landlords, ‘Last orders. Time, gentlemen, please!’”¹⁹ “What people mean by the plea to save the earth,” writes Lovelock, is “save the planet as we know it,’ and that is now impossible.”²⁰

The series of monumental climate events keeps unfolding. As a transient example, the draft United Nations report of the IPCC announced a couple of weeks ago that “another 15 years of failure to cut heat-trapping emissions would make the problem virtually impossible to solve with known technologies and thus impose enormous costs on future generations.”²¹ Yet this impending impossibility was a mere blip on the *New York Times* Web site. The Gaia complex has formidable soporific force.

Lovelock captures the perplexity of our civilizational stupor with another rousing image. It is, he says, as though an alarm clock were sounding as we sleep. “I fear that we still dream on and, rather than waking, we weave the sound of the alarm clock into our dreams.”²² Even those who accept the science can hardly hold it in daily consciousness. We tuck its alarming scenarios into the category of “the future” and therefore of the unpredictable, just beyond the realm of immediate consequence. We quietly hope the apocalypse is propagandistically overstated. Do the occasional doses of information then serve as inoculation? This is no innocent ignorance, this collective dream state. The alarm has been sounding since the 1970s; scientific consensus had been reached by the second decade of the twenty-first century; the stupor persists. But others than the author of the

Gaia hypothesis will have trustier insight into the political economy, the technological feasibilities and the counter-apocalyptic rhetorics appropriate to the shift at hand.²³

If the political unconscious is maintained by ruse, one example is well narrated by Jim Hansen, the world's premier climatologist. He tells of his earnest testimonies before government panels about how "the world in which civilization developed, the world with climate patterns that we know and stable shorelines, is in imminent peril."²⁴ Then he realized that what was happening was "government greenwash": the expression of "concern about global warming and the environment while taking no actions to actually stabilize climate or preserve the environment."²⁵ Greenwashing names a ruse, itself not unconscious, for tucking the alarm down into the dream. Out of touch. Hansen turned into a multiply arrested activist.

More forthright strategies have in the interim succeeded in neutralizing the alarm. Thus Senator James Inhofe's *The Greatest Hoax: How the Global Warming Conspiracy Threatens Your Future* manages an impressive reversal.²⁶ It is not the collusion of carbon-based corporate capitalism with the political right and dominion Christians exposed as conspiracy, but atheist scientists and leftists. The political unconscious, Jameson notes, operates by "grisly and ironic reversals."²⁷ Investigative researchers are exposing the highly funded cabal of corporate, political, and media power, with a handful of rogue scientists, that disseminates this disinformation. It would count as a prime instance of "agnotology," the deliberate production of ignorance—as such, the ultimate foil for the docta ignorantia. Let us consider further this question of the relation of climate uncertainty to the eco-unconsciousness.

Naomi Oreskes' and Erik Conway's *Merchants of Doubt* exposes the relation between a prior case of obscured truth, that of the medical effects of tobacco smoke, to global warming. Indeed some of the same strategists have been involved.²⁸ Oreskes and Conway offer an important illustration of the present fold of apophatic entanglement. The merchandising of doubt has only been able to work so well "because we have an erroneous view of science. We think that science provides certainty, so if we lack certainty, we think the science must be faulty or incomplete."²⁹ They offer a parable: it is as though a giant banquet has been going on for 150 years—and suddenly someone in a white jacket comes to present the

bill. But in pursuing the dream of progress and prosperity, we didn't realize there would be a bill. And when there is uncertainty in the tally, it is quite normal, according to decision theory, to defer action. Why give up definite benefits now for uncertain future gains?

There are of course multiple layers of uncertainty in climate science. We know of no more complex system than that composed of the intra-activity of the earth, its elements, and its inhabitants. So the fact that science has reached consensus does not at all eliminate the uncertainty of processes that are calculated through probabilities, tested with empirical evidence, and negotiated through collective debate and refinement. Oreskes and Conway note that the popularly held prejudice that science provides certainty is an old one, but one "most clearly articulated by the late-nineteenth-century positivists, who held out a dream of 'positive' knowledge—in the familiar sense of absolutely, positively true."³⁰ Misinformation as to the character of science itself thus enables misinformation about the climate and about climatology. What Bruno Latour has dubbed "factishes," the product of the fetishism of factual certainty, have survived postmodern revolutions in the sciences of complexity as well as quantum physics. But the smooth objects of the positivist legacy serve the marketable technologies—and every economy of deanimated, commodifiable matter.

So perhaps it should not surprise us that neoliberal capitalism has successfully fused a scientific, high-tech positivism with its polar opposite—the antiscientific religious positivism of the Christian right. In cloud perspective the theological negation of every form of Christian positivism here enters another register. For the ecophobia of this residual positivism, carrying an ethos of conquest, control, commodification, runs deeper than modernity. If, in chapter 4, we considered the resonance of an old Christian apophysis with the entangled relationalism of the quantum universe, might we now apply the negative theological corrective to the religio-economic-scientific positivism? For there is now growing recognition of the implication of a cosmological relationalism for any viable planetarity. But this ecorelationalism will only sustain credibility if also allowed its cloudy nuance. This means—*de docta ignorantia*—remaining mindful of the layers of the uncertainty of climate science and the indeterminacy of the climate. And it means minding the crowded intersections of all our issues, class and race and sex and gender, in the social ecology of our planetary entanglement. The affirmation of

the interdependent life of Gaia is predicated upon a negation of triumphal positivisms: only complexity can replace the complex. The failed and flailing positivism of Western civilization will not be answered simply by louder facts and louder alarms, which only provoke deeper defenses. Without recourse to some practice of mindful unknowing, the unknowability of our future—intricately ensnared in what we *can* know—locks into the impossible.

If uncertainty as to the human future tangles inextricably into the calculabilities of climate science, here is a fact (an *apophact*?) for the cloud of the impossible: “Climate feedbacks are the central source of scientific (as opposed to socioeconomic) uncertainty in climate projections. *The dominant source of uncertainty are cloud feedbacks, which are incompletely understood.*”³¹ Clouds exercise both warming and cooling effects—and which will dominate, “despite decades of improvements in computer models of Earth’s climate,” remains the great Gaian question. The apophatic cloud has gone literal on us.³²



We’re running Genesis backwards, decreating.

—BILL MCKIBBEN, *EARTH*

It took me several weeks to make myself open Bill McKibben’s *Eaarth: Making a Life on a Tough New Planet*. It was the pivotal text of a planetary transition. The unpronounceable second *a* in the planet’s name spells the difference. He was not, though he could have been, playing off the unpronounceable misspelling of *différance*. With the silent *a* McKibben signifies the unspeakable that yet must be said: “The earth that we knew—the only earth that we ever knew—is gone.”³³ This is a new apophysis: the unsaying of the known Earth.

This cloud must be entered if we are to get through it. These authors are not doomsayers. McKibben, for instance, sturdily persists through this transition in sketching out scenes of possibility, of life meaningfully, communally, agriculturally, locally adapted to the tough new planet. We can collectively, we can still, as I write, stop running Genesis backwards: woe, woe, whoah!

The transition that we find ourselves within, from which there seems to be no return, is ceremoniously referred to as the shift of focus *from mitigation to adap-*

tation. This shift is a matter of degree, not of an apocalyptic absolute. Indeed it is a matter of keeping the warming to 2 degrees C. Otherwise the whole system lurches toward the 6 degrees centigrade of change that threatens by the end of the century to undo the sixth day of Genesis. (That would indeed approximate the apocalypse: accompanied by the deterioration of food sources and a relentless Malthus curve of population growth, it seems to assure our species' collapse.) But we can adapt to the degree or two of shift. Mark Lynas, in *Six Degrees*, frames the transition in terms of the notion, gaining wider currency now, of the anthropocene: "The Holocene—the 10,000-year, climatically equable post-ice age era during which human civilization evolved and flourished—has slipped into history, to make way for the Anthropocene. For the first time since life began, a single animal is utterly dominant: the ape species *Homo sapiens*."³⁴ Our dominance—shades of Pergamon—has so far followed a pattern of aggressive colonization. Not that it has to.

Lynas in *The God Species* argues that we *can* use our forceful resourcefulness to make the shift from competition to responsibility. He does not mean his titular "God" theologically. Yet the very trope of a "God species" reinscribes the *imago dei*. It supports ecotheological revisions of the ancient Genesis "dominion," which in its context does not license anything like the present extinction spasm. The species now being exterminated by human dominance are what count there as "good." And what is divinely pronounced "very good" is not the human, we recall, but "everything." But the agnotological interpretation of Genesis continues to dominate. Similarly, the anthropocene signifies the destructive dominance of our artful species—and at the same time the *possibility*, which is to say the *adaptability*, with the same talent, to ply a planetary convivencia.

Adaptation, in the meantime, is forcing changes we do not want to think about. Adaptation signifies "the new geography of violence" unleashed by climate change. It involves both a technical and a political challenge, according to Christian Parenti. The technical adaptation means "*transforming our relation to nature* as nature transforms: learning to live with the damage we have wrought by building seawalls around vulnerable coastal cities, giving land back to mangroves and everglades so they can act to break tidal surges during giant storms, opening wildlife migration corridors so species can move north as the climate warms,"³⁵ and so forth. That is the cosmic fold of the cosmopolitical. The other is that of *political*

adaptation, which “means transforming humanity’s relationship to itself.” This requires new strategies of “containing, avoiding and deescalating the violence that climate change fuels.” His *Tropic of Chaos* shows, for example, that, across the planet, “extreme weather and water scarcity now inflame and escalate existing social conflicts.”³⁶ Competition over increasingly scarce resources of water and arable land for stressed and growing populations is rapidly intensifying, especially in the “tropic of chaos, that violent and impoverished swathe of terrain around the mid-latitudes of the planet.” What is normally reported as political, tribal, drug, or religious violence is enmeshed in what he calls a “catastrophic convergence” with climate change. For instance, violence attributed to Muslim extremism in the Sudan turns out to be motivated primarily (this would not surprise Cavanaugh) by desperation about dwindling water sources and arability. A Swedish government study analyzes forty-six countries verging on extreme violence based on climate change.

Adaptation is possible, through multiplication of experiments in local agriculture and cooperation—and of course through global economic redistribution and peace-making diplomacies working in tandem with ecological resilience. But so far another form of political adaptation is underway. Parenti calls it “the politics of the armed lifeboat: responding to climate change by arming, excluding, forgetting, repressing, policing, and killing.”³⁷ Picture Noah’s ark fitted with military drones, Athena at the prow. Yet the age of new millions—pardon, hundreds of millions—of climate migrants has barely begun. As they flee the rising seas—the flooding overpopulated coastlines of much of southeast Asia—where will they find hospitality? In *Soil Not Oil: Environmental Justice in an Age of Climate Crisis* Vandana Shiva emphasizes the exorbitant disproportion of social costs for the world’s poor of planetary changes caused by overconsumption of the wealthy.

When such stressed populations fight for their lives and homes, or when they migrate, seeking a life cut off from their own piece of earth—are they not again marked as the barbarians, the faceless hordes, enemies of civilization, dirty children of Gaia? So we see our diverse issues of justice tangling in the social ecology of the earth. Theological ethicist Cynthia Moe-Lobeda captures this cost not only in terms of class but of the “race debt of climate change.”³⁸ And of course those of us involved in the practice of any shade of theology are scrambling to adapt our own discourse: to find language that awakens our constituencies. Language that

opens the Gaia complex out of its phobia and into the planetary complexity will also, as we now will read it, foster an emergent theology of interreligious complexity, a comparative eco-theology.



*The Gaia Theory ends the anthropocentrism of the modern world and
opens the way to a democratic incorporation of the human species
in the whole life [Gesamtleben] of the earth system.*

—JÜRGEN MOLTSMANN, A COMMON RELIGION OF THE EARTH

In a lecture first delivered in Beijing, Jürgen Moltmann concludes that until now the so-called world religions have seen the human world as the universal space for their relevance and expansion.³⁹ But if that human world lives and survives only within the “nature of the earth,” he argues, then “*Gaia becomes the universal space for the world religions.*”⁴⁰ This is unexpected language for a theology that has remained faithfully Protestant, indeed Pauline. He has long tied theology to ecosocial justice. Now he allies himself with the Gaia hypothesis. He pronounces it the beginning of the “democratic incorporation of the human species in the whole life of the earth system.”

Fortunately for the hypothesis of an apophatically entangled planet, Moltmann had drawn upon the Gaia hypothesis in an earlier essay on Giordano Bruno. He lifts up Bruno’s vision of an earth organically integrated within an infinite cosmos. Recall also Bruno’s amplification of Cusa’s cosmology of the infinite universe, his development of the trinity of complication, explication, implication. In the interest of better conversation between theology and science, Moltmann repents on behalf of the church for its hereticization and martyrdom of this Renaissance monk. He insists that Bruno’s mystical cosmology, routinely dismissed as pantheism, be respectfully reread as panentheism, not for the sake of process theology but for an environmentally jeopardized but still democratically inviting Gaia.

Moltmann elaborates: “The so-called great world religions will only prove themselves to be ‘world religions,’ when they become *earth religions* and understand humanity as an integrated part of the planet earth.”⁴¹ Christianity, Judaism, Islam, Hinduism, Buddhism—*earth* religions? Such an admonition challenges

each of these universalizing traditions, each differently, to the core. He is calling for a new earth-human relation as inseparable from a new relation between religions. “When the missionary ‘historical religions’ reach the ends of the earth, they will have to transform themselves into *universal earth religions*. For this, the forgotten ecological wisdom and natural reverence of *local nature religions* will become important again.”⁴²

Christianity *has* reached the ends of the earth. Along the way its nomadic missions warped into crusades and colonizations, its ends into the End of the world. But in its pericope, the Great Commission—to preach this message “unto the ends of the earth” (MK 16:15)—was neither a warrant for violence nor a prediction of apocalypse. Moltmann stirs the hope that a goodly crowd of Christians might undergo this transformation. For them dialogue with other “world religions” might already seem proper, but to become an *earth* religion, like some indigenous or tribal tradition? Impossible. Where Christianity however has undergone such a transformation as Moltmann urges, where it “goes native,” the conversionist pretext of empire dissipates. Marion Grau has shown this beautifully in *Rethinking Mission in the Postcolony*. “Only then do we have cause for cautious hope in the hard, slow work of salvific subversion as grace-filled, entangled reciprocity with the Divine in the earth, cultures, others, selves.”⁴³ Through such work the local “earth religions” can come to voice as fresh forces of cosmopolitical decolonization, beyond tribal self-protection or new age commodification. And mission then yields to coalitions of local groups forming nonlocal ensembles, such as the First Nations Environmental Network or Vandana Shiva’s Earth University.⁴⁴

Indeed Moltmann’s planetary commission bears resemblance to Vandana Shiva’s call for an “earth democracy” grounded in indigenous practices. While the Hinduism of her primary context remains as far removed from a local earth wisdom as the other world religions, she has carefully intensified its tribal and forest background in her activism. In founding the Earth University, she invoked the spirit of Gandhi along with Rabindranath Tagore—who, she writes, “quotes from the ancient texts written in the forest: ‘Know all that moves in this moving world as enveloped by God; and find enjoyment through renunciation, not through greed of possession.’ No species in a forest appropriates the share of another spe-

cies. Every species sustains itself in cooperation with others.”⁴⁵ What ancient Celt would disagree?

In the last chapter we contemplated the cosmopolitics of a mindful inter-religious entanglement. If Gaia now with Moltmann becomes the “space for the encounter and cooperation [*Zusammenarbeit*] of the world religions”—the old world religions will need to outgrow their otherworldly and unearthly emphases and “convert to the earth.” “In this way local wisdoms can be transmitted across the postindustrial world.”⁴⁶ Three decades earlier, Rosemary Radford Ruether had called for the “conversion to the earth.”⁴⁷ Perhaps its time is coming. In *God and Gaia* the call to “an ecofeminist theocosmology” of Gaia is of course not a call *away* from any religion but *to* the practice of planetarily sustainable justice.⁴⁸ Ruether has never ceased, simultaneously, to bring theology into interreligious conversation. The explicit relationalism of feminist theology in Christianity and Judaism has from the start lent itself to religious multiplicity, with naturally special interest in less andromorphic traditions in which goddesses still figure. Ruether’s partners have often been women embodying multiply jeopardized populations within traditional as well as so-called world religions.⁴⁹ Those local wisdoms have of course been badly tattered by colonizations, conversions, commodifications. Like Gaia.

Speaking theologically, Gaia, as Ruether made clear, is not at odds with and also not the same as “the biblical God.” But, as I repeat this, don’t I seem to enshrine the transcendent He-God again above and beyond a She-Body? Don’t I subordinate an old earth wisdom to the universalism that deemed it merely pagan? The cloud may help. If “God” is a nickname for an infinity of which there are—by the Pseudo-Dionysius’s count—innumerable creaturely names, why wouldn’t that of a supreme creature such as a living planet be a most worthy name? Of course the earth would remain a tiny, if perhaps particularly evolved, organ in a boundless body of God. But how on earth is the earth itself, Gaia, inclusive of all of us, a less apt God-name than the name of a mere bit of the earth, like a “father” or a “king”? Gaia would be one noble nickname, old and new, for our participation, all together, in the Infinite Entanglement.

Analogously, note that the *femininity* of Gaia is not in any of its serious ecotheological appearances reified, let alone divinized. But neither is it

underestimated. Thus another ecofeminist, the Irish theologian Anna Primavesi, has written voluminously, luminously, in the name of Gaia, including *Gaia and Climate Change*, *Gaia's Gift*, in direct dialogue with Lovelock (and indirect, vis a vis the gift, with Derrida).⁵⁰ If the ecofeminist Gaia stirs among other feminists anxiety about the maternalization or naturalization of women, such a misreading of the model of planetary homeostasis may itself be treated as a symptom of the Gaia complex. Civilizational ecophobia remains almost indistinguishable from the formative gynophobias. Let me venture the twisted thought that this entanglement is itself cause for green hope. For if we admit that there is some systemic justice along the way, much certainly has shown itself in the rapid undoing of millennia of gender/sex arrangements. Gender—and now sex—are so tangled in our queerly eligible Earth that in resonance with an interreligious planetarity their vibrant movements may do much to stir up a sustainable future.

Our economic arrangements may undermine that hope. Class difference has during these same few decades grown precipitously, right along with greenhouse gas emissions. The ruses of free trade, greenwashing, and all the profitable market solutions to climate and to poverty fuel the corporate carbon juggernaut. Of course one is tempted to swat away *the possible* because it is not *the probable* and relieve oneself of the vulnerability of hope. But then don't we just bow to the Olympians of late capitalism? Finally, the separation of the over-resourced few from the vulnerable rest of us cannot hold. Adrian Parr, tracking the "wrath of capital," succinctly articulates the threshold: "We are poised between needing to radically transform how we live and becoming extinct."⁵¹ That radical transformation remains in this time of transition—to put a counterapocalyptic spin on it—maddeningly *possible*.



He was not crazy; he had never been crazy. He had only seen and heard the world as it always was: no boundaries, only transitions through all distances and time.

—LESLIE MARION SILKO, CEREMONY

If Gaia is to be faced rather than feared, it is fortunate that Gaia, the theory, is taking hold. Not just in theology. Bruno Latour, the leading continental philosopher

of science, has in his recent Gifford lectures given its credibility a great transdisciplinary boost. He finds in a “multiplicity of engagements, of strategic assemblies of humans and nonhumans,” the only way “to cope with what the multiple loops traced by the instruments of science reveal of *the narrative complexity and entanglement of Gaia*.” The narrative complexity may offer the only cure for the complex. Latour seeks a political theology after religion: it is “by facing Gaia, that wholly secularized and earthbound set of processes, that there is a dim possibility that we could ‘let the Spirit renew the Face of the Earth.’”⁵² The possibility can seem dim indeed. The desert spreads. But when were the prospects for that renewing Spirit ever more than im/possible? Nonetheless, spirited new solidarities of the secular with a religiously earthbound multiplicity and, at the same time, of humans with nonhumans seem to be forming.

And so, in the interests of that narrative complexity and entanglement of Gaia, let us end in another story, far from Pergamon or Galatia. Tayo is the half Laguna, half white protagonist of Leslie Marmon Silko’s classic novel *Ceremony*. It channels voices of one of those old earth wisdoms, finding utterance after all the wars, all the colonizations. Psychically shattered by service in the Pacific theater of World War II, Tayo has finally found ritual healing in the kiva. Or rather he realizes he hadn’t been crazy. He just hadn’t learned to repress the dizzying, demanding reciprocities of the world. His grandfather is guiding him. “But you know, grandson, this world is fragile.”⁵³ The word chosen to express “fragile” “was filled with the intricacies of a continuing process, and with it a strength inherent in spider webs woven across paths through sand hills where early in the morning the sun becomes *entangled in each filament of web*.”⁵⁴ Did Silko know of the quantum entanglement of photons through “all distances and times”? No matter. With visionary precision the novel brings to light a primordial icon of planetary entanglement: the web. It shimmers through any mobilization of our constitutive relationality. The resilience of the web suggests the *posse* of the adaptive potentiality, the cloud power of active reciprocity, that we may together yet learn to actualize.⁵⁵ Thought Woman in her manifestation as Spider had appeared early in the novel: more apt names for the Complicatio. If the web of the life of the planet is coming undone as surely as was Tayo’s psyche—we know and say this, we unknow and unsay this. And we are not crazy to grieve and fear the losses. Insanity lies in our collective denial. The work of healing will keep us close to the indeterminacy

of all transitions. There precipitates in that sensitive uncertainty the great crowd of earth relations. They fold in degrees of the knowable into a kataphatically ecological theology, apophatically boundless and emphatically earthbound.

Speaking of narrative complexity: what if within the contemplative space of the cloud the hybrid vet Tayo—back in touch—brings to life the petrified Celt of Pergamon? Might Pallas Athena, at last listening to her companionable owl, conspire like a good feminist with the barbarians for a democracy yet to come—a *demos* of fellow creatures?⁵⁶ Might the fierce Galatians and their cosmopolitan Paul join us in a demonstrative Gaian entanglement—in this space of no boundaries, only transitions? Crazy?

ten

IN QUESTIONABLE LOVE

To make myself understood and to diminish the distance between us, I called out: "I am an evening cloud too." They stopped still, evidently taking a good look at me. Then they stretched towards me their fine, transparent, rosy wings. That is how evening clouds greet each other. They had recognized me.

—RAINER MARIA RILKE, STORIES OF GOD

Knowledge will come to an end; love never ends.

—PAUL'S LETTER TO THE CORINTHIANS, 13:8

APOPHATIC ENTANGLEMENT. If it is the answer, just what was the question? It may be time to restate it, at this late point within a discourse that will already have undone its chance for a final answer. We hope instead for *answerability*: the ability to answer *to* an other, to answer *for* oneself, to respond. Across the registers of entanglement so far considered, response is an ability calibrated to the nonknow-ability clouding its relations. But then won't the question already, with quantum alacrity, have been responding to its possible answer? The answer, if it keeps faith with the indeterminacy by which there is answerability at all, will accordingly keep itself *questionable*—*able to be questioned*.

The particular question of apophatically entangled difference that wants answering here, after all the self-implicating complications of this cloud, may now

put itself more simply (recalling that even *simplicity* comes folded). *How shall we greet the unknown before us?* Not now the unknown or the uncertain in general, not the hazy crowd of all relations—but that which breaks from it to confront me, face me. It calls for my response, my recognition. Evening cloud or calamity, it appears, existentially speaking, as some particular face or ensemble of relation, some specific contraction of cosmos, presenting itself to me, smudging familiarity with nonknowing. It may appear in random unpredictability or alluring enigma, in anxious indecision or unspeakable horror. But it only matters, calls or questions me, because I am somehow *implicated*.

The unknown that is before me: the reader of this sentence, the friend breaking into tears, the viability of theology. The homeless face beseeching. The news flash infuriating. Or the immediate future of Gaia facing us all. Before we are called out again by any possible apocalypse, however, let us take note of the odd grammar of the “unknown before us.” There is something peculiar in the preposition *before*. What comes before me signifies, after all, what has happened *already*, in the past of my present. This is the character of re-cognition: what is before me becomes knowable only by its repetition of a past. “They had recognized me.” Yet that which is *before* me is precisely that which is *ahead* of me, in the still unpredictable future of this present.

The unknown before me—how does it at once come *in advance* and *after* me? It “goes before” me; column of fire or cloud, I follow it. It precedes me like the dark precursor into the future. It is a virtual future, potential, indeterminate as to the actual outcome. Does the alpha before us in the past thus coincide with the omega before us in the future? If so—the clothesline of a temporality strung straight between the poles collapses. But coincidentia was never identity. Time itself does not fold down, nor do the differences of its tenses. In the multiple rhythms, speeds and series of becoming, time appears not straight but spiraling, surging, and breaking in waves. Is there superposed here the quantum space-time in which the observed already *answers* to the observer? Which comes *before* which at the immeasurable speed, if it is a speed, of entangled influences? What appears before us, in such a co-incident of an alpha and an omega?

The unknown before me precedes me *in possibility*. It implicates itself in me and me in it, intra-actively. And it yet fails on principle to determine what I become here and now. If we note here a certain co-incident of the before with its af-

ter, however, are we not once again simulating a timeless symmetry rather than an event of becoming? The antique visions of changeless eternity, Parmenides' Goddess of the Eternal Present or the Advaita Brahman, exposed as illusion, *maya*, any time line of things running separately through the hoops of three tenses. But they also then canceled the reality of multiple becomings. If our nonseparable materializations will *not* melt away as illusion, we find their time neither dissolving into digits nor straightening into the line, but emerging in the *spacing* and the doubling of the fold.¹ Space-time is the field composed of the relations between becoming events. We considered a triple fold in which the affect-charged repetition of the past in the present provokes novel possible futures.

So the alpha and the omega, in this co-incident, fold not into providential pre-determination but nonseparable difference. "I am the Alpha and the Omega"—but not necessarily the Origin and the End. And it is that difference which comes before us at any moment—familiar or strange, soft or monstrous, the Other, the Others, the Hyperobject.² It mirrors us back to ourselves enigmatically. It calls to us in the interplay of question and answer. And it selectively contracts a cosmos in which I am already enfolded. The relations in which it implicates me may be toxic. Or they may be antidote. They crowd dangerously, in any event, and in a new sense, bluntly and literally, into the macro-event of the anthropocene.

How to *greet* the unknown before us? That question perhaps transliterates for us here a prior question: what is the fold between our nonknowing and our nonseparability? For the "before" marks what enters into the space-time of perceptible relation, without forfeiting, as it enters, its dark nuance. That relationality remains in itself vastly amoral, that is, ontological: relations are neutral, good, ill, ambiguous. But *mindfulness* of our own entanglement, I have argued, forfeits moral neutrality. It implicates itself: it folds itself into its own plurisignularity, into a knowing-together that structures greater complexity and stabilizes wider cooperation. In other words, it stimulates responsive participation in entangled difference. For when the space-time of mutual entrainment is minded its subjects know themselves answerable no matter what. For they take part in one another across any space-time.

Such an altered subject we might say performs *the self-implication of relation: that is, it knowingly folds multiplicity beyond knowing into a knowing-together*. That con-sciousness knows itself hopelessly limited and, by the same token, gruesomely

wide. It questions any fixed limit to the width of a possible conviviality. Beyond kin and ken, these relations.

The ethical implications become *explicit—unfolded mindfully*—in concrete events of particular self-*implication*. Implicating yourself in the others before you, your difference ceases (as in process theology God has ceased) to be the exception. You become exemplification. You *mind* your implication in all the ethically questionable systemic powers. You ply collective resonances with more affect and more effect, energizing the ripples, the fractals. You are not just you singular; you are not just you plural; you are plurisingularly you. Networks of resistance to the rules of planetary dominance gain strength; new collectives of transformation emerge across greater distances. The folds of past are unfolded and refolded in relation to the possibilities of future. This does not expunge any entanglement. But it *unsnarls the knots* that render entanglement a captivity and relationship a trap. It keeps self and other in question and so unfolding. Yet such questioning does not resemble criticism that dismisses, that cancels, that silences.

The negative theological gesture finds both its edge and its opening in questioning any name: “silent cry” (Dorothea Soelle) or “rebellious no” (Noelle Vahanian), *neti neti* or dark nuance.³ This is not, as we have seen, a perpetual skepsis machine, but an emancipation of mystery from mystification. So then the knowing self-implication of our *nonknowing* signifies *questionability*. What then, in the chiasm of apophatic entanglement, does *the self-implication of our nonseparable difference* yield? What is relation turned mindful of itself and therefore desirous, deliberate? What urges us into the mutual answerability—which is always also question-ability—of subjects? In other words, what lets us intentionally—and as should be clear by now not only humanly—enfold and be enfolded? Might enfolding then become embrace? In the face of all the complication, what makes possible, *posse ipsum*, the answerable embrace? Could it be that intensification of desire that is called “love”?

What a questionable notion. Love, just as wastefully overnamed as its most solemn metonym, God. But without it passion cuts free of compassion, respect goes limp, ethics for material space-times turns to timeless rule—and the world gets stuck. *Hesed, agape, caritas, eros*—that is all intensively and unsentimentally theological language, apophatic and kataphatic. And indelibly scriptural. Is this how we greet the unknown before us—in *questionable love*?

CHRISTOGRAPHICS OF THE CLOUD

AUGUSTINE

Time's stretch is ever in danger of becoming a grasping, a futile attempt to hold onto what was or will be. Eternity's reach is not a grasping but an opening, an opening to the depth of the moment. Eternity is harbored within the flux of temporality, then, even as God is secreted within the abyssal capacity of bodies to smell, taste, feel, hear, see—finally to love—the abyssal beauty of bodies.⁴

—BURRUS, JORDAN, AND MACKENDRICK, SEDUCING AUGUSTINE

In moments of enflamed love we can hardly miss the nonseparability of our difference. In fantasy or in flesh that other before me at once enfolds and eludes me. And in the unfolding of love, felt—so unquestionably—as the most vivid affect of a life, committing, full of hope and faith, we also learn its questionability. The uncertainties, fragilities, and betrayals that beset love are the stuff of every comedy, every tragedy. I do not need to elaborate. But on love I might. Is it the case that those loves live longer and stronger that have built into themselves the ability to *be* questioned? Then doubt—who is this before me, really, after all?—need not sink to despair. Then no discrete love need bear the full force of our desire. It can't. Love's indiscretion is boundless. Love, in other words, is never just a private affair. What movement of collective materialization—religious, political, ecological—has a chance if it fails to channel that passion, binding us to one another while stimulating our singular gifts? No other force is equal to the kin and ken of prior patterning.

In the West's great narrative of self-questioning, Aurelius Augustine implicates, with all their shades of indiscretion, his own past loves. "I dared to run wild in different darksome ways of love" (2.1.1). He wanted only "to love and be loved" (2.2.2). As in recollecting he collects himself in the Confessions in the name of one embracing love, one question above all guides his narrative: "What is it then that I love when I love you?"⁵

The negative answer seems clear: "Not bodily beauty, not the clear shining light, lovely as it is to our eyes, not the sweet melodies of many-moded songs . . . not limbs made for the body's embrace, not these" (10.6.8). Not finally any crea-

turely, temporal bodies—or souls. So are the authors of *Seducing Augustine* enticing us to a misreading? How would he sanction the abyssal love of bodies? Perhaps precisely through the ascetic reordering of love that interprets for him the love of the neighbor: “each man insofar as he is a man should be loved for the sake of God, and God for his own sake” (On Christian Teaching I.27.28).⁶ All the creatures may be loveable, but all the creaturely loves fail—unless the creatures are loved not for their own sake but for the sake of their source. We are to “love all things in God” (4.12.18).⁷ This too familiar injunction “conveys a perhaps still unappreciated proposal, namely, that by embracing ‘the friendship of mortal things’ both promiscuously and unpossessively, we are not bound but freed in love. Such a freeing love is, by definition, simultaneously love of creatures and love of that in which they transcend themselves, for indeed one can only love creatures ‘in God,’ just as one can only love God in the beauty of creation.”⁸ No creature is thereby unloved, but each is spared the onus of saving me—and I am spared the delusion that it might.

Any finite love, private or public, will capsize if it is made to bear the meaning of my life or the freight of the ultimate. And how quickly our fiery commitment to the particular other before us—person, community, institution, movement, planet—may then roar up into its impossibility and burn out. Alternatively, love may find the renewable energy of a sustainable relation: “Too late have I loved you, O Beauty so ancient and so new” (10.27.38).⁹ Its beginnings and endings reach beyond knowing. Such Beauty might relativize by mere subordination of the finite. Or by drawing all into relation in an alternate temporality. It surely knocks time out of line—“Too late have I loved you.” Better late than *ever*. Always before us, waiting all along. It twists space inside out, outside in: “you were within me, while I was outside” (10.27.8).¹⁰ Its Beauty—You—may relieve us of our amorous idolatries. Another strategy of passionate non-attachment? Tapping the supreme Love need not on the Augustinian model compete with the creaturely loves. The Christian tradition can be read, according to Kathryn Tanner (though she is stressing the contribution of Origen and Gregory of Nyssa) as the basis of a “noncompetitive economy.”¹¹ Questions however remain. For instance Augustine famously explains that “if we love somebody for his own sake, we enjoy him [*frui*]; if for the sake of something else we use [*uti*] him. But it seems to me that he should be loved

for the sake of something else” (On Christian Teaching, 1.22.20). That something in which “the happy life” is grounded. Ergo—and Hannah Arendt notes that “it is with some reluctance that he comes to the conclusion”—we must use the neighbor, not enjoy him or her.¹² But is this not to instrumentalize the creature? And so to risk—in a move warped into the later and cruder Christian conquests and commodifications, using and enjoying voraciously, indeed—making any body a means to Christian ends? “I never love my neighbor for his own sake, only for the sake of divine grace,” in Arendt’s paraphrase.¹³ And that grace is itself the instrument of “mere passage” to eternal life.

Surely in its biblical inscription another possibility had been signaled: when the listener is urged to “love God . . . and to “love the neighbor as yourself,” is the loving of God not a means to the love of the neighbor-creature—just as surely as, conversely, the love of the neighbor is a means to the love of God? To enfold each love in the infinity of love is one thing; to make it a *mere* means to an unquestionable End is another. If creatures become means alone, then it is not surprising that in the later Augustine a full-fledged and eternal hell could burn with a ferocity commensurate with the heavenly love. Oddly, Kant provided for a later ethics the needed corrective of this relational nuance of the Great Commandment: “So act that you use humanity, whether in your own person or that of any other, always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means.”¹⁴

Still, the inside-out Beauty of Augustine’s love teaching can turn his own triumphalist externality outside in. The interiority of “Augustine’s prayer closet,” writes Virginia Burrus, “does not appear at first glance to leave room for anyone else.” But his confession of the power of the world of relations to draw love so forcefully that it “turns to an acquisitive lust” may be what twists the space, the time, open again. “Augustine seeks to take lust around another turn, to convert it” at the very point “where earthly transience and heavenly eternity meet.”¹⁵

The ambiguity in which love entangles us is infinite. It may require an infinitude of love to free us. Whether the Augustinian love liberates us *for and within* rather than cleanly *from* the many relations, remains in the light of the eternal crowd of the City of God, possible; but also, in the light of the damned, indeed questionable.

“What do I love when I love my God?” (10.6.8) asks Augustine.¹⁶ And his answer does resound with a mindful unknowing of love itself: “I cannot measure so

as to know how much love may be wanting in me to that which is sufficient so that my life may run to your embrace, and not be turned away, until it be hidden in ‘the secret of your face’” (13.8.9).¹⁷



In a spirit closer to Origin’s salvation of the whole, and to the Cappadocian epektasis, with the soul in love journeying infinitely to the infinite, Christian eschatology was not incapable of keeping its love apophatically open. It may then question every love as it falls short of the infinite and therefore betrays the finite loves of its own creaturely entanglement. But these loves are not one, and neither are the betrayals. Entangle mindfully, the cloud translates; to each love a universe clings. Where will it end? There before us come all the endlessly unknowable creatures implicated in those few we do know directly—at least in part. Love picks up where knowing leaves off. I do not in Augustine know the scope of my own love. What—whom—do I love when I love You? You, who? Whom I may address without naming.

And how is this amorous nonseparability a *nonknowing of God*?

To answer this question (however questionably) we go back to what comes textually ever before theology. *Biblios* still comes before us even in its double meaning: it is the book of books—a whole crowd of its own, enfolded permanently as canon, its alpha and omega entangled in the Western fate or fatality of the Book. Whenever love exceeds local bonds, duties and escapades—as for example in the “politics of love” among neo-Marxist commentators—its biblical intertextuality remains inescapable.¹⁸

GOSPELS

If I speak so little and late of Jesus, it is a silence of solidarity. He had enough of the “Lord, lord” sayers early on.¹⁹ Worshipping the Lord became the great Christian alternative to the love-risk. No Christology is forthcoming within this context, in which the logos of theos has posed a big enough question, one to which no logos of christos could offer itself as final answer (as for example: the Father is aloof, but in the Son He has fully revealed himself to us: the basis of every Christian positiv-

ism). The apophatic operation kicks in as soon as I hear “Jesus”: *not God*, not the same substance, not any substance, not the only Son, not the one Messiah. And not *not*.

The unpronounceable YHWH and the enigmatic I Am are echoing, as Richard Kearney captures it, in Jesus’ resistance to any categorical identity. “In fact it is only the ‘demons’ who claim to *know* Jesus, as in the exchange with the unclean spirit at Capernaum who called out ‘I *know* who you are—the Holy One of God.’ To which Jesus responds: ‘Be quiet! Come out of him’ (Mark 1.25).” Nonetheless, here too, not only before the one he nicknamed *Abba*, not all naming needs exorcism. Mere silence becomes repression. I do not want, no more than does anathemism, to feed the secularist Christ complex, which pushes the originary texts and contexts for much of what it deems ethical progress out of hearing. This leaves them to the religious right and prevents them from questioning and being questioned (rather than dismissed) by the secular left. So the denial of Christian entanglement does nothing for the relational pluralisms and democratic convivialities protective of non-Christian perspectives. Let me try instead a *christographic* exercise, hoping that a few vivid strokes (admittedly and perilously homiletical) will illustrate an apophatic opening to and within the hermeneutics of the second testament.

Across their dialects the gospels ply Jesus as teacher, rabboni, anointed one, son of man, child of Sophia. Though interested in the communal construction—“who do *you* say that I am?”—it was not his own identity that he laid bare but his priority: “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your might; and the neighbor as yourself.” Here he just cites scripture.²⁰ To do to others as you would have them do to you is to implicate yourself in the other. You enfold yourself in the becoming other, knowing the other already enfolded in you. It reverses the normal—do to others as they do to you—the common sense of a masked entanglement. The Nazarene does not propose a competition, a metaphysical exceptionalism, or a supersession. Versions of this ethics of the implicated self found form across the traditions of the world. The amorous priority of the Great Commandment—if Sunday School has not ruined this language—wraps affect and agency mindfully into relation to God and passes it immediately, superpositionally, to the “neighbor.” To whichever other comes before you. “As yourself”: difference is not reduced. The neighbor might be the

enemy. The neighbor is not the self. But nonseparable: because you are entangled already in this relation, that relation is part of who you will be. You affect and are affected willy-nilly. Entangle mindfully.

What “heart,” the affect of love (and it was never, despite many ethical translations, reducible to mind and will), does is to pump entanglement toward a boundless flourishing, rhythmically entrained with time, undefeated by death. And with its radicalization in the love beyond kin and ken, not just of the stranger but of the enemy, it practices the courage (*couer-age*) that simultaneously expands and deterritorializes the self, dispossesses it of its properties, its substance.

In the christographics of the Gospel of Matthew, the theatrics of final judgment becomes a parable for the entanglement of Jesus with all of the hungry, the imprisoned, the sick, the “least.”²¹ And therefore—this is the point—for the participation of those who would follow him. Those for whom he comes *before*. From the eschatological viewpoint of the story, he *questions the love* of those who claim to know him. He is holding them answerable to that gruesome width—to that endless crowd of the suffering, the poor. He isn’t who they thought; his “I” exhibits a world of disturbingly precarious material relations. The parable exposes the “Lord, Lord” ruse.

This rabbi nonseparable from the embodiment of his teaching was then taught—and why not—as the incarnation of his own message: “the parabler became the parable.”²² The loving becomes the love. In this novel self-implication in the relations of an emergent collective, his plurisingular life displays no exclusive new truth, except when it backfires: where its truth turns unquestionable.

It is only the fourth gospel that proclaims the singular teacher as divine. He now appears as the Logos that comes *before* all things, through which they come to be, who now stands *before* them in the flesh. The incarnate God-word thus explicates a love implicated in the unfolding of the entire creation. John frames the enfleshment as gift of love itself: “God so loved the world that he gave his Son . . .” In context the giving is the gift of a new human chance. But that verse is endlessly yanked out of context as a proof-text that the Father donated his Son as blood sacrifice and only way to heaven. The language of John’s gospel, with its becoming-flesh of the Creator’s word, appears of the four the most foreign to Jesus’ own language. It is also the most susceptible to betrayal. It can all too readily be read as a litany of final answers. Similarly, and to devastating effect, a willful ignorance—

ignorant first of all of its own implication in hermeneutics—severs “no one comes to the Father but by me” from its context. Relentlessly it hardens his Ego into The Way and final Answer. *In* context, however, that pointer is a gesture of love toward disciples grieving already his portended death.²³ I am now part of you, my way is yours, you will not get lost. The text has nothing to do with rivalry between religions.

It is John’s gospel that draws the love motif into fertile figurations of entanglement: “I am the vine, you are the branches. Those who abide in me and I in them bear much fruit.” It is also a text of pruning—the cut. Relationality as constituent is not therefore comfortable.²⁴ The prolific imagery of mutual indwelling offers not just a glimpse of ontological relationality *avant la lettre* but a strategy for its intensification.. We come all mixed up together: in raw relation there is no salvation. The vining unsnarls and unfolds relation, entangling its branching multiplicity indissolubly with a particular life and its flesh. The flesh is vibrant matter, alive, eating and eaten. John makes of Jesus a sacrament: “Those who eat my flesh and drink my blood abide in me, and I in them.”²⁵ Flesh materializes here “not as a self-contained mass, but as an element transformed as it is given.” Thus Mayra Rivera unfolds this Johannine flesh : “Like bread, flesh is shared, becoming part of many bodies, transformed into the very materiality of those bodies that partake of it. The exchange entails not only *his* flesh, but also the carnality of those invited to share in its life. If in the prologue Word becomes Flesh and appears in the midst of people—exposed—here we are invited to imagine it *in* the people—as food nurturing spiritual life.” She points to a Latin American history extending from de las Casas to Dussel connecting the eucharistic bread and wine, its flesh and blood, with the life of the poor the bodies of workers and the productivity of the Earth.²⁶

What *is* the way that gets incarnate in order to feed the hungry and lead the lost—but that of an amorous participation in each other’s flesh? In the “flesh of the world”? This abiding, dwelling (*shakan*) is not temporary shelter; it may repeat its intra-actions endlessly. Even at the quantum level, after all, entanglement may abide across any expanse of time and space. In the human flesh before us in John, it effects *zoon aionios*, “life of the age” precariously translated as “eternal life.” It is no timeless, worldless eternity, but the time-full entirety of the “age,” the cosmic expanse of relevant space-time.

The christographic difference of this gospel is figured as a divinely human *exemplum* for a people, a community, a species. Later in the age, he congealed into the absolute ontological *exception*: the God-man, metaphysically wrought of two separate substances, divine and human. The power of the exception, mimicking the dominance of a Sovereign, then infused empire with the political theology of unquestionable Lordship. Might we, with John's blessing, let the power of the exception dissolve into the lure of the exemplum? Perhaps then the incarnation would get redistributed as *intercarnation*: no creature lives outside of bodied participation in its fellows. And *therefore*, to echo Cusa, in God. But some creatures more than others *answer to* the truth of that participation.

In the the self-implicating entanglement of our differences—not of the one exceptional difference—the Johannine Jesus predicts those who will do more and greater than he.²⁷ He comes not as the one and only but the one who *per exemplum* made himself the most hospitable rhizome, the fruit of the vine, the edible host. And this self-implication of love in John's epistle then spins back upon the meaning and the name of God: God becomes love. The very love by which we perform our communities, our worlds. This love signifies *a relation, not an entity*. Language of the Holy Spirit as love itself, relation itself, has held this fresh disclosure in language. But the Trinity would in the Western tradition render the Spirit subordinate to the Father and the Son,²⁸ and relationality thereby gets subordinated, as befits the substantialist grammar of the Greco-Roman world, to the anthropomorphic subjects—personal entities who *have* relations. But if this God is more than an idol of human male power, then we have to do with a relation that exceeds knowing not just by way of unsaying but of feeling, action, and contemplation. Heart, will, and mind. We might provisionally say that “God” names *our* relation to everything, including God. Not just any relation, but an amorously boundless one. It is a relation, and so a God, which does not happen apart from our participation.

To the extent, however, that the “love of Christ” has been betrayed by its heirs, variously hardened, domesticated, and weaponized, has it *failed*? Well, surely, over and over. But does failure let us—the heirs—off its hook? When we interrogate the early christograms, finding even there no purity of origin, we may find that our questions mark and hook us further. Failure, as for instance J. Halberstam, in *The Queer Art of Failure* avers, offers the cloudy and negative chance to practice an al-

ternative reality.²⁹ But not without a more overt failure to know, a more apophatic entanglement, than the language of the gospels has articulated.

EPISTLES

It is in the Pauline corpus that love announces an unmistakeable apophysis: “Knowledge will come to an end; love never ends.”³⁰ Paul’s Christ brings this amorous infinity into its enigmatic self-implication. We recognize an acute knowledge of unknowing: “to know the love of Christ that surpasses knowledge.”³¹ Love partakes of the boundlessness incapable of epistemic or religious closure. Paul here in Corinth (not just at the altar to the Unknown God in Athens) anticipates the eros of negative theology, the amorous cloud of unknowing, the relationality of the *docta ignorantia*.

Knowledge is not repressed but surpassed, exceeded, rendered questionable: “knowledge puffs up, love builds up.”³² This edification (“building up”) alludes to the psalmist: “I will build all things with love.” *Olam hesed yibenai*.³³ *Olam* actually means the whole or the universe as temporalized, as “very distant time,” past or future, close to the aeon misleadingly translated as “eternity.” The past is at once “before” one and “after” in Hebrew.³⁴ So this love is building up all that comes—before. So then *hesed*, translatable as “loving-kindness, mercy, fidelity,” holds the Christian *agape* answerable to its actual spatiotemporal world. This building capacity pertains to any theology that calls itself *constructive*—and so resists the inflationary certainties to which confessional and systematic traditions are prone. Is it the apophatic excess that plies the construction—and recurrently undoes it? (If so, a constructive apophatics ceases to be an oxymoron.) *Hesed*, in responsive fidelity rather than self-same eternity, fired up prophetic ethics from the outset. The most oppressed, of course, may not need the love motive for exodus; those called to answer for them *do*. But *all*—at least the 99 percent—will need to be “built up” against the onslaught of impossibility. One can dangle eschatological threats and promises; but love has the fragile advantage of being its own reward. If it surpasses knowledge, is it passing into the cloud (another kind of puffy)—and *through* it into actualization? Into actions of intercession?

Paul pulses with the intensification of love in the embodiment of this “new law.” He cites Jesus citing the Hebrew love language. Fold after fold of *torah*:

Paul, according to certain recent Jewish interpreters, is no longer to be read as the first Christian supersessionist, but as a radical Jew.³⁵ He builds *hesed* into living cells of affective, risk-taking community: “Who will separate us from the love of Christ? Will hardship, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword?”³⁶ This apophatic love holds up in the face of the unspeakable. And it holds its members together not from the outside but as parts, nonseparably different, of an organism. The great figure of communal entanglement arises: the many gifted members of a body. “If one member suffers, all suffer together with it; if one member is honoured, all rejoice together with it.”³⁷ With an eye to the 99 percent, Joerg Rieger translates Paul’s metaphor of political solidarity, for example, into the language of trade unions: “an injury to one is an injury to all.” Pressing liberation theology into an explicit relationalism, Rieger points to “the complexity of our connections to other people, including the severe distortions in these connections.” Without seeing these connections “we will never be able to transform them in life-giving ways.” Rieger is riffing on the Pauline reception of the neighbor-love. The “as yourself” “reminds us that self-interest is always tied to others, whether we notice it or not.”³⁸

Within a few verses burst the love lyrics of the Corinthian hymn: “If I speak in the tongues of men or of angels, but do not have love, I am only a resounding gong or a clanging cymbal. If I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing.”³⁹

There may be no single more apophatically acute entanglement of negative theology *avant la lettre* in amorous relationalism. But if one has heard it intoned at too many wedding services (however queer) it may be—irony mounting—a rigorous Marxist and unequivocal atheist who will help us hear it with fresh ears “In the case of the preeminence of love,” writes Alain Badiou of this hymn, “which alone effectuates the unity of thought and action in the world, it is necessary to pay attention to Paul’s lexicon.”⁴⁰ Reflecting on how “love . . . rejoices in the truth,”⁴¹ Badiou finds love in Paul a “subjectivation,” a motive-force that yields the following “theorem.” We may read it as a terse rendition of the ethical self-implicature of apophatic entanglement: “The subjective process of a truth is one and the same thing as the love of that truth.”⁴² This is a truth with and beyond knowledge, the activation of a perspective that, arising in a concrete spatiotem-

poral event, extends boundlessly outward. Of course we may question any claim of universality—especially of as carrying “the militant real.” When is it not just another particularism rendered imperial, one carrying, in this case, the supreme Christological sanction? Yet, without some version of “the universal address,” do we not we deny every answerability beyond kin and ken? It is not the universal but its repression in the name of a dominant particular, an *ethnos*, argues Badiou, that leads to the death camp. Perhaps, but the racialized *ethnos* does not fail to claim its own universal. Instead of pitting the universal truth against the particular, we may insist on the self-implicature of our own address, questioning the scope and the limits of our *hesed*. The public we address may indeed be that of the planet as a fold of the universe—the universalism, then, of a materializing cosmopolitics. We may with Badiou, and with the surprising new ensemble of non-Christian and nontheist fans of Paul, recognize in the militant (and nonviolent) love a dramatic breakthrough of radical egalitarianism.⁴³ If so, it is repeating differently the *exodus* motif, at once internalized and universalized, upon the roads of the Roman Empire.

As to the human universal, Badiou does at least consider the standing problem of Paul’s sexism, the veil, and “man not made from woman, but woman from man.” He considers it all solved by the text three verses later: “Nevertheless, in the Lord woman is not independent of man or man independent of woman. For just as woman came from man, so man comes through woman; but all things come from God.”⁴⁴ *Now*, in the newness of the event. Paul, in Badiou’s paraphrase, almost answers the feminist critique: “What matters, man or woman, Jew or Greek, slave or free man, is that differences *carry the universal that happens to them like a grace*.”⁴⁵ And by this grace he has Paul mean, quite beautifully, “no instantaneous salvation; grace itself is no more than the indication of a possibility.”⁴⁶

Paul and his assemblies do not evenly actualize the possibility. The gender hierarchy, the acceptance of the institutions of class and slavery, the heterosexual and, of course, Christocentric exclusivism will not be erased. The Pauline epistles will remain potent weapons of the Christian right. Indeed the same love-saturated letter to the Corinthians concludes thus: “Let anyone be accursed who has no love for the Lord. Our Lord, come!”⁴⁷ Love or be cursed? Maranatha as messianic menace?

This is to say that Pauline love remains *not expendable—but questionable*. It displays the ambiguity of Christian love: the problem of a love *identified* with Christ, when Christ is identifiable with God and God is an . . . identity. Then the relation becomes the entity—and oh so knowable. The clanging gong overpowers the grace event.

Fortunately Paul's apophatic nuance keeps returning. And here my colleague Melanie Johnson-DeBaufre offers such a revelatory exegesis of the Pauline apo-phasis of love that I quote her at length:

Paul invites the ethical practice of measuring all things by love. In English, such a declarative list—love is, love is, love is—tempts Christians to a confidence that love is definable, knowable, possessed by some and not others. But love here eludes and ever surpasses such sureties. In fact, the primary word in verses 4 to 7 is not *is* but *not*. Love exposes not-love. And stepping up the negation one more notch: love *never* ends. Love always exceeds and is beyond what is known, what is partial. In this sense it is always complete. But knowing cannot know its completeness, thus is it always also open-ended. For those of us troubled by some of Paul's words, this sense that love never falls or fails leaves open that the meanings of even Paul's words—regardless of their intention—can be known and measured as not-love. Paul's idea of love that surpasses understanding exceeds his own completeness and our own and opens every present toward the possibilities of love.⁴⁸

This questionable and questioning Paul stands before us past and future. The christographic difference did not need to turn into the christocentric exclusion. And so its universal address still plies the possibility of a perspectively entangled planetarity. Deterritorializing the Roman order of separations—*divide et impera*—he stirred a dissident (Stoic) cosmopolis, diffracted through the contagious communalism of the gospel. In their context the epistles unfold ensembles with subversive possibilities of gender, ethnos, class. And even of an envaginated kosmos: "the whole creation has been groaning as in the pains of childbirth right up to the present time."⁴⁹ Birth then signified a high-risk endeavor. The earth evinces a queerer eligibility now, with no eschatological guarantee of a final conviviality. In the meantime, the entangling excess that is love continues to lure Christians and not-Christians to surpass our not-loving certainties.

RECAPITULATIO

To greet the unknown before us: in an ancient christographics the eschaton before us implicates an aeon, past and future. The self-implication of the presumptive love takes the form of a recapitulation. Such enfolding is not a matter of mere summation. The second-century Irenaeus of Lyons introduced the doctrine of *recapitulatio*. This bishop in Roman Gaul drew the term from ancient rhetoric, signifying the “final repetition,” which sums up in “bringing to a head” (*anakephalaio*). “Therefore he came to his own in a visible manner, and was made flesh, and hung upon the tree, that he might sum up all things himself.”⁵⁰ The repetition provokes the novel effect. He was not, however, thinking of the Deleuzean third repetition. Irenaeus is citing Ephesians: “All things in heaven and earth alike should be gathered up in Christ.” This cosmic Christ enfolds and iterates the entire history of our species. So the New Adam repeats with a difference the primal earthling in whose earth (*adamah*) we are all still entangled. Indeed the whole creation is repeated, it comes to a head: Christ becomes the paradigmatic kosmos-persona. The recapitulatio thus repeats the systemic distortion that original sin signifies; it implicates us all in the violence of the cross. And it does so not in chronological time but in the unstraightened repetitions of liturgy, story, and the whole species’ entanglement. As that one body enfolds a whole aeon in its life and in its death, we too are enfolded. And so we may unfold in our lives the life that can be redeemed from that death. At least this is a reading.

Yet in cloud perspective we question the Christological closure toward which Irenaeus—and most Christian eschatology before process theology—*unquestionably* thunders. And there is a venerable tradition, particularly of feminist and womanist theologians, questioning any notion of atonement by sacrificial substitute.⁵¹ The cross has commonly been deployed to revictimize the vulnerable, beginning with the Jews. But the “final repetition” may unfold otherwise. We might, for example, supplement Irenaeus with a contemporary U.S. reinterpretation of that bloody symbol of the cross. I quote at length because the theopoetics is hard-won and revelatory, the *exemplum* prophetic: “All the hatred we have expressed toward one another cannot destroy the profound mutual love and solidarity that flow deeply between us—a love that empowered blacks to open their arms to

receive the many whites who were also empowered by the same love to risk their lives in the black struggle for freedom. . . . We were made brothers and sisters by the blood of the lynching tree, the blood of sexual union, and the blood of the cross of Jesus. . . . What God has joined together, no one can tear apart.”⁵²

Entangled we come. Altogether divergently. James Cone, finding the Black experience of the cross enfolded in the lynching tree, makes no excuses for the history of white supremacism, the crusades of the KKK, and the condescension of white liberals. Because some white folk became mindful of their own implication in the racism, another complicatio becomes possible. What we will together unfold remains perilously and promisingly uncertain, billowing in a dense cloud of multicontextual entanglements. Issues within issues, flesh within flesh, folds within folds. We will continue to snarl up the complexity. The most effectual love of the enemy may only exacerbate the enmity. And even where it works, it tangles. Some advance against racism may trade against sexual justice, religious difference, class, climate. That “profound mutual love and solidarity” enfolds us in crucifying histories, indeterminately overdetermined. Yet, as Elizabeth Freeman puts it, “nonsequential forms of time (in the poem, unconsciousness, haunting, reverie and the afterlife) can also fold subjects into structures of belonging and duration that may be invisible to the historicist eye.”⁵³ Thus the nonsequential forms of Black poetry, ancient scriptures, slave songs, liturgies of protest, and the blues vibrate through Cone’s work of militant love.

To recapitulate (and it is getting to be that time): life together does not get more convivial as it gets planetary.⁵⁴ Barely recognizable others come before us already too familiar, in crowds culturally overextended, digitally mediated, poignantly needy. Without our widest aeon, our pasts recapitulated in the counter-narratives and queer temporalities of our most becoming perspectives, how can we greet the unknown yet before us? In other words, I see no way out of this cloud that engulfs love. Except to push deeper into it.

ANCESTORS IN THE CLOUD

We witnessed the ancient emergence of negative theology in Gregory of Nyssa’s exegesis of a passage of Exodus: “I am going to come to you in a dense cloud, in

order that the people may hear . . . and so trust you ever after.” In an inaugural incident over a millennium later, between Sinai and Cappadocia, the luminous darkness again makes its appearance: “While he was still speaking, a bright cloud covered them, and a voice from the cloud said, ‘This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased. Listen to him!’”⁵⁵

The audio-visual cloud again, in the full luminosity of its opacity: in this precise echo of the public empowerment of Moses, the revealing, revealing cloud is once more written into a desert wilderness. Recapitulation within recapitulation: in the altered state of transfiguration, Moses and Elijah are here seen “talking with him.” Peter is disoriented by the multiplicity of this vision-crowd, by this alter-knowing. He wants, achingly hospitable, to build “huts” for each of them (apparently like the tabernacle/tent of the original epiphany). Far from any supersession, the cloud powwow performs Jesus’s nonseparability from the ancient spirit ancestors. He enfolds his collective in a solidarity with those that came long before them; the deep repetition prepares them to face the impossibilities of their future. Of betrayal, pain, loss, abandonment—but before that and after, still before us now, still barely possible, of the gathering of a planetary movement. His plurisingular life offers no exclusive new truth, except when it backfires: where, after the fact, its truth-relation turns unquestionable.

How to greet the unknown? With trembling hospitality, the text suggests. This time it may be the beloved there before us. Ancestral and messianic, alpha and omega. Just here and now.



Loving, after all, does involve softening and yielding our flesh one to another. There is no civic being, no friendship, no neighbor, no public, no commons, without a mutual yielding of our tissues and the shared embrace of social flesh, of intercorporeal generosity.

—SHARON BETCHER, *SPIRIT AND THE OBLIGATION OF SOCIAL FLESH*:

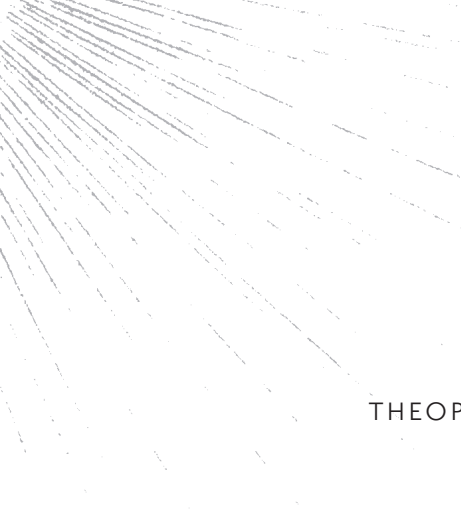
A SECULAR THEOLOGY FOR THE GLOBAL CITY

Shifting cloud formations meet us now, ancient visages appearing, mingling; they dissolve into an insinuation of old mothers, Thought Woman and Mary conferring with Gaia; the fond profile of a Buddha is glimpsed riding Ibn Arabi’s caravan

of love just as it morphs into an exodus of endangered butterflies.⁵⁶ But the cloud of witnesses never ceases to expand, engulfing the determinisms of past destruction in pasts that might have been, into possibility, *forcefields of space-time* that might yet be. Cocreating the field.⁵⁷ Gestalt psychology had early contemplated the cloudy morphology of relationality. As my friend Deborah Ullman writes, “in the contemporary field-theoretically focused understanding of Gestalt, we are fundamentally and integrally part of the field, before we are separate beings. Not in the field only, but of the field. This understanding carries with it compelling ethical implications.”⁵⁸ There arise new crowds, unpredictable movements (on this random morning church folk demonstrating for the rights of same-sex love in my denomination, students getting arrested for the love of the planet by the hundred at the White House) . . . The beloved diffuses into love itself. It always did. We didn’t always notice. It goes planetary, polyamorous. The social flesh softens.⁵⁹ It confuses every defense against the swarming others. The deconstruction of the religious fortresses comes first. Otherwise this love does not implicate itself and so ceases to be lovable.

The hospitality of the cloud enfolds the pressing differences nonseparably even as they multiply. Scarcity precipitates new sacraments. And so a host, the one who once superposed the Passover Seder not as separation but as anticipatory grief and performative re/membering of his body, is radically redistributed.⁶⁰ But this entangling materialization does not dissipate the nonlocal logos that the local Jesus signified. Intercarnation does not supersede, it multiplies the incarnation. Self-giving in the self-loved flow of the “relational power of *jeong*” (Wonhee Anne Joh) minds the stickiness of every ambiguous entanglement; in the “agapology” of a cosmic resource (Jung Doo Kim) or in the “kenotic erotics” that empowers even when sacrifice becomes unavoidable (Anna Mercedes): these new theological voices startle life into failed and faltering *christo-logoi*.⁶¹ Still the love, erotic or agapic, may not, just when we most want it, answer to the name “God.” We recognize our question, our plea, already plying its own response. We can break the mirror but not see through it. The indeterminate entanglements of our best knowledge will continue to knit the fringes of our relations into frustration as well as mystery. The love will remain intercorporeally questionable. It will precipitate disfigurations as well as transfigurations. So then shall we finally give up the logos of theos, the theory and the practice of God? We can honorably draw the line,

dispel the cloud and march forward in the faith of progress after all. But can we do it honestly? Is there any depth of criticism, reason, science, liberation that does not push into a brilliant darkness of its own? "There is always something more to be said and understood," writes Kearney, "some inexhaustible residue never to be known."⁶² Then where would the line settle between my apophasis and yours? (My questions are turning rhetorical. They recapitulate a book. Their answerability begins to coincide with their questionability. They mean to answer to . . . you.) Is there any width of solidarity in which nicknames of the infinite complication are not whispered in the night? Is there before us any coming conviviality not becomingly questioning its ancestors ? And *after*?



AFTER

THEOPOETICS OF THE CLOUD

AFTER ALL, STILL, the God question. With one last gasp of theological authority, let me therefore say unto you—that for which God is a nickname cares not whether you believe in God. Doesn't give a damn. Isn't in the damning business. What matters, what might matter endlessly, is what we earth-dwellers now together embody. Not what we say *about* God but how we *do* God.¹

Or to put that in traditional language: *theopoiesis*, “God-making.” Materializing in and beyond speech a love-relation to your widest world. “It undoes me / wider than wide . . .” (Hadewijch).² Facing the economies of indifference, it may work to name that relation love itself. Facing the hardened impossibilities, it may help to name the im/possible posse ipsum, possibility itself . . .

As you see I am trying to conclude something that is behaving with recalcitrant endlessness. But the logic of the infinite provides me no further excuses. There must be a *fin*, however endlessly any ending might echo into the future, repeating its last words beginningly or gesturing beyond words *definitively*. Not that contemplation ends now and action begins. Such a binarism of inside and out, theory and practice, cloud and crowd, or alpha and omega collapsed a while back. The whole asymmetrical co-incident of this book folds in and out of its own cloud. As an apophatically entangled becoming it would activate potentialities spooky or sensuous, upclose or planetary, that work together in mindfulness

of their enigmatic co-implication. The divine complication—that nickname appeals to its own explication, its unfolding, its getting *done*. It urges a practice that remains contemplative even in its most activist, most affirmative, most gender-queerclassraceabilitypluralistecopolitical unfoldings. How could it *not*? All this language will come to an end. Its entanglements may not.



But wait, really—God-making? Theopoiesis?

That early Christian lexeme arose with Gregory of Nyssa, in the unfolding infinity of his dark cloud. It signified “divinization” or “becoming God,” later contracted to *theosis*. To most ears then and now divinization sounds not amorous but arrogant, like one pretending to *be* the Omnipotent, competing with His damning and saving Sovereignty. So the ancient teaching of theosis blacked out in the West. No great loss, had there then resulted a culture of humility, wary of sanctified power plays. Instead we got empires puffed up with pride in their Christian supremacy. Always bending the knee modestly before the Lord. With current secularized superpower the imposition of an economics unaccountable to the collective good depends on the support of a conservative Christian constituency that considers any notion of divinization, any bodying of God beyond the one exception, to be the height of heresy. This is one reason some of us on the other side won’t quit doing God.

By whatever names, what is named God, when it resists objectification as the Big Other, billows into an infinity uncontained in any over-against, any above-and-beyond. One can ignore it but one cannot move out of it. There isn’t somewhere else to live. One might ignore it responsibly, attending to the particular becomings. Or one might ignore it willfully, resentful of the whole fragile world of becoming.³ By whatever names, participation in the cloud-infinity always already invites care for its finitudes. And only therefore does it do God.

Certainly the apophatic theory practices theosis all along.⁴ The Neoplatonic heritage as we noted along the way had, however, little vocabulary for the *becomingness* of the God implied in “becoming God” if God is changeless. We scrutinized Cusa’s hint of a creatable God closer to the truth in his cloud than the

creating God, he said, and both true only in their unsaying. (Apophysis lent cover to questionable orthodoxy.) Yet the ancient formula of theopoiesis had the most orthodox of sources. As Athanasius pronounced it incarnationally: “He [the Logos] became human that the human might become God.”⁵ This becoming, far from entraining all bodily becoming, all too readily signifies “bearing nothing earthly in ourselves.”⁶ But the loss of the participatory radicality of this early form of Christic chiasmus only contributed to the intensifying dualism. I do not mean, however, to begin another story.

For present purposes christology has not been erased but decentered, its self-implicating love turned against its own constitutive exclusions. Theos-logos thus translates into theopoiesis in an opening beyond christocentrism, androcentrism, anthropocentrism. So then it is opening into and never beyond a cosmos whose logos embodies itself endlessly: as in Laurel Schneider’s polydoxically “promiscuous incarnations.” The incarnation, in other words, becomes interarnation. The becoming of any creature reverberates in a universe readable as God’s body. Thus the “inhumanist” poet Robinson Jeffers:

*The human race is one of God’s sense organs
Immoderately alerted to feel good and evil
And pain and pleasure. It is a nerve ending*⁷

Affect materializes minimally, maximally, as I hope I have helped you to feel, and for us therefore, in the earth. Doing God means acting *not* as separable agents but in differential collectives mindfully enfleshing our planetary entanglement. And planetarity itself enfolds our earthbound participation in the whole unfathomable universe of mostly dark energy. The entangled apophysis of this meditation encourages agential collaborations, not isolating mysticisms or sufficient microcosms. So any theopoiesis here repeated as a contemporary possibility will (by a now familiar maneuver) quickly unsay itself.

It will negate this very language of God-making, of divinization, before it congeals—only to say it again, in some moment of the self-implicating inscription of our tiny, humble, and crowded oikos, nerve ending or microorganism, in the unfathomable body of bodies, “worlds without end.”⁸ Amen, almost.



*I dwell in Possibility –
 A fairer House than Prose –
 More numerous of Windows –
 Superior – for Doors –*

—EMILY DICKINSON

The discourse that now on occasion calls itself *theopoetics*—as has this book—marks its God-talk with its proper im/possibility. Yet in its proximity to radical theology in the patrilineage of the death of God, most self-designated theopoetics remains detached from the ancient *theopoiesis*, with its metaphysical associations. If I am to keep doing God, I need both. The poetics by which I have occasionally transcribed logos highlights language as constructive, *poietic*, making something: but never quite from nothing. Words that body forth meaning are not just words. They do not materialize surface without volume, face without deep.

“Theopoetics as the insistence of a radical theology” has here quietly been folded together—and never identified—with theopoiesis as the persistence of an ancestral iconoclasm.⁹ The epistemic intensity of theopoetics as such, bound up with deconstruction, highlights what language itself does, makes, constructs. And from the time of the coining of the term (coincidentally, in my institutional space, just decades before my time) it was bound up with the genres of literature, of poetry.¹⁰

Conversely, the cosmological explicatio of an apophatically unfolding God ultimately brought the creation itself into theopoiesis, expanding boundlessly and contracting relationally into each quantum of becoming. Attention to language was acute all along, but mainly in the negation, and double negation, of doctrines far from poetry. Hence the chiasmus that structured this meditation. It invites crossings between its material chaosmos, so vibrant with entanglement, and its linguistic chasm, so precariously, poetically charged—“in a bottomless abyss, Never could I come out of it.”¹¹

Yet theopoetics in this present form lends also dwelling place (shakan, shekhi-nah) in the abyss: home amidst the bottomless, ground amidst the clouds—indeed, a constructive theology amidst the deconstructions. The theopoetics of the cloud is then the affirmation made possible by the negation. This does not mean we replace our theos-logos with poetics or that we become poets; sometimes we train, entrain, with them. After all, it is the “poet’s pen” that “gives to airy nothing a local habitation and a name.”¹² (The no-thing of the air was of course never a void—cloud note.) And for Emily Dickinson poetry is itself the “house of possibility.”¹³ Her poem continues:

*Of Chambers as the Cedars –
Impregnable of eye –
And for an everlasting Roof
The Gambrels of the Sky –*

Her earthbound house rises beyond visibility. Into a negatively theological imperceptible?

*Of Visitors – the fairest –
For Occupation – This –
The spreading wide my narrow Hands
To gather Paradise –*¹⁴

Enfolding, vulnerably contracted, unfolded wider than wide. And yes, the poem ends there, with a dash—the syntactical impropriety of her resistance to closure.¹⁵ Recall that in Cusa’s narrative there is within the cloud the wall that cracks open into paradise: “and it is there in paradise that you reside.”¹⁶

Still, does even such a generously fenestrated house suggest too much structure—earth, community, construction—for a cloud? Surely. And so the cloud is never enough; it *is* not any of the ensembles elemental or social that it makes possible; *is* not the theology, not the theopoetics. It lets us face an impossibility of our *oikos* with some new possibility. In the present book the cloud has offered itself not as a home, not as an earth, but as a perspective hospitable to experiments in dwelling differently. They are therefore hard to end—



The ending one wants to avoid is the apocalypse. And the atmosphere that beclouds the planet now provokes ever more scientifically reasoned apocalypses. Thoughtful philosophers startled by climate change now decry hope as a delusion and a distraction.¹⁷ They intone Milton's "abandon all hope . . ." It is not God damning us to hell this round but we ourselves. And yes, "often, by clinging to hope, we make the suffering worse."¹⁸ But, really, beyond the inadvertently apophatic gesture, is no-hope the answer to a misguided hope? Will hopelessness before the eco-apocalypse stimulate the still possible adaptations and mitigations? It is of course easy to confuse hope with optimism, which by way of disappointment hardens into willful ignorance, indeed cruelty.¹⁹ The unshadowed positivism of the optimist has trapped time and language into the straightness of progress toward a final goal. It plays off its equally determinist opposite, the purposeless pessimism that clings to false *realism*. Which sends people running into the arms of false hope again.²⁰ Latour puckishly captures the alternative: "abandon all hype, ye who enter here."²¹ (Not a bad poster for negative theology.)

We have explored the third space, alien to pessimism or optimism, of the luminous darkness. In its present incarnation it stirs up the amorous *chance*—future unknown—of some contagious conviviality. Concretely that means that intentionally earth-entangled structures already dwelling in the possibility of a just and sustainable common life can lurch toward its actualization. Let me borrow a concluding statement of purposefulness from William Connolly: "The overriding goal is to press international organizations, states, corporations, banks, labor unions, churches, consumers, citizens, and universities to act in concerted ways to defeat neo-liberalism, to curtail climate change, to reduce inequality, and to instill a vibrant pluralist spirituality into democratic machines that have lost too much of their vitality."²² I read there an apophatically hopeful answer to apocalypse.

Does a voice yet whisper—is it too late? If so another answers: isn't it always? When else do we mobilize before what is—already before us?

In other words we may break apocalyptic closure into dis/closure (the meaning of *apo-kalypsis*, after all) along the same diagonal that cracks open the im/possible.

Hope here remains clouded, not canceled, by tragic knowledge and manifold uncertainty.

The coincidentia of light and darkness runs as we have seen through multiple ensembles, each of which disclose a different register of apophatically entangled becoming—precipitating in this book theologically, physically, philosophically, ethically, poetically, politically, ecologically. But a wider *recapitulatio*, and with it another co-incident, wants voice here. It happens that during the last years of the last millennium I wrote a book on the last book of the Bible. And then during the first years of the new millennium I wrote a book on its first book, indeed its first verses. But it isn't that I had some master plan for an authorial opus writing its way back from omega to alpha.

With *Apocalypse Now and Then* I surrendered to a demand that possessed me for *some* U.S. theologian to address the force with which the religious right, then empowered at the highest political level, was making Revelation a self-fulfilling prophecy.²³ I resisted a tempting feminist antiapocalypse (the text *is* profoundly misogynist), proposing instead a counterapocalypse. John of Patmos wrote the major denunciation, after all, of the Roman Empire, parodying it as the cross-dressing “whore of Babylon,” with its wrapping of the planet, human and nonhuman, in a vast spiral of destruction: fires, droughts, marine death, deforestation, disease, wars, hunger, conflagration. . . . Toxic in its finalism—the original case of “running Genesis backwards”—it never actually announces the “end of the world.” Fundamentalists do that. And the vengeful indifference toward the planetary weal is colluding efficiently with carbon-pumped capitalism to bring on the End. But the history of the effects of the old text is as progressive as it is reactionary (just check out Bloch's *Principle of Hope*). Might we (I wondered) deconstruct the determinisms of planetary doom with an apo/calypse of prophetic responsibility? Open up the endpoint, the omega, to its uncertainty?

And then, with no intention to answer the omega with its alpha—I wrote *The Face of the Deep*, the book that confronts, well, yes, in depth, the unquestionability of the doctrine of the *creatio ex nihilo*. Not only does the theology of a single origin from omnipotent transcendence lack biblical warrant. The ancient texts narrate genesis from the fluent deep, abysmally, wombily, no *thing* . . . but nothing like “nothing.” Process theology has always denied absolute origin along with absolute end or a deity who would *do* them: there are multiple, dramatic events of

novelty; a universe may come and may go, but this would signify one phase of a process. There needed however to unfold from the deconstruction of the origin, I thought, right in its face, a theological construction, a poiesis: the chaosmos of a scripturally entangled, ecofeminist theology of becoming. In its *creatio ex profundis* the beginning opens into an affirmative cocreativity—"it is good!"—vibrant with relations of indeterminacy.

So then between the fires of endtime and the waters of beginning, yet after both, the cloud appears. It writes a third space that is not a midpoint between poles, between alpha and omega, but that folds opposites asymmetrically into itself. Tempestuously menacing, or cherubically pink and peaceful, the cloud perhaps can only appear when the time line running straight, so straight, from the omnipotently determined origin to the final punishments and rewards, breaks up. Breaks into folds. The supernaturalist and secularist inscriptions of the time line together come undone.

The salvation historical narrative had been crafted early, already with Irenaeus, producing the temporality of creation-fall-cross-church-eschaton. Its linearity conducted the multiple spatiotemporalities of the earth into a single forward-moving momentum. In the next millennium this surged powerfully forward in the secularized translations of progress, with its vastly uneven distribution of rewards. Modern optimism horizontalized the heavenward eschatology, while modern pessimism cast the perduring shadow of apocalypse. I am simplifying; I am recapitulating. The point is not to deny the adventurous gains in empirical knowledge and democratic pluralism made possible by the historicism of the West, built upon the God of history.

Attention to the creativity of time's process does not erase the forward surge. It nuances and complicates it. It interferes with it. Quantum uncertainty—only with entanglement, we are just learning—"is the putative source of the arrow of time."²⁴ At its multiple scales, variant rhythms of nonseparability, waves, currents, and vortices fold and unfold the irreversible and nonlinear space-time of our becoming. The ocean of creativity and the fire of apocalypse no longer sit at opposite ends of a time line. But the cloud does not unite them; it does not extinguish or absorb them. What, now, is its drift?

A cloud is of course a phenomenon of the circulation of fire and water—of shifting intensities of the sun's heat interactively producing earth's vapors from its

waters. Now more than ever we are recognizing ourselves in the complex feedback loops of Gaia, the circulations of elemental, vegetal, animal, personal relations. I have argued that the relationality exhibits its more promising potentiality in cloud perspective. For here endings and beginnings coincide. Here where no God spells out time from alpha to omega, an Elohimic plurisignularity instead complicates each in each and all in all.²⁵ And urges us, lures us, to some particular configuration of sociality, institution, church, movement, art, and media by which, with irreducible difference, we may now mindfully implicate our histories in each other—and therefore in our entangled futures.

Here *we* have to make our world, but never alone. We are doing a deity who does not do for us or to us, but does make do with us. Us altogether. Not a personal God-entity, this. Is God then the personal nickname of the mere impersonality of the universe? Or of something endlessly more complicating, inclusive of all persons inhabiting it? And therefore suggestive of a more than, not less than, personal embrace, enfolding personality, animality, vegetality, elementality in the instantaneity of its superpositions?

The “I am” in burning bush or Red Sea waters stirs the elemental imagination even as it entangles itself unspeakably in each witnessing “I.” The cloud continued to host new liberations. “I am the alpha and the omega.” Was this, as the desperate hope goes, the exodus from the earth—at last? Or only from the known order, from all that represses the new creation, the new atmosphere and earth?

So we might say, among friends: the coincidentia of alpha and omega comes as a phenomenon of cloud. It yields for the earthlings a house of possibility, billowing shekchinically into the unknown.²⁶ In this temporal crossover of genesis and new creation, in its co-incident now, the threat of doom is not disappearing. Or we might say in a more public language: the pressure of looming climate cataclysm has been deepening the dangerous denials, the willful ignorance. And at the same time it may—if relayed in wisdom rather than panic—provoke the shift forward, beyond this epoch of our species’ suicidal momentum.

Inside the apocalyptic warning lurks the lure. Its hope may be a dim nuance of improbable future. But without the attractive power of amorously shareable possibility, the frightening facts cannot be heard. Fear hardens denial and seeks easy foes to finger. Prophetic discourse will work best if it attends both to the “sixth

extinction" *and* to "the tender elements in the world, which slowly and in quietness operate by love."²⁷



To sum up, again, otherwise: a fold of nonseparability and nonknowing, whether as relational and apophatic theologies, or as crowd and cloud, patterned this book. Its chiasm can now also locate itself in the theopoetic time of a co-incident of alpha and omega. But then, admittedly, a specter of classical salvation history—creation, Christ, new creation—does seem to linger. Inasmuch as a christographics of love has inscribed itself upon the present cloud, and so upon a space where genesis coincides with new becoming, this book honors the Nazarene it largely unsays, that is, respects with silence. But cloud-inscriptions yield porously to the multiplicity of religious and ethical Ways, insofar as they remain mutually questionable and questioning. "The Way that can be spoken of is not the constant Way; the name that can be named is not the constant name."²⁸

So Logos does not arrive—just in time—to recenter the timeline. The apophatic constancy of the Way is not an intersecting eternity. Nor does it unfold the straight temporality of a one-way truth. When Christ comes again (now and then) it is to deconstruct the christomonist certainties. Jesus was not about—himself. What he nicknamed Abba, what he *did*, the love he made, was redistributing itself in him to the wretched. Given that "the least" remain so many, was this embodiment a failure? Always a kosher question. The incarnation remains an experiment, result still indeterminate, in interarnation.



Indeterminacy however comes entrained in the cumulative determinations of the past. The very climate circulates figures and parables of impossibility. The economies of indifference spew planetary death. And at the same time a rosy-cheeked morning cloud floats graciously before you.

No facts will bring closure; no apocalypse will trump its own apophasis. "As imagination bodies forth the forms of things unknown,"²⁹ fresh ecoreligiopolitical

strategies, effectual lamentations, resilient coalitions, nonviolent militancies, unexpected breakthroughs will keep happening. Across the threshold of catastrophe, the convivial cosmopolis can—posse ipsum—yet coalesce. There is no God-guarantee on the outcome; but there is the lure. To come forth, to come out, to come again, and, further, to encounter in the knowingness of nonknowing whatever comes. It may never have left, and never left off multiplying. “It is capable of being the mother of the universe; I do not know its name.”³⁰

Every now and then a powwow in the cloud may transfigure figures of speech into agencies of planetary creativity. To the practice of nonseparable difference and by way of its smudged panentheism are invited any theisms, atheisms, pluri-theisms, anatheisms, pantheisms willing to tarry there. All are invited to practice mindfulness of their own apophatic entanglement. Enfold a world as you breathe in; unfold it differently as you exhale. Many will have their own amorous nicknames for the entangled life of the universe. Many will ignore everything but the endangered lives of the earth.

Too much, too many? But each of us is that already, as Cloud Cult sings it:

*And everybody here is a crowd,
we all walk around with a million faces.
Somebody turn the lights out.
There's so much more to see
In our darkest places.*³¹

NOTES

BEFORE

1. Jacques Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," in *On the Name*, trans. David Wood, John P. Leavey Jr., and Ian McLeod (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1995), 75.
2. Ibid., 43.
3. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, ed. and trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 251.
4. Ibid.
5. Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (New York: Free Press, 1967 [1925]), 25.
6. Édouard Glissant, *Poetics of Relation*, trans. Betsy Wing (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1997), 27.
7. Sharon V. Betcher, *Spirit and the Obligation of Social Flesh: A Secular Theology for the Global City* (New York: Fordham, 2014), 17.
8. Richard Kearney, *Anatheism: Returning to God After God* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010), 5.
9. *The Love Poems of John Keats*, xi, cited by David Wood, who frames a "post-deconstructive approach to ethics and politics" in terms of the negative capability, which "here means letting go of the seemingly attractive idea of reaching an end, never having to struggle again." Such an idea certainly mesmerizes most religion as well as most anti-religion. "Negative capability is both a conceptual and an existential achievement—the recognition of ongoing contingent engaged temporality as the plane on which we all must make our fragile sense." David Wood, *The Step Back: Ethics and Politics After Deconstruction* (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2005), 7.

10. *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, trans. Colm Luibheid (Mahwah, NJ: Paulist, 1987), 997 A–B.
11. Justin Gillis, “Clouds’ Effect on Climate Change Is Last Bastion for Dissenters,” *New York Times*, www.nytimes.com/2012/05/01/science/earth/clouds-effect-on-climate-change-is-last-bastion-for-dissenters.html?_r=1&pagewanted=all (accessed December 17, 2013).
12. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 346.

I. THE DARK NUANCE OF BEGINNING

1. “Consider the book. It has extraordinary staying power . . . Why then do we continue to hear prophecies about the death of the book?” Robert Darnton, *The Case for Books: Past, Present, and Future* (New York: PublicAffairs, 2009), 68.
2. I find myself starting close to where Rubenstein concludes: “The wonderer wonders: jaw dropped in astonishment, incomprehension, anticipation, rage: ears trained on what calls for help, for justice, for thought; eyes wide open to the absence of sense, the limits of knowledge, the touch of all things that opens out possibility.” Mary-Jane Rubenstein, *Strange Wonder: The Closure of Metaphysics and the Opening of Awe* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2008), 196.
3. The Swedish ethicist Elisabeth Gerle examines the “dangerous simplifications” exemplified in xenophobic cases of religio-political violence. She shows how forms of liberal secularism sometimes surprisingly echo right wing versions of Islamophobia.. *Farlig förenkling: Om religion och politik utifrån Sverigedemokraterna och Humanisterna* (Nora: Nya Doxa, 2010).
4. *The Poems of Emily Dickinson*, ed. R. W. Franklin (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1998), 504. For further reflection on the contemplative iconoclasm of Dickinson vis-à-vis the theological heritage, and in particular as the uncanny muse for an entangled (trans) feminist intersectionality, apophatic uncertainty, and polydoxical multiplicity, see Catherine Keller, “‘And Truth—so Manifold!’ Transfeminist Entanglements,” *Feminist Theology* 22 (2012): 77–87.
5. *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, trans. Colm Luibheid (Mahwah, NJ: Paulist, 1987), 98.
6. *Ibid.*, 82.
7. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, ed. and trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 252.
8. Édouard Glissant, “The Unforseeable Diversity of the World,” in *Beyond Dichotomies: Histories, Identities, Cultures, and the Challenge of Globalization*, ed. Elisabeth M. Mudimbeboyi (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2002), 252.
9. See Catherine Keller, “Theopoetics and the Pluriverse: Notes on a Process,” in *Theopoetic Folds: Philosophizing Multifariousness*, ed. Roland Faber and Jeremy Fackenthal (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013), 179–194.

10. 1 Corinthians 13:12 contains the phrase *βλεπομεν γαρ αρτι δι εσοπτρου εν αινιγματι* (*blepomen gar arti di esoptrou en ainigmati*). And the “mirror” was in King James’s time like ours, of glass, but in Paul’s of polished brass. The Babylonian Talmud states similarly “All the prophets gazed through a speculum that does not shine, while Moses our teacher gazed through a speculum that shines.” Yevamot 49b. But such shining does not render the mirror a figure of representationalism or of transparency. For crucial feminist reflections on the mirror, see Luce Irigaray, *Speculum of the Other Woman*, trans. Gillian C. Gill (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1985).
11. “The attempt at introspective analysis in these cases is in fact like seizing a spinning top to catch its motion, or trying to turn up the gas quickly enough to see how the darkness looks.” William James, *The Principles of Psychology* (New York: Holt, 1890), 1:244.
12. 1 Corinthians 13:1. All biblical citations unless otherwise noted are from the New Revised Standard Version, see ed. Michael David Coogan, Marc Zvi Brettler, Carol A. Newsom, and Pheme Perkins *The New Oxford Annotated Bible: With the Apocrypha* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2010).
13. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 40. We will return recurrently to this line of thinking in Whitehead, especially in chapter 5, as the great breakthrough of a scientifically grounded and theologically game-changing ontological relationalism.
14. Jacques Derrida, *The Animal That Therefore I Am*, ed. Marie-Louise Mallet, trans. David Wills (New York: Fordham University Press, 2008), 29. For transdisciplinary theological reflection on this animal, bodily, multiplicitous, and ecological differentiation, if not ecological shift in Derrida’s thinking, see *Divinanimality: Animal Theory, Creaturely Theology*, ed. Stephen Moore and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press, 2014).
15. Stéphane Mallarmé, “Remembrance of Belgian Friends,” in *Collected Poems: A Bilingual Edition*, trans. Henry Weinfield (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1994), 53.
16. See Laurel C. Schneider, *Beyond Monotheism: A Theology of Multiplicity* (London: Routledge, 2008). Schneider demonstrates that *monotheism* as a term does not appear until 1698 (19), and should not be confused with the biblical and Jewish meaning of the one God, which harbors its own complexity. The monistic logic she so persuasively questions is that in Hellenism of “the One, immutable, indivisible, disembodied, perfect, and eternal” (52).
17. See Roland Faber, “Bodies of the Void: Polyphilia and Theoplicity,” in *Apophatic Bodies Negative Theology, Incarnation, and Relationality*, ed. Chris Boesel and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press, 2010), 200–227.
18. Cloud Cult, “Everybody Here Is a Cloud,” www.cloudcult.com/track/222710/everybody-here-is-a-cloud?feature_id=33133 (accessed February 6, 2014).
19. The location of this source is contested. Here is a brief history on the history of contestation: <http://qlipoth.blogspot.com/2009/11/easier-to-imagine-end-of-world.html>.
20. Bertrand Russell, *The History of Western Philosophy* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1945), xiv. Thanks to Krista E. Hughes for this reference.

21. William E. Connolly, *Capitalism and Christianity, American Style* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2008).
22. See William E. Connolly, *Why I Am Not a Secularist*. (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999); David Ray Griffin, John B. Cobb, Richard A. Falk, and Catherine Keller, *The American Empire and the Commonwealth of God: A Political, Economic, Religious Statement* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2006); Melanie Johnson-DeBaufre, Catherine Keller, and Elias Ortega y Aponte, eds., *Common Good(s): Ecology, Economy, and Political Theology* (New York: Fordham University Press, forthcoming).
23. Yvonne Sherwood and Kevin Hart, eds., *Derrida and Religion: Other Testaments* (New York: Routledge, 2005), 53–96.
24. Phillip Clayton, *Adventures of the Spirit: God World Divine Action* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2008), 25.
25. Žižek offers as his own “Christian stance” a parallax of Che Guevara and the Jesus who brings not peace but sword; he calls it “the opposite of the Oriental attitude of non-violence, which—as we know from the long history of Buddhist rulers and warriors—can legitimize the worst violence.” Slavoj Žižek, Eric L. Santner, and Kenneth Reinhard, *The Neighbor: Three Inquiries in Political Theology* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2005), 186.
26. Georges Bataille, *Inner Experience*, trans. Leslie Anne Boldt (New York: SUNY Press, 1988 [1954]), 4.
27. John D. Caputo, *The Insistence of God: A Theology of Perhaps* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2013), 62f.
28. Jim Perkinson, quoted in *On the Mystery: Discerning Divinity in Process*, ed. Catherine Keller (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2008), 157–158.
29. Meister Eckhart, “Sermon 83: Renovamini spiritu,” in *Meister Eckhart: The Essential Sermons, Commentaries, Treatises and Defense*, trans. Edmund Colledge and Bernard McGinn (Mahwah: Paulist, 1981), 208.
30. The context is that of Jeremiah, citing YHWH, who is confronting King Josiah: “Did your father not eat and drink and do justice and righteousness? Then it was well with him” (Jeremiah 22:15b, 16). Relationality of Hebrew “knowing” trends toward the broadest possible justice, not only toward humans: “The righteous know [*yada*] the needs of their animals, but the mercy of the wicked is cruel” (Proverbs 12:10). Such sophic sarcasm anticipates our world of efficient corporate cruelty, if not our time of mass extinctions.
31. Jean-Luc Marion, *The Idol and Distance* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2001), 141.
32. Thomas King, *Green Grass, Running Water* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1993).
33. Cf. Cheryl Gilkes’s discussion of the limitations of the notion of triple jeopardy and of Deborah King’s suggestion of “multiple jeopardy.” Cheryl Townsend Gilkes, “The ‘Loves’ and ‘Troubles’ of African-American Women’s Bodies: The Womanist Challenge to Cultural Humiliation and Community Ambivalence,” in Katie Geneva Cannon, Emilie M.

- Townes, and Angela D. Sim, eds., *Womanist Theological Ethics: A Reader* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2011), 86.
34. Pantheism has served as a helpful marker of, for instance, process theology's God/world relation and all those that emphasize "all in God" and so "God in all" rather than "God above all" (the dualism of classical theism) and "God as all" (the monism of pantheism). Its third position should not suggest any symmetry of power or position between orthodoxy and what it accuses of pantheism. Nor should the differential "in/en," as we shall see, reinscribe the habitual separation. For a helpful introduction, cf. John W. Cooper, *Panentheism, the Other God of the Philosophers: From Plato to the Present* (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker Academic, 2006). Also panentheism now serves a useful comparative function across the world religions, cf. also Loriliai Biernacki and Philip Clayton, *Pantheisms Across the World's Traditions* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2014).
 35. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 352.
 36. Nelle Morton, *The Journey Is Home* (Boston: Beacon, 1985).
 37. See Catherine Keller, "The Apophasis of Gender: A Fourfold Unsayings of Feminist Theology," *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 76, no. 4 (2008): 905–933 and "The Cloud of the Impossible" in *Apophasis: Negative Theology, Incarnation, and Relationality*, ed. Chris Boesel and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press, 2010), 25–45.
 38. Nelle Morton (vis-à-vis the feminist "goddess"), then Sallie McFague, in *Metaphorical Theology*, and again, strongly, Elizabeth Johnson, in *She Who Is*, have driven home the theopolitics of metaphor over a couple of formative generations of feminist theology.
 39. Howard Thurman, *The Luminous Darkness: A Personal Interpretation of the Anatomy of Segregation and the Ground of Hope* (New York: Harper and Row, 1965), vii–viii.
 40. Catherine Keller, *Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003).
 41. When receiving the Nobel Peace Prize in 1964, King hailed the "successful precedent" of using nonviolence "in a magnificent way by Mohandas K. Gandhi to challenge the might of the British Empire. . . . He struggled only with the weapons of truth, soul force, non-injury and courage." Martin Luther King Jr., "The Quest for Peace and Justice: Nobel Lecture, December 11, 1964," in *Nobel Lectures: Peace, 1951–1970* (London: World Scientific, 1999), 338.
 42. See John Thatamanil's beautiful exposition of the interreligious depth of the Ghandhi/King ensemble, in "The Hospitality of Receiving: Mahatma Gandhi, Martin Luther King, Jr., and Interreligious Learning," in *In an Inescapable Network of Mutuality: Martin Luther King, Jr. and the Globalization of an Ethical Ideal*, ed. Lewis V. Baldwin, Paul R. Dekar, and Vicki L. Crawford (Eugene: Cascade, 2013).
 43. I thank the Rev. Christian Kakez y Kapend, a Drew Ph.D. student, for this helpful supplement: "However much Martin Luther King, Jr. might have been influenced by Western or Asian relational thought, let us not forget that he also had a relational thinking from his

- 'African' heritage. This could be traced back to the traditional African ethic of Bumuntu that stresses the intricate interconnectedness and interdependence of all creatures. And by the way, 'Bumuntu' is the Swahili term for the Xhosa and Zulu word 'Ubuntu.'" Note also that Laurel Schneider's chapter on the "roots of multiplicity in Africa," an examination of the beginnings of trinitarian theology with the North African Tertullian, is called "I am because we are" (John Mbiti's Ubuntu alternative to Descartes). Schneider, *Beyond Monotheism*, 65.
44. For this phrase I thank the Quaker educator, artist, community organizer, and scholar L. B. Callid Keefe Perry, *Way to Water: A Theopoetics Primer* (Eugene, OR: Cascade, 2014).
 45. Martin Luther King Jr. at Oberlin, www.oberlin.edu/external/EOG/BlackHistoryMonth/MLK/CommAddress.html (accessed January 30, 2014).
 46. As I revised this section I happened to receive an e-mail from Drew Ph.D. student Anna Blaedel, visiting home in Iowa, about to organize a church tea with ninety-six-year-old "Marion Solomon, an activist, Quaker, great-grandma, nurse, and justice-seeker. She marched with King, has been arrested protesting School of the Americas, participated in numerous trips to Palestine working to end the occupation, and walked with the Gandhians through India. She is a trained nurse and spouse of United Methodist clergy. Commitments to peace with justice, nuclear disarmament, and Palestinian liberation have propelled her life work. She laughs loudly, and the back of her car is haphazardly plastered with bumper stickers."
 47. James Cone, as the father of Black Liberation theology, majestically tracks both King's influence and Black divergence, in *Martin and Malcolm and America: A Dream or a Nightmare* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1991). Dream or nightmare: the wrenching indeterminacy of the cloud of the impossible.
 48. Ivone Gebara, *Out of the Depths: Women's Experience of Evil and Salvation*, trans. Ann Patrick Ware (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress, 2002), 132 (italics mine).
 49. Ibid.
 50. See the previously mentioned Sallie McFague, *Metaphorical Theology: Models of God in Religious Language* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1982) and *The Body of God: An Ecological Theology* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 1993).
 51. Ibid.
 52. I juxtaposed these two Latin American feminist theologies in chapter 1 of *Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003).
 53. Just as I finish this final draft, I receive in the mail, for instance, Whitney Bauman's *Religion and Ecology: Developing a Planetary Ethic* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014), an ecological relationalism that concludes with this dramatic performance of what I am calling apophatic entanglement: "The only certainty is that when certainty is imposed on the world love is impossible and violence is inevitable" (172).
 54. See John D. Caputo and Gianni Vattimo, *After the Death of God*, ed. Jeffrey W. Robbins (New York: Columbia University Press), 2007.

55. Clayton Crockett, *Radical Political Theology: Religion and Politics After Liberalism* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011), 55.
56. Saint Cyril of Jerusalem, "Catechetical Homilies" in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wallace (New York: Cosimo, 2007), 7:33.
57. Ibid. "For we explain not what God is but candidly confess that we have not exact knowledge concerning Him. For in what concerns God to confess our ignorance is the best knowledge."
58. Édouard Glissant, *Poetics of Relation*, trans. Betsy Wing (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1997), 186.
59. Michael A. Sells, *Mystical Languages of Unsayings* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994), 3.
60. Amy Tan, *Saving Fish from Drowning* (New York: Penguin, 2005).
61. Meister Eckhart, "Sermon 83" 53.
62. See Marguerite Porete, *The Mirror of Simple Souls*, trans. Ellen Babinsky (New York: Paulist, 1993).
63. Sells, *Mystical Languages of Unsayings*, 1.
64. "Durchbruch meant breaking through to another, altogether more strange and forbidding region where, embarrassed by the clumsiness of the things we say about God and the meanness of our desires to get what we can from God, we are finally led to break off all such human pettiness and to appreciate the sheer transcendence of God, his utter resistance to this kind of mortal folly." John D. Caputo, *Radical Hermeneutics: Repetition, Deconstruction, and the Hermeneutic Project* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1987), 269.
65. Ibid., 3.
66. Ibid., 12.
67. Jacques Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," in *On the Name*, ed. Thomas Dutoit, trans. David Wood, John P. Leavey Jr., and Ian McLeod (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1995), 71.
68. He is folding together in his terse crystallization two traditions: the first a practice of reading scripture, particularly that performed by Gregory of Nyssa's exegesis of Moses' encounter with the one God in the "dark cloud"; the second that of reading Platonism, particularly of Plotinus's One "beyond being."
69. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Mystical Theology*, trans. Colm Luibheid (New York: Paulist, 1987), chapter 5, 141.
70. She continues: "What the divine nature is is constituted by who God is in triune relationality without remainder." While the very threeness of the trinity begs the apophysis of an indeterminate multiplicity, the translation of trinitarianism "without remainder" into relationalism is a propitious doctrinal strategy. Elizabeth A. Johnson, *She Who Is: The Mystery of God in Feminist Theological Discourse* (New York: Crossroad, 1992), 127.

71. Jacques Derrida, "How to Avoid Speaking: Denials," trans. Ken Frieden, in *Derrida and Negative Theology*, ed. Harold Coward and Toby Foshay (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 74.
72. *Ibid.*, 77.
73. Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," 69.
74. Jacques Derrida, *Specters of Marx* (New York: Routledge, 1994), 59.
75. Derrida, *On the Name*, 43–44. "Die überunmöglichste ist möglich. / Du Kanst mit deinem Pfeil die Sonne nicht erreichen, / Ich kan mit meinem wol die ewge Sonn bestreichen."
"The most impossible is possible. / With your arrow you cannot reach the sun, / With mine I can sweep under my fire the eternal sun."
76. Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," 85.
77. Kevin Hart, *The Trespass of the Sign* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2000), 186.
78. Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," 74.
79. Jacques Derrida, *The Gift of Death* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1995), 77.
80. *Ibid.*, 77f.
81. Jacques Derrida, "Deconstructions: The Im-possible," in *French Theory in America*, ed. Sylvère Lotringer and Sande Cohen (New York: Routledge, 2001), 31.
82. Richard Kearney had more heartily preceded Derrida in calling upon Cusa's posse ipsum in *The God Who May Be: A Hermeneutics of Religion* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2001).
83. Derrida, "Deconstructions," 31.
84. "On the Summit of Contemplation," in *Nicholas of Cusa*, 295.
85. I mean here a fleeting shout-out to Mel Y Chen, *Animacies: Biopolitics, Racial Mattering, and Queer Affect* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2012) for her calling upon a wild range of affinities while demanding "fierce sensitivity to their differences." Indeed the apophatic entanglement is at hand: she returns beautifully to Trinh T. Minh-ha's ethnographic ethics "not to speak about/Just speak nearby" (237).
86. James Joyce's "chaosmos of Alle," borrowed by Deleuze, who applies it to Whitehead's cosmology, lends itself also to a reading of creation not *ex nihilo* but ever emergent from the darkness upon the *tehom*; see Keller, *Face of the Deep*.
87. Glissant transmutes the nightmare ocean of the middle passage into an im-possibility, thus opening his *Poetics of Relation*; see the epigraph to "Before," this volume.

2. CLOUD-WRITING

1. Charles M. Stang, "Negative Theology from Gregory of Nyssa to Dionysius the Areopagite," in *The Wiley-Blackwell Companion to Christian Mysticism*, ed. Julia A. Lamm (Malden: Blackwell, 2013), 170.

2. Numbers 14:14. Biblical citations continue to be drawn primarily from the New Revised Standard Version.
3. Exodus 19:9.
4. Exodus 19:16.
5. Jeffrey L. Rubenstein, *The History of Sukkot in the Second Temple and Rabbinic Periods* (Atlanta: Scholars, 1995), 245.
6. Ibid., 249.
7. Ibid., 251.
8. Ibid., 255; Daniel 7:13.
9. Mayra Rivera, "Glory: The First Passion of Theology?" in *Polydoxy: Theology of Multiplicity and Relation*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel C. Schneider (London: Routledge, 2011), 177.
10. Ibid., 180.
11. Exodus 24.
12. Daniel Boyarin, *Border Lines: The Partition of Judaeo-Christianity* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2004), 166.
13. Ibid., 165.
14. "On the Question Why Certain Names in the Holy Scriptures Are Changed," in *The Works of Philo Judaeus*, trans. C. D. Yonge (London: Henry G. Bohn, 1854), 2:240.
15. Andrew Louth, *The Origins of the Christian Mystical Tradition* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1981), 19.
16. *Parmenides*, in *The Collected Dialogues of Plato*, ed. Edith Hamilton and Huntington Cairns, trans. Francis MacDonald Cornford (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1961), 937.
17. Ibid.
18. Plotinus, *Ennead* V.5.6, in William Franke, ed., *On What Cannot Be Said: Apophatic Discourses in Philosophy, Religion, Literature, and the Arts, vol. 1, Classic Formulations* (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 2007), 51.
19. "An overview of Western apophasis would begin with Plotinus (d. 270 CE). Though elements of apophasis existed earlier, it was Plotinus who wove these elements and his own original philosophical and mystical insights into a discourse of sustained apophatic intensity." Michael A. Sells, *Mystical Languages of Unsaying* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994), 5.
20. Plotinus, *Ennead* V.5.6, in *On What Cannot Be Said*.
21. In the Eastern church Neoplatonism would fund the distinction between the essence and the energies of God, formalized in the thirteenth century with Gregory Palamas.
22. I'm grateful for some informal comments from Charles Stang, which are thus included, along with engagement of his published work.

23. Cited in Henny Fiska Hägg, *Clement of Alexandria and the Beginnings of Christian Apophaticism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006).
24. William Franke notes that “even Porphyry’s supreme God, the One that *is*, has no concern for any of the things that are, the beings that come after him.” Franke, *On What Cannot Be Said*, 15–16.
25. *Ennead* VI.8.15, lines 1–3. This passage, although somewhat odd in the wider landscape of the *Enneads*, is put to much use by not only Pierre Hadot, in *Plotinus, or The Simplicity of Vision*, but also by Julia Kristeva in “Narcissus: The New Identity,” in *Tales of Love* (New York: Columbia Press University Press, 1987), 103–121.
26. Acts 17:23.
27. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses* (New York: Paulist, 1978), 95.
28. *Ibid.*
29. *Ibid.*
30. *Ibid.*
31. Denys Turner, *The Darkness of God: Negativity in Christian Mysticism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995), 17.
32. *Ibid.*
33. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*, 95.
34. See Catherine Keller, *Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003).
35. Virginia Burrus, *Begotten Not Made: Conceiving Manhood in Late Antiquity* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000), 109.
36. Stang, “Negative Theology,” 166–167. “They are crucial for understanding the development of negative mystical theology precisely because there is, so to speak, an apophaticism without mysticism, an astonishingly austere and astringent negative logic that, in the effort to safeguard the transcendence of the one true God, banishes that God from its own creation.”
37. *Gregory of Nyssa: Contra Eunomium II*, ed. Lenka Karfiková, Scot Douglass, and Johannes Zachhuber (Leiden: Brill, 2007), 73.
38. *Gregory of Nyssa: Contra Eunomium II*, 75, 62, 77.
39. Stang, “Negative Theology,” 168–169.
40. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*, 97.
41. See Virginia Burrus, “Theology and Eros After Nygren,” in *Toward A Theology of Eros: Transfiguring Passion at the Limits of Discipline*, ed. Virginia Burrus and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press, 2006), xiii.
42. Stang, “Negative Theology,” 169.
43. *Ibid.*, 169.
44. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*, 46.
45. *Ibid.*, 115.

46. Michael Nausner, "Subjects In-Between: A Theological Boundary Hermeneutics," Ph.D. diss., Drew University, 2005.
47. Ibid., 2.238.
48. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*, 50.
49. Ibid., 117.
50. Gregory of Nyssa: *Contra Eunomium II*, 74, 83.
51. Rowan Williams, "Gregory of Nyssa on Mind and Passion," in *Christian Faith and Greek Philosophy in Late Antiquity*, ed. Lionel Wickham and Caroline P. Bammel (Leiden: Brill, 1993), 244.
52. Gregory of Nyssa: *Contra Eunomium II*, 75.
53. Ibid., 83.
54. Kathryn Tanner, "In the Image of the Invisible," in *Apophatic Bodies: Negative Theology, Incarnation, and Relationality*. Ed. Chris Boesel and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press.)
55. Ibid., 84.
56. Ibid., 84–85.
57. Stephen F. Brett, *Slavery and the Catholic Tradition: Rights in the Balance* (New York: Peter Lang, 1994).
58. Gregory of Nyssa, *Homilies on Ecclesiastes: An English Version with Supporting Studies*, ed. Stuart Hall, Proceedings of the Seventh International Colloquium on Gregory (Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, 1993), 74.
59. "When rational thought approaches the impossible and incomprehensible it will surely fail." Gregory of Nyssa: *Contra Eunomium II*, 75.
60. Turner, *The Darkness of God*, 13.
61. Ibid., 13.
62. Jean-Luc Marion, *The Idol and Distance: Five Studies* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2001), 141.
63. Pseudo-Dionysius, *Mystical Theology*, in Franke, *On What Cannot Be Said*, 1:174.
64. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Ecclesiastical Hierarchy*, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 195.
65. Ibid., 217.
66. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Mystical Theology*, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 137.
67. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Celestial Hierarchy*, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 180.
68. Quoted in Turner, *The Darkness of God*, 21.
69. Ibid.
70. Jacques Derrida, "How to Avoid Speaking: Denials," trans. Ken Frieden, in *Derrida and Negative Theology*, ed. Harold Coward and Toby Foshay (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1992), 77.
71. Pseudo-Dionysius, 98. Mary-Jane Rubenstein comments on Derrida's "no" that "it is tempting to recuperate even this denial under the apophatic tent, and Derrida concedes that 'this

- reading will always be possible. Who could prohibit it? In the name of what?" "Dionysius, Derrida, and the Critique of 'Ontotheology,'" in *Re-Thinking Dionysius the Areopagite*, ed. Sarah Coakley and Charles M. Stang (Malden: Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), 197.
72. Franke, *On What Cannot Be Said*, 1:159.
 73. Derrida, "How to Avoid Speaking," 77.
 74. Jean-Luc Marion, *In Excess: Studies of Saturated Phenomenon*, trans. Robyn Horner and Vincent Berrand (New York: Fordham University Press, 2002), 132.
 75. Jacques Derrida, "Sauf le nom (Post-Scriptum)," in *On the Name*, ed. Thomas Dutoit, trans. David Wood, John P. Leavy Jr., and Ian McLeod (Stanford: Stanford, 1995), 71.
 76. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Mystical Theology*, 139.
 77. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Celestial Hierarchy*, 150.
 78. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Divine Names*, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 56.
 79. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Mystical Theology*, 141.
 80. *Ibid.*, 139.
 81. *Ibid.*, 141 (*italics mine*).
 82. Then again John Caputo protects Aquinas too against the Heideggerian charge: "in St. Thomas metaphysics itself tends to break down and to pass into a more profound experience of Being," John D. Caputo, *Heidegger and Aquinas: An Essay in Overcoming Metaphysics* (New York: Fordham University Press, 1982), 8.
 83. Eugene Thacker, *After Life* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2010), 35.
 84. Turner, *The Darkness of God*, 22.
 85. *Ibid.*
 86. T. S. Eliot, "Burnt Norton," in *Four Quartets* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1943).
 87. Sells, *Mystical Languages of Unsayings*, 12.
 88. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Divine Names*, in *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, 56.
 89. *Ibid.*
 90. *Ibid.*, 109.
 91. *Ibid.*, 82.
 92. Charles M. Stang, *Apophasis and Pseudonymity in Dionysius the Areopagite: 'No Longer I'* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2012), 169.
 93. Pseudo-Dionysius: *The Complete Works*, 82.
 94. Stang, *Apophasis and Pseudonymity*, 164.
 95. *Ibid.*, 170f.
 96. *Ibid.*, 169.
 97. *Ibid.*, 204.
 98. Turner, *The Darkness of God*, 47.
 99. Grace M. Jantzen, *Power, Gender, and Christian Mysticism* (Cambridge: University of Cambridge University Press, 1995), 107.
 100. *Ibid.*, 108.
 101. Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Divine Names*, 92.

102. Ibid., 66.
103. Pseudo-Dionysius: *The Complete Works*, 66, 7.
104. Turner, *The Darkness of God*, 29.
105. *The Pursuit of Wisdom: And Other Works by the Author of the Cloud of Unknowing*, ed. and trans. James Walsh (Mahwah: Paulist, 1988), 54.
106. *The Cloud of Unknowing*, ed. and trans. by James Walsh (Mahwah: Paulist, 1981), 128.
107. Walsh, *The Pursuit of Wisdom*, 75 (italics mine).
108. Jantzen, *Power, Gender, and Christian Mysticism*, 132.
109. *The Pursuit of Wisdom*, 75.
110. Nicola Masciandaro, "Unknowing Animals," in *Speculations II* (2011): 228–244, 241.
111. Gillian Rudd, "From Popular Science to Contemplation: The Clouds of *The Cloud of Unknowing*," in *Literature and Science*, ed. Sharon Ruston (Cambridge: English Association, 2008), 18.
112. Ibid., 32.
113. Ibid.
114. *The Cloud of Unknowing*, 128.
115. Dorothee Soelle, *The Silent Cry: Mysticism and Resistance* (Minneapolis: Augsburg, 2001), 58.
116. Ibid., 58.
117. "If we pay attention to Mirabai's and Hadewijch's ways of knowing and seeing the world, we find that they point to passionate non-attachment: paths of attachment fueled by longing, yet sheltered from possession or consumption-based systems of desire by these very energies of longing, as they open up into non-attachment." Holly Hillgardner, "Passionate Non-Attachment: Practice of Mystical Longing in Mirabi and Hadewijch: A Comparative Study," Ph.D. diss., Drew University, 2013.
118. *The Cloud of Unknowing*, 131.

3. ENFOLDING AND UNFOLDING GOD

1. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 235 (233–291).
2. Ibid., 236.
3. Ibid., 24 (italics and translation mine).
4. Michel de Certeau and Catherine Porter, "The Gaze: Nicholas of Cusa," in *Diacritics* 17, no. 3 (Autumn 1987): 6.
5. For a "moderately anachronistic" analysis of Cusa's "explicit complications" in philosophical context, see Von Arne Moritz, *Explizite Komplikatione: Der radikale Holismus des Nikolaus von Kues*, Buchreihe der Cusanus-Gesellschaft, band 14 (Münster: Aschendorff, 2006).
6. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 239.
7. Ibid., 243.

8. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 91 (85–206).
9. “And in his withdrawal, he confounds the gaze by making himself both eye and gaze.” *Ibid.*, 88.
10. *Ibid.*, 90.
11. Jean-Luc Nancy, *The Ground of the Image*, trans. Jeff Fort (New York: Fordham University Press, 2005), 10.
12. Karsten Harries, *Infinity and Perspective* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2001), 63.
13. De Certeau and Porter, “The Gaze,” 9.
14. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 244.
15. *Ibid.*
16. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 126.
17. Mary-Jane Rubenstein, “On Shepherds and Goat-Gods and Mountains and Monsters: The Matter with Pantheism,” in Catherine Keller, Mary-Jane Rubenstein, and Elias Ortega-Aponte, eds., *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and the New Materialism* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2015).
18. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 126.
19. *Ibid.*, 122.
20. Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 43.
21. *Ibid.*, 53.
22. In an impressive book just out as I finish, Hoff analyzes Cusa’s holism as a “radicalization of Dominican realism” and so as an alternative to “the analytic rationality of modernity,” to both its atomized individuality and totalization. His reading, differently than the present one, highlights the continuity of Cusa’s ontology of love with medieval Christological and participatory models. Johannes Hoff, *The Analogical Turn: Rethinking Modernity with Nicholas of Cusa* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2013).
23. Hoff argues that “the all-seeing gaze of Cusa’s icon is incompatible with the strategy of early modern portrait art which seeks to tie the faze of a portrait to a fixed angle of vision from which it becomes annexed and controlled.” *Ibid.*, 32.
24. De Certeau and Porter, “The Gaze,” 32.
25. *Ibid.*
26. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 243.
27. *Ibid.*, 244.
28. *Ibid.*
29. Ernst Cassirer, *The Individual and the Cosmos in Renaissance Philosophy* (New York: Harper and Row, 1963), 32.
30. Thus “every view of God is as much conditioned by the nature of the ‘object’ as by the nature of the ‘subject’; every view includes the thing seen as well as the manner and the direction of the seeing.” *Ibid.*

31. Ernst Cassirer, *Substance and Function and Einstein's Theory of Relativity* (New York: Dover, 1953), 23–24, *The Individual and the Cosmos in Renaissance Philosophy*, 32, 64, and *Determinism and Indeterminism in Modern Physics: Historical and Systematic Studies of the Problem of Causality* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1956), 32.
32. Cf. also Regine Kather, “The Earth as a Noble Star: The Arguments for the Relativity of Motion in the Cosmology of Nicholas of Cusanus and Their Transformation in Einstein’s Theory of Relativity” in *Cusanus: The Legacy of Learned Ignorance*, ed. Peter J. Casarella (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 2006), 226–251.
33. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 160–161.
34. Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 32.
35. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 242.
36. *Ibid.*, 251.
37. Catherine Keller, *From a Broken Web: Separation, Sexism, and Self* (Boston: Beacon, 1987).
38. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 87.
39. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 251.
40. *Ibid.*
41. *Ibid.*
42. *Ibid.*
43. *Ibid.*
44. *Ibid.*, 245.
45. W. J. Mitchell and Arnold I. Davidson, *The Late Derrida* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007), 230. Perhaps, along with the echoes of his earlier engagements of Dionysius, and then Silesius, his teacher (and the doctoral adviser of Deleuze) De Gandillac’s great work on Cusa is echoing (*La philosophie de Nicolas de Cues*.)
46. *Ibid.*
47. Jacques Derrida, “A Certain Impossible Possibility of Saying the Event,” in *The Late Derrida*, 227.
48. *Ibid.*, 240.
49. See John D. Caputo, *The Insistence of God: A Theology of Perhaps* (Bloomington: Indiana University, 2013).
50. *Ibid.*, 142.
51. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 252.
52. The unpredictable twists along of this synesthetic theologoumenon continue: “you speak to the earth, and you call it into human nature. *The earth hears you, and its hearing this is its becoming human being.*” *Ibid.*, 253. The creating is a calling, and it is at the same time a hearing which is a becoming. In a proto-Deleuzean gesture the human being is an event of the becoming earth. Presumably each species is the earth contracted in a new becoming.
53. *Ibid.*

54. Ibid., 256.
55. Ibid. (italics mine).
56. Ibid., 257 (italics mine).
57. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 257.
58. "Since everything which exists is not other than itself, assuredly it does not have this fact from any other. Therefore, it has it from Not-other." Nicholas of Cusa, *On Not Other (De Li Non Aliud) Complete Philosophical and Theological Treatises of Nicholas of Cusa*. Trans. Jasper Hopkins (Minneapolis: Arthur J. Banning, 2001), 2:1112. I am always indebted (if not not-other) to Roland Faber's interpretations of Cusa, to whose Non Aliud he is especially partial: "Using the term expressive in/difference, I take up Nicolas of Cusa's conception of God as non aliud. Cusa states that in being non aliud God 'is nothing other than the Non-Other.' Therefore, divine reality is identical with itself as the in/difference of anything and of itself. Since God is 'nothing other' than any reality, God cannot be stated as 'another' reality. God's singularity cannot be told within the differences we use to name reality (onto-logically). Hence, God cannot be identified as the Non-Other like any Other. Therefore, God is totally expressive of the reality to which God relates in God's being in/different to it; nevertheless, God as the 'Non-Other' is also not identical to this reality." Roland Faber, "De-Ontologizing God: Levinas, Deleuze, and Whitehead," in *Process and Difference: Between Cosmological and Poststructuralist Postmodernisms*, ed. Catherine Keller and Anne Daniell (Albany: State University of New York Press, 2002), 222.
59. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 251.
60. Ibid.
61. In deconstructing the orthodox unquestionability of the *creatio ex nihilo*—in which the biblical text is squarely on my side—I found certain Kabbalistic distinctions (as between the infinite Eyn Sof and the emergent or indeed "created" Elohim) crucial. Catherine Keller, *Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003), 178.
62. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Contra Gentiles*, trans. A. C. Pegis (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1957), 100.
63. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 150.
64. Process theology in its church-oriented explications is like all theology tempted to underplay its own cognitive uncertainty and to literalize its God as a discrete personal entity.
65. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 348.
66. Ibid., 193.
67. Ibid.
68. Ibid., 343.
69. "The consequent nature of God is his judgment on the world. He saves the world as it passes into the immediacy of his own life." Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 346.

70. Animal theorists in the wake of Derrida's "divinanimality" take note. Catherine Keller and Stephen Moore, *Divinanimality: Creaturely Theology* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2014).
71. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 162. When God is imagined as the soul of the world, the implication—which could not be directly stated without the accusation of heresy and pantheism—is of course that the universe is God's body. Charles Hartshorne, and later Sallie McFague, would unfold the implication, steering it panentheistically away from both a dualist and an identist soul/body relation. See my my "The Flesh of God: A Metaphor in the Wild," in Darby Ray, ed., *Theology That Matters: Economy, Ecology, and God* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2006).
72. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 21.
73. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 137. Cusa borrows the notion of the maximum, *maximitas*, from Anselm.
74. Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 134.
75. According to Elliot Wolfson, drawing a bridge to Kabbalah from this passage in Cusa, "we can, nay must, conclude that God both is and is not identical with the world, identical precisely because different, different precisely because identical." Perhaps in this rigorously paradoxical sense, in which transcendence and immanence are identified as well, a neighboring and risky version of apophatic entanglement is unfolding. Elliot Wolfson, *Language, Eros, Being: Kabbalistic Hermeneutics and Poetic Imagination* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2005), 31.
76. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 346.
77. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 247.
78. I thank the poet Susan Pensak for her suggestion of this paraphrase of *apophatic entanglement*.
79. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 246.
80. *Ibid.*, 246.
81. *Ibid.*, 244.
82. Sylvia Marcos, *Taken from the Lips: Gender and Eros in Mesoamerican Religions*. Forward by Catherine Keller (Leiden: Brill, 2006).
83. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 195.
84. *Ibid.*, 157.
85. *Ibid.*, 148.
86. Peter J. Casarella, "Nicholas of Cusa and the Power of the Possible," *American Catholic Philosophical Quarterly* 64, no. 1 (1990): 20 (7–34).
87. Jasper Hopkins, *Nichols of Cusa on God as Not Other: A Translation and an Appraisal of de li non aliud* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota, 1979), 49. Cf. Clyde Lee Miller, *Reading Cusanus: Metaphor and Dialectic in a Conjectural Universe* (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press), 2003.

88. Nicholas of Cusa, "On the Summit of Contemplation," 295.
89. Cusa, "On the Summit of Contemplation," in *Nicholas of Cusa*, 294.
90. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, *Outside in the Teaching Machine* (New York: Routledge, 1993), 38.
91. Proverbs 1:20.
92. "Hermeneutically retrieving Cusanus's idea of God as absolute possibility (*absoluta potentia*), I hold firm to the view that such *potentia* cannot be reduced to a totalizing necessity where every possible is ineluctably actualized from the beginning of time—history being reduced, by extension, to a slow-release 'unfolding' of some pre-established plan." Richard Kearney, *The God Who May Be: A Hermeneutics of Religion* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2001), 105. I suggest that by reading Cusa's posse ipsum in tandem with his earlier cosmology and his recurrent teaching of creaturely freedom, the determinist potential of his holism is interrupted.
93. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 135.
94. Ibid.
95. *Parmenides* (Second Hypothesis), in *The Collected Dialogues of Plato*, ed. Edith Hamilton and Huntington Cairns, trans. Francis MacDonald Cornford (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1961), 937.
96. Mary-Jane Rubenstein, *Worlds Without End: The Many Lives of the Multiverse* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014), 86.
97. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 140.
98. Ibid.
99. Ibid., 138.
100. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 80.
101. Ibid., 50.
102. Rubenstein, *Worlds Without End*, 83. She refers here to *De docta ignorantia*.
103. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 140.
104. Cited in Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 59.
105. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 134.
106. Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 50.
107. Cited *ibid.*, 24.
108. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 131.
109. Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 23.
110. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 130. Brad Bannon comments, "Yes, it does not take its place but gives its place (*es gibt*) so that the in-finite can take place in-the-finite, thereby losing one aspect of its infinity—shedding its hyperousiology." Yes, indeed.
111. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 134.
112. Rubenstein, *Worlds Without End*, 82.
113. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, 135.
114. Ibid., 158 (my emphasis).

115. Ibid.
116. Ibid., 159.
117. Harries, *Infinity and Perspective*, 23.
118. Ibid.
119. Nicholas of Cusa was never formally charged with pantheism. But Johannes Wenck, in his attack on *De docta ignorantia*, repeated in fact some of the accusations that had been made against Meister Eckhart. In his *Apologia doctae ignorantiae*, as response to Wenck's *De ignota litteratura*, Cusanus repeats his distinction between the "creature's contracted being" and "God's absolute Being." And, as Dupré notes, he also defends Eckhart against misinterpretations. Louis Dupré, "The Question of Pantheism from Eckhart to Cusanus," in *Cusanus: The Legacy of Learned Ignorance*, ed. Peter Casarella (Washington, DC: Catholic University Press, 2006), 75.
120. When Milbank proceeds to name this road not taken "a radicalization of Trinitarian orthodoxy," he is constructing a possible Cusanism, attractive to the radically orthodox version of postmodernity. Slavoj Žižek and John Milbank, *The Monstrosity of Christ: Paradox or Dialectic?* ed. Creston Davis (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2009), 193.
121. Cusa's own practices as a busy reformer would often disappoint not only Protestant criteria but current feminist, democratic, and pluralist sensibilities.
122. William E. Connolly, *Capitalism and Christianity, American Style* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2008), 50. See also my "Connolly's Mysterious Trinity Machine: A Panentheistic Reading," *Political Theology* 12, no. 2 (April 2011): 202–209.
123. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 249.
124. Ibid.
125. Watch for *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and Materiality*, the volume to come forth from Drew's most recent Transdisciplinary Theological Colloquium, with Karen Barad, March 2014 (New York: Fordham University Press, 2015). See note 21, this chapter.
126. Indeed some of his actual practices, however they must be relativized to historical context, leave much to be desired ethically.
127. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, 249.

4. SPOOKY ENTANGLEMENTS

1. Jeanette Winterson, *Gut Symmetries* (New York: Vintage, 1997), 84.
2. David Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order* (London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 1981), 225.
3. David Kaiser, *How the Hippies Saved Physics: Science, Counterculture, and the Quantum Revival* (New York: Norton, 2011), 3.
4. Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham: Duke University Press), 3.
5. Ibid., 396.

6. "Kabir 1440–1580," trans. Robert Bly, in *The Enlightened Heart: An Anthology of Sacred Poetry*, ed. Stephen Mitchell (New York: HarperPerennial, 1993), 70. Kabir, one of the great mystical poets of India, wrote in the Hindi vernacular and carries antidogmatic traces of Vedic and Quranic religion.
7. Phillip Clayton, *Adventures in the Spirit: God, World, Divine Action* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2008), 61.
8. Ibid., 60.
9. Ibid., 61.
10. Cf. Kirk Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God: Divine Relationality and Quantum Physics* (New York: Routledge, 2011). More recently, specialists of the science/theology dialogue have begun to discover quantum entanglement and to adapt it to a more orthodox theological language of relationality. See also, for a more preliminary set of essays by scientists and theologians, J. C. Polkinghorne, *The Trinity and an Entangled World: Relationality in Physical Science and Theology* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2010.)
11. "I am not arguing that the European trust in the scrutability of nature was logically justified even by its own theology. My only point is to understand how it arose. My explanation is that the faith in the possibility of science, generated antecedently to the development of modern scientific theory, is an unconscious derivative from medieval theology." Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (New York: Free Press, 1967 [1925]), 13.
12. See John Mason, "Quantum Flip-Floppers: Photon Findings Add to Mystery of Wave-Particle Duality," *Scientific American*, www.scientificamerican.com/article.cfm?id=quantum-delayed-choice&WT.mc_id=SA_CAT_physics_20121109 (accessed February 5, 2014).
13. Feynman et al. quoted in Karen Michelle Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham, NC : Duke University Press 2007) 254. Barad is citing Richard P. Feynman, Robert B. Leighton, and Matthew Sands, *The Feynman Lectures on Physics*, vols. 1-3 (Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1964).
14. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 91.
15. Brian Greene, *The Elegant Universe: Superstrings, Hidden Dimensions, and the Quest for the Ultimate Theory* (New York: Norton, 1999), 3.
16. Henry P. Stapp, "Bell's Theorem and World Process," in *Il Nuovo Cimento* 29, no. 2 (1975): 270–276.
17. John S. Bell, *Speakable and Unsayable in Quantum Mechanics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 169, 172.
18. Louisa Gilder, *The Age of Entanglement: When Quantum Physics Was Reborn* (New York: Knopf, 2008), xv.
19. Anton Zeilinger, *Dance of the Photons: From Einstein to Quantum Teleportation* (New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2010), 129.
20. Gilder, *The Age of Entanglement*, 1.

21. Fred R. Shapiro and Joseph Epstein, *The Yale Book of Quotations* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2006), 228.
22. Cited in Michel Weber, *After Whitehead: Rescher on Process Metaphysics* (Frankfurt: Ontos, 2004), 100.
23. Jeffrey Bub, "The Entangled World: How Can It Be Like That?" in *The Trinity and an Entangled World: Relationality in Physical Science and Theology*, ed. J. C. Polkinghorne (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2010), 16.
24. Wolfgang Pauli cited in Brian Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos: Space, Time, and the Texture of Reality* (New York: Vintage, 2004), 103.
25. Cf. Kaiser, *How the Hippies Saved Physics*, 68. For those in whose lives odd coincidences seem no less meaningful than random, the Jung-Pauli collaboration on the account of synchronicity as "non-causal connecting principle" may be illustrative.
26. Greene, *Fabric of the Cosmos*, 99.
27. Bruce Rosenblum and Fred Kuttner, *Quantum Enigma: Physics Encounters Consciousness* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2006), 188.
28. *Ibid.*, 170.
29. *Ibid.*, 188.
30. Marcelo Gleiser, *The Dancing Universe: From Creation Myths to the Big Bang* (New York: Dutton, 1997), 233.
31. Cited in Paul Davies, *God and the New Physics* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1983), 112.
32. Erwin Schrödinger, "Why Not Talk Physics," in *Quantum Questions: Mystical Writings of the World's Great Physicists*, ed. Ken Wilber (Boulder: Shambhala, 1984), 80.
33. Gleiser, *The Dancing Universe*, 235.
34. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 33.
35. *Ibid.*, 283.
36. As, for example, Wesley Wildman argues in "An Introduction to Relational Ontology" in *The Trinity and an Entangled World*, 55–74.
37. Davies, *God and the New Physics*, 103 (*italics mine*).
38. Though physics haunts deconstruction almost not at all, nonetheless the term is coined in response to the "specters of Marx" and thus to a form of materialism the Newtonian construction of which is coming here undone (though the "indeconstructibility of justice" is precisely what does not cease to haunt).
39. David Bohm, *Fragmentation and Wholeness* (Jerusalem: Van Leer Jerusalem Foundation, 1976), 8 (*italics mine*).
40. Sir Isaac Newton, *Opticks: Or, a treatise of the Reflections, Refractions, Inflections and Colours of Light* (London: William Innis, 1730), 376.
41. Cloud Cult, "Everybody Here Is a Cloud," www.cloudcult.com/track/222710/everybody-here-is-a-cloud?feature_id=33133 (accessed February 6, 2014).

42. I thank Kevin Mequet for the following supplement and for other gracious supplements:
 “The issue from Barad’s diffractive rereading of Bohr is that if the photon or electron or proton remains which-path indeterminate then an interference pattern develops with a maximum at the midline axis between the diffraction slits, but if the photon or electron or proton is rendered which-path determinate there is no interference pattern but a Gaussian normal distribution ‘Bell’ curve symmetrically about the midline axis between the diffraction slits and if the photon or electron or proton is 50/50 which-path indeterminate/determinate the interference pattern is inverted with a minimum at the midline axis between the diffraction slits. This forms the basis of Barad’s posthumanist performativity.”
43. I thank Clayton Crockett for this and many other friendly clarifications: “Specifically, in overlapping, which is to say ‘interfering’ with one another, waves can either add to form constructively double their crests or troughs, or subtract to form destructively zero amplitudes. They superpose upon one another, or form ‘superpositions’—structures transcendent of classical ‘positions.’”
44. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 265.
45. “Scoop up the Water and the Moon Is in Your Hands: On Feminist Theology and Dynamic Self-Emptying,” in *The Emptying God: A Buddhist-Jewish-Christian Conversation*, ed. John B. Cobb Jr. and Christopher Ives (Maryknoll: Orbis, 1990).
46. Henry P. Stapp, *Mindful Universe: Quantum Mechanics and the Participating Observer* (Berlin: Springer, 2007), 26–27.
47. “The quantum state of a single elementary particle can be visualized, roughly, as a continuous cloud of (complex) numbers, one assigned to every point in three-dimensional space.” It determines at any moment the “probability of finding’ (i.e. experiencing) a particular outcome.” Ibid., 25.
48. Ibid., 85–86.
49. Ibid., 88.
50. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality: An Essay in Cosmology*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 35.
51. Cited in Henry P. Stapp, *Mind, Matter, and Quantum Mechanics*, 3d ed. (Berkeley: University of California, 2009), 164.
52. “I may have gone beyond the explicit statements of Heisenberg by specifying that his actual events occur not only in true measurement situations, in which there is a human observer of some external device, but equally in all physically similar situations, regardless of whether a human observer is present or not.” Ibid., 284.
53. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 361.
54. Interview with Karen Barad, <http://quod.lib.umich.edu/o/ohp/11515701.0001.001/1:4.3/new-materialism-interviews-cartographics?rgn=div2;view=fulltext> (accessed February 6, 2014).
55. Henry P. Stapp, “Quantum Collapse and the Emergence of Actuality from Potentiality,” in *Process Studies* 38, no. 2 (2009): 339. See in this same issue Epperson’s *also* Whiteheadian

critique of Stapp as dualistic in his account of the psychophysical poles; but Stapp uses Whitehead's dipolar language rather precisely, if not with philosophical nuance. The problem may be exacerbated in that Stapp insists on *consciousness*, whereas Whitehead of course restricts that to a minority of animal occurrences, using *awareness* or *feeling* as the ontological term.

56. Ibid., 323.
57. Stapp, *Mindful Universe*, 94.
58. Ibid., 9.
59. Ibid., 117.
60. Ibid., 332 (italics mine).
61. Samuel Laurent, "Incarnational Creativity: A Pneumatology of Improvisation," Ph.D. diss., Drew University, 2012.
62. Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, 99.
63. Timothy Ferris, *The Whole Shebang: A State-of-the-Universe(s) Report* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1997), 269.
64. Gilder, *The Age of Entanglement*, 4.
65. John S. Bell, "Speakable and Unsayable in Quantum Mechanics," in J. S. Bell, *Collected Papers on Quantum Philosophy: Speakable and Unsayable in Quantum Mechanics*, ed. Simon Capelin (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 172.
66. Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, 111.
67. Barad continues: "either the very idea that individual objects possess discrete attributes is wrong, or interactions among objects are nonlocal, or both." Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 292.
68. George Greenstein and Arthur G. Zajonc, *The Quantum Challenge: Modern Research on the Foundation of Quantum Mechanics* (Sudbury, MA: Jones and Bartlett, 1997), cited in Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 292.
69. Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, 114.
70. Ibid., 115.
71. Ibid. As quantum entanglement is a phenomenon of intensive research in current physics, recent experimental results keep changing, moving to greater distances and to bigger objects. Its effects have been demonstrated with photons, electrons, molecules the size of buckyballs, and, recently, small diamonds. See, for instance, Olaf Nairiz, Markus Arndt, and Anton Zeilinger, "Quantum Interference Experiments with Large Molecules," *American Journal of Physics* 71 (April 2003): 319–325. Also K. C. Lee, M. R. Sprague, B. J. Sussman, J. Nunn, N. K. Langford, X.-M. Jin, T. Champion, P. Michelberger, K. F. Reim, D. England, D. Jaksch, I. A. Walmsley, "Entangling Macroscopic Diamonds at Room Temperature," *Science* 334 (December 2, 2011): 1253–1256.
72. Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, 115.
73. Rosenblum and Kuttner, *Quantum Enigma*, 227f.
74. Greene, *The Fabric of the Cosmos*, 16 (italics mine).
75. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 293–294.

76. Shimon Malin, *Nature Loves to Hide: Quantum Physics and Reality, a Western Perspective* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2003), 80.
77. My emphasis. "The discovery of impossibilities have often been important milestones in the history of physics." And then: "The framework of complementarity can be considered, then, a first step in the direction of transforming science into a mode of exploration that can incorporate ineffable truths." He then outlines the difficulties regarding data and its processing involved in such a deepening. *Ibid.*, 236–238.
78. *Ibid.*, 189.
79. "In contrast, the two connected but distinct events correspond to the appearance of an itch on her left leg, to which she responds by scratching it with her right hand. The graceful lifting of hand and leg is really a single movement; its two correlated components take place simultaneously. The two movements of itching and scratching are separated in time, however, since one is a reaction to the other." *Ibid.*, 187.
80. Bernard d'Espagnat, *On Physics and Philosophy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2006), 19. "If you are driving, you see the rainbow moving. If you stop it stops. If you start again, so does the rainbow. In other words, its properties partly depend on you." This might seem to be a parable about perspective. But he means more: the quantum object does not exist as some thing-in-itself that we simply cannot perceive, or only perceive partially. He argues that by taking the input of our senses literally, we have become falsely fixated on sense objects. "Classical physics taught us already that, while we tend to take a stone to symbolize the very notion of 'fullness,' it is, in fact, mainly composed of vacuum (the space between the nucleus and the electron)."
81. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 40.
82. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 336.
83. *Ibid.*, 338.
84. *Ibid.*, 345.
85. *Ibid.*, 350.
86. Most physicists do still believe that "the collapse of the wavefunction cuts the bond of entanglement." Kirk Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God: Divine Relationality and Quantum Physics* (New York: Routledge, 2011), 121 on Penrose.
87. Spyridon Koutroufinis, a philosophical biologist with background in theoretical physics, has generously offered this beautiful reading: "Universe as con-text. My association: Universe as text—Physiosemiotics. If cosmos is a semiotic whole the EPR is like the connection of two letters in one word or two words in one sentence. Those connections do not require that something 'travels' between the connected places. Letters and words appear locally but are connected non-locally. The same semiotic connection could apply to quantum entanglement."
88. Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God*, 123.
89. *Ibid.*, 211.

90. Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God*, 140.
91. The epigraph to this section is from “The Word,” in Ernesto Cardenal, *Pluriverse: New and Selected Poems* (New York: New Directions, 2009), 204. Cardenal founded, on the island of Solintiname in Nicaragua, 1965, a mostly peasant commune, was for a while minister of culture for the Sandinistas, has written the epic *Canticos Cosmicos*, always spliced with liberation and scientific narratives. He is considered the greatest living Latin American poet.
92. John S. Bell, *Speakable and Unspeakable in Quantum Mechanics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1987), 160.
93. Michael Talbot, *The Holographic Universe* (New York: HarperCollins, 1991), 38.
94. *Ibid.*, 41.
95. See David Bohm, *Causality and Chance in Modern Physics* (London: Routledge, 1957).
96. The mathematician John Nash (the subject of the movie *A Beautiful Mind*) tried to stand up for him. Decades later he blamed his plunge into insanity on his own attempt—triggered by that fight with Oppenheimer—“to resolve the contradictions in quantum theory.” Sylvia Nasar, biographer of Nash, cited in Gilder, *The Age of Entanglement*, 222.
97. David Bohm, *Infinite Potential: The Life and Times of David Bohm* (Reading: Addison Wesley, 1997), 133.
98. David Bohm and B. J. Hiley, *The Undivided Universe: An Ontological Interpretation of Quantum Theory* (London: Routledge, 1993), 352.
99. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 176.
100. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 351.
101. *Ibid.*, 352.
102. *Ibid.*
103. *Ibid.*
104. Cited in Davies, *God and the New Physics*, 112.
105. *Ibid.*
106. *Ibid.* (my emphasis).
107. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 149.
108. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 353.
109. *Ibid.*, 354.
110. *Ibid.*, 14.
111. *Ibid.*, 297.
112. Wegter-McNelly, *The Entangled God*, 123.
113. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 354.
114. *Ibid.*, 355.
115. Talbot, *The Holographic Universe*, 47.
116. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 148–149.
117. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 320.
118. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 199.

119. Ibid., 200 (italics mine).
120. Talbot, *The Holographic Universe*, 50.
121. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 386.
122. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 323.
123. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 207. Chapter 5 will consider a different version of the comparison of Whitehead and Leibniz.
124. "Matter feels, converses, suffers, desires, yearns and remembers." Interview with Karen Barad, in *New Materialism: Interviews and Cartographies*, ed. Rick Dolphijn and Iris van der Tuin (Ann Arbor, MI: Open Humanities, 2012), 69.
125. David Bohm and David Peat, *Science, Order and Creativity*, 2d ed. (New York: Routledge, 2000), 180.
126. Bohm, *Wholeness and the Implicate Order*, 386.
127. "For Whitehead, misplaced concreteness means more broadly the tendency to overlook entanglements between energized, real entities that exceed any atomistic reduction of them, as when a climate pattern and ocean current system intersect and enter into a new spiral of mutual amplification, or when a cultural disposition to spiritual life befuddles the academic separation between an economic system and religion by flowing into the very fiber of work motivation, consumption profiles, investment priorities and electoral politics." William E. Connolly, *The Fragility of Things: Self-Organizing Processes, Neoliberal Fantasies, and Democratic Activism* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013), 154.
128. See Karen Barad, "Nature's Queer Performativity (The Authorized Version)," in *Kvinder, Køn & Forskning* 1–2 (2012): 22–53.
129. Interview with Karen Barad, in *New Materialism*, 69.
130. Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 389.
131. *Nicholas of Cusa*, 241.
132. Ibid.
133. The ecotheology of the followers of Thomas Berry develops a parallel insight. The image is in danger of a self-defeating anthropocentrism only if humans alone can serve this mirror function. Also its holism remains in danger of determinism if the mirror merely mirrors; if in its holography the creativity of each creature—as it mirrors the whole in itself—is masked. David Bohm cannot settle these matters. And in this very passage he indicates that such a "theory of the whole" is "in no sense a theory of everything." Bohm and Hiley, *The Undivided Universe*, 389.
134. Malin, *Nature Loves to Hide*, 186.
135. Karen Barad, *What Is the Measure of Nothingness? Infinity, Virtuality, Justice*, dOCUMENTA notebook no. 099 (Ostfildern: Hatje Cantz, 2012).
136. Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 396.
137. Ibid.

5. THE FOLD IN PROCESS

1. Aristotle named the treatise that followed *Ta Physika* (*the Physics*), *Ta Meta Ta Physika* ("that which follows the physics").
2. Jacques Derrida, *The Animal That Therefore I Am*, ed. Marie-Louise Mallet, trans. David Wills (New York: Fordham University Press, 2008), 3.
3. Isabelle Stengers, Michael Chase, and Bruno Latour, *Thinking with Whitehead: A Free and Wild Creation of Concepts* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2011).
4. As Deleuze's translator in Gilles Deleuze, *Expressionism in Philosophy: Spinoza* collates them: "Translator's Preface," in *Expressionism in Philosophy: Spinoza*, trans. Martin Joughin (New York: Zone, 1990), 5.
5. *Ibid.*, 16.
6. *Ibid.*, 17.
7. Deleuze, *Expressionism in Philosophy*, 175. The previous notes from this book are the translator, but this is from the body of text.
8. Joshua Ramey, *The Hermetic Deleuze: Philosophy and Spiritual Ordeal* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2012).
9. Gilles Deleuze, *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque*, trans. Tom Conley (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 5.
10. *Ibid.*, 5f: Thus contra the "absolute fluidity" of Descartes and the "absolute hardness" of the atomists, a body "has a degree of hardness as well as a degree of fluidity, or that it is essentially elastic."
11. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987), 3.
12. See Joerg Rieger and Pui-lan Kwok, *Occupy Religion: Theology of the Multitude* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2012).
13. Connolly enfolds Deleuze, James, and now also Whitehead into his indispensable political philosophy. It fosters a "deep, multidimensional pluralism" that aims "to intensify or amplify a care for this world that already courses through us to some degree." William Connolly, *A World of Becoming* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2011), 79.
14. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *What Is Philosophy?* trans. Hugh Tomlinson and Graham Burchelle (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 23.
15. *Ibid.*, 275.
16. Gilles Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, trans. Paul Patton (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994), 83.
17. *Ibid.*, 75.
18. In conversation with Whitehead, Deleuze, and a poetic array of Korean sources, Jea Sophia Oh develops an ecofeminist theology of *salim* ("life") as planetary shalom. Jea So-

- phia Oh, *A Postcolonial Theology of Life: Planetarity East and West* (Upland, CA: Sopher, 2011), 51ff.
19. Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (New York: Free Press, 1967 [1925]), 175–176.
 20. Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, 284–285.
 21. Ibid., 284.
 22. Derrida cited in John D. Caputo, *The Prayers and Tears of Jacques Derrida* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1997), 7.
 23. Clayton Crockett, *Deleuze Beyond Badiou* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2013), 39.
 24. Ibid., 88.
 25. Ibid., 33.
 26. Ibid., 39.
 27. Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, 90.
 28. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality: An Essay in Cosmology*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 136–137.
 29. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 6.
 30. Karmen MacKendrick, *Word Made Skin: Figuring Language at the Surface of Flesh* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2004), 98.
 31. Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, 123.
 32. Ibid.
 33. Ibid., 280.
 34. Ramey argues that the “experimental stakes” and indeed political potentiality of contemporary philosophy “call for a revision and extension of the perennial hermetic project: the proliferation, differentiation, and nonidentical repetition of cosmic processes of regeneration and renewal.” Joshua Alan Ramey, *The Hermetic Deleuze: Philosophy and Spiritual Ordeal* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2012), 8.
 35. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 6.
 36. Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (New York: Free Press, 1953), 49.
 37. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 88.
 38. Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World*, 65.
 39. Ibid., 65.
 40. Ibid., 91.
 41. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 81.
 42. See Deleuze, *The Fold*, 91.
 43. Anne Conway, *The Principles of the Most Ancient and Modern Philosophy* (Leiden: Martinus Nijhoff, 1982), 209.
 44. On Anne Conway, see my “Be a Multiplicity: Ancestral Anticipations,” in *Polydoxy: Theology of Multiplicity and Relation*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel C. Schneider (London:

- Routledge, 2011). Also see Carol Wayne White, *The Legacy of Anne Conway (1631-1697)* (Albany: SUNY Press, 2008).
45. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 86.
 46. Here is the fold of folds, offered as a variation on the theme of the Whiteheadian event: "A vertical harmonic can no longer be distinguished from a horizontal harmonic. . . . The two begin to fuse on a sort of diagonal, where the monads penetrate each other, are modified, inseparable from the groups of prehensions that carry them along and make up as many transitory captures."
 47. Deleuze, *Expressionism in Philosophy*, 22.
 48. With Guattari he comes much later to the "One-All" in *What is Philosophy?* Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *What Is Philosophy?* Trans. Hugh Tomlinson and Graham Burchell (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994).
 49. Deleuze, *Difference and Repetition*, 89.
 50. As Laurel Schneider, naming God a multiplicity, delightfully argues in her "Crib Notes from Bethlehem," we have always cribbed our vocabularies. But what is rare is acknowledgment of the multiplicity of our sources—avowal of our polydox dependencies. Laurel Schneider, "Crib Notes from Bethlehem," in *Polydoxy: Theology of Multiplicity and Relation*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel Schneider (New York: Routledge, 2011), 19–36.
 51. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 92.
 52. Gilles Deleuze, *Cinema: The Time-Image*, trans. Hugh Tomlinson and Robert Galeta (Minneapolis: Athlone, 1989), 131.
 53. Luke Higgins, an important voice for reading Whitehead through Deleuzian lenses, persuasively argues that "instead of conceptualizing the divine aim as that which arrives from above to organize the material web of relationships that sustains us, I would suggest that it is better understood as a certain crystallization of that web, one that occurs from within its 'middle' or from its deep interstices." On this basis he argues that the lure, read as immanent, addresses the desperate needs of the biosphere not from a "transcendent schema of order, but precisely by keeping ourselves within the changing immediacies of its demands." Luke B. Higgins, "Becoming Through Multiplicity: Staying in the Middle of Whitehead's and Deleuze-Guattari's Philosophies of Life," in *Secrets of Becoming: Negotiating Whitehead, Deleuze, and Butler*, ed. Roland Faber and Andrea M. Stephenson (New York: Fordham University Press, 2011), 144.
 54. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 7.
 55. *Ibid.*, 7.
 56. "Philosophers (and presumably theologians) can never hope finally to formulate these metaphysical first principles. Weakness of insight and deficiencies of language stand in the way inexorably. Words and phrases must be stretched toward a generality foreign to their ordinary usage; and however such elements of language be stabilized as technicalities, they remain metaphors mutely appealing for an imaginative leap." Whitehead, *Process and*

- Reality*, 4. For an incisive discussion of Whitehead's concept of metaphor by an author highly tuned to the mystical tradition, see Joseph A. Bracken, *The One in the Many: A Contemporary Reconstruction of the God-World Relationship* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2001).
57. *Ibid.*, 32.
 58. *Ibid.*, 7.
 59. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 92.
 60. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 348.
 61. Roland Faber, *God as Poet of the World: Exploring Process Theologies* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2008).
 62. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 92.
 63. Deleuze and Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus*, 275.
 64. Isabelle Stengers, "The Cosmopolitical Proposal," in *Making Things Public: Atmospheres of Democracy*, ed. Bruno Latour and Peter Weibel (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2005), 995.
 65. Isabelle Stengers, "Beyond Conversation: The Risks of Peace," in *Process and Difference: Between Cosmological and Poststructuralist Postmodernisms*, ed. Catherine Keller and Anne Daniell (Albany: SUNY, 2002), 249.
 66. The similarly radical discontinuity of the "to come" in Moltmann's theology of hope and in Derrida's nonanalogous "Messianism Without a Messiah" is discussed in Catherine Keller and Stephen Moore, "Derridapocalypse," in *Derrida and Religion: Other Testaments*, ed. Yvonne Sherwood and Kevin Hart (New York: Routledge, 2005).
 67. MacKendrick hears the affective intensity of this calling close to silence, word luring word (and for that vocation she would use a stronger language than I, who know only a resistable lure): "Sometimes where we love or loathe or desire most, we find our words drawn irresistibly forth; just as often, we find them shattered and forestalled by the spaces they cannot fill." Karmen MacKendrick, *Word Made Skin: Figuring Language at the Surface of Flesh* (New York: Fordham, 2004), 105f.
 68. Deleuze, *The Fold*, 93. In the collection of essays and interviews *Two Regimes of Madness: Texts and Interviews, 1975–95* (Los Angeles: Semiotext(e), 2007), there is an essay called "Zones of Immanence" in which Deleuze directly discusses Cusa's whole interweaving dynamic of complicatio and explicatio.

6. "UNFOLDED OUT OF THE FOLDS"

1. I am thinking of a lover of Whitman's poetry, Ernesto Cardenal, and his *Versos del pluriverso*, published in Nicaragua in 2005; see Ernesto Cardenal, *Pluriverse: New and Selected Poems* (New York: New Directions, 2009) and note 90, chapter 4, this volume.
2. Walt Whitman, "Autumn Rivulets: Kosmos," in *Leaves of Grass: Authoritative Texts, Prefaces, Whitman on His Art, Criticism*, ed. Sculley Bradley and Harold W. Blodgett (New York: Norton, 1973), 392–393. Further references to Whitman's poems are to this edition.

3. Gilles Deleuze, *Essays Critical and Clinical*, trans. Daniel W. Smith and Michael A. Greco (London: Verso, 1998), 56–57.
4. *Ibid.*, 56f.
5. Eric Wilson, "Whitman's Rhizomes," *Arizona Quarterly* 55 (Autumn 1999): 1–21. Wilson seeks to "avoid imposing hermeneutic unity" on the "linguistic distributions" of the 1855 poem eventually entitled "Song of Myself" by reading the poem as "nomadic, rhizomatic poetry," "a primer of nomadic writing and reading," based on the image of rhizomes ("true multiplicities, assemblages of heterogeneous parts"), "the primary trope of the nomad thought of [Gilles] Deleuze and [Félix] Guattari, who proffer a perpetually mobile philosophy moving on the margins of tradition, beyond stable, universal concepts."
6. Robert Weisbuch's contextualization of Emily Dickinson remains germane. Even as he distinguishes her subtle revolt from Whitman's exuberance, he captures the New England transcendentalist rhizome thus: "Like all of the American romantics—Hawthorne and Melville as well as Emerson, Thoreau, and Whitman—Dickinson chooses to see symbolically and to expand meanings to their furthest bounds. Like them, she dramatizes this methodology as a revolt against the life-draining elements of her culture; like them she adopts an outsider's stance, a mood of continual desire, a mode of continual quest; like them, she longs for the spiritual nourishment but not for the dogmatic beliefs and tortured consciences of her great grandparents." Robert Weisbuch, *Emily Dickinson's Poetry* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972), 7.
7. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 25," 55.
8. *The Routledge Encyclopedia of Walt Whitman*, ed. J. R. LeMaster and Donald D. Kummings (New York: Routledge, 1998), ix.
9. Whitman, "By Blue Ontario's Shore: 16," 353.
10. Martha Nussbaum, *Upheavals of Thought: The Intelligence of Emotions* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2001), 646.
11. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 31," 59, "Song of Myself: 21," 49.
12. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 21," 49.
13. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 31," 59.
14. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 23," 51.
15. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 24," 52.
16. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 30," 58.
17. Whitman, "Song of Myself," 52f.
18. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 32," 60.
19. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality: An Essay in Cosmology*, corrected ed., ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 50.
20. Nussbaum, *Upheavals of Thought*, 656.
21. Deleuze, *Essays Critical and Clinical*, 59.
22. *Ibid.*

23. Bernd Herzogenrath unfolds "Deleuze/Guattari's concept of a minor literature" along with "Tocqueville's notion of the nexus of American literature and democracy" in order to "connect Whitman's literary style to a 'political style,' to see how Whitman derives a concept of a 'new democracy' from his experiments with language," and examines how Deleuze's link of Anglo-American literature to "Humean empiricism" helps us understand "the paratactic politics of both Hume and Whitman," who both wrote in a time of "union and fragmentation." He also examines how Deleuze's essay on Whitman allows us to see how, "for Whitman—and in Whitman's America—the fragment is at the same time both a question of literary style and of the Body/Politic," leading Whitman to engage in a "minor politics" that is "not a politics of identity and striation but of difference and constant variation; not a static politics [state politics] but a politics as dynamic and complex as life itself," apparent not only in Whitman's ideas but in his "poetic line," which has "a close affinity with what Deleuze/Guattari call the "nomadic line," a "streaming, spiraling, zig-zagging, snaking, feverish line of variation." Bernd Herzogenrath, *An American Body-Politic: A Deleuzian Approach* (Hanover, NH: Dartmouth College Press, 2010).
24. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 24," 52.
25. Ibid.
26. Ibid., 55. "Seems a thrilling counter-question to the barrage out of the whirlwind in Job—Whitman's "not" transfers the locus of divinity, it seems to me." Mary-Jane Rubenstein, reflecting in an informal communication on "were you there when I laid the foundations of the earth" (Job 38:3).
27. Ibid.
28. Ibid.
29. Deleuze, *Essays Critical and Clinical*, 59.
30. Nelle Morton, *The Journey Is Home* (Boston: Beacon, 1985), 41.
31. Sébastien Scarpa claims that Whitman was a "scientific poet," and describes *Leaves of Grass*, following Deleuze and Guattari, as "a pure energetic milieu, a sort of intermezzo of expressive forces reposing oddly on the postulates of nineteenth-century science (from evolutionism to astronomy, while passing through mechanics and physics)." Sébastien Scarpa, "I Sing the Body Electric': Science et poésie dans l'oeuvre de Walt Whitman," in Ronan Ludot-Vlasak and Claire Maniez, eds., *Discours et objets scientifiques: Dans l'imaginaire américain du XIXe siècle* (Grenoble: ELLUG, 2010), 21–31.
32. Genially titled "Unfolding the Mysteries of the Brain," a recent article in the *Boston Globe* reports that the surface of the brain—the layer associated with our emotions, memory, and thought—is a complex landscape, featuring endless peaks and valleys. "This *intricately folded outer layer*, known as the cerebral cortex, is one of the brain's most noticeable features. But it's also one of the least well understood." It would seem that the secrets of human intelligence are embodied in a quite literal complicatio. Again science pushing into a

cloud of its ignorance makes a beautiful discovery. The surface, sculpted by the doubling and twisting, thus grows a labyrinthine depth; it no longer resembles a boundary separating a within from a without. This foldedness, in ways still unknown, embodies "the greater cognitive powers of humans in comparison with species with smoother brains." Emily Anthes, "Unfolding the Mysteries of the Brain," *Boston Globe* (written August 3, 2009), www.boston.com/business/articles/2009/08/03/unfolding_the_mysteries_of_the_brain/.

33. The peculiar locution of Deleuze signifies, as noted in chapter 5, an indivisible organism, "an organism without parts," not subject to hierarchical anatomies. Later it is extended to the Earth itself, as a composition of multidirectional flows. See Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987).
34. Harold Aspiz, "Unfolding the Folds," *Walt Whitman Review* 12 (December 1966): 81–87. "Unfolded Out of the Folds" may be interpreted in several ways: (1) as a paean to the evolution of the human soul and to the race of physical and spiritual heroes destined to appear in America, (2) as a glorification of sex, motherhood and fatherhood, (3) as an illustration of Whitman's knowledge of phrenological doctrines, and (4) as an autobiographical celebration of the poet himself.
35. Whitman, "Autumn Rivulets: Unfolded Out of the Folds," 391.
36. Betsy Erkkila, *Whitman: The Political Poet* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1989), 258.
37. Vivian R. Pollack, *The Erotic Whitman* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2000), 186.
38. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 21," 48.
39. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 31," 59.
40. Alicia Ostricker, "Loving Walt Whitman and the Problem of America," in *The Continuing Presence of Walt Whitman: The Life After the Life*, ed. Robert K. Martin (Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 1992), 227. See also the rich conversation between critics unfolded in chapter 7 of Vivian Pollack's *The Erotic Whitman*, "Whitman's Visionary Feminism."
41. Whitman, "Autumn Rivulets: Unfolded Out of the Folds," 391.
42. Ibid.
43. Whitman, "Calamus: Earth My Likeness," 132.
44. The question of Walt Whitman's sexuality remains historically ambiguous among scholars—almost apophatically so—even as he opens sex itself to new articulations. See Ed Folsom and Kenneth M. Price, *Re-scripting Walt Whitman: An Introduction to His Life and Work* (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2005); Fredson Bowers, ed., *Whitman's Manuscripts: Leaves of Grass (1860)* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1955); Jonathan Ned Katz, *Love Stories: Sex Between Men Before Homosexuality* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2001); and Betsy Erkkila, "Whitman and the Homosexual Republic," in *Walt Whit-*

man: *The Centennial Essays* (Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 1994). Folsom and Price, alongside other cultural theorists, caution that "the coded expressions and indirections of love talk are not easy to decipher, and expressions of fervent attachment may or may not imply the same level of sexual intimacy as such an expression would imply in our own time. It is good to remember that we inescapably read Whitman from a post-Freudian, post-Stonewall perspective, a perspective that is simultaneously distorting and illuminating" (63). They ply Whitman's life between 1855 and 1860, when the first volume of *Leaves of Grass* was published. At the bohemian Pfaff's saloon, a popular gathering place for artists in New York City, Whitman joined the Fred Gray Association, a loose collective of men exploring "new possibilities of male-male affection" (61–62). Whitman met and had an intense relationship with Fred Vaughan who might have inspired the homoerotic love poems "Live Oak, with Moss," a series of sonnets-like poems which suggest the loss of Vaughan, who married and had children:

*Hours discouraged, distracted,—For he, the one I cannot content
myself without—soon I saw him content himself without me,
Hours when I am forgotten—*

(BOWERS, WHITMAN'S MANUSCRIPTS, 82)

Betsy Erkkila argues that the "Calamus" poems should read not as expressions of Whitman's private life, somehow distinct from his "public" poems. Instead, Erkkila suggests reading the first expression of "a homosexual republic," a new articulation of American democracy where non-procreative sexual feelings join with camaraderie and democratic union. My sense is that all practitioners of same sex love may claim here a potent ancestor, and that the remaining ambiguity between love and practice, private and public, does not lessen the embodied force of the practice coming to its apophatic voice.

45. Fechner also—embarrassingly for scientific descendants—wrote *Nanna, or the Soul Life of Plants*. Here the metaphor of the universe as the body of God takes on an intricate anatomy: "Has nature or the world a soul?—to the totality of that which we see and apprehend, the whole system of bodies revolving about one another, greening and blooming and carrying the creatures and their history, does their correspond a unified Being which only to itself is apparent, just as to the totality of circulation, veins and bones, there corresponds such a being? Such a Being is no more to be known by telescopes, deep drillings in the earth, measurements and all the mathematics in the world, than is the corresponding being in us to be known by microscopes, scalpels, chemical analysis and mathematics." Fechner remains virtually unknown—except among lovers of Gustav Mahler. Yet William James championed his cause, confident that his time would come. And Hartshorne recognizes him as the greatest intellect among the nineteenth-century ancestors of panentheism: "he saw so much and wrote with such feeling that one is amazed that he has been subject to

- such neglect." See Catherine Keller, "The Luxuriating Lily: Fechner's Cosmos in Mahler's World," in *Mahler in Kontext/Contextualizing Mahler*, ed. Erich Wolfgang Partsch and Morten Solvik (Vienna: Böhlau, 2011), 153–164.
46. Thanks to Sam Castelberry for this locution.
 47. Overpopulation is not the cause of climate change; but the devastating effects of biospheric collapse on densely populated publics, including forced migration and reactionary immigration racism, is ignored at our peril. See "Crisis or Adaption? Migration and Climate Change in a Context of High Mobility," *Environment and Urbanization* 21 (2009): 513–525.
 48. Daniel T. Spencer, *Gay and Gaia: Ethics, Ecology, and the Erotic* (Cleveland: Pilgrim, 1996).
 49. Daniel T. Spencer, "Restoring Earth, Restored to Earth: Toward an Ethic for Reinhabiting Place," in *Ecospirit: Religions and Philosophies for the Earth*, ed. Laurel Kearns and Catherine Keller (New York: Fordham University Press, 2007), 416.
 50. Whitney Bauman, *Religion and Ecology: Developing a Planetary Ethic* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014).
 51. Not that he remains forever optimistic; indeed he becomes more preoccupied with the mystery of death, of earth-bound mortality. Engagements are called for with such contrasting moods as signified by J. Halberstam's *The Queer Art of Failure* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2011).
 52. Whitman, "Autumn Rivulets: Kosmos," 393.
 53. *Ibid.*, 393.
 54. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses* (New York: Paulist, 1978).
 55. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 24," 52–53.
 56. *Ibid.*, 52.
 57. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1987), 275.
 58. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 24," 52–53.
 59. *Indecent Theology*, by Marcella Althaus-Reid, shows queer people and otherwise sexually tainted folks get excluded even by a liberation theology that privileges the heterosexually decent poor. Marcella Althaus-Reid, *Indecent Theology: Theological Perversions in Sex, Gender, and Politics* (London: Routledge, 2000).
 60. Theopoiesis, or theosis, was a common patristic theme: "God became man that we might become God"—Athanasius. Cf. "After."
 61. As Mayra Rivera luminously infers from Irenaeus ("The glory of God is the human being fully alive"), "the glory of God is always encountered as flesh." And so "touch reveals the simultaneity of transcendence and intimacy, a divine enveloping through which God may caress creation and feel its joy and suffering." Mayra Rivera, "The Touch of Transcendence,"

- in *Polydoxy: Theology of Multiplicity and Relation*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel C. Schneider (New York: Routledge, 2011), 136, 140.
62. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 1," 28.
 63. I think here of Mel Chen's queering "condition of animate transubstantiation," drawn into the locus of the transsexual (not quite yet a theme for Whitman!) from Deleuze and Guattari's concept of the "body without organs." Mel Y. Chen, *Animacies: Biopolitics, Racial Mattering, and Queer Affect* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2012), 152.
 64. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 46," 84.
 65. Ibid.
 66. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 48," 86.
 67. Ibid.
 68. Ludwig Feuerbach, *Gesammelte Werke*, ed. W. Schuffenhauer (Berlin: Akademie, 1967), 1:18.
 69. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 48," 86.
 70. Whitman, "A Song of the Rolling Earth: 3," 224.
 71. Whitman, *Leaves of Grass*, 49.
 72. Whitman, "Song of Myself: 44," 80.

7. UNSAYING AND UNDOING

1. Hadewijch II, "All Things," in *Women in Praise of the Sacred: Forty-three Centuries of Spiritual Poetry by Women*, ed. and trans. Jane Hirshfield (New York: HarperCollins, 1994), 106. This is a translation of Mengeldict 21.
2. The subject—the human—is not surprisingly hard to name even as a disciplinary category. To call upon "anthropology" is to summon a misleadingly scientific discourse, from which "theological anthropology" seems to detach itself; whereas to call this fold "psychology" would be just as misleadingly personal and interpersonal for present purposes.
3. Judith Butler and Athena Athanasiou, *Dispossession: The Performative in the Political* (Malden: Polity, 2013), 107.
4. Hadewijch II, "All Things."
5. With thanks to Drew University theological librarian Ernest Rubenstein for finding the original Flemish.
6. Reaching beyond any identity, alternately grieving and ecstatic, this poet of *Minne*, Love, practices what she calls a "noble unfaith" that Holly Hillgardner (*not* without Butler's influence) interprets, in a case study of comparative theology, as "passionate nonattachment." Holly Hillgardner, "Spirited Transformations: Pneumatology as a Resource for Comparative Theology," in *Divine Multiplicities: Trinities, Diversities, and the Nature of Relation*, ed. Chris Boesel and S. Wesley Ariarajah (New York: Fordham, 2014), 348.

7. Hadewijch tells the tale of "Eleventh, a virgin called Geremina, who for nine years constantly underwent such great stress of love within her that she could by no means rest nor could she forget love. It made her often experience great woe as though she was going into labour of childbirth. And felt that all her members would split in two, and she became so horribly wide that she thought that she swallowed all of hell's inhabitants in order to spoil them with the newness of her love, to feed and to protect each one on earth as they each deserved. And she also swallowed all the inhabitants of heaven and transformed them into new glory, and conducted them to new thrones." She does mature into a selectivity that allows her serenity. Hadewijch of Brabant, "List of the Perfect by Hadewijch of Antwerp," trans. Helen Rolfson, *Vox Benedictina: A Journal of Translations from Monastic Sources* 5, no. 4 (1988): 277–287.
8. Judith Butler, *The Psychic Life of Power: Theories in Subjection* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 1997), 198.
9. It is predominantly the latter third of Hadewijch's *Mengeldichten* that leads some scholars to surmise that there is more than one Hadewijch on the basis of these texts' tone, "mystic content," imagery, and vocabulary. See Saskia Murk-Jansen, *The Measure of Mystic Thought: A Study of Hadewijch's Mengeldichten* (Göppingen: Kummerle, 1991), 14f.
10. See Catherine Keller, *From a Broken Web: Separation, Sexism, and Self* (Boston: Beacon, 1986).
11. Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality: An Essay in Cosmology*, ed. David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978 [1929]), 50.
12. Judith Butler, *Gender Trouble: Feminism and the Subversion of Identity* (New York: Routledge, 1990), 18.
13. *Ibid.*, 25.
14. *Ibid.*, 43–44.
15. Butler, *The Psychic Life of Power*, 21.
16. Christina K. Hutchins, "Unconforming Becomings: The Significance of Whitehead's Novelty and Butler's Subversion for the Repetitions of Lesbian Identity and the Expansion of the Future," in *Process and Difference: Between Cosmological and Poststructuralist Postmodernisms*, ed. Catherine Keller and Anne Daniell (Albany: SUNY Press, 2002), 127. Also I thank Christina for her generous comments on the first draft of the present paper.
17. Homi K. Bhabha, *The Location of Culture* (New York: Routledge, 1997), 314.
18. Braidotti's intervention vis-à-vis the originary separation is serious: "Butler shares the Lacanian assumption that entry into language or access to the Symbolic requires the separation from and loss of the maternal body. She goes on, however, to the next step of her argument. . . . 'Insofar as language appears to be motivated by a loss it cannot grieve to repeat the very loss it refuses to recognize, we might regard this ambivalence at the hear of linguistic iterability as the melancholy recesses of signification.' From this originary loss, which can only be rendered *a posteriori* as the fantasy of a lost origin, Butler derives the—for me un-

- founded—conclusion that the materiality of the body as a whole denies any pre-discursive validity.” Rosi Braidotti, *Metamorphoses: Towards a Materialist Theory of Becoming* (Malden, MA: Polity, 2002), 45.
19. Hutchins, “Unconforming Becomings,” 128.
 20. *Ibid.*, 129.
 21. Judith Butler, *Undoing Gender* (New York: Routledge, 2004), 195.
 22. “The event is a vibration with an infinity of harmonics or submultiples.” Gilles Deleuze, *The Fold: Leibniz and the Baroque*, trans. Tom Conley (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1993), 137.
 23. Judith Butler, *Precarious Life: The Powers of Mourning and Violence* (London: Verso, 2004), 22 (*italics mine*).
 24. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 147.
 25. Butler, *Precarious Life*, 33.
 26. *Ibid.*, 22.
 27. Jean-Luc Nancy, *Being Singular Plural*, trans., Robert D. Richardson and Anne E. O’Byrne (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2000), 27.
 28. Butler, *Precarious Life*, 22.
 29. Butler and Athanasiou, *Dispossession*, 4.
 30. Judith Butler, *Giving an Account of Oneself* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2005), 7.
 31. *Ibid.*, 6, 7–8.
 32. *Ibid.*, 21.
 33. Mary-Jane Rubenstein, “Undone By Each Other: Interrupted Sovereignty in Augustine’s *Confessions*,” in *Polydoxy: Theology of Relation and Multiplicity*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel Schneider (London: Routledge, 2010), 106.
 34. Butler, *Giving an Account of Oneself*, 136.
 35. Butler, *Undoing Gender*, 227.
 36. See my *The Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003), 179, for an experimental translation of the grammatically plurisingular *Elohim*. Dhawn Martin has just reminded me that I discuss the kabbalistic unfolding of this multiplicity on the same page as a reference to *Gender Trouble*, which (in the spirit of kabbalistic intertextualism) bears citing: “The recapitulative flow of a becoming-feminism depends upon the emancipatory force of sheer plurality. As Judith Butler puts it: ‘If the regulative fictions of sex and gender are themselves multiply contested sites of meaning, then the very multiplicity of their construction holds out the possibility of a disruption of their univocal posturing.’”
 37. Butler and Athanasiou, *Dispossession*, 107–108.
 38. Butler, *Giving an Account of Oneself*, 20.
 39. *Ibid.*, 103.

40. This ambiguous relational stickiness is theologically elaborated in the Korean term *jeong* in Anne Wonhee Joh's *Heart of the Cross: A Postcolonial Christology* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox), 2006.
41. Butler, *Undoing Gender*, 227 (italics mine).
42. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 3 (italics mine).
43. See Butler's initial engagement with Adorno and the "problem of morality," of universals disconnected, abstracted from "particular interest" and lives. Butler, *Giving an Account of Oneself*, 5–7. Also I think of Dhawn Martin's recent theopolitical reading of the resurrection of Lazarus through a Butlerian lens, with its wonderful neologism *universatality*. Dhawn Martin, "Resurrections, Insurrections, and How Identities Might 'Get a Life,'" American Academy of Religion, Montreal, 2009.
44. Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, 56.
45. Whitehead, *Modes of Thought*, 237.
46. *Ibid.*, 75.
47. Judith Butler, "On This Occasion," in *Butler on Whitehead: On the Occasion*, ed. Roland Faber, Michael Halewood, and Deena Lin (Lanham, MD: Lexington, 2012), 8.
48. Butler, *Undoing Gender*, 198.
49. See Catherine Keller, "Undoing and Unknowing: Judith Butler in Process," in *Butler on Whitehead*, 43–61.
50. I thank Drew Ph.D. student Anna Blaedel for this instance of the use of mourning for ecological activism. "Despair," writes Joanna Macy, "doesn't stay static. It only doesn't change if we refuse to look at it, but when we look at it, when we take it into our hands, when we can just be with it and keep breathing, then it turns. It turns to reveal its other face, and the other face of our pain for the world is our love for the world, our absolutely inseparable connectedness with all life." Joanna Macy, "A Wild Love for the World," interview with Krista Tippett, *On Being*, www.onbeing.org/program/wild-love-world/transcript/4905.
51. Latour continues, "Let me put it bluntly: political ecology has nothing to do with nature." Bruno Latour, *Politics of Nature: How to Bring the Sciences Into Democracy*, trans. Catherine Porter (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2004), 4–5.
52. Butler, "On This Occasion," 11.
53. *Ibid.*, 3.
54. *Ibid.*, 15.
55. Jacques Derrida, *The Animal That Therefore I Am*, ed. Marie-Louise Mallet, trans. David Wills (New York: Fordham University Press, 2008), 29.

8. CRUSADE, CAPITAL, AND COSMOPOLIS

1. Maureen Miller, "Introduction," in *Power and the Holy in the Age of the Investiture Conflict: A Brief History with Documents* (Boston: Bedford/St. Martins, 2005). I thank medievalist

- Dr. Catherine Peyroux for explaining to me how the Crusades and the sacralization of violence are an extension of the Reform movements emanating from Cluny, influencing from the start the Peace and Truce of God movements.
2. Cited in *Medieval Worlds: A Sourcebook*, ed. Roberta Anderson and Dominic Aidan Belenger (New York: Routledge, 2003), 90.
 3. Enrique Dussel, "Europe, Modernity, and Eurocentrism," in *Nepantia: Views from the South* 1, no. 3 (2000): 2.
 4. Nicholas of Cusa, *On Interreligious Harmony: Text, Concordance and Translation of De Pace Fidei*, ed. James E. Biechler and H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Edwin Mellen, 1990), 3.
 5. *Ibid.*, 4.
 6. During the same year Cusa has reconnected with his friend Segovia, who, with very similar intent and desperate effort at finding an Arab translator, coins, or uses for the first time with the meaning of "conference" in our day, the term *contraferentia*. R. W. Southern, *Western Views of Islam in the Middle Ages* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1962), 91. See also Dr. Jesse Mann (to whom I am grateful for excellent comments on this essay), "Truth and Consequences: Juan de Segovia on Islam and Conciliarism," *Medieval Encounters* 8 (2002): 79–90.
 7. Nicholas of Cusa, *On Interreligious Harmony*, 7.
 8. *Ibid.*, cf. 222.
 9. Namsoon Kang, *Cosmopolitan Theology: Reconstituting Planetary Hospitality, Neighbor-Love and Solidarity in an Uneven World* (St. Louis: Chalice, 2013); Judith Butler, Jürgen Habermas, Charles Taylor, and Cornel West, *The Power of Religion in the Public Sphere* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011).
 10. Anders Breivik, an Islamophobic Christian terrorist in Norway, shot to death seventy-seven Norwegians. He performed this mass murder in 2011, carefully timed for July 22, the date of the founding of the Crusader kingdom in 1099.
 11. For a prescient and still timely analysis of the "cold war" between the West and Islam, see Emran Qureshi and Michael A. Sells, eds., *The New Crusades: Constructing the Muslim Enemy* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003).
 12. William Cavanaugh, *The Myth of Religious Violence: Secular Ideology and the Roots of Modern Conflict* (Oxford: Oxford University Press 2009), 4.
 13. Cavanaugh continues: "They have not yet learned to remove the dangerous influence of religion from political life. Their violence is therefore irrational and fanatical. Our violence, being secular, is rational, peace making, and sometimes regrettably necessary to contain their violence. We find ourselves obliged to bomb them into liberal democracy." *Ibid.*
 14. Nicholas of Cusa, *On Interreligious Harmony*, 4.
 15. Enrique Dussel and Michael D. Barber, *The Invention of the Americas: Eclipse of "the Other" and the Myth of Modernity* (New York: Continuum, 1995), 90.
 16. Enrique Dussel, "Europe, Modernity, and Eurocentrism," in *Nepantia: Views from the South* 1, no. 3 (2000): 468.

17. Ibid.
18. Dussel and Barber, *The Invention of the Americas*, 88.
19. Portugal also established in the early fifteenth century footholds in Africa all the way to Goa.
20. Enrique Dussel, "Eurocentricism and Modernity," in *The Postmodern Debate in Latin America*, ed. John Beverley, Michael Aronna, and José Oviedo (Durham: Duke University Press, 1995), 67.
21. The degree to which the convivencia was merely a mythic golden age, and the indubitable examples of cultural, religious, and political collaboration unlike anything in northern and western Europe, is hotly contested. Norbert Rehrmann, "A Legendary Place of Encounter: The Convivencia of Moors, Jews, and Christians in Medieval Spain," in *The Historical Practice of Diversity: Transcultural Interactions from the Early Modern Mediterranean to the Postcolonial World*, ed. Dirk Hoerder with Christiane Harzig and Adrian Shubert (New York: Berhann, 2003), 35ff.
22. Dussel and Barber, *The Invention of the Americas*, 90.
23. Thanks to Jacqueline Winter for sharing with me personal photographs of colonial era paintings of the Viceroyalty of Peru, on the theme of "the Defense of the Eucharist." In many paintings from the school of Cuzco, the enemy of the faith is represented by a Moor, as symbolizing all infidels.
24. Frederic Jameson, *The Political Unconscious* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1981), 102.
25. Nicholas V, *Dum Diversas*, 1452/54. Alexander VI extended it from Africa to America in 1493, and Leo X renewed it in 1514. Cited by Diana Hayes, "Reflections on Slavery," in *Change in Official Catholic Moral Teachings*, ed. Charles E. Curran (Mahwah, NJ: Paulist, 2003), 67.
26. Vlad, known as "the Impaler," had grown up as a royal hostage in the Ottoman court, as part of an imperial strategy to keep the loyalty of subject royalty in Europe. It worked in his brother's case. Dieter Harmening, *Der Anfang von Dracula: Zur Geschichte von Geschichten* (Konigshausen: Neumann, 1983).
27. Nicholas of Cusa, *On Interreligious Harmony*, 5.
28. Ibid., 5, 6 (italics mine).
29. Ibid., 6.
30. Ibid., 6.
31. Ibid., 6f.
32. Ibid., 20.
33. Ibid., 25.
34. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 124.
35. Ibid.
36. Ibid., 124–125.

37. I thank Ryan Coyne for emphasizing the limitations of Cusa's interreligious capacity in his response to an earlier form of this chapter. "An Uncertain Avowal: A Response to Catherine Keller," *Process Studies* 40, no. 2 (Fall/Winter 2011).
38. Catherine Cornille, *The Im-possibility of Interreligious Dialogue* (New York: Crossroad, 2008).
39. John Thatamanil, "God as Ground, Contingency, and Relation: Trinitarian Polydoxy and Religious Diversity," in *Polydoxy: Theology of Multiplicity and Relation*, ed. Catherine Keller and Laurel C. Schneider (New York: Routledge, 2011).
40. A concept developed as an alternative to separative pluralism in Catherine Keller and Roland Faber, "A Taste for Multiplicity: The Skillfull Means of Religious Pluralism," in John Cobb, ed., *Religions in the Making: Whitehead and the Wisdom Traditions of the World* (Eugene, OR: Wipf and Stock, 2012).
41. Nicholas of Cusa, *De docta ignorantia*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 135.
42. Nicholas of Cusa, *On Interreligious Harmony*, 4.
43. The honor of being the first theologian to expose, systematically, the human and ecological costs that globalization would exact belongs to John B. Cobb Jr., of course, with Herman Daly, *For the Common Good* (Boston: Beacon, 1989).
44. Gary Dorrien explains that "after World War II the Bretton Woods Agreement established a system of fixed exchange rates that limited capital flows from one country to another. In 1971, however, Richard Nixon, struggling with a large trade deficit and a costly war in Vietnam, suspended the dollar's convertibility into gold, which ended the Bretton Woods system." Capital flows could now rush across borders, and "the financial futures market was created." Gambling for high returns prevailed, and now the banks "want nothing to do with an updated version of Bretton Woods." Gary Dorrien, *Economy, Difference, Empire: Social Ethics for Social Justice* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010), 159.
45. Cited in Joerg Rieger, *No Rising Tide: Theology, Economics, and the Future* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2009), 75.
46. *Ibid.*, 72.
47. "There are various types of cosmopolitanism with different labels: Abject, Actually-existing, Comparative, Critical, Cultural, Dialogic, Discrepant, Market, Moral, Organic, Political cosmopolitanism, Postcolonial, Rooted, Rootless, Situated, Subaltern, Working-class, or Vernacular cosmopolitanism." Kang, *Cosmopolitan Theology*, 35.
48. Though "military force must guarantee the conditions for the functioning of the world markets." Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, *Multitude: War and Democracy in the Age of Empire* (New York: Penguin, 2004), 177.
49. Édouard Glissant, "The Unforeseeable Diversity of the World," in *Beyond Dichotomies: Histories, Identities, Culture and the Challenge of Globalization*, ed. Elisabeth Mudimbe-Boyi (Albany: SUNY, 2002), 287.
50. *Ibid.*, 287f.

51. Édouard Glissant, *Poetics of Relation*, trans. Betsy Wing (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1990), 191.
52. *Ibid.*, 190.
53. *Ibid.*, 190.
54. William Connolly, *Capitalism and Christianity, American Style* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2008), 128.
55. *Ibid.*, 58.
56. *Ibid.*, 61.
57. See William Connolly, *Why I Am Not a Secularist* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999). In this work he might concur with John Cobb's theological distinction between "secularization" as a healthy impetus of autocritique and worldly responsibility discernible in all major faiths until they settle into "religion," from "secularism," which performs an insularity that mirrors religion.
58. Connolly, *Christianity and Capitalism*, 40.
59. See chapter 5.
60. Dussel and Barber add that Cartesian "Skepticism becomes the means to reach certainty and provide a solid foundation to the self." Dussel and Barber, *The Invention of the Americas*, 245.
61. *Ibid.*, 138.
62. *Ibid.*
63. Alfred North Whitehead, *Adventures of Ideas* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1969), 285.
64. Carl Schmitt, *Political Theology: Four Chapters on the Concept of Sovereignty*, trans. George Schwab (Chicago: University of Chicago, 1985), 36. Clayton Crockett argues that Schmitt's tainted critique of liberalism cannot be avoided in our period, with its dual crisis of the death of God and the disintegrating boundary between the religious and secular spheres.
65. Paulina Ochoa Espejo, "Does Political Theology Entail Decisionism?" in *Philosophy and Social Criticism* 38, no. 7 (2012): 7. See also, for a Whiteheadian development of the notion of the "people as process," *The Time of Popular Sovereignty: Process and the Democratic State* (University Park: Penn State University Press, 2011).
66. Cited in *Medieval Worlds: A Sourcebook*, ed. Roberta Anderson and Dominic Aidan Belenger (New York: Routledge, 2003), 224.
67. Cf. Melanie Johnson-de Baufrie, Catherine Keller and Elias Ortega-Aponte, *Common Good(s): Economy, Ecology, Political Theology* (New York: Fordham University Press, forthcoming).
68. Ochoa Espejo, "Does Political Theology Entail Decisionism?" 9–10.
69. John B. Cobb Jr., *Process Theology as Political Theology* (Manchester: University Press and Philadelphia: Westminster, 1982), xvi, 158.
70. *Ibid.*, 10.
71. William E. Connolly, *A World of Becoming* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2011), 29.

72. Ibid.
73. Ibid., 7.
74. William Connolly has long incorporated complexity theory into his political philosophy, as one resource for communicating the political potentiality of “a cosmos composed of innumerable, interacting temporal force fields with varying degrees of self-organizational capacity.” William E. Connolly, *The Fragility of Things: Self-Organizing Processes, Neoliberal Fantasies, and Democratic Activism* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013), 9. In this book he links Whitehead to Bohr, partly with Michael Epperson’s help, and continues the entrainment with Lynne Margulis’ symbiogenesis and Stuart Kauffman’s biology of complexity.
75. Ibid., 218.
76. Ibid., 154.
77. Ibid., 178.
78. William C. Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge: Ibn al-Arabi’s Metaphysics of Imagination* (Albany: SUNY, 1989). According to Chittick, this hadith is normally translated, “He was in a cloud,” but “Ibn al-Arabi makes clear that ‘He came to be’—a meaning equally allowable by the Arabic—is how he understands it” (125).
79. I must not let Ibn Arabi take possession of me now. I will only quote a bit more of the cloud-passage: “Since God is the root of every diversity (*khilaf*) in beliefs within the cosmos, and since He also has brought about the existence of everything in the cosmos in a constitution no possessed by anything else, everyone will end up (*mā’al*) with mercy. For it is He who created them and brought them into existence within the Cloud, which is the Breath of the Allmerciful. So they are like the letters in the breath of the speaker at the places of articulation, which are diverse.” Ibid., 338.
80. Michael Sells notes that the multiform becoming of the “heart” is interpreted elsewhere by Ibn Arabi himself in terms of a marvelous pun between the heart, *qalb*, and perpetual transformation, *taqallub*. The heart changes, writes Ibn Arabi, “with the influences that come upon it, which change with its conditions, which change with the divine manifestations to its heart-secret.” Michael Sells, *Mystical Languages of Unsayings* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994), 110.
81. This counter subjectivity—so alien to the *ego conquiro*, so enfolded in apophatic mysticism—strikes me as remarkably convivial with Connolly’s politically charged “interinvolvement” and of course with Whitehead’s attention to prehensive influence, key for any discussion of the moral-political potential of process-relational theology. Ibid., 90.

9. BROKEN TOUCH

1. Fredric Jameson, *The Political Unconscious: Narrative as a Socially Symbolic Act* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1981).

2. Steven Pinker mobilizes numerous startling quantifications of the evidence for his argument that violence has steadily decreased over millennia in terms of *proportion* of the population victimized. Steven Pinker, *The Better Angels of Our Nature: Why Violence Has Declined* (New York: Viking, 2011).
3. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, *Death of a Discipline* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2003), 72, 74.
4. Bruno Latour, *Politics of Nature: How to Bring the Sciences Into Democracy* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2004).
5. Brigitte Kahl, *Galatians Re-Imagined: Reading with the Eyes of the Vanquished*, (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2010), 3.
6. *Ibid.*, 3.
7. *Ibid.*, 74.
8. *Ibid.*, 3.
9. “Galatia(ns) and the Orientalism of Justification Theology: Paul Among Jews and Muslims,” in *The Colonized Apostle*, ed. Christopher D. Stanley (Minneapolis: Augsburg Fortress, 2011), 206–222.
10. Kahl, *Galatians Re-Imagined*, 272.
11. Cf. “My Athena,” in Catherine Keller, *From a Broken Web: Separation, Sexism, and Self*, (Boston: Beacon, 1986).
12. Kahl, *Galatians Re-Imagined*, 272.
13. See for instance, Daniel Boyarin, *A Radical Jew Paul and the Politics of Identity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1997). And for a cross section of the buzzing current conversation, see Ward Blanton and Hent de Vries, *Paul and the Philosophers* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013). Alain Badiou’s Paul will appear in chapter 10.
14. “Combat, competition, and mindless consumption of the other—the human and the other of the Earth—in Paul’s system are the ‘works of the law’ and the signature of the ‘flesh’ (sarx) in enslavement to sin, crying out for the liberating transformation of the spirit.” Cf. Kahl’s brief meditation on “Gaia and the Cosmic Ecology of New Creation,” *ibid.*, 272–273.
15. James Lovelock, *The Vanishing Face of Gaia: A Final Warning* (New York: Basic Books, 2009), 1.
16. *Ibid.*, 2.
17. Phillip Clayton, *Religion and Science: The Basics* (New York: Routledge, 2012), 94.
18. Revelation 3:2.
19. Lovelock, *The Vanishing Face of Gaia*, 29.
20. *Ibid.*, 19.
21. Michael E. Mann, “If You See Something, Say Something,” *New York Times*, www.nytimes.com/2014/01/19/opinion/sunday/if-you-see-something-say-something.html?_r=0 (accessed February 3, 2014).

22. Lovelock, *The Vanishing Face of Gaia*, 29.
23. While I consider his Gaia hypothesis an indispensable narrative experiment, Lovelock is also prone to an apocalyptic rhetoric that on the one hand confronts us with a vengeful female and offers salvation only through nuclear technology. See the witty lampoon by John Clark, "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry Metaphor: James Lovelock's Revenge of Gaia," *Capitalism Nature Socialism* 19, no. 2 (June 2008). Thanks also to my informant, Shelley Dennis, who has written that, "similar to John of Patmos' access to privileged and salvific information through revelation, James Lovelock claims the same through scientific inquiry." See Shelley L. Dennis, "Surviving the Unsustainable Empire: Apocalyptic Echoes in Climate Change Literature," MA thesis, Northern Arizona University, May 2012, 71.
24. James Hansen, *Storms of My Grandchildren: Coming Climate Catastrophe and Our Last Chance to Save Humanity* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2010), ix.
25. Ibid.
26. James Inhofe, *The Greatest Hoax: How the Global Warming Conspiracy Threatens Your Future* (Washington: WND, 2012).
27. Fredric Jameson, *The Political Unconscious: Narrative as a Socially Symbolic Act* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1981), 102.
28. Naomi Oreskes and Erik M. Conway, *Merchants of Doubt: How a Handful of Scientists Obscured the Truth on Issues from Tobacco Smoke to Global Warming* (New York: Bloomsbury, 2010).
29. Ibid., 267.
30. Ibid.
31. Tapio Schneider, "How We Know Global Warming Is Real," *Skeptic* 15, no. 1 (2008): 35 (italics mine).
32. Despite decades of improvements in computer models of Earth's climate, estimates of the climate sensitivity—the change in global average surface air temperature in response to a doubling of carbon dioxide concentration—remain uncertain (1). Much of the uncertainty results from radiative feedbacks that amplify or dampen climate changes. Particular attention has been given to the cloud feedback. Global warming is expected to change the cloud cover, but these changes and their effects on global temperature are very difficult to predict. Karen M. Shell, "Constraining Cloud Feedbacks," *Science* 338 (2012): 755–756.
33. Bill McKibben, *Eaarth: Making a Life on a Tough New Planet* (New York: Times/Holt, 2008), 27.
34. Mark Lynas, *The God Species: How the Planet Can Survive the Age of Humans* (London: Fourth Estate, 2011), 5.
35. Christian Parenti, *Tropic of Chaos: Climate Change and the New Geography of Violence* (New York: Nation, 2011), 10.
36. Ibid., 9.
37. Ibid., 11.

38. For an incisive analysis of the link between climate injustice and environmental racism, see Cynthia D. Moe-Lobeda, *Resisting Structural Evil: Love as Ecological-Economic Vocation* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2013), 36ff.
39. Jürgen Moltmann, "Eine gemeinsame Religion der Erde (A Common Religion of the Earth): Weltreligionen in ökologischer Perspektive (World Religions in Ecological Perspective)," in *Verlag Otto Lembeck* 10/1605, "Okumenische Rundschau" (2011), 26 (author's translation). This is an epigraph.
40. Ibid.
41. Ibid., 27.
42. Ibid. (my emphasis).
43. Marion Grau, *Rethinking Mission in the Postcolony: Salvation, Society, and Subversion* (London: T&T Clark, 2011), 287. She calls for "polydox Christianities" minding the aporias of the daunting multiplicity of their situation—and their gift.
44. Forum on Religion and Ecology at Yale, "Engaged Projects," <http://fore.research.yale.edu/religion/indigenous/projects/> (accessed February 3, 2014).
45. "Vandana Shiva: Everything I Need to Know I Learned in the Forest," *Yes!* www.yesmagazine.org/issues/what-would-nature-do/vandana-shiva-everything-i-need-to-know-i-learned-in-the-forest (accessed February 3, 2014).
46. Moltmann, "Eine gemeinsame," 28, 27.
47. Rosemary Radford Ruether, *Sexism and God-Talk: Toward a Feminist Theology* (Boston: Beacon, 1983), 255–256.
48. Rosemary Radford Ruether, *Gaia and God: An Ecofeminist Theology of Earth Healing* (San Francisco: Harper San Francisco, 1992), 247–253.
49. See, for example, Rosemary Radford Ruether, *Integrating Ecofeminism, Globalization, and World Religions* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2005) and *Goddesses and the Divine Feminine: A Western Religious History* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2005); Rita M. Gross and Rosemary Radford Ruether, *Religious Feminism and the Future of the Planet: A Christian-Buddhist Conversation* (New York: Continuum, 2001).
50. For more see Anne Primavesi, *Gaia and Climate Change: A Theology of Gift Events* (London: Routledge, 2009), *Gaia's Gift: Earth, Ourselves, and God After Copernicus* (London: Routledge, 2003), and *Sacred Gaia: Holistic Theology and Earth System Science* (London: Routledge, 2000).
51. Adrian Parr, *The Wrath of Capital: Neoliberalism and Climate Change Politics* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2013), 3.
52. Bruno Latour presented "Facing Gaia: Six Lectures on the Political Theology of Nature" as part of Edinburgh University's prestigious Gifford Lectures on February 18–28, 2013. The annual lectures series seeks "to promote and diffuse the study of Natural Theology in the widest sense of the term—in other words, the knowledge of God." Latour's six lectures, "explore what it could mean to live at the epoch of the Anthropocene when what was

until now a mere décor for human history is becoming the principal actor.” He confronts the “controversial figure of Gaia” which is not Nature, nor a deity, but a form of power, best explored through the lens of political theology. Only once the new *geopolitics* of the Anthropocene are articulated can planetary boundaries’ be recognized as “*political delin- eations*” and the question of peace addressed. The lectures are available in video format from the University of Edinburgh (www.ed.ac.uk/schools-departments/humanities-soc-sci/news-events/lectures/gifford-lectures) and are forthcoming as a volume. The quotations in this book are taken with permission from an unofficial version made available by Bruno Latour.

53. Leslie Marmon Silko, *Ceremony* (New York: Penguin, 1986), 32. It is tempting to meditate on the profound resonance between the grandfather’s utterance and William Connolly’s *The Fragility of Things: Self-Organizing Processes, Neoliberal Fantasies, and Democratic Activism* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013).
54. Ibid.
55. The social ethicist Elias Ortega-Aponte writes in dialogue with George Tinker that “Reciprocity is an important aspect of the Native-American way of life. It is fundamental to the participation, balancing, and harmony of the world. To practice reciprocity according to Tinker, one needs to develop a spiritual understanding of the cosmos and the place of humans in relation to the cosmic whole. It recognizes that every action has an impact in the cosmic whole and stretches or tightens the ties that bind us. This carries a built-in form of knowing, holding ‘that every action has its unique effects,’ meaning that ‘there had to be some sort of built-in compensation for human actions, some act of reciprocity’ (Tinker 2000, 248).” Elias Ortega-Aponte, “Eucharistic Celebration and Interdisciplinary Reflection,” *Philosophy and Theology* (forthcoming). See also G. Tinker, “Community and Ecological Justice: A Native American Response,” in *Earth at Risk: An Environmental Dialogue Between Religion and Science*, ed. Donald B. Conroy and Rodney L. Petersen (New York: Prometheus, 2000).
56. Sallie McFague, in yet another ecotheological classic, asks: “What if we refused this inner/outer, spirit/world split and imagined a ‘democracy of life’?” She is thinking with Whitehead’s statement, where he thinks with James, that “we find ourselves in a buzzing world amid a democracy of fellow creatures.” Sallie McFague, *Blessed Are the Consumers: Climate Change and the Practice of Restraint* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2013), 23.

10. IN QUESTIONABLE LOVE

1. We hear rumors of a “queer time” that not only unstraightens chronology but “overtakes both secular and millennial time.” Elizabeth Freeman, *Time Binds: Queer Temporalities, Queer Histories* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2010), x, xi.
2. See Timothy Morton, *Hyperobjects: Philosophy and Ecology After the End of the World* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2013).

3. Noëlle Vahanian, *The Rebellious No: Variations on a Secular Theology of Language* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2014).
4. Virginia Burrus, Mark D. Jordan, and Karmen MacKendrick, *Seducing Augustine: Bodies, Desires, Confessions* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2010), 114.
5. *The Confessions of St. Augustine*, trans. John K. Ryan (Garden City, NY: Image, 1960), 233.
6. Augustine of Hippo, *On Christian Teaching*, trans. R. P. H. Green (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2008), 34.
7. Burrus, Jordan, and MacKendrick, *Seducing Augustine*, 28.
8. Ibid.
9. *The Confessions of St. Augustine*, 254.
10. Burrus, Jordan, and MacKendrick, *Seducing Augustine*, 28.
11. Tanner proposes “setting Christian ideas of the production a circulation of goods into a comparative economy,” which she frames as a material—and monetary—economics. Grace becomes the “greatest challenger and most obstreperous critic” of the capitalist economy. Kathryn Tanner, *Economy of Grace* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2005), 29.
12. Hannah Arendt, Joanna Vecchiarelli Scott, and Judith Chelius Stark, *Love and Saint Augustine* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996), 42.
13. Ibid., 11.
14. Immanuel Kant, *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals*, ed. Mary Gregor (New York: Cambridge Texts in the History of Philosophy, 1997), 38. Not unlike Augustine’s ordering of loves, Kant makes a distinction between pathological and practical love. Pathological love is dependency on another to satisfy one’s needs and has no moral value for Kant. Practical love is a commitment to another as a matter of one’s whole character. The latter is the way that Kant understands the Christian commitment to love, and it also becomes an essential part of his understanding of religion within the limits of reason alone. Thanks to Pierre Keller for this analysis.
15. Virginia Burrus, *Saving Shame: Martyrs, Saints, and Other Abject Subjects* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2008), 145f.
16. *The Confessions of St. Augustine*, 233.
17. Ibid., 340.
18. The politics of love designates a theologically charged (and consistently atheist) breakthrough in Michael Hardt and Antonio Negri, *Commonwealth* (Cambridge: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2009), 179ff., 198.
19. Matthew 7:21.
20. He combines Deuteronomy 6:5 with Leviticus 19:18: “You shall not take vengeance or bear a grudge against any of your people, but you shall love your neighbor as yourself: I am the Lord.”
21. Matthew 25:35–40.
22. John Dominic Crossan, *The Dark Interval: Towards a Theology of Story* (Salem, OR: Polebridge, 1988), 24.

23. In narrative context Jesus is preparing them gently for his death, as they are panicking—nothing to do with competition with other religions: “Little children, I am with you only a little longer. . . . Just as I have loved you, love on another / . . . Do not let your hearts be troubled . . . Thomas said to him, “Lord, we do not know where you are going. How can we know the way?” Jesus said to him, “I am the way, and the truth, and the life.” . . . “I will not leave you orphaned” (John 13:32, 34, 14:3, 6, 18).
24. John 15:5. “He cuts off every branch in me that bears no fruit, while every branch that does bear fruit he prunes so that it will be even more fruitful” (John 15:2).
25. John 6:56.
26. Mayra Rivera, *Poetics of Flesh* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2015) and *The Touch of Transcendence: A Postcolonial Theology of God* (Louisville: Westminster John Knox, 2007).
27. John 14:12. “Very truly, I tell you, the one who believes in me will also do the works that I do and, in fact, will do greater works than these, because I am going to the Father.”
28. Cf. especially Jürgen Moltmann’s engagement of the problem of the filioque clause and its precipitation of the divorce of Eastern and Western Christendom. Jürgen Moltmann, *The Spirit of Life: A Universal Affirmation* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2001).
29. Halberstam draws on queer cultural figures, artists, theorists, and productions to propose what it might mean to see, to know, and to act from a place of failure. For Halberstam these figurations call for a way of knowing from the dark, uncertain places of failure from which each in its own way stems. Indeed, Halberstam recognizes that this terrain of negativity represented by failure has been and continues to be trodden by the queer, the colonized, the woman, the African American, the child, and all “losers” who have come before. Ultimately Halberstam’s hope is that we might fail better, together, and more often. (I thank Karen Bray for introducing me to Halberstam.) J. Halberstam, *The Queer Art of Failure* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2011).
30. 1 Corinthians 13:8.
31. Ephesians 3:19.
32. 1 Corinthians 7:36.
33. Psalm 89:3.
34. Before and after: *kedem* (*kadesh yamenu kikedem*) is way back in time, but *kadimah!* is “forward: march!”
35. Daniel Boyarin, *A Radical Jew: Paul and the Politics of Identity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1997).
36. Romans 8:35.
37. 1 Corinthians 12:26.
38. Joerg Rieger, *No Rising Tide: Theology, Economics, and the Future* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2009), 161–162.
39. 1 Corinthians 13:1–2.
40. Alan Badiou, *Saint Paul: The Foundation of Universalism*, trans. Ray Brassier (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2003), 91.

41. Ibid.
42. Ibid., 92.
43. The new philosophers of Paul make an impressive block: Ward Blanton and Hent de Vries, *Paul and the Philosophers* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013); John Milbank, Slavoj Žižek, and Creston Davis, *Paul's New Moment: Continental Philosophy and the Future of Christian Theology* (Grand Rapids: Brazos, 2010); John D. Caputo and Linda Alcoff, *St. Paul Among the Philosophers* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2009); Giorgio Agamben, *The Time That Remains: A Commentary on the Letter to the Romans* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2005); Alain Badiou, *Saint Paul: The Foundation of Universalism* (Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2003); Slavoj Žižek, "The Politics of Truth; or, Alain Badiou as a Reader of St. Paul," in *The Ticklish Subject: The Absent Centre of Political Ontology* (London: Verso, 1999), 127–170; and Ward Blanton, *A Materialism for the Masses: Saint Paul and the Philosophy of Undying Life* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014).
44. 1 Corinthians 11:11–12.
45. Badiou, *Saint Paul*, 106.
46. Ibid., 91.
47. 1 Corinthians 16:22.
48. Personal communication.
49. Romans 8:22.
50. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies*, in *The Writings of Irenaeus*, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1868), 1:105; cf. Catherine Keller, *Face of the Deep* (New York: Routledge, 2003), 43–64.
51. For the classic feminist critique of atonement, or indeed cruciform theology see Rita Nakashima Brock, *Journeys by Heart: A Christology of Erotic Power* (New York: Crossroad, 1988). The womanist analogue followed shortly: Delores S. Williams, *Sisters in the Wilderness: The Challenge of Womanist God-Talk* (Maryknoll, NY: Orbis, 1993).
52. James H. Cone, *The Cross and the Lynching Tree* (Maryknoll: Orbis, 2011), 166.
53. Freeman, *Time Binds*, xi.
54. Dr. Martin Luther King captures this planetarity—a convivial universalism that does not need to be so designated—in his Nobel prize speech: "We have inherited a big house, a great 'world house' in which we have to live together—black and white, Easterners and Westerners, Gentiles and Jews, Catholics and Protestants, Moslem and Hindu, a family unduly separated in ideas, culture, and interests who, because we can never again live without each other, must learn, somehow, in this one big world, to live with each other. This means that more and more our loyalties must become ecumenical rather than sectional." Martin Luther King Jr., "The Quest for Peace and Justice, Nobel Lecture, December 11, 1964," in *Nobel Lectures: Peace, 1951–1970* (London: World Scientific, 1999), 344. This is the radical meaning of "ecumenism," from *oikos*, now forever translatable as ecology.
55. Matthew 17:5.

56. I am thinking of Barbara Kingsolver's important novel of climate change, with its crucified and risen cloud/crowd of monarch butterflies, *Flight Behavior*. Barbara Kingsolver, *Flight Behavior: A Novel* (New York: Harper, 2012).
57. Deborah Ullman and Gordon Wheeler, eds., *CoCreating the Field: Intention and Practice in the Age of Complexity* (New York: Gestalt/Routledge, 2007).
58. Deborah Ullman, "Mindfulness, Magic, and Metaphysics," *ibid.*
59. See Sharon Betcher, who is cited at length in the epigraph for this section, Sharon V. Betcher, *Spirit and the Obligation of Social Flesh: A Secular Theology for the Global City* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2014), 193.
60. I write on the eve of the Passover, which I celebrate annually with my partner's family.
61. Wonhee Anne Joh, *Heart of the Cross: A Postcolonial Christology* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox, 2006); Anna Mercedes, *Power for Feminism and Christ's Self-Giving* (London: T&T Clark, 2011); Jung Doo Kim, "Love, the Spirit, and Eschatology: Towards a Planetary Theology of Love," Ph.D. diss., Drew University, May 2012.
62. Richard Kearney, *Anatheism: Returning to God After God* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010), 180.

AFTER

1. Despite an antagonistic relation to "metaphysics" (an inadequate label for the problems that confront us), Caputo's theological work puts this "doing" admirably as "deed": "God is an insistent claim or provocation, while the business of existence is up to us—existence here meaning response or responding, assuming responsibility to convert what is being called for in the name of God into a deed." John D. Caputo, *The Insistence of God: A Theology of Perhaps* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 2013), 14. In this he echoes Paul Tillich's (metaphysical) insistence that God does not exist but is the ground of existence.
2. Hadewijch II, in *Women in Praise of the Sacred: Forty-three Centuries of Spiritual Poetry by Women*, ed. and trans. Jane Hirschfield (New York: HarperCollins, 1994).
3. I echo here William E. Connolly's most recent two books, *A World of Becoming* and *The Fragility of Things: A World of Becoming* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2011), *The Fragility of Things: Self-Organizing Processes, Neoliberal Fantasies, and Democratic Activism* (Durham: Duke University Press, 2013).
4. Nancy J. Hudson, *Becoming God: The Doctrine of Theosis in Nicholas of Cusa* (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 2007).
5. In the context of Christ's incarnation, Athanasius introduces his deification exchange formula, where, paraphrasing Irenaeus, he states, "For he [the Logos] became human that we might be made god [*theopoiethomen*]." As Kharlamov explicates intertextually, Athanasius then expands Irenaeus's statement: "And he [the Logos] manifested himself by a body that we might receive the idea of the unseen Father." He thus "affirms the incarnation of God

- more than it does the deification of the human being.” Vladimir Kharlamov, *The Beauty of the Unity and the Harmony of the Whole: The Concept of Theosis in the Theology of Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite* (Eugene: Wipf and Stock, 2009), 39.
6. St. Nikodimos of the Holy Mountain and St. Makrios of the Corinth, *The Philokalia: Volume 2*, trans. G. E. H. Palmer, Phillip Sherrard, and Kallistos Ware (London: Faber and Faber, 1981), 171.
 7. “The unformed volcanic earth.” This is one of the late poems of Jeffers (1953–62). *The Selected Poetry of Robinson Jeffers* (New York: Random House, 1938), 693. He coined the term *inhumanism* as part of his immense alternative to anthropocentrism.
 8. Mary-Jane Rubenstein, *Worlds Without End: The Many Lives of the Multiverse* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2014).
 9. See John Caputo, “Theopoetics as the Instance of Radical Theology,” in Caputo, *The Insistence of God*.
 10. I was rather proud of my neologism *theopoetics* in the 1980s, only to realize that, coincidentally, it had been coined already by Stanley Hopper, a professor at my very institution (Drew University) decades earlier. Thus Amos Wilder: “I believe that I had picked up the terms *theopoetic* and *theopoesis* from Stanley Hopper and his students, no doubt in one or another of the remarkable consultations on hermeneutics and language which he had organized at Drew and Syracuse to which so many of us are indebted.” Amos Niven Wilder, *Theopoetic: Theology and the Religious Imagination* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1976). For me, the term arose in conjunction with feminist theological and then continental philosophical experiments in language—the latter especially in complicity with the Whiteheadian/Deleuzian “theoplicity” of Roland Faber. Cf. *Theopoetic Folds: Philosophizing Multifariousness*, ed. Roland Faber and Jeremy Fackenthal (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013). Cf. also “Theopoetics and the Pluriverse: Notes on a Process” in the same volume.
 11. Hadewijch II, trans. Sheila Hughes, as quoted by Jan van Ruysbroeck (1293–1381), *Women in Praise of the Sacred*, 107.
 12. Donald J. Richardson, *The Complete Midsummer Night’s Dream: An Annotated Edition of the Shakespeare Play* (AuthorHouse, 2013), 155.
 13. Robert Weisbuch, *Emily Dickinson’s Poetry* (Chicago: University of Chicago, 1972), 5.
 14. Emily Dickinson and Helen Vendler, *Dickinson: Selected Poems and Commentaries* (Cambridge: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2010), 466.
 15. The dash is a much discussed syntactical impropriety of her writing, where lines, stanzas and whole poems end in dashes. According to Weisbuch, “Dickinson’s dashes create a pressure, a tension, a nervous breath which tells its own story”—and at the same time a “hinge.” Weisbuch, *Emily Dickinson’s Poetry*, 73. The dashes mark her refusal of the closure of prose and its certainties; and also of the closet. (“They shut me up in Prose—As when a little Girl/ They put me in the Closet—Because they liked me ‘still’—.” Dickinson and

- Vendler, *Dickinson*, 445. (Franklin 1999, p. 206) See also my reflections on Dickinson, "And Truth—So Manifold! 'Transfeminist Entanglements,'" in *Feminist Theology* 22, no. 1 (2012): 77–87.
16. Nicholas of Cusa, *De visione Dei*, in *Nicholas of Cusa: Selected Spiritual Writings*, trans. H. Lawrence Bond (New York: Paulist, 1997), 252.
 17. Latour considers a series of such neo-apocalypses. "Without making the threat visible *artificially*, there is no way to make us spring into action. This is what Günther Anders called a 'prophylactic' use of the Apocalypse, or what Jean-Pierre Dupuy defines as the necessity of 'enlightened catastrophism,' a somewhat tame oxymoron that has the same content as Clive Hamilton's argument that we should first abandon hope—projecting ourselves *from* the present *to* the future—in order to turn around—being reoriented by some powerful figure *from* the virtual future *to* transform the present." Bruno Latour, "Facing Gaia: Six Lectures on the Political Theology of Nature," from *Being the Gifford Lectures on Natural Religion*, Edinburgh, February 18–28, 2013, 111. Clive Hamilton wrote *Requiem for a Species—Why We Resist the Truth About Climate Change*. (New York: Routledge, 2010). I mostly concur with both; but unfortunately Latour shares with him this confusion: "we have to uproot hope from our desperately optimistic frame of mind." *Ibid.*, 101.
 18. Simon Critchley, "Abandon (Nearly) All Hope," *New York Times*, April 19, 2014. He comes out for a kind of realistic or pragmatic, modest hope, but concludes nonetheless with this bit of Nietzsche, "Hope is the evil of evils because it prolongs man's torment."
 19. See Lauren Berlant, *Cruel Optimism* (Durham, Duke University Press, 2011).
 20. Christianity in its moments of radical self-implicature steps out of the cycle of optimism and pessimism: "Hope," wrote Karl Barth, "is in the act of taking the next step." *Church Dogmatics IV. 3* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1962), 938f. Cited in Catherine Keller, *On the Mystery: Discerning Divinity in Process* (Minneapolis: Fortress, 2008).
 21. Latour, "Facing Gaia," 101.
 22. Connolly, *The Fragility of Things*, 195.
 23. Catherine Keller, *Apocalypse Now and Then: A Feminist Guide to the End of the World* (Boston: Beacon, 1996).
 24. Natalie Wolchover, "Time's Arrow Traced to Quantum Source," in *Quanta Magazine*, www.simonsfoundation.org/quanta/20140416-times-arrow-traced-to-quantum-source/ (accessed April 28, 2014).
 25. The Hebrew God-name *Elohim* has a plural ending even as it functions as a grammatical singular—hence, a "theological plurisignarity," cf. Catherine Keller, *The Face of the Deep: A Theology of Becoming* (New York: Routledge, 2003).
 26. No one has brooded more profoundly on the complex relation of Shekhinah to kabbalistic apophaticism (and also to current feminism) than Elliot Wolfson. Each of his chiasmic utterances slips into the ineffable: "What has inspired the quest for me has been the discernment on the part of kabbalists that the ultimate being-becoming being-nameless

one known through the ineffable name, yhwh—transcends oppositional boundaries, for, in the one that is beyond the difference of being one or the other, light is dark, black is white, night is day, male is female, Adam is Edom.” Elliot Wolfson, *Luminal Darkness: Imaginal Gleanings from Zoharic Literature* (Oxford: Oneworld, 2007), xvi.

27. There have been five mass extinction events over the past half billion years; scientists now monitor the sixth, going on before our eyes and by our doing, predicted the most cataclysmic since the asteroid’s impact eliminated the dinosaurs. Elizabeth Kolbert, *The Sixth Extinction: An Unnatural History* (New York: Holt, 2014). Alfred North Whitehead, *Process and Reality*, corrected ed., edited by David Ray Griffin and Donald W. Sherburne (New York: Free Press, 1978), 343.
28. The famous opening verse of chapter one of Laozi’s *Daodejing*. For a brilliant analysis of its “no-thing-like character,” one that indeed stages a postcolonial entanglement of Whitehead, Deleuze, Hardt, Negri, and the Daoist forcefield of Neoconfucian thought, see Hyo-Dong Lee, *Spirit, Qi, and the Multitude: A Comparative Theology for the Democracy of Creation* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2013), 47.
29. Richardson, *Midsummer Night’s Dream*, 155.
30. *Daodejing*, chapter 25, in Lee, *Spirit, Qi, and the Multitude*, 46.
31. Cloud Cult, “Everybody Here Is a Cloud,” www.cloudcult.com/track/222710/everybody-here-is-a-cloud?feature_id=33133 (February 6, 2014).



ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

THIS REALLY IS impossible. This thanking that comes after cannot capture the multiplicity thinking with me, for me, before me. What a cloud-crowd of influence—gratefully known and precariously unknown—accompanies such a project.

If I dedicate this text to my colleagues at Drew's Theological School, it is because my appreciation only deepens through time for this forcefield of wildly gifted and irreducibly diverse collaborators. That Deans Maxine Beech, Anne Yardley, and Morrey Davis have firmly supported the annual Transdisciplinary Theological Colloquia, which have lent community to writing, is its own great gift. Particularly the Apophatic Bodies (2006), Planetary Loves (2007), and Polydoxy (2009) conferences seeded this book even as they produced volumes of their own.

The Graduate Division of Religion has also afforded me the chance twice to teach seminars called "Cloud of the Impossible." Each of the student participants has affected this project. Some doctoral students have rendered particularly helpful readings of portions of the text: I thank especially my erstwhile R.A. Elijah Prewitt-Davis for indelible contributions. Karen Bray and Anna Blaedel also made incisive comments. Before the seminars, Jake Erikson, a poet as well as theologian, introduced me to the music of Cloud Cult (who have graciously permitted me to frame this book with their lyrics). Also the now Dr. Dawn

Martin offered rich cosmopolitical engagement. Holly Hillgardner helped with Hadewijch. Brad Bannon, now at HDS, lent comparativist expertise. Most recently Sam Castleberry and Lisa Gasson labored intensively with me to finalize the manuscript. But the members of the entire doctoral collective, which extends hazily into the past and the future, form the liveliest context of this text. The apophatic feminism of Sigridur Gudmarsdottir, Ph.D., precedes my own. Among noble precipitates of the collective, professors Michael Nausner, Marion Grau, and Mayra Rivera (with her students) have generously offered their feedback.

Without the luminous interventions of Mary-Jane Rubenstein in every phase and chapter, often delivered faster than light, this project might have drifted into its own impossibility. Further help on the cosmology came radically toned from Clayton Crockett. Philip Clayton and Spyridon Koutroufinis also chimed in on the science (here is where I need to say—they aren't to blame . . .). In the Whiteheadian dimension the voice of Roland Faber and conferences of his WRP reverberate between the lines; and for planetary guidance I rely, as ever, upon John Cobb. In mobilizing the Christian classics, Kathryn Tanner's help was and is always a grace. My thanks to John Thatamanil for help with chapter 1, Charles Stang with chapter 3, Briggitta Kahl with chapter 9, and Melanie Johnson-DeBraufrie with chapter 10.

And there is another range of comradeship in this cloud, that of thinkers minding the textuality of the text. I am lucky to have had the astute research support of Ernie Rubenstein, Drew theological librarian until recently, and now succeeded by Jesse Mann, who had already helped me with fifteenth-century history. And then there is the *sine qua non*-hood of the team at Columbia Press, Wendy Lochner, Christine Dunbar, and, intensively, Susan Pensak, with her awesome mix of editorial and poetic endowment.

For one and a half writing retreats with Mary de Shazer I am fortunate. From my friend Glen Mazis I keep gleaning wisdom. Shall I note the secret relevance of such moments as Dan Dietrich resisting the seaweedy entanglement or Deb Ullman constellating relationality? Or as the clouds that my siblings Karen, Gregory, and Pierre, my niece Jennifer, have passed through with me and without? That would be a less academic sort of avowal. But the genre does allow a word of gratitude to the most known and still mysterious Jason Starr.

Manhattan

July 24, 2014

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